

John Evjen

Sinner and Witness

An Uncomfortable Gift to the AFLC
and a Living Apologetic for the First Principle

With Historical Texts by
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A Layman's Introduction by Aaron Dahlen

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FUNDAMENTAL PRINCIPLES

(Guiding Principles of the Lutheran Free Church and Association of Free Lutheran Congregations since 1897)

1. According to the Word of God, the congregation is the right form of the Kingdom of God on earth.
2. The congregation consists of believers who, by using the means of grace and the spiritual gifts as directed by the Word of God, seek salvation and eternal blessedness for themselves and for their fellow men.
3. According to the New Testament, the congregation needs an external organization with membership roll, election of officers, stated times and places for its gatherings, and other similar provisions.
4. Members of the organized congregation are not, in every instance, believers, and such members often derive false hope from their external connection with the congregation. It is therefore the sacred obligation of the congregation to purify itself by the quickening preaching of the Word of God, by earnest admonition and exhortation, and by expelling the openly sinful and perverse.
5. The congregation directs its own affairs, subject to the authority of the Word and Spirit of God, and acknowledges no other ecclesiastical authority or government above itself.
6. A free congregation esteems and cherishes all the spiritual gifts which the Lord gives for its edification, and seeks to stimulate and encourage their use.
7. A free congregation gladly accepts the mutual assistance which congregations can give one another in the work for the advancement of the Kingdom of God.
8. Such assistance consists partly in the mutual sharings of spiritual gifts among the congregations through conferences, exchange visits, lay activities, etc., whereby congregations are mutually edified, and partly in the voluntary and Spirit-prompted cooperation of congregations for the accomplishing of such tasks as exceed the ability of the individual congregation.
9. Among such tasks may be mentioned specifically the training of pastors, distribution of Bibles and other Christian literature, home missions, foreign missions, Jewish missions, deaconess homes, children's homes and other work of mercy.
10. Free congregations have no right to demand that other congregations shall submit to their opinion, will, judgment, or decision: therefore, domination by a majority of congregations over a minority is to be rejected.
11. Agencies found desirable for conducting the joint activities of congregations, such as conferences, committees, officers, etc., cannot in a Lutheran Free Church impose any obligations or restrictions, exert any compulsions, or lay any burden upon the individual congregation, but have the right only to make recommendations to, and requests of, congregations and individuals
12. Every free congregation, as well as every individual believer, is constrained by the Spirit of God and by the privileges of Christian love to do good and to work for the salvation of souls and the quickening of the spiritual life, as far as its abilities and power permit. Such free spiritual activity is limited neither by parish nor by synodical boundaries.

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1 A Layman's Introduction

If a principle may not be tested, then it may not truly be believed.

Let's begin with a quote from John Oluf Evjen that appeared in a 1930s book on Lutheranism:¹ It is an important quote as it frames the conversation into what became known as the Evjen controversy.

It was my good fortune to come to Augsburg College and Theological Seminary, Minneapolis, headed by the greatest theologian that America has ever had, Professor George Sverdrup [sic]... Augsburg taught spirited Lutheranism to a high degree. After completing seven years in this institution..."

Evjen adored and respected Sverdrup. We will show that this was true in 1910, which starts the beginning of our study. It remained true as Evjen wrote about Sverdrup and Oftedal throughout his life.

Evjen was an engineer at heart. I see many of my engineering instincts in his writings. He was fastidious to a fault. He was a man who latched onto a single idea and worked on it for years. He studied the source texts, dog-eared the pages, wrote notes in the margins, and assembled piles upon piles of notes. His ideas were placed under a microscope, twisted, pulled, broken, and reassembled until there is clarity.

Evjen dedicated a significant portion of his life to defending Sverdrup's work. The contents of this book document that work from 1910 through 1918. I would argue that significant work was done before 1910, because Evjen's 1910 polemic (Section 2 of this text) demonstrates a deep understanding of Sverdrup's work and how it would be received in our hostile world. This concern is captured in the first paragraph as Evjen begins with a small poem written by Bjørnstjerne Bjørnson. It is prophetic for both Sverdrup and Evjen.

When all that you meant was met with mockery,
and all that you wrought was only despised,
when your whole intent, however good it was,
is dismissed as nonsense by a self-satisfied fool,
then it must be practiced,
then it shall be tried,
your love.

This is love as perseverance. Sverdrup and Evjen struggled to define the boundaries between faithful adherence to the Word, dogmatics, ecclesiology, and polity. All of this is done at the congregation level, which Principle One defines as "the right form of the Kingdom of God on earth."

¹John O. Evjen, "What Is Lutheranism?" in *What Is Lutheranism? A Symposium in Interpretation*, ed. Vergilius Ferm (New York: The Macmillan Company, 1930), 9.

1.1 Why is Evjen such a controversial figure in AFLC history?

Evjen was a systematist attempting to carefully define his terms and then place the ideas within a greater structure, document the consequences, and place clear warning labels on the load-bearing beams. Make no mistake: you and I as faithful members of the AFLC are standing on those same load-bearing beams today.

Evjen asks the same question we should ask ourselves today: can we identify the beams, and do we understand how much weight they carry? What happens if one fails or if we start to move the load-bearing walls? For over a century, the faithful have been asking these questions. They are not simple and make people, especially modern readers, very uncomfortable.

As a test case, consider Gene Edward Veith's work on vocation. In practice, we often think and act in what Luther calls the mask of God. Suppose we amend the Fundamental Principles so that they explicitly call the individual to vocation. This is a dangerous ecclesiology plus polity question unless we fully understand the structure and order preserved by the Principles. We also need to understand and be willing to explore the Lutheran ideas beyond the safe wall of dogmatics.

Consider vocation. It is ecclesial, not merely individual, a point developed later through the sailor's model. This is the clarity passed down from Sverdrup and Oftedal. P1 demands nothing less than God's gifts being placed into service by all hands within the congregation. This is the visible congregation manifesting spirit and life. The struggle for a clear definition of congregation is an uncomfortable gift that John Evjen has given the AFLC. With an engineer's mind he stress-tests the Fundamental Principles starting with the first:

According to the Word of God, the congregation is the right form of the Kingdom of God on earth.

Before we continue, we must understand that Evjen is a flawed witness to the AFLC principles. In this book you will see his academic tenacity, his imbalance that many found disturbing, his unwillingness to yield, and language that is downright offensive to a modern audience. He is no hero, any more than Sverdrup or Oftedal were heroes. Yet, these flawed men speak to us today. We stand in wonder at the boundaries they established for our congregations.

But like a newly discovered fence in the woods, we may forget why it is there. We should therefore be very careful and not remove Chesterton's fence. We do not know if it is keeping something out, purposefully constraining those within its boundaries, or serving as a visible boundary that gives shape and meaning to something precious. Perhaps it is all three.

Yet, P1 is too strong a claim to survive on sentiment within the AFLC. Without a living apologetic, it will either be rejected by wider Lutheran instincts or reduced among us to the vague language of "spirit and life." Without the inherited obligation, P1 becomes the very thing Sverdrup and Evjen warn us against over and over again.

This work serves to breathe life into the Principles. P1 is not presented as a clean description but as a spoken confession held upright in tension between dogmatics, ecclesiology, polity, and individual obligation.

Evjen is prickly and hard to admire. Dislike does not change the fact that he forces us to see the foundations of the AFLC. If a principle may not be tested, then it may not truly be believed.

1.2 Contents

This book includes selected articles by John Evjen related to the works of Georg Sverdrup and Sven Oftedal. Evjen is a witness to what is now the Fundamental Principles of the Association of Free Lutheran Congregations (AFLC) with an emphasis on Principle #1. A copy of the AFLC's Fundamental Principles is included in the front matter.

This is not a biography of Evjen, Sverdrup, or Oftedal. Nor is it a history of the AFLC. However, Evjen's works from 1910 to 1918 are still with us today. Together, the five sections ask if the AFLC principles still serve as the foundation for living congregations or if "spirit and life" has become a slogan.

This book contains five sections:

- Section 1: *A Layman's Introduction* by Aaron Peder Dahlen.
- Section 2: *A Contribution to the Understanding of Professor Georg Sverdrup and His Selected Writings*: The text originally appeared in *Folkebladet* on May 4, 11, and 18, 1910. It was later bound and published as a small pamphlet by the Free Church Book Concern of Minneapolis, Minnesota.

This section is important as it captures Evjen's optimism. It was written immediately after the release of the first two [of six] volumes of Professor Sverdrup's *Sketches and Addresses* (*Skisser og Afhandlinger*) edited by Andreas Helland. Evjen's pamphlet reads like an overly enthusiastic review of the twin volumes. We can feel Evjen's relief. He is settling into the joy that Sverdrup's words are now accessible. He supposes that it is only a matter of time before the Lutheran Free Church (FLC) will read and understand Sverdrup's writings. We know better.

- Section 3: *Guidance: The Principles of the Lutheran Free Church*: This is a collection of writings by Sverdrup and Oftedal compiled by Evjen. It was published in book form in 1914 by the Free Church Book Concern of Minneapolis, Minnesota.
- Section 4: *The Position*: This is an 11-part argument written by Evjen. It appears in *Folkebladet* from March 13 to May 22, 1918.
- Section 5: *The Editors*: This includes materials written by the *Folkebladet's* editors. Their writings are important to understanding Evjen's exchange with The Editors in "The Position."

Note that *Guidance* contains no commentary by Evjen—not even a foreword explaining why these particular writings were selected. The inclusion of Oftedal's Hennepin County affidavit is also puzzling. From "The Position," we learn that Evjen used *Guidance* as a textbook while teaching at seminary. For example, the affidavit shows that Sverdrup and Oftedal were anchored in the American free-church current of their time:²

But one thing must not be left unsaid. Oftedal and Sverdrup used the same arguments to prove the scripturalness of their conception of the congregation

²Installment 4: "Folkebladet" April 3, 1918

and of their view of the office, lay activity, and church organization as the Congregationalists did. The patterns of argument are remarkably similar, which they can only be when the presuppositions are the same. This applies not only to their marshalling of scriptural proof, but also to the polemic against the arguments which the opponents of the congregational principle have brought into the field.

1.3 Definitions

When we say that the congregation is the body of Christ here on earth, we are no longer speaking in terms of polity. Instead, we are making a dogmatic claim about the nature of the church.

For our purposes we will use the following definitions:

- **Dogmatics:** What we confess because Scripture teaches it.
- **Ecclesiology:** What we believe Scripture teaches about the nature of the congregation.
- **Polity:** How we organize and operate the congregation.

These three terms are tightly coupled, as polity depends on ecclesiology and ecclesiology depends on dogmatics.

As we read Sverdrup, Oftedal, and Evjen, we need to be very careful with these terms. This may sound silly, but I recommend you make three notecards, one for each term. As you read this material, select and hold the appropriate card in your hand. Do this for each point. Even better, read the passage again with one of the wrong cards and see how it changes your point of view.

Much of the Evjen controversy involves holding the correct card at the correct time. **If you are holding a dogmatics card and your opponent is holding a polity card, the argument is already lost.** As you read the remainder of this book, always have the cards in hand and ask which is being used in any given argument.

Let's try a few examples:

Example 1: The Bible is the inerrant Word of God This is a dogmatic claim describing how we stand under Scripture. We will not understand everything, and there are sections we will not like. Yet we receive the Word as it is written and struggle together to find meaning and application in our lives.

Example 2: We are all sinners This is a dogmatic claim that points the way to Jesus, from Genesis to the Cross. Without your sin and my sin, there would be no reason for Jesus to die. Our best works appear as filthy rags. Jesus nailed our sins to the Cross.

Example 3: All members of the congregation are called (have a vocation) to use their gifts to help each other This ecclesiology claim is encoded into the latter half of the AFLC's principles, especially P9 and P12.

Example 4: The congregation is the body of Christ This starts out as dogmatics but refuses to stay there. Jesus is not stationary. Instead, he gives spirit and life to the congregation. Order and mission (polity) are gifts to guide the movement of the congregational body.

Example 5: “Silent Night” and “Amazing Grace” sung a cappella Let’s call this a local polity consideration with its heart grounded in ecclesiology. It recognizes that when the congregation sings together, the members must be able to hear one another. Active voices are more important than a wall of music, no matter how beautiful. As with the Lord’s Prayer, the congregation must be able to hear itself as we confess our sinful nature and the promise of the Cross.

Amazing grace (how sweet the sound)
that saved a wretch like me!
I once was lost, but now am found,
was blind, but now I see.

Example 6: Lutherans are confessional This statement is hard to categorize. It is an operational statement (polity) confessed through the creeds according to the church calendar. It is also sung in our great hymns. But it refuses to let go of the nature of the church (ecclesiology) because that is what Lutherans believe (dogmatics). Lutheran laypeople occasionally refer to the Augsburg Confession, but let’s be honest, that’s a hard read.

Example 7: Principle 1: “According to the Word of God, the congregation is the right form of the Kingdom of God on earth.” This layered statement is so complex that it requires its own section. Actually, it requires more than the 200 pages of this book allow.

1.4 Crossing Boundaries with P1

The first principle is the keel for the entire AFLC. It refuses to categorically fit within our clean definitions. Instead, it has elements of all three:

- **According to the Word of God:** This is a dogmatic biblical teaching.
- **the congregation is the right form:** This is a dogmatic assertion leading to an ecclesiological claim about the nature of the congregation.
- **of the Kingdom of God on earth:** This is an ecclesiological description of the visible congregation. This profound heavenly confession will not be constrained. By implication, it pulls at the remaining eleven principles.

Finally, we must recognize that P1 does not stand by itself. It carries the weight of the eleven other principles that cast it as a unifying polity statement. Taken together, P1 is a dogmatic authority statement describing the ecclesiological nature of the congregation, with a polity

call to duty. The bottom line is that P1 is not reducible. We are not going to solve this with a pure biblical claim, a clear ecclesiological claim, or a clear polity-based statement.

This is why those notecards are so important. They remind us to be very careful with our AFLC apologetics.

1.5 How Can We Hear Sverdrup, Evjen, and The Editors?

Apologetics begins with a hymn.

We cannot understand Sverdrup merely by reading Sverdrup, because we no longer have the common frame of reference. As evidence, consider this clause from P1: “Kingdom of God on earth.” I ask you to take it seriously with all the implications applicable to the congregation and individual members operating within and beyond the church.

This is a good time to stop and find an old hymnal, as our hymns are downstream of theology. They are not neutral; they carry the emotion, prayer, and outlook. They also reflect a sense of mission. In modern language, we would say that hymns encode a call to action. This allows us to gauge the theological temperature of a period without drowning in historical detail.

To fully understand Sverdrup’s time period, immerse yourself in the Kingdom described by these hymns:

- *Battle Hymn of the Republic*
- *Stand Up, Stand Up for Jesus*
- *We’ve a Story to Tell to the Nations*
- *Onward, Christian Soldiers*
- *Bringing in the Sheaves*
- *From Greenland’s Icy Mountains*
- *Work, for the Night Is Coming*

There is an incredible optimism woven into these hymns, an American heat whose supreme confidence borders on sinful pride. They all sing in the same triumphant key about the Kingdom coming to all the earth. Do we dare take the next step and declare that the "Kingdom of God on earth" is here embodied in the congregation and its faithful members? Is this not the force pressing P1 forward?

According to the Word of God, the congregation is the right form of the Kingdom of God on earth.

You can read more about this uniquely American church history era under the category of postmillennialism. You will find the power best exemplified in the refrain of “We’ve a Story to Tell to the Nations:”

For the darkness shall turn to dawning,
and the dawning to noonday bright,
and Christ's great kingdom shall come on earth—
the kingdom of love and light.

This is the providential calling to the congregation as well as individual duty, urgency, and frankly, the unquestioned march driving the church's mission forward. It's also mixed up with American manifest destiny, and even technology as factories, agriculture, and steam power reshape life.

Understand that this is the empowering water that surrounded Sverdrup, Oftedal, Evjen, along with the Congregationalists in the mid-to-late 1800s up until about World War 1. Like a fish in water, I'm not convinced they could see it. They certainly would not have used the term *postmillennialism*, instead preferring to describe the life of the Norwegian immigrant in America. Yet, it is this same American theological current that carried "John Brown's Body" to your hymnal with the words:

Glory! Glory! Hallelujah!
Glory! Glory! Hallelujah!
Glory! Glory! Hallelujah!
His ~~son~~ truth is marching on.

Do not write off Sverdrup and Oftedal as postmillennial thinkers. To the contrary, they offer something profound that calls to us today. The problem is that we are a century removed. The language has changed and the shared metaphors with their deadly serious polemical force have softened so much that we only hear the echo.

We can clearly see the postmillennial thinking because we are at least two hymnal generations removed. I'd argue that the first shift occurred around the 1950s, with a de-emphasis on anything that looked like the Protestant vocational work ethic, striving, or moral progress carried beyond Sunday morning. Hymns such as *Work, for the Night Is Coming* became uncomfortable for many Lutherans. The latest hymnal generation emerged around the turn of this century with an ever-growing emphasis on comfort and assurance. The unyielding hammer of judgment—that we are all sinners—has become a hidden footnote. The evidence is written in the hymnals, or in some cases, the abandonment of hymnals altogether.

The opening hymns set the stage. They remind us of the American confidence into which P1 was born. Yet, it would be a mistake to nostalgically return to those times. Instead, we need something stronger, more disciplined, and biblically grounded. Let's continue using a ship analogy with a modern understanding of vocation. But before we do, let's reset our ear to the confessional register with one of Luther's greatest hymns. Ponder the embodied wisdom of this hymn. The wisdom which is inseparable from the anchor of the Kingdom of God on earth. We cry from the depths (Psalm 130). Our lives in the way of the old Adam are unmanageable. We cannot stand upright before the hammer of the Judge who remembers every sin. Yet, there is our Shepherd to lead the way.

Out of the Depths I Cry to Thee:

1 From depths of woe I cry to Thee,
Lord, hear me, I implore Thee.
Bend down Thy gracious ear to me;
my prayer let come before Thee.
If Thou rememb'rest every sin,
if naught but just reward we win,
could we abide Thy presence?

2 Thy love and grace alone avail
to blot out my transgression;
the best and holiest deeds must fail
to break sin's dread oppression.
Before Thee none can boasting stand,
but all must fear Thy strict demand
and live alone by mercy.

3 Therefore my hope is in the LORD
and not in mine own merit;
it rests upon His faithful word
to them of contrite spirit
that He is merciful and just;
this is my comfort and my trust.
His help I wait with patience.

4 And though it tarry till the night
and till the morning waken,
my heart shall never doubt His might
nor count itself forsaken.
Do thus, O ye of Adam's seed,
ye of the Spirit born indeed;
wait for your God's appearing.

5 Though great our time and sore our woes,
His grace much more aboundeth;
His helping love no limit knows,
our utmost need it soundeth.
Our Shepherd good and true is He,
who will at last His people free
from all their sin and sorrow.

1.6 A Model of the Congregation

P1 is exposed by our disobedience.

The model described in this section is required to visualize the dangers described by Evjen and by The Editors. Like many Lutheran ideas, it is held in tension—between the ditches as Luther might say. Evjen asks us to seriously consider the visible form and order that hold the congregation together; The Editors ask us to consider the living Spirit within those structures. Eliminate either side and the congregation collapses.

To better understand this world, I offer a model of the visible congregation as a ship on a mission at sea. This model allows us to better understand the water in which the visible congregation is sailing. Evjen was writing about Sverdrup in the decade following his untimely death. We are reading Evjen and Sverdrup a century later. I suspect Evjen was too close to the fire and we are so far away that we cannot distinguish the smoke through the fog. The model provides a conceptual framework that makes it easier to visualize the congregation. Conversations are easier, and operational failures become easier to describe and harder to deny.

Keep in mind that the ship is my metaphor and, to the best of my knowledge, not used by Sverdrup, Oftedal, or Evjen. The ship is a natural metaphor for me as I served on icebreakers and a three-masted barque. I've sailed far north of Alaska and south to Antarctica. Let me share the first lesson of sailing. A ship is built for a crew, not an individual. Crewmembers are specialized and handle the ship's daily work according to their gifts and training. The ship and everyone on board depend on the faithful work of the individual in service to the ship in service of the mission.

Recall that P1 does not fit cleanly within dogmatics, ecclesiology, or polity boundaries. Yet our understanding requires that we anchor each statement within that framework. For the ship, dogmatics declares what we believe from Scripture, ecclesiology describes the nature of the ship and crew, and polity describes the crew's operational obligations. I've added what I believe is the correct category for each statement. I encourage you to test my classifications, especially when more than one term applies.

Quoted material in this list is contained within the Guiding Principles (See front material).

The Ship is Given by Christ

- Dogmatics: The ship is a gift from Christ, originating at Pentecost in the upper room. Its purpose is Christ's purpose: to make dead men live.
- Ecclesiology: The ship's hull marks the visible and bounded form of the congregation. It defines the boundary between internal Christian obligation and mission to the outside world.
- Ecclesiology: There are many ships of many designs. Yet none are warships wielding the sword. All have a mission from Christ.
- Ecclesiology: The crew is a gift from Christ. The visible congregation consists of men

and women, young and old. All members brings gifts. Yet, all are sinners capable of sins of both omission and commission. When the ship is damaged, all are in danger.

- Ecclesiology: Within the ship is a living and visible congregation that acts.

The Ship's Power and True Center

- Dogmatics and Ecclesiology: The Word is preached clearly so that all hands can point the way from old Adam to the promise of the Cross.
- Dogmatics: The ship is powered by the Word and sacraments. All crewmembers are marked with the cross at baptism. The crew kneels for the body and blood of Christ given and shed for you. Yet the sacraments are not hidden in the engine room. They are visible and sacred acts received and witnessed by all crewmembers.
- Dogmatics: Justification was purchased at the cross. Sanctification is the Spirit's work. In the Reformation tradition, we confess that faith alone justifies, but faith is never alone. Consequently, we fear a passive crew as the ship is in peril.
- Ecclesiology: The ship is delicate. Some wrongly assume the ship is strong with a faithful crew that carries the armor of God. In reality, the congregation is composed of Adam's fallen children. Collectively, they are capable of great things, but they default to sin. Also, individual members tend to fall away in the face of conflict, hollowing out a once proud and capable ship.

The Crew as a Living Congregation

- Polity: The crew learn about each other over coffee and cookies. This is not an optional exercise as it is one of the primary ways that members of the congregation become known to one another. The resulting prayers are real as the crew cares enough to hear how others are suffering.
- Ecclesiology: An individual's contributions changes with time. We all have seasons. God willing, we pass from child, to youth with strength and vigor, to wisdom, to autumn, to fading strength. Gifts change, yet we remain part of the body. All hands are required at every stage.
- Ecclesiology: A healthy ship is in a constant state of training to reinforce both the spiritual as well as vocational skills of the crew.
- Polity: Bear ye one another's burdens, and so fulfil the law of Christ (Galatians 6:2).

Order, Watchstanding, and Lay Responsibility

- Polity: Each ship must have order or it will sink, dash against the rocks, or burn to the waterline, leaving the crew stranded. When the storm strikes, the crew must be ready to respond reflexively.
- Ecclesiology: Each member is "constrained by the Spirit of God and by the privileges of Christian love" to freely exercise their spiritual gifts.

- Polity: The active use of all hands is essential. However, there are select positions that must be filled to maintain a healthy congregation. There must be leadership, along with serious lay members to strengthen leadership as steel on steel. Watchstanders are required to identify the obstacles and the opportunities: Sunday school teachers, Bible school leaders, council members, treasurers, and perhaps more importantly, caring members who extend a welcoming hand to visitors or to those who cannot attend.
- Ecclesiology and Polity: The crew must sound the ship and tap the pipes to retain the knowledge of what keeps the ship afloat and running. Faithful laity must understand the ship well enough to inspect and help repair as necessary.
- Ecclesiology: The impact of sin propagates through the crew. All members bear the consequences of each other's sin. None are immune.
- Polity: All hands are alert; every faithful member is a watchstander. The alarm must be sounded when the ship is in danger.

Mission Beyond Sentiment

- Ecclesiology: The ship, as a visible congregation, is on a mission with a calling from Christ. The congregation is composed of individual sinners gathered together as the ship's crew. The ship is the visible structure in which Christ's work is carried out.
- Ecclesiology and Polity: The ship gathers sinners who would otherwise drift without purpose, community, and meaning. They are welcomed long before their station is clear. Brotherhood, correction, responsibility, and training are given so that each may bear life's load under God's rule in both kingdoms.
- Ecclesiology and Polity: The ship carries memory as obligation. The boundaries and mission are inherited from those who can no longer stand the watch. They are honored through faithful action to maintain the ship and mission on Christ's given course.

Danger, Failure, and the Anti-Sentimental Guardrail

- Dogmatics: This is not a naturally healthy ship. We are all sinners full of pride, resentment, and hypocrisy. I am a chief among the hypocrites for daring to write these ideals for which I stand condemned.
- Dogmatics: Satan the father of lies is whispering to the crew, and the real world presses in with political, societal, and economic constraints. There are also openly hostile enemies to Christianity.
- Ecclesiology: This is not a safe ship. It's not some sentimental ark to weather the storm. It's an operational ship dependent on the shared responsibility of the crew to perform the ship's business while taking care of all members. There is an old saying that "a ship in port is safe, but that's not what a ship is for."
- Ecclesiology: A congregation may appear safe when it avoids mission, repair, conflict, responsibility, and pays the pastor until it closes its doors. But that's not what a

congregation is for. Or as Sverdrup once stated, a congregation may appear to have all its members, but it may be missing the most important thing: life.

- **Dogmatics and Ecclesiology:** Being a member of the crew does not, in itself, imply that we are saved. This is not works-righteousness. You will not be saved by working harder, longer, or by advancing in station aboard the ship. Not even the captain is automatically saved. However, in the same breath, you are called to work “as far as its abilities and power permit.”

In summary, the ship is used to visualize the Pauline language of Ephesians 4:16:

From him the whole body, joined and held together by every supporting ligament, grows and builds itself up in love, as each part does its work.

The Kingdom of God on earth is Christ’s ordered gift of life together under Word and sacrament. We sinners are given to one another and called to live faithfully within the obligations those gifts create.

1.7 A Broken Model of the Congregation

The danger is not that P1 is too difficult to understand, but that it is too costly to believe.

The ship metaphor works. We can clearly see that the congregation acts. It carries the gifts of Christ to the world. The congregation and every member within depend on the faithful work of each individual in service to the congregation in service of the mission in Christ.

The individual responsibility to the congregation is clear. Yet, the model breaks precisely at the level of individual responsibility. Let me explain with another hard-learned sailor’s lesson, “You represent the ship. Act accordingly as you go ashore.” Stated another way, if you are a member of the visible congregation that confesses itself to be the “Kingdom of God on earth,” then you have obligations. It’s an uncomfortable position for the Lutheran and for the American Christian in general, however, the implications are unavoidable.

Even more uncomfortable is the fact that the relationship runs both ways. The congregation has an obligation to those who go ashore. It does not end with confirmation and magically restart when marriage and children make the individual visible again. If we profess that the congregation is the Kingdom of God on earth, people are not left to drift. The congregation’s vocation of brotherhood, correction, responsibility, and training extends beyond the hull. To be blunt, the nice polite sailor abandons the crew by ignoring fire, flooding, or a drowning shipmate. It is an abdication of duty.

Let’s refine our definitions to include Luther’s concept of vocation with assistance from Veith:

- **Dogmatics:** What we confess because Scripture teaches it.
- **Ecclesiology:** What we believe Scripture teaches about the nature of the congregation.
- **Polity:** How we organize and operate the congregation.
- **Vocation:** How an individual operates outside the ship and in the sinful world in terms of work, family, neighbor, and civic obligations. The sovereign individual does

not escape obligation while ashore. Freedom is rightly ordered through the service of daily bread. At the same time, individuals within the congregation have a vocation toward those who go ashore.

Just as the ship has a mission, so too does the individual. We are anchored in the Principles, “every individual believer is constrained by the Spirit of God and by the privileges of Christian love...” We could use Pauline language and talk about a leg that wants to leave the body, as if the severed leg could live or the body could continue its mission unharmed. Christ gives the authority and Paul gives us the body. The ship helps us see the body at work.

Principle One is not merely an academic problem as framed by Evjen, but an existential vocational problem. At its core it demands something from every member of the crew while on board and ashore. Remember that the congregation is a gift from Christ. It’s an operational support vessel with a single course toward the Cross. We are called to carry Christ in all that we do in the congregation, family, neighbor, and yes, even nation. The Spirit and life are given. However, these gifts must be developed by all hands for the glory of God and the necessity of daily bread. Sverdrup would say:

By congregation we mean a gathering of active Christians, who use the means of grace and the gifts of grace for their own and their fellow men’s salvation and blessedness. Where such a gathering of active Christians is found, the question does not become one of binding and controlling lay activity and other gifts of grace, but much more of giving them room and freedom, occasion and encouragement, so that they may come to the greatest flourishing and the most effective use.³

In modern language: do not sin against vocation.

If we are unwilling to develop and use these gifts “as far as its abilities and power permit” the congregation fails. “Spirit and life” is not a revival statement about Jesus my buddy, but a life-and-death question about the duty performed by the individual members of the congregation. In biblical terms, P1 is a declaration that works follow faith: we are saved by grace through faith, “not a result of works,” yet “created in Christ Jesus for good works” (Eph. 2:8–10). A serious acceptance of the “Kingdom of God on earth” demands no less.

This may seem like an insurmountable problem, yet it has been with us all along as Principle 12:

Every free congregation, as well as every individual believer, is constrained by the Spirit of God and by the privileges of Christian love to do good and to work for the salvation of souls and the quickening of the spiritual life, as far as its abilities and power permit. Such free spiritual activity is limited neither by parish nor by synodical boundaries.

And finally we arrive at Sverdrup’s and Evjen’s core message concerning a living and visible congregation. This is a calling. It acts. There is room for all of God’s gifts and work for every hand.

³See Sverdrup’s full article, “The Congregation and Lay Activity

Can we bear the weight of our earthly vocation? Will we accept P1 not as a sentimental statement of spirit and life but as a call to act as serious members of the body of Christ? Evjen calls to us:

The question—the real one—becomes: Does one stand in living accord with the future of God’s kingdom, and is one willing to let oneself be used for the kingdom’s advance, to labor for the fulfillment of the prayer: hallowed be your name; your kingdom come; as in heaven so also on earth—your will be done!”⁴

It is possible to bury the principles and get a peace that is as silent as the grave’s.⁵

My language has been the bracing language of duty. Such language speaks openly. It does not whisper, does not threaten. It does not whisper in the twilight, does not compose protests and does not circulate petitions.⁶

1.8 Epilogue

Professor Evjen is a voice lost to history. You will find no monument or statue. What you will find is living memory and a LFC footnote regarding the contents of this book that has become known as the “Evjen Controversy.”

Evjen emerges at a particularly difficult time for the FLC. Sverdrup and Oftedal are dead. The cultural default of the Norwegian ethnicity is waning against a powerful American patriotic current fueled by the relentless advance of technology, westward expansion, and events such as WWI.

We are all Americans, and we are Americans first. If that wasn’t true in 1918 it accelerated in the crucible of WWII. The unfortunate result was the loss of a living Norwegian language in America. We nearly lost access to Sverdrup, Oftedal and Evjen in the process. We can thank the Sverdrup Society for carrying the torch. Recent efforts to digitize the world’s libraries and the rise of AI-assisted research allow us to revisit the wisdom of the FLC founders.

This change in temperature is reflected in the AFLC Rules for Work as adopted in 1967. Originally rule #2 stated “Its purpose is to labor for the vivification and liberation of all Norwegian Lutheran congregations...” this was changed to “Its aim shall be to work toward making Lutheran congregations free and living, so that, according to their calling and ability...”

I would argue that the “Evjen Controversy” is not so much about Evjen as the sudden, unexpected, and undisciplined transfer of power in the FLC. In the founders’ absence, people naturally question who they are and the meaning of their mission exemplified in the founding principles. If you will allow the imperfect analogy, this is Israel wandering in the desert without Moses. The promise was given but people lost direction. Many returned to the larger synodical body. Others soldiered forward with unquestioned allegiance to Sverdrup and Oftedal, forgetting that the founders are witnesses to a principle and not a substitute for the real thing.

⁴Installment 11: “Folkebladet” May 22, 1918

⁵Installment 9: “Folkebladet” May 08, 1918

⁶Installment 9: “Folkebladet” May 08, 1918

Evjen with his systemizing probe of at the founding principles was salt in the wound. His actions were unwelcome in 1918 and remain challenging today in 2026. In fact, it may be harder in 2026 as the polemic language seems overly harsh and foreign to our ears.

Returning once again to Evjen, this is what we do know. Shortly after writing *The Position* in Folkebladet, he was dismissed from the seminary. Tragically, I've found no additional Evjen writings in Folkebladet. His name emerges again as head of Mayville, North Dakota. There he wrote a piece titled *The Teachers College: Its Place in the Educational System*.⁷ You may appreciate this quote where we see the same Evjen pattern all over again. He suffers no fools and drives straight at the heart of the problem.

A WEAKNESS IN HIGHER EDUCATION

The trouble with many of our colleges to-day is this: They have aspired to be universities, they have copied the English system, making the college the zenith institution of education. And yet, the copying has been so imperfect that the average American B. A. lacks three years of being equal to an Oxford B. A. For some inexplicable reason our colleges have built a German postgraduate department on top of the collegiate, and called the entire confusion a "university."

Ironically, this is another live-wire topic that has been exposed in today's America. In that sense, Evjen refuses to be silent and calls to us a century later.

As Israel is forever called to wrestle with God, so too the AFLC must wrestle with the Principles beginning with P1, not as the slogan "spirit and life" but as a living vocational obligation that calls all hands to work for the Kingdom. Therefore, pray for wisdom and guidance as you walk your earthly vocation as an academic, seminarian, pastor, or layperson. We are all called to witness and live without apology under this confession: "According to the Word of God, the congregation is the right form of the Kingdom of God on earth."

Fail forward.

1.9 How I Found Sverdrup through Evjen

It started with curiosity. I found a piece of Danish text on the Sverdrup Society page and wondered if it could be translated by AI. After several hours of prompt refinement, this translation emerged:

The formation of the Church is the holy work of the triune God.

Sin had marred creation, and death ruled over the fallen world; divine wrath rested upon humanity, once created for salvation. Yet God's eternal plan—conceived in love and grace—sought to restore what sin had corrupted, to overthrow the powers of sin, death, and condemnation, and to grant new life and immortality to those enslaved by death. Therefore, no congregation could come into being, no fellowship of God's redeemed children could be established, except through reconciliation in

⁷John O. Evjen, *The Teachers College: Its Place in the Educational System*, State Normal School Quarterly Bulletin, new ser., no. 12 (December 1920): 17.

Christ's death, through life raised from the dead in his resurrection, and through union with God by the Holy Spirit. God's free and living people on earth share their closest communion with him through the death and resurrection of his Son and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit.

A month later this passage emerged from the machine translation:

All hands on deck, draw the sword from the sheath, let the cannons glint in the sun, strike upon the souls, that the sound of weapons may be heard far throughout the land. The time has come, the air is pregnant with thunder; let the thunder roll in the cloud and the lightnings strike with flash upon flash in the murk of night. The powers of the world are stirred; let the powers of heaven stir themselves in us. God's Church is in danger; let weapon-bearing men defend it. Against the lie we use sharp swords, against the lie we bear flashing helmets, against the lie we take up bright shields. **But the lie is not outside God's Church, but within its walls.** Therefore awake, you Christian Church, wherever you are found; therefore awake, you watchman of Zion, and blow the trumpet, that it may give a clear sound.

The lie is this, that Christ is dead; for behold, he lives. The lie is this, that Christianity is mere doctrine and the understanding of understandings and the clarity of thought; for behold, it is the life of love and the folly of love. The lie is this, that the Church is an institution for ruling over men; for behold, it is the home of freedom and the fellowship of the liberated. The lie is this, that the Church must use the world's falseness and deceit in order to be shrewd as a serpent; for behold, it is the holy witness of truth and simplicity. The lie is this, that the world is the Church's most dangerous enemy; for behold, it is the object of God's love. The lie is this, that the Church is pure; for behold, it is full of rottenness and stench. The lie is this, that Christianity is hatred of the world; for behold, it is love for the world. The lie is this, that the Church must fear the world; for behold, the world has been overcome. The lie is this, that the Church must go outward to find its life; for behold, its enemy is in the midst of it. Let us find him where his work is among us; let us know him as the one he is. Let us meet him as Christ did of old: I am the one you seek.

Wow, Sverdrup could write! I was hooked. From that point forward, I spent hundreds of hours translating Sverdrup with the AI. This included the entire book of sermons *Aand og Liv* (*Spirit and Life*) by Professors Oftedal and Sverdrup.

Patterns emerged. The first was a preaching style where Sverdrup would take hold of you with an Old Testament lesson until you knew—deep down, you really knew—that you were the old Adam. And then Sverdrup's sermon would turn on its hinge, revealing the freedom of the Gospel.

But Sverdrup was not merely a preacher; he was a teacher of preachers. He was also a layman, having never been ordained. There, we see the deeper pattern where Sverdrup serves as the defender of the congregation, shepherd to the preachers, and rouser of laymen to action. Sverdrup writes with clarity on this topic. He holds the Fundamental Principles in

high regard, while keeping them wholly subservient to Word and Cross. These are the same principles the AFLC holds today. They are presented in the front matter of this book.

1.9.1 Evjen and the Permission to Question Principle One

Up until this point, Sverdrup had been a fascinating project. I had dedicated six months of free time translating and reading hundreds of pages. The work was serious, interesting, and enjoyable, but I had yet to find what I was looking for. Specifically, how should a person act beyond the congregation? If the congregation is a vessel, how should the sailor act when ashore?

I was attempting to reconcile Sverdrup with both Martin Luther and Gene Edward Veith. I knew there was a relationship, but could not yet describe it. I had the pleasure of exploring these ideas with my mentor, Loiell Dyrud.

Almost as an afterthought, Loiell placed an old, faded copy of a Norwegian book called *Guidance* into my hands. This book contained material from Sverdrup and Oftedal compiled by Evjen; see Section 3. A month later, Professor Martin Horn asked me to machine translate Evjen's *The Position*; see Section 4. It was Evjen who allowed me to see Sverdrup clearly. One night the entire structure snapped into position. I could see the red thread running from the Pauline language in Ephesians, through Luther, through Sverdrup, and yes, even through Veith's witness.

1.10 Disclaimer

This volume is an independent scholarly and technical project. It is not affiliated with, endorsed by, or issued under the authority of any church body, academic institution, or other organization, including but not limited to the Association of Free Lutheran Congregations (AFLC), the Sverdrup Society, Augsburg Seminary, or any related bodies.

The texts presented herein are historical documents. The English translations, transcriptions, and editorial materials are supplied solely for educational and research purposes. They do not claim doctrinal, ecclesiastical, institutional, or critical authority.

The English translations in this volume were produced with the aid of artificial intelligence-based language tools operating under detailed scholarly instructions. Editorial responsibility consists of methodological design of the AI translation prompts, critical oversight, source comparison, translation review, and presentation. An honest assessment reveals that shards of Aaron Dahlen are present in the translation; none of this was a simple click of the button.

The original source texts remain definitive.

Editorial Note

This document is a working translation and reconstruction from a source that is in poor physical and typographic condition. Some passages remain uncertain owing to faded print, damaged pages, archaic spelling, irregular orthography, and the inherent limitations of OCR and other machine-assisted recovery methods; such tools can assist transcription, but they cannot by themselves guarantee correct readings in difficult witnesses.

Readers should therefore treat this as a provisional scholarly working text rather than a final critical edition. The project is maintained openly on GitHub and constructed in L^AT_EX, so that the text, formatting, annotations, and editorial decisions may be revised transparently over time.

Corrections, source checks, and suggested improvements are welcome through the project repository on GitHub, where revisions and editorial decisions may be tracked transparently.

<https://github.com/apdahlen/Evjen>

Et Bidrag til Forstaaelse af
Prof. Georg Sverdrup
og hans
Samlede Skrifter i Udvalg

I. Bind: Skisser og Afhandlinger

II. Bind: Menigheden

Af

John O. Evjen

Dr. phil. [Leipzig Universitet]

Prof. theol. ved Augsburg Seminarium

Aftrykt efter „Folkebladet“
for 4, 11, 18 Mai 1910

2 A Contribution to Understanding Prof. Georg Sverdrup and His Selected Writings

When all that you meant was met with mockery,
and all that you wrought was only despised,
when your whole intent, however good it was,
is dismissed as nonsense by a self-satisfied fool,
then it must be practiced,
then it shall be tried,
your love.

Bjørnstjerne Bjørnson.

The little verse above, by our great poet, is found unsigned in the Collin manuscript collection. It was printed for the first time in 1907, the year of Professor Sverdrup's death. We do not know when the poem was composed, or whether the poet wrote it for any particular person. We do know that scarcely anything could be more fitting as a tribute to Sverdrup, if we wish to express how great his work was, and how little it was understood.

A longer time must pass before history can give a many-sided assessment of Sverdrup's life and work. As things now stand, there are far too many who have no understanding of what he accomplished among us. On the other side are those who seem to forget that Sverdrup too was subject to human frailties, and that now and then he was mistaken.

But there ought not to be divided opinions as to whether the goal at which Sverdrup aimed was the right one, and whether the principles upon which he built were sound. Likewise, no one should doubt that his whole labor was borne by earnestness, honesty, and love.

Although much has been said about the goal and about the principles, it is a fact that, to a great extent, they are both unknown and misunderstood. Among many of our people there has been a lack either of good will or of ability to concern themselves with them. Many have done what they could to lay obstacles in the way of the principles' realization. Some have practiced them in such a manner that they have become mere caricatures. Others, demonstrative riders of principle, have degraded them into meaningless slogans. The well-deserved mockery has not failed to appear, though it has fallen more upon the innocent than upon the guilty.

Yet amid all this there are many who have labored with sobriety for, and in faithfulness to, the principles upon which Sverdrup laid such great weight: the doctrine of the child (Barnelevdommen), the congregational autonomy, and purposeful pastoral training. These principles existed both in theory and in practice before Augsburg came to be; but for the Norwegian people here as well as in Norway they were unknown. Augsburg joined them together and made them, already in the seventies, its *sine qua non*; the question of originality and priority we may leave out of account. What is of consequence is that Augsburg has done incomparable pioneer work in the Norwegian-American Church, and that it has impressed upon the consciousness of our people these truths: that life is more than doctrine, the congregation is more than a mere institution, pastor more than teacher and liturgist. And of consequence for Augsburg is this, that a theologian such as Sverdrup laid down his life in its service, thirty-three years of hard, self-denying, almost incomprehensible labor, which has

borne and will bear blessed fruit for the Kingdom of God.

In Sverdrup's Collected Writings there is now given a new occasion to make oneself acquainted with what Sverdrup willed, worked for, and meant. By reading his contributions and treatises, which extend over a period of thirty-eight years, one will see whether there was any breach in his development, any groping in his work, any self-contradiction in his principles. The work is planned for five or six volumes; it is therefore the most significant literary undertaking yet produced by Norwegian-American publishing.

Sverdrup has made so great a contribution to our ecclesiastical development that our Norwegian-American church people, in order to understand the present alignments among our church bodies, and in order better to find a remedy for certain ecclesiastical defects, ought and must make themselves familiar with the most important treatises from Sverdrup's pen. Difference in church view and theological direction ought not to keep anyone from concerning himself with his collected writings, which concern the laity no less than the learned, and are no less intelligible to the former than to the latter. For everything Sverdrup wrote was clear, logical, and written for ordinary people.

His writings may be read with profit by all. But with special profit they will be read by his students, who heard him at the lectern.

In judging what a man has written, there are not a few who take as their standard the impression they have received of him as a speaker. Everything they must measure by the yardstick of eloquence. Such people, if for example they have heard Bjørnson and Ibsen speak, will naturally think more highly of Bjørnson's literary productions than of Ibsen's; for Bjørnson was as powerful in speech as he was with the pen, whereas Ibsen, the greatest dramatist of our age, was a poor speaker. A mixed audience will always produce rather different judgments. Most who read Otto Funcke's writings will probably think that Funcke was a mighty speaker, which is not at all the case. And many have the notion that it was an imposing bearing, a magnetic personality, and brilliant gifts of speech that proved decisive in Paul's great work; for Paul was indeed one of the greatest organizers known to world history. But we learn that his critics in Corinth maintained that his letters were weighty and strong, but his bodily presence weak and his speech to be set at naught (2 Cor. 10:10). He did not impress by Greek rhetoric, but he possessed profound Christian insight (2 Cor. 11:6).

Neither did Sverdrup impress by his outward appearance, or by "American Oratory": there are those who find no trace of authority either in what he wrote or in what he spoke.

What was great in Sverdrup was his deep Christian insight. But he also knew how to present it with weight and force in speech. But where? Was it in the pulpit, on the platform, or at the lectern?

Where did his strength as a speaker lie?

Before we answer this, we may mention a couple of interesting things that have been said about him and will be said about him still; for the wisdom of the street will never die.

A workingman once told me that he had once heard Sverdrup in the pulpit. "It was a dry sermon," he said. A merchant received a pamphlet which Sverdrup had written about

Augsburg's principles. In irritation he burst out: "They do not go deep." A pastor told me that he thought it strange that Sverdrup had so many admirers; for everything he wrote was poor as well. But—to return to our question.

It was not in the pulpit that Sverdrup's proper strength lay. And yet he was a great preacher. When he preached, one received a sermon pervaded by the biblical spirit; it was a many-sided exposition and application of the text, fresh, original—Sverdrup never traveled the bare country road in his treatment; it had not a little in common with Old Testament prophetic speech. He did not stand in the pulpit in order to entertain, but to edify. He therefore preached without a trace of declamation, priestly unction, theatrical pathos—those artificial additives which, for many, are the essential thing in a sermon. One had to become accustomed to Sverdrup's preaching. The more one heard him, the more one wished to hear him. For he opened the Scriptures.

Nor did his strong side appear upon the platform. His occasional speeches were free of theatrics, even in tone, unforced, and weighty with thought. They flowed easily, and the right word was never lacking; but it was too much marked by earnestness to serve up colorful fireworks, sparkling witticisms, brilliant flashes of wit.

If, on the other hand, when it came to debating a matter where he had opposition, then one learned to know him from a new side. Here one saw him as the ready and fearless disputant, who struck his opponents quickly, hard, and surely. Nothing could throw him off balance. He mowed down one row of arguments after another, and that with such self-command and force of conviction that his opponents could stare at him in mute, helpless bitterness. The annual meeting of the United Church, which in the nineties was given over almost entirely to debate and business, more than once showed that Sverdrup had been endowed from the cradle with something that had a disturbing effect on some of those who occupied the seats of honor in the assembly. To end the connection with Sverdrup, all constitutional procedure was set aside.

Sverdrup's strongest side was the lectern, especially systematic theology. His other principal field was introductory Old Testament study and exegesis. Characteristic of his teaching in the Old Testament was his pragmatic presentation of the Lord's dealings with Israel's congregation, the gripping psychological portrayals of the Lord's chosen instruments, the people's pride, unbelief, chastisement, deliverance. In the Old Testament he was at home as few were, for he had penetrated into its spirit. A great deal of his work on the Old Testament survives, though it has never been printed. It would be a great loss if it were not included in the planned work. We mean especially his introduction and his commentary on the Psalms and the Prophets. Yet it was in systematic theology that Sverdrup, so to speak, took things by storm. For here he had use for his dialectic. It was especially with a view to his inspiring lectures in dogmatics that I wrote in an English paper in Philadelphia (1907) the following words—a small excerpt from a longer article:

His lectures captivated friend and foe alike by their brilliancy, force, and logic.... All was life, energy, enthusiasm when he was at the desk; his students were then all eye, all ear, exerting themselves to the utmost to get a verbatim report. Even the notes of his mediocre hearers are readable literature. His command of language

was wonderful. He had the happy faculty of saying things in such a way that they were not to be forgotten. Every lecture was an oration, natural and unstudied, full of vim and vigor, with a most happy interplay of color and rhythm. Every sentence seemed to bristle with suggestions, every utterance breathed the spirit of liberty and convincing calmness.

It is to be regretted that, during the three years when the theological professors of the United Church were at Augsburg, Prof. Sverdrup did not teach Dogmatics—and, we may add, Symbolics. In Dogmatics one would have received the best that Sverdrup had to offer, together with a scholarly grounding of the many doctrinal propositions that both he and the leading conservative-liberal Lutheran theologians in Europe accepted, but of which our local dogmatic theologians here partly knew little, and partly did not wish to know anything. In Symbolics one would have received a scholarly account of the ecclesiastical position he took.

If Sverdrup had taught Dogmatics and Symbolics in the years 1890–93, which he did both before and afterward, the historical divisions that came to light in the days of strife might perhaps have looked somewhat different. As matters stood, the opportunity for a scholarly academic discussion of systematic theology and for a historical treatment of the church's confessional symbols was cut off. And Sverdrup was too much of a scholar to find the whole of Lutheran Dogmatics in Job and Daniel. He held fast to 'the text.'

Owing to the unhappy church conflict in Norway, the word "scholarly" has acquired a bad sound in certain of our church circles. But just as there is much that passes itself off as Christianity which is not Christianity, so there is much that is called scholarship which is nothing of the kind. We have used the word in its proper sense. As secretary of the theological faculty at Augsburg in 1875, Sverdrup calls the faculty "the bearer of scholarship." "We strive to make ourselves organs of a reciprocal interaction between the congregation and scholarship, which we regard as a fundamental condition for an ecclesiastical development, and for which only the free church provides full scope." (Conf. Annual Report 1875, 63f.)

It is especially in systematic theology that this reciprocal interaction will bear ripe fruit. But the one who teaches this subject ought to know what the church is, and what scholarship is. Sverdrup knew the one as well as the other; but in the faculty there were those who taught what they had inherited from St. Louis and from Mt. Airy: the seventeenth century's elementary conception of congregation, and the eighteenth century's conception of scholarship, which was bound to lead to complications.

Sverdrup has been called a disciple of Gisle Johnson. But certainly unjustly. For the fact that a man hears a professor for some years does not of itself make him that professor's disciple. Sverdrup studied as long abroad as he did in Christiania, and his writings, so far as theology is concerned, bear witness far more to German influence than to Norwegian. Nor did he owe anything to Fr. Petersen, a man for whose eclectic theology Sverdrup had no esteem. The judgment that Bishop Bang passes on Petersen in his *Reminiscences* Sverdrup would no doubt have subscribed to as well. Neither did Sverdrup owe anything to Krogh-Tønning. Sverdrup's students know well enough how severely Krogh-Tønning was dealt with time and again in the old theological classroom at Augsburg. When others found Tønning's doctrine of the church in order—indeed, so good that it had to be crammed—Sverdrup repeatedly let

his students understand that Tønning was ready to go over to the Catholic Church, where he too eventually ended up.

In Symbolics Sverdrup was the same open-minded man as in Dogmatics. For him the point was to find what was historically warranted in the different branches of the church, not to go on crusade after “deviating doctrines.” It is characteristic that he branded chapters 4–13 in Graul’s Symbolics as “mere hairsplitting,” and referred the students, for a correspondingly concise but factual treatment of the sects, to Prof. Gumlich’s (d. 1902, Berlin) Symbolics.

Nor can it be said that Sverdrup was a disciple of Caspari. He tended rather toward the psychological school represented by Delitzsch and later carried on by Buhl.

If we are to connect Sverdrup’s name with any theological school, then our choice must fall upon the Erlangen school. In his view of history, Scripture, the Confession, theological method, and the church, Sverdrup was essentially an Erlangen theologian. So far from standing isolated in his ecclesiastical-theological position, he had the most excellent predecessors to support him: eminent theologians such as Harless, Höfling, Hofmann, Schöberlein, Thomasius, Delitzsch, Luthardt, Theodosius Harnack, Frank, Plitt, Beischwitz. Among his contemporaries, during whose time the Erlangen school entered a new heyday, may be named an authority in the history of the Old Covenant such as Köhler, a patristic scholar and New Testament exegete such as Zahn, church historians such as Hauck and Kolde, dogmaticians such as Seeberg and Ihmels.

It is characteristic of our circumstances that an Erlangen product such as Seeberg, in his well-known book, *From the Professor’s Chair to the Twentieth Century*, received a very laudatory review from Prof. Sverdrup (in *Folkebladet*), while it became the object of wholly different treatment in *Lutheraneren*, where a unionist such as Pastor Ole Nilsen and an anti-missionary such as Pastor Gjære occupied 40–50 columns in order to show that Prof. Seeberg was a false teacher—despite the fact that Norwegian orthodox theologians such as Prof. Odland and Provost Gustav Jensen had also given the book the warmest recommendations.

Erlangen theology came to Augsburg in the seventies. The attempt that was made in the nineties to exchange it for the seventeenth century’s restorationist theology failed.

Whether, or to what degree, Sverdrup worked creatively in theology shall not be decided here. We may concur with Bishop Bang when he says: “Over there [among us] one has not been able to cultivate theological scholarship for scholarship’s own sake.” And it is at any rate not too much to say when he adds: “One has indeed shown theological scholarship a serious labor in practical-ecclesiastical interest, and this has left fruits in the literature that are worthy of all honor.”

In the *Collected Writings* the weight has been laid upon the practical. This will become evident from what follows.

2.1 Volume I. Sketches and Essays

The first volume is by now so well known, at least by prospectus, that we need not list the titles of the various essays or treat the separate contents. About 300 pages in this volume

are reprinted from Kvartal-Skrift, which is now very difficult to obtain except at great cost. Many will welcome this reprint.

As typical of Sverdrup's treatment of the Old Testament narratives, where the point was edifying exposition, the essay "The Prophet Samuel" deserves special attention. Eli is presented as a priest utterly devoid of insight into spiritual things. Everything he did was wrong. The pious Hannah as she prayed he accused of being drunk, since he did not know the difference between the effects of wine and the effects of the Spirit. His house was undisciplined. The announcement of punishment from the Lord he listened to in an apparently pious resignation which in reality was helpless indifferentism. Prophets had to be raised up; the worship at the temple had been secularized.

The ethical essays on the sanctification of Sunday and on the public school also deserve attention, essays occasioned by the Synod's radical understanding of the day of rest and by its disparaging judgment upon the common school because it does not teach religion. Here too Sverdrup shows himself, as we knew him, a good American citizen, who defends a democratic institution—and an evangelical Christian, who upholds the free nature of religion. No doubt the German Missourians have their own elementary schools, but these schools stand far behind our common schools. Experience will prove Sverdrup right in this matter. The essay on Sunday ought to be read by the many among us who share the Reformed view of the Sabbath.

Of a practical-dogmatic kind, and important for understanding why Sverdrup had so little use for the Synod's "pure doctrine," is the third section of the book. The essay on "Justification by Faith and the Justification of the Teachers" is as instructive and as necessary for us now as it was thirty years ago. That Sverdrup spoke a timely word in these essays will appear from what Prof. Madsen at the University of Copenhagen writes (in Nielsen's Church Lexicon for the North) about the Bornholmers, and from Prof. Fr. Nielsen's article on the same subject in Herzog-Hauck's Protestant Realencyclopedia. From these articles one will also understand why the objective justification is still preached in various places among us. Those especially who preach this misleading doctrine are those who have inherited from Missouri, or who read Rosenius without criticism, unaware that he fell back into the doctrine that only unbelief condemns.

The third section is of a church-historical character. It contains, among other things, four essays still little known. One of them, "Criticism in History," has until now existed only in manuscript. Prof. Helland states that, to judge from the handwriting, it belongs to the very earliest years after Sverdrup's arrival in America. Both the title and the content are characteristic. Those who think that Sverdrup's discussion of criticism began in the nineties will here, if not elsewhere, see that they are mistaken.

Also rather unknown in our circles is the essay "The Norwegian Lutheran Church in America," which Sverdrup had written in French for the Lutheran church paper *Le Temoignage*, and and was then reprinted in translation in *Vestlandsposten* (1897).

Of distinctive interest is the sketch "The Lutheran Free Church." It was written in 1907 at the request of the Census Bureau in Washington, D.C. I concur with Prof. Helland's words: "It will have an increased interest from the fact that it is Prof. Sverdrup's last word on what,

according to his understanding, ‘criticism’ is and is to be. In that respect this little sketch may be said to constitute his testament.”

What we are most grateful for is “Memories from Norway,” a fragment of a manuscript composed during a stay in Norway in the summer of 1886. Here Sverdrup sketches a whole series of Norwegian churchmen from the revival movement. We value this highly, since Sverdrup seldom wrote characterizations of men of more recent times or told anything about them in class.

I cannot understand why the review in *Lutheraneren* says that “Memories from Norway” “is very unfinished, more nearly a rough draft, and could therefore best have been omitted from a book such as this.” In Norway it is precisely this piece to which attention has especially been drawn as interesting. Thus *Luthersk Kirketidende*, *Vor Kirke og Kultur* (Jens Gleditsch), *Morgenbladet* (Bishop Bang).

Let me be allowed to conclude these remarks on the first volume by citing a couple of statements from Norway. Pastor Lars Dahle says in *Norsk Missionstidende*: “Everything (in the first volume) bears the stamp of the author’s powerful, earnest, and logical personality.” Bishop Bang says: “On every page one will find more vivid and strong traces of the author’s warm personality and strong-willed energy.” Of the whole undertaking *Luthersk Kirketidende* says: “The Norwegian church people ought to support this. Prof. Sverdrup was too important a churchman and theologian that one ought to become acquainted with his work.” Bishop Bang recommends the work in the best terms.

2.2 Volume II. The Congregation

The second volume deals with the congregation. It contains 6 sections, or 25 pieces, 9 of which are unsigned editorial articles from Sverdrup’s pen. For local reasons, almost all these treatises and contributions were composed in a popular form; the presentation is always clear and transparent; but it lies in the nature of the matter that not a little requires labor on the reader’s part. Here too the rule applies: “To the one who has, more shall be given.” The one who comes to the book with questions will receive answers.

It is not our intention to enter into the individual articles. We shall mention most of them and attach remarks to such as seem to us to have a particular significance for the understanding of the ecclesiastical development among us.

2.2.1 First Section

1. “What Is at Stake?”, written as early as 1877, with reference to the controversy carried on between the Synod and the Conference, shows that even a whole generation before Sverdrup ended his labors, it was the congregation that was at issue: “Our definite conviction is this, that in this controversy it is the congregation that is at stake.”
2. “The Holiness of the Congregation” states clearly that the holiness of the congregation, and the question bound up with it, “What is a congregation?”, constitutes “the real main question in the Free Church.” It should be noted, first, that the article was written in 1889,

the year before the union, and many years before the Lutheran Free Church was formed; second, that Sverdrup was opposed to the “unsound views” for which Pastor Trandberg and his Reformed compatriots were spokesmen.

It is emphasized that there may be a congregation without organization or formal constitution; for the congregation in Jerusalem was not organized; further, that the empirical congregation is still truly a congregation, even though many of its members are hypocrites, dead, sleeping, unbelieving, and ungodly. Sverdrup’s position here—as it always was—is in agreement with Article 7 of the Augsburg Confession, which depicts the congregation according to its idea, true essence, its invisible-visible form—and with Article 8, which depicts the congregation according to its historical-empirical appearance, a mixture of hypocrites and evil men with the believers, who form the congregation’s real core.

3. “The Liberation of the Congregation,” 1896, points out that it was the new direction in the Conference that “held back,” so that “the congregation’s being kept in a state of dependency” did not proceed so rapidly, and that the old direction found staunch allies in the union, so that the United Church in the course of a few years left “all the other bodies far behind in ecclesiastical corporatism and tyranny over the congregations.” The author lays the blame for this partly upon the State Church upbringing. “Many times that which in the State Church was done by compulsion is here among us imitated by habit and custom. Custom among the people is a stronger power than the law for compelling men, and the old habits reign long after legal compulsion has ceased, especially when many zealous pastors labor with all their might to maintain the old habit and custom, that all shall belong to the congregation” (p. 19). Among other things, S. emphasizes the necessity of lay activity and points out that in the Norwegian State Church there is quite great freedom for lay activity because the law protects it, and that there was far greater freedom for lay activity there than in most “majority congregations.”

Distinctions of rank and class, and clerical pomposity, must go.

4. “The Quickening of the Congregation,” 1898, includes, among other things, substantial material on Luther’s understanding of church order.

2.2.2 Second Section

1. “Which Church Polity Is Most Fitting for the Evangelical Lutheran Church?”, 1869. This is perhaps the oldest literary contribution from Sverdrup’s hand that we now possess. It is interesting because it gives us an insight into what a theological student, 20 years old, could say about church polity. One will be astonished that Sverdrup at so young an age could grasp a question of church polity with such deep interest as this treatise bears witness to, and still more at the ability with which it is handled. As far as I can see, S. is here the spokesman for Rudelbach’s ideas, in that he pleads for consistories and synods, but disapproves of congregations of the independent type.

In our country Sverdrup was, from first to last, the defender of the independent congregations. In a free country, he held that the episcopal, the presbyterial, the consistorial polity that one had in the Lutheran lands of Europe stood far behind the congregational form of polity. The

Free Church was therefore built upon a congregationalist basis. That was something new—at any rate in the history of the Lutheran Church. In Europe too eyes have been opened to the superiority of the polity of a free congregation. None less than the clear-sighted and learned church historian Loofs at the University of Halle says: “Who knows whether the congregationalist church polity does not also have its future among us, when one day the State Churches in the old world collapse.”

2. “The Free Church Community,” 1877–78. This treatise, of 46 pages, I regard as the most important in the whole book. It falls into six subdivisions: The Congregation, The Local Congregation, The Office in the Free Congregation, The Pastoral Office and Lay Activity, The Diaconal Office in the Congregation, The Fellowship of the Congregations. Here we find answers to questions such as: how are we to found congregations? what does it mean “to compel them to come in”?

It is the Word, says S.—not outward compulsion or inducements or party spirit—that shall gather a congregation. “Even among the Norwegian emigrants, who indeed had all once been received into God’s Church through Baptism, it would have been far better if one had never organized any congregation or gathered congregational members in any other way or by any other means than by the preaching of God’s Word, publicly and privately. For even baptized persons are many a time, alas, in such a condition that it is better both for themselves and for the congregation that they ‘stand outside’ and are the object of the congregation’s influence in that way, than that they should be inside and perhaps there sleep the deepest sleep, precisely because they are ‘in the congregation.’”

After dwelling somewhat upon the all too hasty admissions into the congregation, and the dangers bound up with church discipline and exclusion, Sverdrup lays the weight upon this: that the congregation must be gathered by God’s Word, and that the constr

2.2.3 Third Section

The third section contains 6 pieces, 5 of which are editorial articles. We shall highlight the polemic against “Lutheraneren,” Chairman Homme, Dr. Schmidt — “The Old Church Order,” 1897-98 — so instructive in so many respects. Likewise: “Do You Want a Congregation?” in which Sverdrup crosses swords with T. N. S. Finally, “The Biblical Legitimacy of Our Congregations and the Relation of God’s Children to a Free-Church Congregation,” 1898, in which Pastor Müller-Eggen’s new concept of the congregation, sanctioned as it was by The United Church, receives its condemnation in black and white.

Here, then, that man is the critic, concerning whom the review column of “Lutheraneren” recently said: “As clear as Sverdrup’s view is when it concerns the invisible Church, so hazy does it become when there is question of the visible congregation and the relation between the two.”

We must ask: “Whose view was hazy? Was it Sverdrup’s or Müller-Eggen’s, or theirs who sanctioned Eggen’s concept of the congregation, including the clever comparison of visible congregations to barrels of salted meat?”

The fourth piece in this section, “Can One Minister to a Believer?” is an assessment of Pastor

Lundeberg's congregational program.

2.2.4 Fourth Section

The whole fourth section is devoted to lay activity. In one essay the memory of Hauge's calling as a preacher of repentance is celebrated. Another treats T. A. S.'s theory of evolution as applied to lay activity. A third discusses lay activity as it was treated in 1906 by "the great Joint Committee which is negotiating concerning the union of the church bodies."

2.2.5 Fifth Section

The fifth section, in three articles, treats infant baptism and confirmation.

2.2.6 Sixth Section

The sixth section contains lectures on congregational life, the condition for the formation of a congregation, the significance of mission for the congregation, and the unity of believers.

These lectures are, if one may so speak, somewhat abstract by comparison with the fuller contributions of earlier days. But it is always the same goal, the same principles, that are at issue.

We break off. From these scattered remarks one will perhaps gain some little idea of the abundance of material which the book presents. The work itself offers the best survey through the introductions and notes with which its editor, Professor Helland, has furnished the individual sections and articles.

In his excellent essay "On the Conditions for a Norwegian Theology" (1908), Olaf Moe, docent at the University of Christiania, writes: "Thus the chapter on the Church also becomes one of the weakest in our practical dogmatics. One understands easily that the Church is invisible, but one understands only poorly that it is also visible; one perhaps believes in the forgiveness of sins, but does not know that it is 'in this Christian congregation we receive a daily full forgiveness of sins.'" When a man such as Docent Moe can write thus — and who can deny that he has hit the mark? — it may be hoped that Sverdrup's book on the congregation will have its importance for the Norwegian churchfolk on both sides of the ocean. — The third volume, which will soon be published, will be discussed later.

2.3 Advertisements included in the book

The first three volumes of Professor Georg Sverdrup's Selected Writings have been published

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3 Guidance

3.1 Concepts of Church Fellowship and the Union in 1890

Editorial article in “Folkebladet” for September 20, 1893.

We shall dwell here upon those misunderstandings—intentional or unintentional—of the concept “church fellowship,” which among some within the United Church have been set in circulation and threaten to gain accepted standing.

A couple of statements in recent times serve to cast a sharp light upon these congregation-endangering notions. In an issue of “Kirkebladet” there was recently—indeed by stealth—smuggled in the remark that Augsburg was a “private” opposition school.

In “Samfundet” No. 2 it is said of Prof. Oftedal—and it must be applied also to Prof. Sverdrup—that he “until quite recently served as a theological professor.”

Such a mode of expression—apart from the childish insult intended in it—rests upon the view that when Augsburg is no longer the seminary of the United Church, then it is a private institution, and that when Professors Sverdrup (and Oftedal) have resigned as theological professors in the United Church, then they are no longer theological professors at all, however much they continue at Augsburg, as they have now been doing for nearly twenty and seventeen years respectively, before anyone had yet heard mention of the United Church.

Such naïve statements and notions spring again not only from that notion of the significance of the United Church, exaggerated beyond all reason, which the majority’s pastors have set in circulation, but essentially, and in the last instance, from an altogether Catholicizing and anti-congregational concept of church fellowship, which the pastors of the old or synodical tendency with all diligence cultivate and exploit—when it can serve their advantage and strengthen their power over the congregation.

For they regard the “association” as a higher form of the congregation, and especially their own fellowship as the real manifestation of the one Church, make it identical with “the Church,” and regard everything outside it as sectarianism.

But is the fellowship such a most holy thing, that the congregation in it as it were disappears, and is handed over into the control of the association?

No, by no means.

Not even the practical carrying out of this by deciding, at the command of a few men, upon the erection of a new and thereby necessarily oppositional seminary, without asking a single congregation for counsel, does not change the matter in the least.

A church fellowship under our free conditions is nothing other than a free mutual agreement between a greater or lesser number of congregations—the number makes no difference to the matter—to work together in certain common undertakings, as for example a seminary, mission, the publishing of religious books, etc., where either an individual congregation is unable to do so on its own, or where the union of common forces will bring each congregation a proportionately greater benefit. Such a union of congregations for mutual support and

help is therefore not any larger congregation or a higher form of the congregation; for the Church's basic unit is and remains, according to God's Word, the congregation alone, and no church fellowship, not even the Catholic Church, has, without vigorous contradiction from others, been able to arrogate to itself the right to be regarded as "the Church."

Such a Catholicizing concept of a church fellowship therefore cannot be continued or put into practice without the greatest damage to the congregation's independence and Christian liberty, and will, since it has only the purpose of advancing the corporate interests of the clergy and gradually bringing forth the office of bishop, unavoidably press the individual congregation and its spiritual need more and more aside, and let our Norwegian Lutheran Church gradually sink back into the Norwegian Synod's state-churchliness and dead orthodoxy.

Since therefore the joining together of congregations in a fellowship is essentially a practical arrangement for pooling spiritual resources and saving means, it is likewise not such a most holy institution, into which it is easy to come, but which a congregation cannot leave without making itself guilty of schism, sundering, and sin. If a congregation by free decision enters into a fellowship in the hope of finding there spiritual help and mutual edification, and it finds itself disappointed in this expectation, then it is its incontestable right, which no clergy under papal overreach can obstruct, to withdraw from such a fellowship-connection whenever it judges this to be expedient. And although every congregation both ought and will use caution in the exercise of this right and not in all things look only to its own advantage, but also to the advantage of its fellow congregations, still it becomes a downright step toward Catholicism when a clergy, bound together by artificial means, in any way seeks to arrogate to itself authority to hinder a free Lutheran congregation in this inviolable right to join itself to whatever Lutheran fellowship-connection it finds good.

When now the majority in the United Church, through its leaders, claims such extraordinary importance for its church body, that a seminary incorporated for nearly twenty-five years at once becomes a "private" opposition school as soon as the said leaders, in breach of faith and honor, break their—moreover only half-committed—connection with it, or that its professors cease to be professors when they no longer desire to stand in connection with such leaders, then this is all the more absurd and ludicrous in this case, since the congregations of the United Church have not yet formed any completed fellowship-connection.

In 1890 it made the first essential step toward a full union by choosing a common governing body and adopting a common seminary and common mission work for the congregations and fellowships participating in the work of union; but since other significant conditions were attached to this union, and these have not been fulfilled, and since one of the stipulations, namely concerning a "common seminary," has even by the said leaders of the majority directly and without right been broken without consultation with the congregations, then it ought to be evident to everyone who has not become crazed by the majority that no union in the full sense of the word has yet come into being, and that every congregation is free, and every one of the three contracting parties as well, on account of the majority's breach of contract, to withdraw from the work of union at this stage without either causing division or withdrawing. For if it is the congregation's indisputable right to withdraw even from older fellowships, when its welfare requires it, then obviously there can be no question either of schism or of withdrawal where not even any full fellowship-connection has been brought into being. In

that case there can only be question of drawing back until a more satisfactory form of union might possibly become the subject of negotiation.

It is therefore clearly high time that the majority leaders tone down their lofty language about the extraordinary importance of that fellowship which the work of union aimed to bring about. The United Church is not identical with the United States, nor with the Church itself. It has only a single, fully corporate legal existence, and that not by virtue of its organization under the law of the congregation or of the Body of Christ, but simply by virtue of its incorporation under the civil law, and even that of a doubtful sort. It thus has the same significance as every other incorporated institution and thereby has—formally—received the right, of which it also has made ample use, namely to initiate legal proceedings. This right any three persons or three congregations whatsoever can acquire by being incorporated under the laws of the state, and is therefore not something over which to exalt oneself so extravagantly.

A measure of sobriety in the concept of fellowship, and modesty in self-assessment, one may demand even of old church fellowships and schools with a fairly fruitful past; the lack of these becomes then not only unchristian, but downright ludicrous in a fellowship which after two years of cooperation has still not attained full union, or in a seminary scarcely more than a few days old.

Sven Oftedal

3.2 On Inner Mission

"Folkebladet," November 22, 1893.

Our starting point is this: that Inner Mission is simply the proclamation of the Word and the administration of the Sacraments for the founding and upbuilding of congregations in places where the people are either too poor or too indifferent to support the church's work themselves. We do not regard mission work primarily as an expansion of the Association, but as the forming of new Lutheran congregations. We do not regard the mission contributions as ordinary expenses of the Association, which is why they are not paid out of the Association's treasury either. We do not regard the mission gifts as an instrument of power in the hands of a mere majority, so that it may use these holy gifts according to the majority's whim. We do not regard the mission committee either as a part of the governing board of the Association or as an independent mission board, but as a servant intermediary between the congregations that give and the congregations that receive help. We therefore believe that faithfulness to the Association in mission matters is the greatest possible zeal for the salvation of souls, for the upbuilding of Lutheran congregations, for the diligent proclamation of the Word, and for the right administration of the Sacraments.

It might therefore very well be an act of great faithfulness in mission work even if we were to help a congregation belonging to Hauge's Synod or to the Norwegian Synod in a place where it was truly needed. The more genuine Lutheran impartiality can be shown in Inner Mission, the better for our people, for our church, and for the Association. . . .

The minority's mission committee asks no other question of those it supports than this: Is

there need, and has help been denied by the majority? Whether the congregations we support are willing to promise aid to Augsburg or not, we have not asked them. We know that the proclamation of the Word among them would suffer a corresponding curtailment if we did not help them; therefore we help as far as we can.

Georg Sverdrup.

3.3 Are the Pastors the "Society's" Servants?

"Folkebladet" for March 7, 1894.

By "the society" I mean here the organized church society which at its annual meetings decides its common affairs by majority vote.

I see that people have now furthermore begun to call the pastors "the society's servants," just as in earlier times these were called "the Lord's servants," "the Word's servants," "the congregation's servants." People speak of their "standing in the service of the United Church," so long as they are proclaimers of the Gospel in congregations which belong to this society.

This manner of speech, of which there are more and more examples at least within our society, may naturally be innocent enough, if it rests upon thoughtlessness or verbal ineptitude; but it may also have arisen from a conception of the pastor's office that is both distorted and dangerous.

That the pastor is the Lord's servant expresses his independence of men and his responsibility before God; that the pastor is the congregation's servant expresses his self-sacrificing labor and suffering for those for whom Christ labored and suffered. Both names are so well grounded in the Word of God and so well understood among all spiritual people that it is surely superfluous to explain them to Christians; and those who would misunderstand these titles of honor would also misunderstand our explanation of them.

It is otherwise, however, with the modern expression: "the society's servants" and "pastors who stand in the society's service." These expressions are wholly foreign to Scripture and therefore also foreign to the way of thinking of spiritual people.

It is therefore not superfluous to ask what is meant by these expressions, and with what intention they are used so frequently.

If by "the society's servants" one meant such persons as seek the society's good and with the sacrifice of time and strength labor for it, men who set the society's best above the favor of the society's majority, then it might do well enough to call the pastors the society's servants. In that sense Paul says that he has become the servant of all; at the same time he powerfully asserts his independence of all, and rebukes it as a sin if anyone seeks to please men by surrendering anything of the truth.

But if something else is meant by it, namely that the pastors are the organs, tools, and agents of a higher power within the congregations, then this designation begins to become dangerous and dubious.

Then the question at once arises: Is the society a governing authority over the congregations? Is the society a higher power over the congregations? And is it really this higher power whose servants the pastors are, so that, if things went as they ought, the society should rather send its servants to the congregations, and not the congregations choose their pastors?

But by that we have entered into a way of thinking far from being according to Christ, and very well fitted to lower the pastors and deprive them of their proper standing and dignity.

For a servant does not know what his master does, and has nothing to do with asking after it. A servant in this sense is one who, when his master says, "Go," goes, and when he says, "Come," comes. He does not ask why, and does not reflect upon it; obedience is his duty, and he shows it without more ado. If such a servant thinks that what is demanded of him is unreasonable, then he can leave the service; therein consists his freedom.

If now the pastors in this sense are the society's servants, that is, if it is their duty without more ado to carry out the majority's decisions and persuade their congregations to accept them, then it is accordingly also the pastors' duty to leave the society if they are not in every respect agreed with the majority's plans. If some pastor finds that the society has acted badly and unjustly, then it is not right for him to remind, admonish, rebuke, and convince the society; he is, after all, a servant. Nor is it right for him to remain in the society's service; there is for him only one single way out, namely, to leave the society.

But if one really wishes to proceed according to this view, which now seems to be asserting itself both in the matter of Inner Mission and in other ways, then one of two things must happen: either the society will become smaller and smaller, as every opposition is continually driven out; or else the pastors will become men without conviction and conscience. And the more compliant a majority finds the pastors, the more matters it draws under its decision, until at last there is no ecclesiastical question left which is not decided by majority vote.

The pastors ought to be the Lord's servants and fearless witnesses to the truth. Before any others their voice ought to be lifted up like a trumpet to declare to the individual and to the society their sins.

And the society, so far from seeking to dampen and stifle this voice either by money or by other means, ought, on the contrary, to receive with the greatest gratitude the pastor who succeeded in rebuking and correcting a fault.

The society is best served by the most self-reliant and independent servants of the Lord, who dare to say of evil that it is evil, even when they must stand like a wall of bronze and a pillar of iron against Judah's kings and priests and princes and against the people of the land. But such men cannot bend their conviction concerning right and wrong according to the decision of a chance majority.

Georg Sverdrup

3.4 Open Letter to Augsburg's Friends

"Folkebladet," August 8, 1894.

Dear Friends!

The condition of our Church is now such that it requires of all earnest Christians both thorough deliberation, urgent intercessory prayer, and vigorous labor. There is indeed inward complacency and outward distress in every direction. The conflict which at first seemed to concern only a mere trifle stretches ever farther and breaks out, one may almost say, in every sphere of church life. In such times, what matters is that each individual Christian, man and woman alike, both seeks to find the way amid the confusion and walks in it with faith and courage.

In the United Church the situation is such that it carries on its work in two divisions. The majority has brought about a split in the seminary and in the mission, so that it has become altogether unavoidable that within this body duplicate work must now be undertaken, at least in these matters.

Now the majority has held its meeting in St. Paul. In spite of every attempt on the part of the minority to secure an amicable and Christian settlement of all that separates and divides, it has refused and rejected the hand that the minority had extended toward full reconciliation. Thereby the minority is compelled to continue the churchly work which must be done, and which the majority is unwilling to carry out. It rests upon us as a holy responsibility to sustain Augsburg Seminary in its old spirit and direction, to preserve the work of Inner Mission where the majority withdraws its support, and above all to uphold the congregation's precious rights both in the calling of pastors and in its own independence and self-government in all internal affairs.

The minority is therefore obliged to come together; and now, since the invitation to the minority meeting has been issued by Augsburg's Board of Trustees and the minority's association committee, it is desirable that all Augsburg's friends set to work to make the meeting in October as numerous, vigorous, and influential as possible. It is true of all work that if it is worth doing, it is worth doing well; all the more is this true of all churchly work.

We need to come together for prayer meetings, so that with united sorrow and sighing we may come before the Lord and pray for grace upon us and for blessing upon our Church.

We need to come together for a friends' meeting, so that we may join hearts and hands, that we may be strengthened in the work and in the struggle, and together consider what is the right way to advance the great cause of our Church's future amid the disordered circumstances of our time.

We need to come together to determine the most suitable form for the work, and whether it is best to endure all the suffering and offense that fall to our lot in the United Church. And whichever course the friends judge to be best, we must adopt such measures that, so far as it lies with us, our part of the churchly work may thrive and bear fruit to God's glory and for the good of our people in time and in eternity.

It is the future of our Church that is at stake. The right resolution of the free-church issues is the responsibility before us. Proper congregational pastoral education, the self-government of the congregations, and the pastors' freedom of conscience must be secured and upheld fully and completely before we attain to "Free Congregation in a Free Church."

Moreover, friends, it is not written in vain that "the stone which the builders rejected has become the chief cornerstone!"

This address to the friends has been written at the earnest request of several brethren. May the Lord prosper the work of our hands and grant us a numerous and blessed meeting.

In brotherly love,

Yours in fellowship,

Georg Sverdrup

3.5 The Program of the Minority

Adopted at the Meeting in Minneapolis in October, 1894.

Preamble: The Minority organized for action desires only to carry on a vigorous work, so that the tasks which the United Church has set itself in the Articles of Union and the Constitution may be carried into practice, maintaining that the United Church is an association of congregations organized in order to give congregational freedom the greatest possible development among us.

Point 1. The principal purpose of this organization is to maintain Augsburg Seminary, which we still regard, according to the Articles of Union, as rightfully the ministerial school of the United Church; and by Augsburg Seminary we mean first and foremost the principle of ministerial training which is followed there, and which we believe works for the good of our church body and of our congregations.

Point 2. With regard to Inner Mission, we regard it as the only right course that it be carried on impartially, and that pastors' and congregations' viewpoint in matters concerning the church body shall not influence the distribution of mission contributions from the mission treasury of the church body. We regard it as all the more our duty to defend in every lawful way the right of pastors and congregations to hold their own independent convictions.

Point 3. We believe that foreign mission among non-Christians is one of the chief purposes of the Christian congregation, no less pressing than any other churchly task at home in Christendom, and that it is therefore a holy duty to use all means and gifts for the spread of God's Kingdom among non-Christians, and not to lend out mission funds in such a manner as has been done, instead of applying them for their designated purpose.

Point 4. We hold fast the congregations' right of call as free and unhindered by interference from the church body or its officers. The church body shall help the congregation secure the greatest possible freedom in the calling of a pastor, not seek to introduce a system of clerical preferment for pastors. To set up new conditions for ordination in the interests of a party we regard as an altogether improper intervention in the congregation's freedom and right of call; and we also regret that congregations delegate their calling of a pastor either to the president of the church body or to some committee outside their own midst. Recommending unworthy persons for a congregational call is a violation of the holiest obligations that rest upon the church body and its officers.

Point 5. We regard a vigorous and spiritual lay activity, and the full use of all spiritual gifts in the congregation, as an incalculable good for the awakening and nurture of Christian life; and this activity must be fostered among us by living revival preaching and by a quickening of heartfelt love for sinners' salvation and blessedness.

Point 6. We believe that the controversy within the church body ought to be settled, and for this purpose we regard it as indispensably necessary that there be an amicable settlement through brotherly discussions.

Point 7. That the church body sets itself up as judge of sin and attempts to bind consciences by its laws and resolutions, we regard as a dangerous and questionable course, which will easily lead into deviations in a Romanizing direction.

Point 8. In general we maintain that the church body is not an ecclesiastical authority over the congregations, such that it can require obedience and submission from them, but only an organ or means by which the congregations carry out certain definite tasks which they are individually too weak to carry out properly, such as maintaining a seminary, conducting Inner Mission and outer mission, and so forth. We therefore regard it as wrong to press congregations into joining together or to split congregations for the sake of church-body controversies and church politics.

3.6 Augsburg and the Minority

"Folkebladet," July 25, 1894

"... After a brief consultation with some of Augsburg's supporters, who gathered in the hall that evening, and in which it was unanimously declared that, in whatever was yielded, Augsburg's principle regarding congregational life and pastoral training must not be relinquished, I traveled to St. Paul the following day, praying that God would guide matters so that they might serve his church for blessing and growth. I was determined to sacrifice everything, even myself, in order to bring about understanding and sincere cooperation between the majority and the minority—but principles could not be given up, nor the cause to which we have committed ourselves for these twenty years.

.....

I was present during the annual meeting's consideration of this matter. Not only the voting, but still more the statements made on that occasion, convinced me that there exists—notwithstanding the personal bitternesses and plans of revenge introduced by the old party—a deep gulf of principle between the majority and the minority, or Augsburg's supporters, precisely in the question of pastoral training and the inseparable questions of the ministry and the congregation, a gulf which I now clearly see cannot be smoothed out and overcome except by persistent and patient labor, in order by way of development, with God's help, to make the free-congregation idea work like leaven within the majority.

That the minority's two theological professors would be forced out if the majority gained control may surely be regarded as self-evident. Of the three theological professors at the majority's school, Prof. Schmidt is opposed to the Augsburg principle; Prof. Lund scarcely

seems to have any principle in this matter except that of the General Council, and that is very far from Augsburg's. Thus only Bøckman remains, who, even if he had been in agreement with Augsburg's educational principle in more than a merely formal respect, was plainly not in a position, with the two men named at his side, to carry through that principle of pastoral training, and that understanding of the congregation, which has hitherto been the prevailing one at Augsburg."

Great changes must surely take place in the majority before there can again be any question of negotiations for transfer. There will first have to be serious, conscientious, perhaps hard-fought negotiations about the principle, so that the same error which Prof. Bøckman admitted the Conference had negligently committed in Scandinavia may not be repeated.

In other words, a more solid, more dependable, and above all more spiritual, more unequivocal basis in keeping with the free-congregation principle will be required if the majority and the minority are to come into true organic union and cooperation with one another.

It is the principles that must now be tried and fought through, until the truth is vindicated in our American Free Church.

Sven Oftedal

3.7 Ordination Refusal and the Constitution of the United Church

Editorial article in "Folkebladet" for January 16, 1895.

The Constitution of the United Church is, both in form and in content, a contract or agreement between Lutheran congregations. It is not intended to set an authority over the congregations; rather, it binds a number of congregations together for specific purposes, thereby giving those congregations greater power and capacity to carry out those tasks that may be too heavy for a single congregation. Among such tasks are the training of pastors, home mission, the distribution of the Bible, and mission to the heathen.

In our Constitution, the ordination of pastors is likewise made a matter for the association, and of course for the same reason as the other matters that belong among the tasks of the association. It is only because it is expedient, not because it is necessary. That is the whole reason and the only reason. It is not assigned to the association because the congregation does not have the right to do it itself, but because there are certain advantages, both for the congregations and for the pastors, in several congregations working together in that matter.

The fact that something is listed in the Constitution as a matter for the association does not make it sinful for a congregation to deal with it. It is not even certain that disorder results if a congregation takes it up. A single example will show this at once: home mission is a matter of the association, and the Constitution treats it as such when it includes among the purposes of the association "to gather and organize Lutheran congregations." In that there lies no prohibition against a single congregation with its pastor carrying on home mission and "gathering and organizing" another Lutheran congregation in its immediate vicinity or farther away. This example makes it perfectly clear that it is by no means the intention that the work of the association should exclude, hinder, or forbid the work of the congregations individually;

that a matter is set forth as a matter of the association does not hinder a congregation from dealing with the same matter. On the contrary, the association can do only what it does because the congregation has the right and duty according to the Word of God to do it.

So also with ordination. It is an act that each congregation can perform for itself with respect to its chosen pastor. No association is needed for that. When, then, our Constitution names ordination as a matter of the association, that is only for expediency's sake. For when several congregations cooperate in this matter, that means that the man whom the one congregation has chosen as its pastor is acknowledged as a Lutheran pastor also by several other congregations. He will be regarded by them all as a servant of the Lord, and the inquiry that properly precedes ordination therefore need not be repeated if another congregation calls him as pastor, just as the ordination itself need not be repeated.

This is a practical and sensible way to arrange matters; but it does not alter the matter itself: ordination is a congregational act, which is carried out by several congregations in common only for reasons of expediency.

From this it follows necessarily that ordination is not such a matter in which the association is lord over the congregations and their right to call a pastor; rather, it is only a matter in which the association serves the congregations.

Our Constitution is far from perfect; yet with good will one could well make use of it without trampling down the little shoot of congregational freedom that had begun, as it were, to appear in the period of union. But when some factional pastors seek to misuse the Constitution in order to abolish congregational freedom, it will be found that he who sows the wind reaps the whirlwind, as is just and fair.

Georg Sverdrup

3.8 The Congregations' Right to Call and the Refusals of Ordination

“Folkebladet,” February 6, 1895.

To deprive the congregations of their right to call is so old an offense within the Church that it is no wonder if it returns again whenever there is occasion.

For there is a tendency, which is in the blood of us all, that the freedom of others is hard to endure, if in any way it restricts our own and runs counter to our personal advantage.

If a tightly knit, carnal clergy could arrange matters so that congregations were simply bundled into pastoral charges, and those calls were lucrative, and then the pastors could divide them among themselves, without these wronged congregations having anything to do with the matter, is there any doubt that all carnal pastors would find such an arrangement exceedingly good?

And since there are always many purely carnal pastors, and since no pastor is pure spirit and therefore has temptations to lord it over the Lord's heritage, it is continually necessary that

the congregations be on their guard, lest they lose the beautiful jewel of liberty and become a livelihood for those who desire to divide the offices among themselves.

Where pastors have become generally deadened in their whole understanding of the congregation and of their position in it, this will make itself known in various ways. Secret pastoral conferences will be formed and maintained, where clerical corporate interests can be advanced; secret pastoral conferences have never been anything else, nor can they become it.

Next, the various attempts will be made to dictate to the congregations which pastor they are to have and not have. If it is a mission congregation, it is advised to surrender the right to call to the mission committee; if it is a more independent congregation, then it is to “apply to the chairman” and get his advice. If the congregation in particular wishes to have a man with whom the secret council is not pleased, then it is said: “No, he is not to be had; there is no use in calling him.” In short, there are many crooked ways by which the congregations’ free right to call is placed in danger once a carnal mind and machine politics first creep into the Church.

In the United Church we see things clearly enough. On the one side there are the “appointments”; on the other side there are the “refusals of ordination.” Both are the fruit of the same bitter root.

There is more than one mission congregation which has been advised to surrender its right to call to the mission committee, and more than one congregation has followed that advice and had its pastor assigned for it. In the “Luth. Kirkeblad” we even find the following from a congregation in the far West:

Likewise we thank the mission committee for its work in supplying and supervising mission pastors, and with prayer that they will as soon as possible send us a pastor again.” (“L. K.” 1895, p. 26.)

Yes, that is the way it goes. State-church order and state-church decrees are smuggled in upon the congregations straight against God’s Word and the freedom and right of the congregations.

Likewise with the refusals of ordination; first people are made to imagine that ordination is a clerical affair or an episcopal act, and then ordination is denied on purely church-political grounds, and then the congregations are to discover that they have come into a predicament from which they cannot get out.

It is first an affront to the congregations’ understanding of God’s Word and Christian order. For where congregations are even somewhat enlightened, they no longer have the Catholic superstition that ordination is an act of the assembled clergy, but rather a Christian act which can be carried out by any Christian congregation, just as the whole Lutheran Church unanimously confesses in the Smalcald Articles, where we read the following words, which may also have their application to our own circumstances with suitable changes.

“But since by divine right there is now no difference between bishops, pastors, or priests, it is beyond all doubt that when a pastor in his congregation ordains capable persons to church offices, then that ordination is effective by divine right.

Therefore, when the bishops persecute the Gospel and refuse to ordain capable men, then in such a case every congregation has full right and warrant to ordain its own ministers. For where the Church is, there is also the command to preach the Gospel. Therefore the congregations must retain the power to call, choose, and ordain church servants.”

So free-minded the Lutheran Church once was; but now men will have the right to “refuse to ordain capable men,” and those who ordain them will be branded as rebels and lawbreakers. First they will make people superstitious, and then use superstition as a bond upon the congregations, so that they shall not dare to exercise their right to call for fear of not getting their called pastor ordained.

Such abuse goes on for a time, especially among dead and sleeping people. We know, however, that it is dangerous work to build church bodies upon ignorance, superstition, and bondage. The United Church will discover that it harms itself by failing to take a clear and straightforward stand on the principle of free-church congregational liberty and fully respecting the congregations’ right to call.

Georg Sverdrup

3.9 Lutherdom and Church Polity

Editorial article in “Folkebladet” for September 30, 1896.

It is a matter which ought to be known by all Lutherans, that the Lutheran Church, on account of its unhappy connection with the State, did not succeed in carrying through its principles with respect to church polity.

The principles may nevertheless be just as sound and good, even if one did not have the courage and strength to carry them through. It is therefore not out of place now, when The United Church has taken so decided a stand for institutional church power and against congregational freedom, to look a little at the Lutheran principles in this matter.

For it is by no means altogether indifferent whether, in matters of church polity, we move onto Catholic ground or remain on Lutheran ground. For it is certain enough that, if once one slides over in the question of the Church and the ecclesial congregation into Catholic ways of thinking, one will soon be compelled to follow after in all other things.

The main question for the Lutheran Church in the sphere of polity is a twofold one: on the one side it concerns preserving freedom of church conviction, and on the other side not losing ecclesial unity.

For the Lutheran Church is from the beginning an opposition party, or a minority. So exceedingly small was this minority, that it was one man against the whole Roman Church. And this one man therefore maintained that he alone had the same right to hold his conviction as the whole external Church together with all its bishops, popes, priests, and councils. And that, when the question was to be decided whether he had the truth on his side or the Church had the truth, then the Church was not judge in its own cause, but only the Word of God

was the highest authority, the only authority to which both sides were unconditionally bound to submit.

It is this mighty declaration of freedom which is, of course, just as intolerable to the fleshly Church now as then. This is the great protest of free conviction against the tyranny of society or Church. For the sake of this cause martyrs suffered death by the thousands at the stake and on the scaffold.

This, then, is a first principle in the Lutheran Church: the right of the individual believer and of the individual congregation to maintain their Christian conviction of conscience unimpaired by the power of the Church and its authorities. If this is a sinful principle of revolt, then of course all Lutheranism is condemned; for in the beginning it had the whole so-called Christian Church against it. It had only the Word of God and the Spirit of God on its side.

But the Lutheran Church does not regard it as indifferent whether Christian people and Christian congregations go their separate ways, in disagreement with one another or not. It does not abolish unity for freedom's sake, just as little as it abolishes freedom for unity's sake. Accordingly, just as Lutherans maintain that one man with the Gospel on his side has an unconditional right to stand against the whole Church with all its authorities, when they depart from the Gospel, at the same time they also maintain that the preaching of the Gospel—one, whole, and unadulterated—must be found in all congregations and be the common bond which binds them together.

Here we have the two principles which in all work of church polity within the Lutheran Church must be inviolably maintained: the freedom to hold personal conviction on the one side, unity in the confession of the Gospel on the other side.

A Lutheran Free Church must therefore set aside all state-church distortions of the congregation's essential nature and outward form; and, in order to be faithful and have firm ground beneath its feet, it is compelled to go all the way back to the New Testament and follow the congregation's pattern there.

And in the New Testament we find a congregational form of church government which precisely joins together the two things that for the Lutheran Church are the overwhelmingly central concern: freedom to hold personal conviction and unity in the confession of the Gospel. The congregations have no outward or human authority over them; but inwardly within the congregation, and outwardly among the congregations, they preserve the unity of the Spirit without any higher governing authority on earth.

Must not we begin on the same way, when we see how altogether impossible it is for our church bodies, with their annual meetings and officials, to preserve the freedom which nevertheless is the very lifebreath of Christianity and the Christian Church?

Georg Sverdrup

3.10 The Free Church and the Congregation

Editorial article in "Folkebladet" for December 16, 1896.

Everyone knows that the new movement and *Folkebladet* labored with power and earnestness for the cause of union; and we are now reproached because we are not so zealous for the product of the union, the United Church, as we formerly were for the cause of union.

To this we must answer: just as surely as it is true that the union would have been impossible and inconceivable without the diligent labor of the new movement and of Augsburg for catechism instruction and the congregation, or what is the same thing, for peace and freedom, just so surely is it also true that we have been deceived and disappointed in our expectations. According to the principles laid down in its constitution, the United Church was to have been the body of congregational freedom; in practice it became the exact opposite. The United Church has not once, but time after time, broken its constitution, both in spirit and in letter, precisely at this essential point.

Hence there is now a new struggle all along the line for the congregation and its freedom. And because this cause is altogether firmly and clearly grounded in God's Word, we are not in the least degree in doubt either about its legitimacy or about its outcome. We know that it will require much suffering; we know also that it may take a long time and pass through many apparent defeats; but for all that it stands no less firm that the cause is good and worth suffering and contending for. The little weak beginning that has already taken place also shows signs of having such vitality in it that it is not altogether strange, after all, if they try to crush it by litigation and other acts of destruction.

And when it is now also subtly hinted that "Augsburg's Friends" are not even satisfied with the work of "the Conference," but want something freer and better, then we answer that it was, after all, the intention of the new constitution of the United Church that it should become a freer and better body than the Conference. For that reason, on our side, we had nothing against the fact that the other bodies were unwilling to enter the Conference; but they insisted absolutely that a new body should be formed with a new constitution more in agreement with the principles of the new movement than the constitution of the Conference; and when, then, a new body was formed with a new constitution more in agreement with the principles of the new movement than the constitution of the Conference, and when we were allowed to remain in this new body because we stood firm on the principle of the congregation, then one can hardly expect of us that we should now take a step backward, when all along we have worked for progress in the interest of congregational freedom.

And if we believe that we can learn something little by little and can follow the light of divine guidance, so that we can now see a little more clearly into the true nature of free-church work than before, then it is surely not so great a fault to try to correct one's errors and to do it better little by little.

If one would then ask how matters stand with the congregation in the Free Church, then our answer is this: exactly and altogether as God's Word in the New Testament sets forth the congregation and its position. We intend, altogether definitely and quite unsparingly, to conform ourselves to the Word; that is the only authority to which a Lutheran Free Church can bow.

The first thing that then comes forth—as the scriptural principle for the relation between congregation and church body—is this: the congregation is the original, and the church body

the derivative; the congregation is the proper, true, apostolic, and free form of God's kingdom on earth in the time from the outpouring of the Spirit until Christ's coming; all outward bodies or churches or institutions or associations or societies have, according to God's Word, only their justification as serving organs for the congregation, not as ruling and commanding authorities.

This principle is the first and most far-reaching of all rules for church polity. The individual local congregation has God's Word over it, has Jesus Christ as Head and Lord, has God's Spirit as its Guide; but it has no other authority over it, and it has no right to give away or lend out its Christian freedom to any other. It can, of course, do so, but it is not biblical or Christian to do so; therefore neither is it without responsibility before God to do so. According to God's Word the congregation is free, but not so free that it can give away that freedom without becoming guilty and suffering harm.

It is altogether clear that the New Testament requires that Christians should not only have an inward fellowship of the Spirit with one another, but that they should also form outward, organized congregations with their officers and their rules. We would depart from the altogether clear requirement of God's Word if we tried to be so spiritual that we would have no outward congregation. The outward congregation belongs to apostolic and biblical Christianity. And the many who will not belong to any outward congregation because it is not spiritual enough for them—their Christianity suffers from a sorrowful deficiency and frailty, though it is far from us to mean that such frail Christians are not Christians at all.

On the other hand, the same does not apply to what is called a church fellowship. Everyone who knows a little about Christianity knows that the Christian congregations have spiritual fellowship with one another, and we shall later try to elucidate that matter more fully; but God's Word shows us no outward, organized church body over or under or outside the local congregation that should be any necessity for the believers or for the congregations. According to Scripture we must have outward congregations and congregational officebearers; we are not, on the other hand, required to have church bodies and offices of the church body and officers of the church body. The congregations can form bodies or refrain from forming bodies, and yet be equally Christian.

The very first fundamental principle of the Free Church for church polity is therefore this: that the Christian Church consists of free, independent, and self-governing congregations. The local Christian congregation has an independent authority that applies to itself alone. It owes obedience to no other congregation, nor does it have the right to rule over any other congregation. And what in this matter applies to a single congregation applies to every single one of them and to them all together. Among one hundred congregations one congregation cannot rule; neither can the ninety-nine rule over the one.

So teaches Scripture. We do well to emphasize it sharply and hold it firmly and immovably. Therefore, if there is anyone who is eager to labor in the Free Church, let him begin with the congregation. In this matter it is Alpha and Omega. And since there is so much lacking in our state-church congregations as to what they ought to be, there is at once, and immediately, room for all the work we can do in this one thing: the liberation of the congregation.

Georg Sverdrup

3.11 Visible Congregation

Editorial article in “Folkebladet” for January 20, 1897.

In Free Church work the congregation is of such surpassing importance that we cannot labor enough for it to be acknowledged in its truth according to God’s Word.

In the New Testament such high and glorious words are spoken concerning the congregation that many have given it up in despair and have sought to escape the holy demand by teaching that all the great and glorious things are said of an invisible congregation. But what we ordinarily have under the name of congregation, that is only the visible congregation, and that is quite another matter.

But what if according to the New Testament it were the same matter?

It is not uncommon in our cities to see a number of members of the congregation—belonging to Norwegian Lutheran congregations—go drunken, reeling with brandy, from saloon to saloon; such, then, are taken for the ‘visible’ congregation.

And conversely, when a congregation is altogether sunk in worldliness and indifference, so that one knows of not a single Christian in the congregation, then one consoles oneself with the assurance that there is at least an invisible congregation somewhere, if nowhere else than in the newborn children.

Where does such a thing lead? Invariably to this: that one despises the congregation and exalts the Church at the congregation’s expense. One sees that the local congregation is neither light nor salt; neither believing nor living; it surely cannot possibly be Christ’s body and Christ’s bride, as it is. And then, in order to escape the truth and the honest confession of sin and transgression, one forms for oneself a dim and vague notion that there is, lifted high above the congregation, a Church about which one prefers not to say anything definite—where it is to be found, or where it ever was.

If there is to be a change for the better among us, then we must begin by acknowledging that the Church is the congregations; and that as the congregations are, so is the Church, neither better nor worse, for it is precisely one and the same matter. We must cease deceiving ourselves with the notion that if we have a bad congregation, we nevertheless have a good and glorious Church; for the Church is altogether nothing other than the congregations, and a bad congregation is shame and misery for itself and its Lord and Savior, and it is harmful to other congregations, whether few or many, according as it comes into contact with them.

But next, it is above all important that it be acknowledged among us that our congregations do not become visible through unbelieving, immoral, profane, and drink-sodden church members; such serve only to hide, cover over, and disfigure the congregation, just as a fair face is disfigured when it is covered all over with filthy splashes.

It is of the very highest importance that the congregation be visible. For it is Jesus Christ’s own body, set to reveal him in the world. What is invisible cannot make manifest; light is required. Therefore what matters is that it may be said of the congregation: “You were formerly darkness, but now you are light in the Lord.” If that cannot be said, then it is no

visible congregation.

In other words, the congregation becomes visible by its believing members and their activity.

It becomes visible by God's Word, that is true, for the Word is a light for the foot and a lantern on the path; its proclamation and use in church and house, in testimony and conversation, serve to make the congregation visible.

It becomes visible through Baptism and the Lord's Supper; for in Baptism one is clothed with Christ, and in the Supper his death is proclaimed until he comes.

But it is not merely a matter of the Word and the Sacrament without faith and without believing people in the congregation. It is written: You are the light of the world, you are the salt of the earth. Scripture does not merely say that God's Word is the light of the world.

Christ's body—that through which Christ is seen, that through which Christ works—is visible, because it is believing men and women who labor with the Word and the Sacraments, and it is their outward, organized community which is called the congregation.

But that does not fit our outwardly organized congregations at all! No, but from that it only follows that we must ask: Do you want a congregation? If the congregation has been lost to us in the undifferentiated mass of the state church, so that we call that congregation which is darkness and not light, then there is simply nothing else to be done but to obey the command: Awake, you who sleep, arise from the dead, and Christ shall shine upon you!

This is the Free Church's first task: to bring the congregation out of the rubble, or, as the Prophet says, to rebuild ruins and restore desolate places.

It is not the great body that matters now, but each individual little congregation. The matter is that in every place where baptized people gather around the Word, there comes to be a visible congregation, a city on a hill, which cannot be hidden.

Men and women, let us labor with faithfulness toward this goal, each in our own place and all together, as many as have the faith of Jesus and the life in the Son of God.

Georg Sverdrup

3.12 The Lutheran Free Church

"Folkebladet" for April 28 and May 12, 1897.

"The United Church" has, through its twenty-year history, demonstrated that it has the power neither to bring peace nor freedom into the Church. And yet it was in order to attain these two things that it was organized.

Church people are left with deep disappointment and empty hearts.

But the cause has neither failed nor been abandoned. In reality it is a step forward that there are already many—and more are becoming so—who acknowledge that peace and freedom in the Church cannot be attained by church politics and lawsuits.

It takes Spirit and life and love, if peace and freedom are to come among us.

It is this consciousness that has called forth the work for the Free Church, which is beginning to show the first small signs of movement here and there among the congregations, and which also makes itself known through the proposed rules that are published today in Folkebladet.*

The thought is that in the Free Church the congregation should come up and the "church body" come down. The intention is to attain the strength of cooperation by Spirit, not by law; by freedom, not by compulsion.

By rules are here meant "Guiding Principles" and "Rules for the Work." They are found on page FIXME 49 ff.

Two things, then, are necessary in the Free Church: 1) that the freedom and authority of the individual congregation be fully acknowledged and without any curtailment, and 2) that the individual congregation truly be filled and permeated by God's Spirit.

Everything in the Free Church depends upon these two things: that the congregations become independent and spiritual. And in truth they cannot become the one without the other.

It is therefore only a pitiful and sorrowful spiritlessness and ignorance of godly things when one says that there is no need among us of any work for the Free Church; we already have it, because state and church are separated from one another.

Indeed? Is the state the only power that can make the Church unfree and that has made it so? If that were the case, then the Catholic Church would be an excellent Free Church. Surely it cannot be the intention to lead us back again into its nature? Or was it not precisely the Catholic bondage that Luther designated by the name: "The Babylonian Captivity of the Church"? No, the truth is this: the Lutherans preferred the dominion of the state in the Church to the hard tyranny of the Catholic Church and desired the protection of the state against this.

By the mere fact that we are out of the power of the state, we are no Free Church. The so-called "church bodies," or synods, exercise more dominion than the state would dare in this age.* But even if we did not have these worldly, lawsuit-mad church bodies over us, we would still be only a caricature of a free congregation, so long as sheer worldliness and death are not only found, but even rule in the congregations, as they do in many places.

Only where the Spirit of the Lord is, is there freedom. Therefore the work for the Free Church is the same thing as the work for the enlivening of the congregation.

In this work of awakening the Lord calls upon all believers to be laborers. All believers, both pastors and laypeople, both men and women, are called out into the Lord's service to save lives and save souls.

The old-fashioned view from the very worst days of Rationalism, that it is only the pastors who make up the Church's labor-force and the Lord's servants, is not sufficient in the great conflict between faith and unbelief into which we have been cast in our time. The principle to be applied is the universal service obligation of all believers.

Therefore the thought is first and foremost to awaken believers to see their calling and to walk and work accordingly, so that they may become zealous to awaken the sleeping within

and outside the congregation.

Only when the congregations are freed from the yoke of worldliness are they truly free.

But if the congregations now become so independent, can they then do any work in common? Will it not become with the congregations in the Free Church as with the so-called "independent" congregations, which the church bodies regarded with so much suspicion and in part with contempt?

That will not happen, if the believers in the congregations step forward in the work. They do indeed have the unity of the Spirit, and they know how to preserve it in the bond of peace. The voluntary laborers will have no difficulty in agreeing to work for the cause they love. And when each works for the cause according to his ability and gift, then it will become altogether different from the "independent" congregations, which often "stood outside" because they wished to escape the work, or because the bonds of the church bodies were too tight for them.

This Free Church work is therefore the only practical and genuine work of bringing believers together—or rather, a work of peace.* Give room to all congregations, let each of them have its freedom and independence unimpaired, do not bind them together in bundles with the bonds of denominational constitutions, and then peace is very near to coming.

If the work has so great a goal, it must of course be content to begin quite small. It is never many who begin a spiritual struggle for the good of the whole. But we have the faith that it depends neither on the many nor on the few, but on the Lord's Spirit, whether such work shall succeed.

But whether anyone is in a "church body" or outside a "church body," they are equally welcome to take part in the Free Church work, if they are agreed in this purpose: the enlivening and liberation of the congregations.

The proposal (for rules for a Lutheran Free Church) cannot be considered too carefully, nor criticized too sharply. For a Lutheran Free Church, in which the congregations truly enjoy that freedom of life and of the Spirit which belongs to them according to the New Testament, is something new, at least here in America.* It has been so, and it is still so rather generally to this day, that there is almost nowhere any possibility of joining a Lutheran congregation without at the same time also having to become a member of an ecclesiastical party.

But when a cause is so new,* then it is altogether certain that it is of great importance to proceed cautiously. And the right caution consists in laying as much weight as possible upon the congregation, that it may receive its right spiritual shape among us according to God's Word; for there lies the Free Church's strength and focal point, and if the congregation is allowed to come forth, then a free church will come into being of itself.

For "Free Church" means, so far as I understand anything of it, nothing other than this: that the congregation is allowed to be and to work in freedom* for the cause of God's Kingdom, not as other people and congregations decide for them, but as they determine themselves.

But if the congregations are truly free, that is to say, living and driven by the Spirit, then it will be a self-evident thing that those who are driven by one and the same Spirit will also find and understand one another, and mutually support and encourage one another. And here

again the New Testament will be able to give us clear and sufficient guidance with respect to the relations of the free congregations with one another.⁸ Those who live the same divine life and are joined as a band of God's children bound together as brothers and sisters—be assured of it—love one another, they understand one another, they have care for one another, they rejoice to see one another, and what interests the one cannot be a matter of indifference to the other. Therefore freedom will not produce strife and disorder, but precisely peace and order. Compulsion and injustice bring about strife and confusion, as we may see daily. Suppose we tried what freedom and love would accomplish! Or does anyone doubt that there will be better understanding where two brothers labor freely at one another's side than where the one would threaten the other into being a slave?"

The right form of cooperation among congregations is common interest and full voluntariness. To this belongs that there be the same lively and spiritual cooperation among the congregations as the New Testament shows us in the Apostolic Age. We must visit one another, we must come together for great and small meetings; we must write letters, we must circulate papers and books.

In this way the Free Church will attain that mutual brotherly understanding which will make it possible for the work of the Church to take place in voluntariness, and that those who are most interested in the advancement of the cause may also have the most influence upon its course. A good cause will find the support it can gain through the interest it awakens. And more than that it surely has no right to demand.

If we could get free and spiritual congregations, then their cooperation would not be lacking, only that it would be the common labor of brothers and sisters in mutual love, not the wearying yoke of enforced duty to the church body.

Georg Sverdrup

3.13 From the Report to the Annual Meeting of the Lutheran Free Church, 1897

Report on the Annual Meeting of the Lutheran Free Church, 1897, p. 12 ff.

The meeting in Fargo in the month of June last year forms a significant turning point in our development and—as we dare hope—in the development of our Church. The decision of June 20 to appoint a Free Church Committee, and the justification of this decision, was the fruit of a spiritual struggle of many years in our Church, and therefore also the point of departure for new spiritual movements.

Already at that time it had become clear that it was altogether indefensible to continue on the old way, forming church body against church body and party against party without end.

There had to be a change, a complete and entire reversal in the whole tendency of the development, if the Lutheran Church among our people was not to be torn apart into a multiplicity of party organizations, whose number could be reckoned only by the many

^{8*} See Professor Oftedal's lecture, page FIXME 57 ff.

small ambitions that would try to lift themselves up at the expense of the freedom of the congregations and with disregard for brotherly love.

The friends of Augsburg could have formed a church body in the old style, and with the passionate force of party spirit sought their own cause and strengthened themselves by a truly solid organization according to all the rules of the art. The temptation was great and close at hand; I confess it. It always seems so much safer to our flesh to rely on human cleverness and ability than on God and His Spirit and His Word.

Yet this was not “the good part” from the Lord. Our Church was not served by having the number of party organizations increased and discord and unfreedom grow. For peace and freedom we have labored and suffered through many years; peace and freedom were what we at least, for our part, sought in the formation of The United Church. We did not find them; just when we thought that a good beginning had been made, it became apparent that the very organization of a church body brings with it a danger which at any moment may become a fall, namely, occasion to use the united power to rule instead of to serve. The United Church succumbed to this danger. The point now was to avoid following in the same track, and the meeting in Fargo therefore demanded the following three things of its Free Church Committee when it charged it to draw up rules for a Lutheran Free Church.

The one was that the freedom of the congregation should be fully and entirely acknowledged and preserved without any restriction.

The second was that the strength of cooperation should be strengthened, not slackened.

The third was that the number of party organizations should not be increased.

It seemed a difficult and insurmountable task. And yet it is beyond doubt that this is precisely what is required if there is to be peace and freedom in the Church. We have seen that neither peace nor freedom can be won by political compromises; nor does it help to build the fences of the church bodies higher and higher, and to shut in and shut out according to arbitrary impulses and whims.

What else was there to do than to find a way by which one simply broke down “the middle wall of partition” between the parties, never to raise it again? In the sphere of doctrine, the most essential work in this direction has been done. There can scarcely be said to be any “doctrinal controversy” any more, since the Catechism has in the main prevailed over the clerical theses. By appealing to that which is held in common, the separation in doctrine has been all but overcome. What in this sphere still remains is disagreement in such doctrinal questions as directly concern the congregation and its life and freedom.

What has taken place in the sphere of doctrine must now also take place in the sphere of constitution, or of organization. Peace and freedom must be sought by taking up the cause of the congregation in full and utter earnest.

We already have many ecclesial tasks among us that are not the concern of any one church body, but simply leap over and pass through the fences of the church bodies without even seeing them, or at least without taking account of them. Some of these tasks are carried on by organizations more or less solid, and yet they work. Here one thinks of such ecclesial or

Christian undertakings as, for example, the mission to the Jews, the mission to China, lay activity, the Santal mission, the deaconess cause, and in recent years also Augsburg Seminary.

Think for a moment about how this goes on among us, and perhaps it will not be so difficult after all to understand where the way of the Free Church lies.

In reality it is not possible to mistake it. It is the congregation that must come to the fore. For its life and freedom there must be labor in all church bodies and outside all church bodies. If the congregations can thrive spiritually within the church bodies, well and good; if the church bodies can tolerate the life and freedom of the congregations, well and good. We have nothing against that; there is no war between us and the church bodies, unless the church bodies bring party coercion and all its bitter consequences into the congregations. When the congregation and its life are corrupted by church-body politics, then there is struggle, utterly uncompromising struggle. For to Christian people the congregation is more precious than father and mother, than children and kin; and there is no peace between those who love the congregation and those who do it harm, whoever they may be.

If then there is to be a Free Church which is not to become a party, there is only one way: to lay the whole weight upon the congregation. It is precisely as in doctrine, to lay the weight upon the Catechism. It is no party cause. If there is any church body that does not approve of all possible effort being put forth for the congregation and its life, what sort of church body is that? It can hardly be a Christian church body. All church bodies are simply bound to acknowledge that such labor is justified, Christian, and necessary. And when the Free Church has only this one purpose, to work for the life and freedom of the congregation, then to that extent it is unassailable from an ecclesial or Christian side. Then one can—rightly—reproach us only that we do not labor enough, or do not labor in the best way. And we must indeed rejoice if anyone will help us to do it better, and most of all if those who fault us will themselves do the necessary work so much better than we are able.

But if free, independent congregations are not to lose anything of the strength of cooperation, then spiritual fellowship is needed. Free cooperation in everything that may serve to advance the Kingdom of God at home and abroad is necessary and beneficial; if this is to take place, then we must understand one another and know one another. We must exchange thought and spirit and thus have the bonds of love tied in the freedom of the Spirit. So far as I can understand, a truly free-church work will be almost impossible under our circumstances without very many free meetings and gatherings.

Such and the like have been the considerations that have also guided your Free Church Committee in its work with the proposed rules. These are now laid before you with the hope that they may be of some use in our efforts to find the way out.

It is not a proposal for a constitution. We proceed from the fact that the congregation is the true organization. These are only rules for cooperation in the one matter with which we are concerned, namely, the spiritual life and freedom of the congregations, so that they may better answer their calling and carry out their tasks.

We have therefore also given up the representative system, which among the so-called church bodies among us has been so abused. We have proceeded from the fact that in spiritual

matters, those who take an interest in a cause and sacrifice something for it are also those who best understand it and most lovingly care for it.

With that, outward power also falls away altogether. Our free-church meetings have only spiritual influence, without any kind of outward bond upon the individual congregations.

Will such a thing then be able to go forward? Yes, why not, if only the congregations will it? We have labored on this voluntary way now for some years, and we cannot complain that it does not go. The rules now proposed aim at letting voluntariness continue to govern.

But in this connection one thing is the one thing needful: faith, faith in God's Spirit, faith in His power to awaken life and preserve life, give love, create freedom, drive to labor, unite and bind the many small forces into one spiritually coherent work.

Georg Sverdrup

3.14 Guiding Principles and Revised Rules for the Lutheran Free Church

3.14.1 Guiding Principles

1. The congregation is, according to God's Word, the proper form of the Kingdom of God on earth.⁹
2. The congregation consists of believing people who, by the use of the means of grace and the gifts of grace according to the direction of God's Word, seek their own salvation and eternal blessedness and that of all their fellow men.
3. According to the New Testament, the congregation requires an outward organization with a register of its members, election of office-bearers, fixed times and places for its gatherings, etc.
4. Since not all members of the congregation's outward organization are always believing people, and since such sinners often take false comfort from their outward connection with the congregation, it is the congregation's holy calling to purify itself both by awakening proclamation of God's Word, by earnest admonition and reminder, and by exclusion of manifest and obstinate sinners.¹⁰

⁹When Principle No. 1 was discussed at the Free Church's annual meeting in 1898, Prof. Sverdrup, according to Folkebladet for June 15, 1898, spoke as follows:

It is of great importance that one declare oneself on these matters; for here it is not a matter of adopting points, but of our also acknowledging from the heart what we confess in these rules. It is something new when in Point 1 we declare the congregation to be the proper form of the Kingdom of God on earth; for for hundreds of years men have called the Church the proper form.

If, however, we adopt this point, then we go back to the time of the Apostles and to God's Word.

According to God's Word, the congregation is not a society governed by Pope, King, Council, or any other authority; but the congregation is the gathering of believing people around God's Word and the means of grace. There is not in God's Word a single sign that any administration should be set over the congregation to rule over it.

¹⁰Point 4 in the Principles originally read as follows: "Ordinarily the congregation's outward organization also includes people who in God's Word are called dead and sleeping, wherefore within the congregation too

5. The congregation governs its own affairs under the authority of God's Word and Spirit, and acknowledges no other ecclesiastical authority or power over itself.
6. The free congregation esteems and loves all the spiritual gifts which the Lord grants for its edification, and seeks to enliven the gifts and promote their use.
7. The free congregation receives with gladness the mutual help which the congregations can render one another in the work of advancing the Kingdom of God.
8. Such mutual help consists partly in this, that the spiritual powers of one congregation come the other to good through free meetings, mutual visits, lay activity, etc.; partly in this, that the congregations voluntarily and according to the prompting of God's Spirit work together for the solution of such tasks as may exceed the powers of a single congregation.
9. Among such purposes are named in particular a seminary for pastors, the dissemination of Bibles and other writings and papers, Home Mission, mission to the heathen, mission to the Jews, deaconess homes, orphanages, and other works of mercy.
10. Free congregations have no right to require that other congregations submit to their opinion, will, judgment, or determination, wherefore every dominion of a majority of congregations over a minority is to be rejected.
11. The common organs which may be found desirable for the cooperation of the congregations, such as larger or smaller meetings, committees, office-bearers, etc., cannot in a Lutheran Free Church impose upon the single congregation any duty, bond, compulsion, or burden, but are only authorized to come forward with proposals and exhortations to congregations and persons.
12. Every free congregation has, like each individual believer, under the impulse of God's Spirit and by the right of love, the right to do good and to labor for the salvation of souls and

the cry of awakening and the preaching of repentance are needed, just as it is the believers' holy calling also within the congregation to be light and salt, lest the outward connection with the congregation become a false comfort and a hindrance.

Since there were some who found a contradiction between Points 2 and 4, Point 4 was altered after Sverdrup had, according to Folkebladet's report for June 16, 1897, made the following statement: As regards the contradiction between the two points 2 and 4, it is the same opposition as in every Christian—the law of the Spirit and the law of the flesh. The congregation consists of those who belong to the body of Jesus Christ—that which lives—what else should it consist of? But the outward organization has dead members in it. God's Word says this too. There was a Judas even among the twelve. The works of the flesh are knotty things to have to do with. Those who try to grapple fast with them injure themselves most and the works of the flesh least. I should wish there were a Word of God that gave another view of the congregation than this Point 4, but I cannot find any. There are vessels for honor and vessels for dishonor in every house. The congregation consists and must consist of living members; but there are dead ones also, and these we cannot by our understanding and our sight separate out. But the congregation does not consist of dead ones. There are many unclean vessels and creatures in a house, but the house does not consist of these unclean things. Can anyone then, for example, sit in judgment upon the children in the congregation, and say, when the children fall out of their baptismal covenant, that they no longer belong to the congregation? Such a congregation I should at any rate leave as soon as possible.—Thus stand the works of the flesh.

In his lectures Sverdrup often used this as a definition of the word "consist": "that which really holds up, even though much else hangs on."

the awakening of spiritual life, as far as its ability and strength reach; in such free, spiritual activity it is restricted neither by parish ties nor by denominational boundaries.

3.14.2 The Revised Rules for Work

1. The name of this association is: The Lutheran Free Church.¹¹
2. Its purpose is to labor for the vivification and liberation of all Norwegian Lutheran congregations, so that according to their calling and their ability they may labor in spiritual independence and freedom for the cause of the Kingdom of God at home and abroad through such organs and institutions as the congregations themselves may determine.
3. This purpose is sought attained chiefly by the training of men and women for spiritual work in and for the congregation, by the holding of larger and smaller meetings, by the dissemination of suitable literature, by the organization of voluntary committees and associations, by the sending out of emissaries, and by other means which may from time to time prove suitable.
4. The Free Church consists of congregational members who in its church order unreservedly

¹¹Originally the 'Rules for Work' read as follows:

1. The name of this association is: The Lutheran Free Church.
2. Its purpose is to labor for the enlivening and liberation of all Norwegian Lutheran congregations, so that, according to their calling and their ability, they may work in spiritual independence and freedom for the cause of God's Kingdom at home and abroad through such organs and institutions as the congregations themselves might determine.
3. This purpose is sought attained chiefly by the holding of greater and smaller meetings, by the dissemination of suitable literature, by the organization of free-church committees and associations, by the sending out of emissaries, and by other means which from time to time might prove suitable.
4. The Free Church consists of Lutheran congregations which, by resolution, acknowledge its principles and rules and report this to the Secretary, regardless of other denominational connection.
5. The Free Church holds an annual meeting, which as a rule begins on the first Wednesday in the month of June, and which elects the necessary committees, emissaries, and officers, and determines which ecclesial matters the meeting will particularly recommend to the congregations.
6. At the Free Church's annual meeting, all voting members of the congregations that constitute the Free Church have the right to vote, insofar as they appear from those congregations; likewise members entitled to vote of other Lutheran congregations who, by submitting their names to the Secretary of the annual meeting on forms specially prepared for that purpose, declare that they approve the principles and rules of the Free Church and will labor for the purpose stated for it in §2.
7. At the Free Church's annual meeting, reports are heard from officers and committees, as well as from such ecclesial institutions as the annual meeting grants access thereto.
8. The officers of the Free Church shall be a Chairman and a Secretary. They are elected by the annual meeting for a term of one year. The Chairman is the presiding officer of the annual meeting; the Secretary keeps the minutes of the annual meeting; together these two officers issue the annual report of the Free Church, determine the time and place of the annual meeting, unless the immediately preceding annual meeting has determined it, and see to it that the annual meeting is announced at least two months before it is held.
9. Each year the annual meeting elects an ordinator, who shall assist the congregations by ordaining theological candidates who have been duly called to be pastors; likewise, each year it elects a committee for Inner Mission, and a committee for mission to the heathen, and a church organizational committee.
10. Besides the regular annual meeting, during the course of the month of June each year local free-church meetings are held in the various congregations, which may invite thereto. At each of these meetings, if possible, one or more of the Free Church's functionaries or sent workers shall be present; and particular weight shall be laid upon conversations and deliberations of an edifying character, intended to cast light upon the work of solving the free-church tasks, and especially upon the enlivening of the congregation among us.
11. These rules may be altered in such a way that a proposal for alteration is brought forward at one annual meeting and voted upon at the next annual meeting; its adoption then requires a two-thirds majority of the votes cast.

assent to the ancient ecumenical Creeds, Luther's Small Catechism, and the Unaltered Augsburg Confession, and who by formal decision acknowledge the Free Church's principles and rules and report this to the Secretary, notwithstanding other ecclesial affiliation.

5. The Free Church holds an annual meeting, which as a rule begins on the second Wednesday of the month of June, and which elects the necessary committees, emissaries, and officers, and determines which ecclesiastical tasks the meeting will particularly recommend to the congregations.

6. The right to vote at the Free Church's annual meetings belongs to all enfranchised congregational members who appear from the congregations that constitute the Free Church; likewise, enfranchised members of other Lutheran congregations who, by submitting their names to the Secretary of the annual meeting on forms specially prepared for that purpose, signify that they approve the Free Church's principles and rules and will work for the purpose set forth for it in paragraph 2.

7. The officers of the Free Church shall be a Chairman, Vice-Chairman, and Secretary. They are elected by the annual meeting for a term of one year. The Chairman is the presiding officer of the annual meeting, the Secretary keeps the minutes of the annual meeting; these two officers together publish the Free Church's annual report and determine the time and place of the annual meeting, unless the immediately preceding annual meeting has determined this, and also see to it that the annual meeting is publicly announced at least two months before it is held.

8. The annual meeting elects an Organizational Committee of three members. One member is elected each year for a term of three years.

9. a) The organization committee labors to make the Free Church's principles and rules known and discussed in the congregations, so that the Free Church's task may gradually come to be more clearly understood and better carried through.

b) It labors that the congregations may be as numerous and generally represented at the Free Church's annual meetings as possible.

c) It provides for the holding of larger meetings, and arranges the time, place, program, and personnel for the same.

d) The committee seeks to bring about a general interchange of the spiritual powers within the congregations.

e) It will assist congregations and pastors with counsel and guidance where this is desired.

f) Each year it gathers and reports to the annual meetings as complete information as possible concerning the Free Church's work in its various branches, such as congregational work, foreign and home mission, Sunday schools, women's societies, youth societies, church buildings, church dedications, etc.

10. The annual meeting elects each year an ordinator, who shall assist the congregations in ordaining theological candidates who in due manner have been called as pastors.

11. The annual meeting elects a mission superintendent, who shall devote all his time to the service of Home Mission and assist the Board of Home Missions in organizing the work of Home Mission. He is elected for three years, and his salary is determined by the Board of Home Missions.
12. The annual meeting elects a school board for Augsburg Seminary and nominates members to the Lutheran Board of Missions, Board of Home Missions, the Corporation of Augsburg Seminary, and its Board of Trustees.
13. Chairman, Secretary, Ordinator, and chairmen of standing committees cannot be re-elected for more than two consecutive terms of office.
14. At the Free Church's annual meetings reports are heard from the organization committee, the Lutheran Board of Missions, the Board of Home Missions, and Augsburg Seminary, and from committees appointed by the Free Church's annual meeting, as well as from such ecclesiastical institutions as the annual meeting gives admission thereto.
15. These rules may be changed in such manner that a proposal for change is introduced at one annual meeting and voted upon at the next annual meeting; its adoption then requires a two-thirds majority of the votes cast.

3.15 Free Connection among Free Congregations

Opening Address at the Free Church's First Meeting, by Professor Sven Oftedal.

Report of the Annual Meeting of the Lutheran Free Church, 1897, p. 62ff.

It may well be maintained as one of the so-called self-evident truths, a matter taken for granted, that if the congregations are free, then the mutual connection among them must also become a free connection.

Nevertheless, or rather precisely because it is self-evident, it is so exceedingly difficult, not to say impossible, to carry out in practice.

It is self-evident that a sinner, because he is a criminal, can be saved only by being pardoned; and yet how difficult, indeed impossible! And how many other ways has not human reason and theology devised in order to avoid this one narrow way, to be saved by grace alone!

Free connection among free congregations is extraordinarily difficult to realize:

* 1. On account of the prerequisite. * 2. On account of the apparent self-contradiction in its execution.

The prerequisite is, namely, free congregations, or a true freedom of the congregation.

By free congregations we understand, in this connection, not congregations that are freed from the supremacy of the state, or even from the tutelage of the priesthood or of the papacy, but congregations that are in truth free in Christ, set free in their individual members by the Gospel, pervaded, governed, and driven by the Spirit of God according to the word: "Where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is freedom" (2 Cor. 3:17).

If congregations of that sort are the prerequisite for the aim here under consideration, then anyone who knows anything of the condition of our congregations will at once understand not only how great, but how difficult, the task lying before the Free Church is.

Only in the same measure as the congregations are awakened, made alive, and set free by the Holy Spirit and power of God can there gradually be any question of establishing a free connection among them. The Free Church therefore is only as it continually becomes.

But even if the prerequisite is present, the execution is equally difficult, because it involves an apparent contradiction. God's congregation is, namely, at the same time that it is many, yet always only one. We believe one holy catholic Church. Connection among the congregations always aims to present an outward visible form of this unity.

But here we are met by the fact that everything in the world is "in part": "we understand in part and we prophesy in part; and only when the perfect comes shall that which is in part be done away" (1 Cor. 13:9-10). Therefore freedom also, true spiritual freedom, is always in part; and naturally every free connection is also in part; it too is only as it becomes, and therefore does not satisfy the demanding reason's claim for an outward, sensible, visible, and perfect unity. The Church cannot at one and the same time be both many and one, says reason.

"Free connection among free congregations," as a presentation of the unity of the Church, is therefore only a beautiful thought-experiment, an unattainable ideal, people say; it is not only a difficulty, but an outright impossibility.

The history of the Church therefore shows us that the "Fathers" have always had to seek more practical and rational ways by which the connection among the congregations might realize the great, inescapable goal: the unity of the Church.

These rational methods of unity, no doubt often forced forth by historical conditions, may be gathered under three great groups:

* 1. The episcopal principle. * 2. The territorial principle. * 3. The synodal principle.

By all these methods one succeeds in presenting an outward, unmistakable form of the unity of the Church, but it always takes place at the expense of the congregation's freedom and individuality. They all run aground on the contradiction: many and yet one; one and yet many (cf. 1 Cor. 10:17).

The episcopal principle, which in reality makes the congregation identical with the bishop, leads in its consistent development to the papacy; that is to say, to the unity of the Church represented by the highest bishop, Christ's vicar. Although the Catholic Church, with its personal visible head and its fully developed organization, has incontestably gone farthest in presenting the unity of the Church on an admirable and almost world-embracing scale, yet we Lutherans acknowledge that this has taken place at the expense both of doctrine and of the congregation. The doctrine of God's Word has been corrupted, and the congregation almost altogether obliterated. The priest has become everything, the congregation nothing. The existence of our Lutheran Church is precisely a serious and definite protest, grounded in the Word of God, against this principle.

The state-church principle, which is also called the territorial principle because the boundaries

of the congregation are determined by geographical divisions or territories, has early been tried both in Catholic and in Protestant lands. Every time it has been tried, it has led to complete worldliness. We have seen its fruits in our old fatherland, where a hundred years ago almost every single priest was a rationalist or freethinker, and Hauge, on account of his revival work, was cast into prison. When God and the world are apparently reconciled, it is God who is excluded; when the congregation and the state are reconciled or united, then there does indeed come about as complete a union as human power and compulsion can produce, but also in this form of the unity of God's Church it is the worldly state that becomes everything; the congregation becomes nothing but an outward form; it is in reality dissolved according to its spiritual essence and passes over into becoming equivalent to a district or a municipality, a township or county, in short a purely worldly organization with the Word and the Sacraments as a label pasted on from the outside.

The synodal principle has also, from the earliest time and right down to our own days, been tried in both Catholic and Protestant lands. It is what in this country we are most familiar with under the name of the associational principle. It has great advantages over the two preceding. In theory, and even in constitutions, it can strongly emphasize and acknowledge the independence of the individual congregation. But since this principle too aims at an outward, visible, and organized unity of the Church and seeks to realize this in the "synod" or the "association," a consistent development seems unavoidably to lead, little by little, to setting up the "synod" or the "association" as a higher sort of congregation, a form of unity of all the congregations belonging to the association. Thereby the congregation has already lost its place as the only outward form appointed by God for His kingdom on earth; it has been reduced to being an intermediate stage leading to a higher form of God's Church, fashioned by men.

Once the development has entered upon this slippery slope, though in many gradations, congregations will unceasingly have to withdraw more and more, until at last they are even reduced to a mere supporting foundation for the financial operations of the "association." The synod, as the totality and unity of all the congregations belonging under it, will in the course of development come to present the outward form of this higher unity in the priests, who will then gradually and involuntarily regard themselves individually as special members of the congregation, placed higher by ordination, and in their totality, as an "estate" or "priesthood," consider themselves the actual representatives of the Church and of its unity. It is here that the synodal principle in its development will meet the papacy, no doubt on a smaller scale, but on no less effective a one. Here too the congregation is sacrificed for outward priestly church-unity.

These different ways of presenting the unity of the congregation, in order to avoid the self-evident and simple, but for human reason impossible thing: the preservation of freedom both for the individual congregation and for their mutual connection, have now for nearly nineteen hundred years again and again been tried and weighed and each time found wanting, because in the course of their development they have all blurred or corrupted "the pillar and ground of the truth, the congregation of the living God," and have set up their own organizations in its place, partly priestly, partly civil.

For serious-minded, independent Christians, therefore, and especially for us, who have to

build a Lutheran congregation as if anew in this country, there remains nothing else than to attempt the "impossible," according to the word that stands written: What is impossible with men is possible with God. "God's temple, His congregation, is holy," says Scripture, and adds: "which you are." The congregation is not something human; it is God's work; it can therefore neither be built nor united in its multiplicity into one, whether by might or by power, but only by the Spirit of God. He alone is the one who can establish a "free connection among free congregations."

It is true that the history of the Church after the apostolic period shows us that the Church's foremost and most earnest leaders, the Fathers, down through the ages, have almost all regarded one of the three above-named principles as divinely warranted in the work of presenting the unity of the Church outwardly; and with apparent justice the old question may also be raised here: "Are you wiser than all our Fathers?"

But first, the same question was put to Luther. Therefore it is true Lutheran doctrine that one Word of God weighs more than all the Fathers. Both the congregation's doctrine and its order, two things which at many points are inseparable, must be tested by the Word of God and by the Word of God alone. Fathers, history, tradition may be of inestimable value for illumination and guidance in spiritual matters. But when it concerns the very pillar and ground of the truth, the congregation of the living God, the body of Christ, its essence and unity, then it is our duty and our right, most of all as Lutheran Christians, to pass beyond both Fathers and Tradition and to seek in the Word itself the knowledge and strength that we need.

Second, the New Testament gives all desirable instruction about the congregation both according to its divine essence and according to its historical reality.

There now therefore present themselves two questions:

* 1. Was the congregation, as it meets us within the period of the New Testament, of the same kind and essence as the congregation now? * 2. Was there among these New Testament free congregations any unity of connection, and can a similar one be brought about among our congregations?

3.16 The New Testament Congregation

The first fact that meets us in this connection is that the New Testament speaks only of "the congregation," the individual congregation; in catholic and state-church usage theological language has, in place of "the congregation," put "the Church," a word which by its very concept has most often — and so also in the free-church clerical bodies here in question — swallowed up the congregation and usurped its place and right. From this standpoint the congregation is therefore regarded essentially only as an intermediate link toward the higher unity, "the Church," and is accordingly, in distinction from "the Church," commonly called the district congregation or the local congregation.

We find, further, that before the congregation was created on the day of Pentecost and set into the world, in other words in the Gospels, this word, "the congregation," occurs only twice, and that in Matthew. First in Matt. 16:18, where the Lord says to Simon: "You are Peter,

and upon this rock I will build My congregation,” the passage upon which the whole Catholic church theory has been built, but against whose Catholic interpretation all Protestants have objected with fully valid reason. Next in Matt. 18:17, concerning discipline in the congregation: “— — tell it to the congregation, and if he does not hear the congregation,” etc. If the Lord here does not refer simply to the Jewish synagogue, there is at all events no doubt that what is meant here is the congregation in the same sense in which the word is otherwise used in the New Testament, the individual local congregation, large or small.

All the more frequently is the word congregation used in the writings after Pentecost, in all more than one hundred times. More than half of these fall in four writings, namely the Acts of the Apostles, which may rightly be called the history of the New Testament Church, the two Epistles to the Corinthians, and the Epistle to the Ephesians, the very writings which also give us the clearest insight into the nature of the congregation according to the presentation of God’s Word.

Among all these many passages where “the congregation” or “the congregations” is meant, there is not one that can be explained of “the Church” in the sense of an outward church-body consisting of some or all congregations as a higher outward unity of them. God’s Word does indeed present all congregations as a unity, as one body — (Eph. 1:22 and 4:16; Col. 3:11; 1 Cor. 10:17, etc.) namely Christ; but it is a spiritual unity, according to that word, that Christ is all in all, that those who are baptized into Christ have been clothed with Christ, and that there is neither slave nor free, male nor female, Greek nor Jew. And what is said of this unity of all congregations is also said, and in the same passages, of the individual outward congregation, namely that it is Christ’s body, or that it is the body and Christ the Head, and that every individual member in this outward congregation is a member on Christ’s body.

In God’s Word there is lacking every indication that for the outward connection between these congregations there was any arrangement or any common government which made necessary an outward head over the congregations in their totality as a higher form of the congregation. Not even the apostles had, so far as appears from God’s Word, any authority in other congregations than the first congregation in Jerusalem and possibly the first congregations in Samaria. Indeed, even concerning the apostles’ activity there is in God’s Word a remarkable — and yet in God’s merciful wisdom well-grounded — silence, in order that there might be in the congregations the least possible temptation to set men over Christ. The New Testament even speaks disproportionately much more of the thirteenth apostle, “one untimely born,” “the least of the apostles,” “who was not worthy to be called an apostle” (1 Cor. 15:9), than of “the very chiefest apostles” (2 Cor. 12:11), although he, as he says, “is nothing,” evidently in order to show the congregations that God’s grace is not bound to human persons, but to Christ alone, and to counteract the tendency which already in the first congregations, and especially in the spiritual congregation at Corinth, showed itself so strongly, namely party-spirit: that one held to Cephas, one to Paul, one to Apollos, one to Christ, and “you endure it if anyone makes slaves of you, if anyone devours you, if anyone takes you captive, if anyone exalts himself, if anyone strikes you in the face!” (2 Cor. 11:20).

It is undeniable that it is in essential part out of this fleshly craving in every human being to regard persons and to find something outward to build upon, that there developed quite early in church history a strong urge to lift the apostles and the first Christian workers so high up

that Christ and His body, the congregation, became in the same proportion of subordinate significance; and this not only in order to build monuments over the prophets, but chiefly thereby to secure for themselves, as the leaders and governors of the “congregation” and later of the “Church,” as priests and bishops, a recognition and authority which they thought they could uphold only as “the successors of the apostles,” “Peter’s heirs,” “Christ’s vicars,” etc., the principle upon which the whole Catholic church order, all state churches, and all clerical bodies are in reality built.

A wholly different picture presents itself when we consider the congregation, without regard to the subsequent history and in part very fleshly development, as God’s Word presents it to us, whether the congregations are considered in and for themselves or in their mutual relation to one another.

There are here portions of God’s Word which are very little heeded because they do not fit into dogmatics and into presuppositions and traditions belonging to a much later time.

3.17 The First Congregation of God

in Jerusalem was, as we all know, created or born by a miracle of the same kind as the creation of the world and Christ’s becoming man, in that God’s Spirit immediately filled the twelve apostles and the others, in all about one hundred and twenty persons, men and women, who were assembled on the day of Pentecost and awaited “the promise of the Father,” “the baptism with the Holy Spirit” (Acts 1:4–5), and received the power of the Holy Spirit which came upon them. Thus the congregation, according to its first origin, is divine, and by the Spirit and the Word has become the firstfruits of God’s saving order in the world, a leaven which shall work through to the ends of the world, everywhere alike holy by reason of the means of grace, according to that word, that if the first of the dough is holy, then the whole dough is likewise, and if the root is holy, then the branches are likewise (Rom. 11:16).

Concerning the growth and development of this first congregation it therefore stands written that when Peter had spoken, there was a multitude which received the Word and was baptized, and about three thousand souls were added to the congregation that same day. Thus the first congregation advanced both in number and in the power of God’s Spirit, and the multitude of the believers were all of one heart and one soul, and all were filled with the Holy Spirit and spoke the Word of God with boldness (Acts 4:31–32).

And yet even then the congregation was not mere spirit. It consisted of human beings with flesh and blood, who formed an outward association or fellowship, had to meet in an earthly meeting-house, had to do with God’s things and worldly things, indeed even with food. What is unavoidable in every regenerate person, the conflict between flesh and Spirit, therefore soon made itself felt also in this glorious congregation filled with the Spirit, and brought it not only into the sufferings that come from the world’s hatred and resistance, but also into those inward conflicts whereby there is filled up what is lacking in Christ’s afflictions for His body (Col. 1:24).

There were Ananias and Sapphira — the leaven of the Pharisees, which is hypocrisy — and there were jealousy and strife between the Greek-born and the Hebrews over — the food.

No congregation any more than any individual Christian can, so long as it is an outward visible fellowship upon earth, avoid these inward conflicts between the flesh and the Spirit; but if this necessity is not concealed or covered over by fleshly sloth or self-indulgence, then God will also by His Spirit unceasingly give the congregation those powers and abilities whereby it can gain the victory in the conflict and learn by experience that the afflictions work in a refining and purifying way, proven character, patience, and hope (Rom. 5:3).

So it also went here; the congregation in Jerusalem, by the apostles' counsel, chose out of its own midst men equipped by God to meet and overcome the threatening danger, and after the first deacons were chosen it stands written that God's Word advanced, that the congregation multiplied, and that even many priests were converted.

Founding of Congregations

Neither was it the apostles who founded new congregations. So far as one can see from God's Word, the apostles took no measures to carry the congregation farther beyond Jerusalem; they had more than enough to do there.

It was through a particular and unexpected leading of God that new congregations were founded. After Stephen's murder a persecution broke out, after which the whole congregation in Jerusalem was driven out over Judea and Samaria except — the apostles. Of these scattered members of the congregation it stands written that they "proclaimed the word of the Gospel wherever they came." Thus, through the deacon Philip, the congregation in Samaria was founded. This, that "Samaria had received the Word of God," awakened to such a degree the attention of the apostles who remained in Jerusalem, and no doubt also their astonishment, that they sent Peter and John down to see how the matter stood, and they prayed that the converts might receive the Holy Spirit through the laying on of hands, which they also received, so that in that state they all became priests under the new covenant (Acts 8:14 ff.).

In the same way Philip became a means by which the Gospel and the congregation came to Ethiopia. And not that alone, but the scattered believers brought the Word and thereby the congregation to the surrounding lands, Phoenicia, Cyrene, and Syria (Acts 11:19–20), and many other places where we later find congregations without God's Word specifically mentioning by whom it was brought there, as for example Alexandria and Rome.

But there was here still another hindrance, in part among the apostles and the congregation in Jerusalem itself; namely, that the separation between Jews and Gentiles was regarded as so great that in their opinion there could be no question of preaching the Gospel directly to the Gentiles, or of there being any hope that Gentiles could receive the Holy Spirit and thus truly become a congregation of Christ.

Here too the Lord had to use, not the apostles' exaggerated wisdom or authority, but quite other and in part extraordinary means in order to make both the apostles and the Jerusalem congregation understand that Jesus died and rose again for all, and that He therefore both can and will save all — Jew or Greek — and make them members of His body, which is the congregation.

First, there were men from Cyprus and Cyrene who first spoke to Greeks in Antioch and

there formed a great congregation of believing Gentiles. At this again the congregation in Jerusalem was astonished and sent Barnabas to investigate the matter, which he found altogether in good order, since he, as it is written, was a good man (Acts 11:20 ff.).

Second, the Lord compelled Peter himself, despite all his resistance, to go to the Gentile Cornelius, a step for which he had to justify himself before the congregation in Jerusalem (Acts 11:1 ff.).

Finally, however, God had appointed a particular instrument for the founding of congregations among the Gentiles, the last man any human being could have thought of, a persecutor, Paul, who therefore also received the grace to labour more than all the others, and received so deep an insight into this great mystery, the congregation, Christ in us, as no other did (Eph. 3:4).

And after these preparations the congregation then went on its victorious course among the nations, in that indeed Paul and his fellow workers laboured chiefly among the Gentiles, Peter and the other apostles chiefly among the Jews, but all who themselves had received a share in Christ through faith and baptism zealously proclaimed everywhere, wherever they went, that salvation from sin and death which is found in the Gospel of Jesus Christ, as we see in such as Aquila and Priscilla, Apollos, and Epaphroditus. Where God's Word fell down into any heart, there it became a seed which grew up and bore fruit, and the fruit was congregations here and there, everywhere in the Roman Empire, as mentioned above, and this without there being any common government or bond between them except God's Spirit and God's Word, "the one Spirit, the one calling, the one Lord, faith and baptism, the one Father," as it is written, "who is over you all and through you all and in you all" (Eph. 4:4 ff.).

The Composition of the Congregations

and their further inner development in the apostolic age also emerges clearly enough from the New Testament writings. At first they consisted of Jews alone, afterward also, and in many places exclusively, of Gentiles from every nation. But whether the congregations were founded among Jews or Gentiles, they consisted of believing men and women and nothing else. Indeed, from the beginning there was no reason whatever why anyone should join the congregation unless they had been delivered from the burden of sin and the fruit of hell through faith in Jesus' blood and therefore were ready to bear His cross. Therefore, too, in the beginning they were called "brothers," "disciples," and "saints," and only received the name Christians as a term of reproach. But all together they were called, from the first moment until now, the congregation.

But as Christian experience teaches us to this very day, both with respect to individuals and to congregations, not all that is sown bears fruit with perseverance. What is begun is not ended, and Satan is never more active than where the life of Christ manifests itself powerfully. The leaven of the Pharisees and the leaven of the Sadducees soon began their baleful work in the first congregations. And thus, as we actually find the congregations, even within the period of the New Testament itself, they were without exception all infected by the spirit of carnality and very far from consisting exclusively of simple and living Christians.

To hide this fact from oneself proceeds either from complete ignorance of God's Word in this matter, or from hypocrisy and falsehood, which through centuries of repetition have

almost attained prescriptive right as a legitimate doctrine. People have grown accustomed to looking upon the first congregations, with their fullness of the Spirit and boldness of faith, as altogether perfect, an unattainable ideal, a company made up of nothing but saints and martyrs, a peculiar divine wonder-time, and so forth; and then, with apparent right, they have concluded: "We cannot expect to be like the first Christians." Thereby they have found an excuse for the crying contrast between the manifold dead mass-congregations among us and the apostolic congregations, and in part have further quieted themselves with the fleshly, self-satisfied thought that "it was another matter in former days," and "that we must be thankful that our congregations are as good as they are"; whereas the truth is this, that if the congregation is the work of God's Spirit, then our congregations too ought at least to become just as living and vigorous, just as bold in faith and patient, just as self-sacrificing and missionary as in the first Christian age.

For what do we find in this first apostolic age? First, Ananias and Sapphira and quarrels about food, as has already been mentioned. Next, that false teachings, grounded in the current Phariseism and the fleshly unwillingness to let oneself be saved by grace alone, to be justified by faith without the works of the Law, quite early stole into the congregation in Jerusalem and outside it.

In the Asiatic congregations this tendency was carried much further, in that they set up a peculiar worship of God (the worship of angels) and an exaggerated asceticism or self-denial, which in their opinion was especially meritorious, in place of faith and grace alone (Col. 2:18ff.; 1 Tim. 4:1ff.). On the other side, in many places people began to set worldly wisdom, long genealogies, and profane fables in place of the simple Gospel (1 Tim. 4:7; 6:20), to deny or explain away the resurrection (2 Tim. 2:18; 1 Cor. 15:12), to explain the Lord's return for fleshly advantage (2 Thess. 3:6), and to use Christian freedom for gain or as an occasion for the flesh (1 Tim. 6:5).

But not only that. Already early the spirit of falsehood and the lust to rule began to creep into the congregations. In the first Thessalonian epistle, which is the earliest letter we have from Paul, he warns against such as either spoke in his name or even sent false letters in his name (2 Thess. 2:2), for which reason at the end of the epistle he expressly calls attention to the way in which he writes his name. In Asia, he says that "all had turned away from him," and besides this he mentions explicitly two persons, Phygellus and Hermogenes. Demas forsook him out of love for the world, and Alexander the coppersmith had done him much evil (2 Tim. 4:10 and 14). Compare with this 2 Tim. 3:1ff.; likewise 2 Peter and the Epistle of Jude. John says that Diotrephes, who likes to be among the foremost, would not even acknowledge him, but refused to receive the brothers and cast them out of the congregation! (3 John 9ff.) And just as Jesus had done with His disciples, so Peter finds it necessary (1 Pet. 5:1ff.) to admonish the elders both against serving for the sake of gain and against lording it over the flock.

And this is not all. In almost every single epistle there are warnings not only against the above-mentioned perhaps somewhat finer spiritual sins, but also against all manner of gross vices, such as were readily carried over from a surrounding heathen world corrupted to the utmost, to which the members of the congregation had every temptation to fall back. (Eph. 5:3ff.; Col. 3:5ff.; 1 Thess. 4:3ff.; Gal. 5:13ff.; etc.)

For to Paul and the other New Testament writers the congregation does not stand forth as something loose and indefinite, something invisible and general, believers wherever they might be found, without regard to their outward visible union and assembly; rather, it stands forth as a distinct circle consisting of men and women, slaves and free, rich and poor, families and children, separated from the rest of the world by this their outward ordering and by the Word and the Spirit by which they had been separated, and in which nevertheless Satan had been able to produce all the deviations and defections and sins mentioned above.

In almost all the epistles Paul sends greetings to named persons in the congregation, and sends greetings not only from individual persons but from whole congregations, just as he also mentions Gospel work as proceeding from the individual congregations as a whole. In the Epistle to the congregation in Rome, where he himself had not personally been, he nevertheless mentions in his greeting by name so many that their number, including the greeted families, can scarcely be put at less than fifty persons. And if he had such knowledge of the individual members of a relatively unfamiliar congregation, how closely must he not have known the individual members in the congregations he himself had founded, such as, for example,

The Corinthian Congregation?

We will therefore dwell briefly on this. We have preserved for us in God's Word two epistles from Paul to this congregation, for which he expresses such heartfelt love and such deep concern.

What, then, was the condition in this congregation?

There were many and great faults. First factionalism: one held to Paul, one to Cephas, and so forth. There were gross sins of immorality, and worse still, a lack of that spirit of holiness which exercises discipline against open ungodliness. There were greed and litigiousness, so common both among Jews and Gentiles. There was carelessness with respect to the holy Lord's Supper, and class-pride, so that one held himself better than another, drank himself drunk at the meals, and let the poor brothers go hungry. There was spiritual pride over their great spiritual gifts, for which reason they also esteemed the more conspicuous gifts, such as tongues, above the simpler but more necessary gifts, prophecy, mutual brotherly admonition, and above all love. False fleshly teachings about the resurrection had crept in, and lukewarmness in Christian works of mercy. They allowed themselves to be led astray by false intruding brothers, who carried on intrigues against Paul and sought to destroy the fruit of his labor. Therefore he speaks sharp words of punishment over them and says: "I fear that, when I come, perhaps I shall not find you such as I wish, and that I shall be found by you such as you do not wish: that there be strife, jealousy, wrath, quarrels, slanders, whisperings, puffed-up pride, disorders; that when I come again, my God shall humble me among you, and I shall mourn over many who formerly sinned and have not repented of the uncleanness and fornication and sensuality which they have committed" (2 Cor. 12:20-21).

"I fear that, as the serpent deceived Eve by his cunning, so your minds shall be corrupted and led away from faithfulness to Christ" (2 Cor. 11:3). "Some of you have no knowledge of God; I say this to your shame" (1 Cor. 15:34), "and many among you are weak and sickly, and a whole multitude sleep" (1 Cor. 11:30).

And, as in Corinth, so there seems more or less, to judge from the exhortations of the apostles and from the seven epistles in Revelation, to have been great deficiencies in all the other congregations as well.

And yet Paul writes to this same Corinthian congregation: “I thank my God always for you, for the grace of God which is given you in Christ Jesus, that in Him you have been made rich in all things, in all utterance and knowledge, even as the testimony of Christ has been confirmed in you, so that you come behind in no gift of grace, as you wait for the revelation of our Lord Jesus Christ” (1 Cor. 1:4ff.).

And in the second Epistle to the Corinthians he says: “Make room for us! We have wronged no one, corrupted no one, taken advantage of no one. I do not say this to condemn you; for I said before that you are in our hearts, to die together and to live together. I have great confidence in you, I boast much of you, I am filled with comfort, I have an exceedingly great joy in all our affliction. For though I grieved you with that epistle, I do not regret it, though I did regret it; for I see that the epistle, though only for a time, grieved you. Now I rejoice, not that you were grieved, but that you were grieved unto repentance; for you were grieved according to God, so that you might in no way suffer loss through us. Therefore we have been comforted by your comfort; but we rejoiced far more over Titus’ joy, because his spirit has been refreshed by you all. For if I have boasted much of you to him, I have not been put to shame; but just as we spoke all things in truth to you, so also our boasting before Titus has become truth, and he has an exceedingly great love for you when he remembers the obedience of you all, how you received him with fear and trembling.”

Such was the composition of the first apostolic congregations. There were vessels unto honor and vessels unto dishonor. They were like a Christian still yet in the world, surrounded and permeated by its sin and entanglement; they were neither perfect, nor had they attained it. But they pressed on after it; they had the life of God’s Spirit in them; they had within themselves an unceasing witness concerning sin and righteousness and judgment, so that they were not allowed to sink either into security in sin, or into comfort drawn from pure doctrine or from holy living, but kept themselves awake unto a daily sorrow and daily repentance unto God.

And thus they were enabled to carry on the work of the Gospel in the world, though in weakness, yet in inward sincerity, in the power and love of Christ’s Spirit; and although the congregations formed neither an episcopal church nor a priestly order, yet there was among the congregations in their mutual relation a manifestation or realization of the unity of the Church such as has perhaps scarcely ever existed since.

3.18 The Congregations’ Free Connection

Just as the congregations in the apostolic age were, in the full sense of the word, free congregations, so also was their mutual connection. God’s Spirit and the love of Christ were that which held them together in unity around the common labor of bringing the Gospel to the ends of the earth.

Therefore, in the New Testament the word congregation is used both to denote the individual

local congregation and the unity of all the congregations, that which in our language is ordinarily expressed by the word “the Church,” the one holy catholic Church.

This is already beforehand an expression of the fact that all the congregations, according to their inward spiritual being, by the common doctrine of salvation and the common life of love, felt themselves to be one, and therefore would also find ways and means, as circumstances required or allowed, to give this unity a practical form in their relation one to another.

The first impulse was given by the persecution after Stephen’s murder.

Those who were scattered abroad (except the Apostles) preached the Gospel everywhere they came. That is the right spirit. The fruit was a considerable number of congregations, round about in Samaria, Galilee, Phoenicia, Syria, Cilicia, Cyprus, Cyrene, and no doubt also Egypt, Italy, and Babylon (see Acts 9:31 and Acts 11:10).

Of some of these congregations we hear later in passing, for example in Tyre and Caesarea and Ptolemais (Acts 21:4), but otherwise the Word of God contains no register of founded congregations; there was as yet no “church statistics.”

Yet their cooperation and inward connection were not for that reason any the less lively; both were promoted and guided by the persecutions. Of the means of connection the following may be named:

1. Messengers or Emissaries and Visitors

The most remarkable example of this is the congregation in Antioch, the first Gentile congregation. It sent out Paul and Barnabas on their first missionary journey together with Mark. The former therefore seems to have regarded this congregation as his headquarters, although it is not expressly mentioned that he was sent out more than that one time. As the Apostle to the Gentiles in a special sense, he afterwards journeyed about as the Spirit drove him, visited the congregations already founded and established new ones, and, as it seems, everywhere took fellow laborers and other messengers with him from the founded congregations (Silas, Timothy, Titus, Luke, Demas [Col. 4:14], Sosthenes, Gaius, and Aristarchus [Acts 19:29], etc.).

But what took place in Antioch we find clear traces of as having taken place in other congregations, although no special description of it is given in each particular case.

Thus Barnabas, after the dispute with Paul, continued the work together with Mark, it being mentioned that he went to Cyprus, without its being further stated where the journey afterwards led. The same Mark we find again considerably later in Babylon together with Peter (1 Pet. 5:13), and elsewhere with Timothy (2 Tim. 4:9).

From Jerusalem many envoys went out, not always of the best sort, round about through the lands, also where Paul had founded congregations, and in part even worked against him (Acts 15:24).

Aquila and Priscilla we find both in Corinth, Ephesus, and Rome, everywhere laboring for their Savior, so that they not only assist Paul, and win thanks from all the churches of the

Gentiles (1 Cor. 16:19), but also become the means of bringing Apollos all the way to a living faith in Christ and of making him a traveling instrument for the Gospel.

From Cenchreae the deaconess Phoebe travels to Rome and is commended by Paul.

In his greeting to the Romans Paul mentions five fellow laborers, among them a woman, Mary.

Paul sends Titus and Timothy and Tychicus and others from congregation to congregation.

In 1 Cor. 16:15 he mentions the household of Stephanas as one that has especially devoted itself to serving the saints, wherefore hospitality also is warmly recommended in so many places (Heb. 13:2; Rom. 12:13; 1 Tim. 4:9).

The congregation in Berea sent brethren to accompany Paul to Athens (Acts 17:14).

The Jerusalem congregation sent Judas and Barnabas with a letter to Antioch (Acts 13:21).

The congregations sent Paul with aid to Jerusalem (Acts 20:4; cf. 2 Cor., chs. 8 and 9).

Agabus came down from Judea (Acts 21:10); and in 11:28 Antioch sends Paul and Barnabas with aid to Jerusalem.

Disciples from Caesarea traveled with Paul from there in order to procure him lodging in Jerusalem with Mnason, an old disciple from Cyprus (Acts 21:15).

Disciples in Puteoli received Paul, and brethren from Rome met him (Acts 28:14), just as the great companies followed him with wives and children from Tyre (Acts 21:5).

The congregation in Corinth sent Stephanas, Fortunatus, and Achaicus to Paul in Ephesus (1 Cor. 16:17).

In 2 Cor. 8:18 a “brother” is mentioned who not only has praise for his zeal in the Gospel in all the congregations, but also “has been appointed by the congregations to travel with us with this gift,”

and in 8:23, Titus and our brethren are the congregations’ messengers and the glory of Christ.

In Phil. 4:15 Epaphroditus is called Paul’s brother and fellow laborer and fellow soldier, but the congregation’s (the Philippians’) messenger and minister to relieve Paul’s need.

Epaphras came to Paul, sent by the congregation in Colossae (Col. 4:12), perhaps also from Laodicea and Hierapolis.

From Thessalonica the Word sounded forth over Macedonia and Achaia and other places (1 Thess. 1:7).

In the Epistle to Titus (3:12) Paul says that he will send him Artemas or Tychicus, and asks him to help Zenas (the lawyer) and Apollos on their way, “that nothing be lacking unto them.”

Paul also sends the slave Onesimus to Philemon, and

Peter sends a letter by Silvanus (1 Pet. 5:12, 13).

2. Letters

were another excellent bond between the congregations, and testimony from the Word of God shows us that they also were diligently employed.

There were first letters from congregation to congregation. In Acts 15:22 we have in full a letter cited from the congregation in Jerusalem to the Gentile-Christian congregations which had already by that time been founded round about.

In several places letters of commendation from congregations and to congregations are mentioned, for example 2 Cor. 3:1 and 2 Thess. 2:2; in Acts 18:27 it is expressly communicated that the congregation (the brethren) in Ephesus sent a letter of commendation with Apollos to the congregations (the disciples) in Achaia and Corinth; and in 1 Cor. 16:3 Paul says that when he comes to Corinth, he will send their delegates with letters to Jerusalem in order to deliver the collected contributions; and so in other places.

Secondly, we have the significant collection of New Testament letters, besides hints of other letters not preserved, which more than anything else shows what an extraordinarily lively connection must have taken place between the congregations in this apostolic age. Paul's greetings in Romans 16 furnish an excellent illustration of this relation, as also does the sixteenth chapter of First Corinthians. It almost seems as though letter-writing replaced what in later times has been carried out by Christian literature.

That the congregations also, where occasion was given, held

3. Joint Meetings

is beyond doubt enough, although such are expressly mentioned only in a couple of places, namely Acts 15:1 ff. and 20:16 ff. More frequently, however, there is mention of

4. Mutual Aid

as one of the means by which the congregations were bound more closely to one another. Thus the congregation in Antioch sent aid to those in need in Jerusalem (Acts 11:29).

Paul had undertaken, as a part of his missionary activity among the Gentiles, to remember the poor in Jerusalem with aid (Gal. 2:10). In accordance with this, he also arranged a general collection for those in need in Judea and obtained delegates, chosen by the congregations, to accompany him in order to deliver the aid (2 Cor., chs. 8 and 9; 1 Cor. 16:1).

What intimate connection was in this way brought about between the congregations, Paul describes in 2 Cor. 9:12 ff.: "For the service rendered by this support not only supplies the needs of the saints, but also bears rich fruit through many thanksgivings to God, while they, because of the proved spirit which this support shows, glorify God for the obedience of your confession to the Gospel of Christ and for your sincere liberality toward them and toward all, while they also in their prayer for you long after you because of God's exceeding grace toward you. But thanks be to God for His unspeakable gift!"

This is the true Christian spirit of fellowship.

Thus it also manifested itself in the aid which the congregation in Philippi sent Paul several

times, while he labored among congregations from whom he would receive no wages (Phil. 4:15–16).

5. Mutual Prayer

was thus also one of the most powerful means by which the spiritual bond and the consciousness of unity in Christ were strengthened and maintained.

6. Shared Orderings

we also find in the New Testament several traces of, as testimonies to, a vigorous and living sense of unity among the free congregations.

In Acts 14:23 it is related how Paul and Barnabas, on the return journey, traveled through the congregations which they had founded on the first missionary journey and had them choose elders in every congregation. In 1 Cor. 11:2 Paul praises the Corinthians because they hold fast the ordinances which he delivered to them, and after having given some most necessary admonitions concerning the Supper, he closes the chapter with the words: "The rest I will set in order when I come."

In the First Epistle to Timothy he gives determinations with regard to the choosing of elders or bishops and deacons, "in order," as he says, "that you may know how one ought to conduct oneself in God's House, which is the congregation of the living God." In the fifth chapter of the same epistle he gives rules for the choice of "widows," as likewise concerning the relation to the elders. Other examples may be adduced; but this is enough to show that fellowship in shared order is not of slight importance for the connection between free congregations.

3.19 Free Fellowship between Free Congregations

We have thus shown that there was indeed an exceedingly lively and extensive free fellowship between the free New Testament congregations, and that, despite differences of place and nationality, by their mutual connection they gave a powerful expression to the holy Church or congregation (Eph. 2:12ff. and 4:15–16).

The question now is this: Are we the same congregation as then? Are we of the same kind and essence as they? For if that is so, then such a fellowship must by God's grace also be possible among us.

I hold that there is only one congregation, the same both in Heaven and on earth, and that if therefore there is at all a congregation of God among us, then it is the same as in the time of the apostles.

It was not the apostles' distinguished fear of God that brought forth the congregation. They had to wait until God's Spirit was poured out upon them; only then did there come to be a congregation.

It is God's Spirit who brings forth the congregation, whether among them or among us. There may be great difference in outward circumstances, as in inward development and gifts, but the Spirit is the same.

There is difference among human beings; they may be strong or weak, great or small, sick or healthy, children or old, dying or newborn: yet they all remain human beings; indeed, a dead human being is still a human being and not an animal, and what it lacks is not human nature, but life.

So also with the congregation. It is God's Spirit who, through the Word and the Sacraments, brings forth the congregation in believing human hearts now as then. And the Word and the Sacraments we have, and God's Spirit still works through them to this very day and is received in faith by penitent hearts, so that the congregation, with its salt and its leaven, does in truth exist among us.

So far as that is concerned, there is nothing to hinder free fellowship.

It is true, there is also difference both in inward conditions and in outward circumstances, some to the harm and others to the benefit of a free fellowship.

In one respect there is great likeness between us and the first congregations, namely this, that we too here in the land must make, as it were, a new beginning.

But in another respect there is just as great a difference, namely this, that among us, in a so-called Christian country, especially since we have come out of a State Church, where by the outward civil arrangements themselves one is, so to speak, forced into the congregation, there is almost no difference between the congregation and the world. This has worked incalculable harm for the congregation also here in the land, without thereby abolishing it, although it may with justice, and indeed in far too many cases, be said to our congregations as John says to the congregation in Sardis: "I know your works, that you have a name for being alive, and yet you are dead."

On the other hand, Christianity has not through these many hundreds of years been without influence upon the world either. Through so-called civilization it has to some degree permeated the world, its ways of thinking and its legislation, with the fundamental principles of Christian morality. At the same time as outward persecution has therefore almost wholly ceased, Christian and worldly morality have unfortunately often been mingled together.

At the same time, the means of outward connection have also, especially in the last century, been developed and refined to a high degree. It is now easier for one congregation to send a messenger of the Gospel to the end of the world than it was for Paul and other messengers of the congregations to come from the one end of the Mediterranean to the other.

Because of the development of the art of printing, it is now possible to place into the hand of every single member of the congregation the book which even Luther, only four hundred years ago, regarded it almost as an inestimable treasure to be able personally to own. The Bible, the source of life and faith both for the congregations and for individual Christians, can and ought now to be found in every house and can thus form the inward living bond between free congregations in a greater extent than even in the apostolic age.

A no less significant bond between our Lutheran congregations is formed by the Catechism. After long controversies it has now no doubt been acknowledged by the greatest part of our Church here as the congregation's own possession, the greatest blessing which the Lutheran

Reformation has bestowed upon the Norwegian Church, a pure and simple presentation of the order of salvation grounded upon the Word and upon the Word alone. With the Lutheran Catechism in its hand and in its heart, the congregation can independently decide what is pure doctrine according to God's Word in contrast to all sorts of hair-splitting clerical babblings and theological speculations. By virtue of the Catechism, the congregation can therefore defend itself against the spirit-devouring theological controversies which both immediately after the apostolic age and in the Lutheran Church have again and again undermined all living Christianity. In the Catechism, therefore, our congregations in this land possess not only an advantage even over against the apostolic age, but also a spiritual basis of unity which, rightly used in connection with the awakening of new life, will form a stronger basis of fellowship between free Lutheran congregations than the most priestly systems of social organization.

But in other respects we stand immeasurably far behind the congregations of the New Testament age. The three ecclesial principles of unity mentioned above have in the course of centuries set their almost indelible carnal mark upon all church bodies. Among us too, the congregations, and with them often also believing pastors, have become so bound in chains by the so-called social organizations, by church politics and clerical regimes, that the congregation has almost forgotten that it exists for any other reason than purely outward ecclesiastical ends. Naturally the congregations have become unable to stir themselves for the high purposes for which the congregation has been set in the world, the mutual coming to one another and help toward the spread of God's Kingdom, which Paul so movingly depicts in Eph. 4:11-16, but which in most church bodies has been made into a mere clergy matter. Who has heard of congregations as such meeting together for mutual edification and encouragement in a State Church or a clerical society? And yet behold what intimate brotherly fellowship took place between the congregations in Christianity's first century!

But worse still, and essentially as a consequence of the congregations' state of bondage under the yoke of the clergy, a great multitude of our congregations are dead and thus altogether unfit to carry out the holy task God has entrusted to them. It is with this before his eyes that the apostle cries out in the letter to the congregation in Sardis: "Be watchful, and strengthen what remains, which is about to die!"

There is therefore, as said at the beginning, one presupposition indispensably necessary if the congregations are to be able to establish a free and living fellowship of unity among themselves, namely this, that they themselves become made alive, set free in Christ.

Praise be to the Lord! It is precisely this presupposition that is beginning to be realized among us, and which on the whole makes it possible to speak with hope of "free fellowship between free congregations," or, what is the same thing, the building up of a true and living Free Church among us. Tribulations and sufferings have in this respect wrought wonders among us as in the first Christian age; from many of our congregations in all church bodies there is heard of awakenings; the Lord has raised up particular instruments for this work of help in distress and will raise up more. The song of the turtledove has once more begun to sound, and the congregations to awaken to spiritual self-consciousness; and however weak and frail many may be, like bruised reeds and smoldering wicks, and however anxious and troubled believing pastors round about may feel, there is nevertheless now felt both obligation and

need for a free and living fellowship between the awakening congregations, and for a fruitful cooperation, unhampered by social bonds, for the living building up of God's Kingdom both among ourselves mutually and among the heathen.

Small and groping attempts we have already made, and the Lord has not withheld His blessing. What now matters is only in childlike faith to set the course straight for the goal, in all things to let oneself be guided by the star of Bethlehem, God's Word and the first congregation. To the right and to the left we see shipwreck and ruins, congregations and peoples fallen into spiritual bondage under the spirit-extinguishing scepter of clerical rule. In the New Testament age we still see the congregation filled with God's Spirit and unbound by the later episcopate and state rule; Christ's freedom and an intimate fellowship of the Spirit united these congregations into one spiritual body, without priestly rule and social chains.

Thither, then, we must steer. We have shown that our congregation, though in great frailty, is nevertheless the same congregation of Christ as in the time of the apostles; for there is only one. The free fellowship which was possible for the first congregations must therefore by God's grace and the mighty working of His Spirit also be possible among us. Only we must go to the work with faith in the power of God's Spirit alone, and not lose courage over the many difficulties, and because that seems new which is nevertheless as old as God's Word.

This lecture has already grown beyond the bounds for an essay intended for the annual report. We can therefore only in all possible brevity indicate the means through which free congregations after the New Testament pattern might come into free, living, and intimate fellowship of the Spirit with one another. Most of these means are neither unknown nor untried.

For the sake of clarity we may divide them into two great branches:

1. Mutual Help.

It will be rendered in general by the congregations' coming into a closer, so to speak personal, relation to one another and visiting one another as one family visits and in many ways assists another.

First, by remembering one another in prayer, just as one person prays for another person. By emissaries or messengers, pastors or laymen, who, each with his particular gifts, are so to speak exchanged from congregation to congregation, so that one congregation might thereby make good what the other lacks. By letters to one another and joint gatherings for edification for those congregations that are near enough to one another for this.

Second, by meetings, conversation meetings, larger or smaller, for mutual instruction and admonition, and for a deeper penetration into God's Word and the Catechism. Joint meetings for children and special revival meetings between congregations according to that remarkable word of Paul in Rom. 1:11, where he says with respect to the congregation at Rome: "For I long to see you, that I may impart to you some spiritual gift, so that you may be strengthened, that is, that I together with you may be encouraged among you by the faith we share, both yours and mine."

2. Cooperation.

First and foremost through mission work, both at home and abroad.

Next, through works of mercy of every kind, deaconess homes, hospitals, children's homes, etc.

Third, through the spread of edifying and awakening literature, papers and books, with special regard to the congregation, its nature and work, so that the congregations might thereby have a constant spiritual meeting place, for the exchange of thoughts and mutual encouragement to watch and pray and endure in the conflict.

Finally, fourth, through schools for the education of pastors and teachers and for the preservation of an unadulterated Word of God, which Satan has often used the keenest scholars to distort. "For we do not wrestle against flesh or blood, but against principalities, against powers, against the rulers of the world who rule in the darkness of this age, against the spiritual host of wickedness under heaven." It is for these purposes no less than for pastoral work that a school for pastors, conducted in God's Spirit with every competence, is altogether indispensable, especially for a Free Church.

This is surely only a scattered indication of what possibilities and means are present and needed for a "free fellowship between free congregations."

Continued treatment and practical experience will by God's gracious assistance demonstrate that a Lutheran Free Church in the sense in which it has here been presented, and will no doubt be acknowledged by this meeting, is not any mere thought-experiment or an unattainable ideal, but truly the old, good church order given by God's Word itself, in contrast to all priestly rule, denominational tyranny, and the state-church system.

3.20 On the Free Church's "Leading Principles"

Georg Sverdrup

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3.20.1 According to God's Word, the congregation is the proper form of the Kingdom of God on earth

As I have been urged to write a little by way of elucidation of the Free Church's principles and rules, I am grateful for the opportunity which *Folketbladet* has kindly granted me, so that these reflections may reach as many as possible among the people of the Free Church.

And it is also fortunate that we have come so far that, in the midst of struggle and opposition, we can calmly consider our own work without looking to the right or to the left.

A Lutheran Free Church is also something so new that it is not strange if many pause short and think the matter over.

The committee which from the beginning prepared drafts of rules for the Free Church's work had a very difficult task. It was forbidden to try to form a new faction, at the same time as it was charged with promoting cooperation among free congregations.

But in difficulties of this kind God's Word shows the way. And for us the only question is to find that "way out" which the New Testament shows, and no other.

For above all other principles in the Free Church stands the decisive authority of God's Word in the matter of the congregation and in church polity, fully as much as in the question of doctrine.

It is therefore not by cleverness and subtle ingenuity that we try to find the way; it is by childlike fidelity to the Lord's Word. And therefore there are no living Christians who cannot and ought not to take part in the solution of the congregational question; for the light of the Word shines no less for the simple than for the wise and understanding, and most of all for the former, so that no one is exempt from occupying himself seriously and sincerely with all that belongs to the Kingdom of God. And next to the question of the salvation of the individual soul, there is no more important question than that of the congregation.

"The Kingdom of God is near" is John's cry, and the preaching of Jesus and His disciples before the outpouring of the Spirit. Since then it may be said that Christian preaching, in this respect, sounds thus: "The Kingdom of God is here." Yet of course always coming anew and ever reaching farther to more, according to the second petition in the Lord's Prayer.

The Kingdom of God has its inner essence, which is righteousness, peace, and joy in the Holy Spirit. It also has its outward form, which is the congregation, the Spirit's people in the world.

It was Jesus' purpose in His coming into the world to bring the Kingdom of God. And He would not only bring a spiritual benefaction into hearts, but He would also have a new society, to which He Himself has given the name congregation.

What Jesus willed, that He fulfilled by death, resurrection, ascension, and the outpouring of the Spirit. Then the Kingdom of God came in the form of the congregation, with power to live and grow and propagate itself, so that "the new creation" might become manifold and fill the earth as the old did; but by new means, God's Word and Spirit, this enlargement and extension was to take place.

For this form of the Kingdom of God, which is the congregation, all the apostles and all the first Christians thereafter labored, because the Spirit drove them to it. And within the revelation of the New Testament there is no mention of any other form for the Kingdom of God.

We hold that in the New Testament there is no mention of any bishopric over, or within, more than one congregation, nor of any papacy, nor of any church department, nor of any church council or council or synod. There is a congregation in every place where there are Christians, and this congregation has its elders or bishops; but there is no "church government" of any kind.

It is a sign of decline and decay that, not long after the days of the apostles, men began to get "church governments" of one kind or another over greater or smaller parts of the church, and thereby thought to obtain a better form of the Kingdom of God. In the actual history of the church there has never at any time been any common church government over the whole

Christian church. Nor is there any such thing now in our own day.

It therefore seems to us an unreasonable and unjust demand when it is now often presented in such a way that all congregations are obliged to belong to this or that outward association, so that they may come under the proper church government. Those are called anarchists who do not regard a common church government as necessary and as a compulsory matter. But what was not found in the apostolic age, what has never since existed in the church, and what does not exist in the present time, can scarcely be necessary to Christianity. For if this were necessary, then there has hitherto never been the right kind of Christianity.

For the Kingdom of God it is, according to the New Testament, necessary to have congregation, but we cannot see that any other outward organization over the congregation is a necessary part of Christianity.

It is therefore a principle in the Free Church, which bows only to God's Word and to nothing else, that the congregation is a sufficient form of the Kingdom of God, and that no other form is required from the outpouring of the Spirit until Christ's return. But according to God's will, revealed in His Word, the congregation is in return absolutely necessary where it is possible. Where a single Christian lives alone in prison or under some other constraint, the lack of a congregation will not become for him unto perdition; but where Christians can be a congregation and will not, there is surely great danger for their souls.

As to whether councils, synods, popes, and church departments, which are not commanded in God's Word, have done more good or harm, we cannot judge; God knows.

Among us here in America these authorities over the congregations have in any case contributed much to factionalism and other sin.

Nothing, therefore, can be more timely and more required among us than a work that aims at the restoration of the congregation in biblical, and especially in New Testament, form. And there is nothing that works more discouragingly upon a Christian mind than to see that so many Lutheran pastors oppose this cause with great zeal.

If it is good for Christian people and for the Kingdom of God on earth that congregation be gathered, and if it is God's Spirit that gathers congregation, why does one not grant the people this good?

In many places the only question is whether the people want a pastor. When it became a matter of serious inquiry whether they also wanted congregation, then the opposition also began in earnest from the side of many pastors. But if the congregation is a great and glorious divine blessing, for the sake of which Christ has come and the Spirit has been poured out, why does one not want human beings to become partakers in it?

3.20.2 The congregation consists of believing human beings, who by the use of the means of grace and the gifts of grace according to the direction of God's Word seek their own salvation and eternal blessedness, and that of all their fellow human beings.

The congregation is the fulfillment of Moses' sigh and prayer in Num. 11:29: "Would that all the Lord's people were prophets, would that the Lord would put his Spirit upon them!"

The congregation is the fulfillment of David's song in Psalm 110:3: "Your people come willingly in the day of your power; in holy splendor your youth come to you like dew from the womb of the dawn."

The congregation is the fulfillment of Jeremiah's prophecy in Jer. 31:33: "But this is the covenant that I will make with the house of Israel after those days, says the Lord: I will put my Law within them and write it in their hearts, and I will be their God, and they shall be my people; and they shall no more teach each his neighbor and each his brother, saying, Know the Lord; for they shall all know me, both small and great, says the Lord; for I will forgive their iniquity and remember their sin no more."

The congregation is the fulfillment of Joel's prophecy in Joel 3:1: "And it shall come to pass afterward that I will pour out my Spirit upon all flesh, and your sons and your daughters shall prophesy; your old shall dream dreams, your young men shall see visions; and also upon the menservants and upon the maidservants in those days will I pour out my Spirit."

And a multitude of other testimonies from the Old Testament might be brought forward, which bear witness that the Lord in the fullness of time would set a new people of God upon the earth, who should not suffer under the deficiencies under which the old Israel suffered.

What the prophets always complained of in the old Israel was this, that it answered so poorly to its calling and its election, because there were so few who were truly filled with the Lord's Spirit and had living faith. Most had sunk into spiritual lifelessness and formalism, not to mention that many even lived outright in sheer worldliness and gross idolatry.

But the Lord promises that the sighing of his children shall be heard and their complaint and lack remedied, and the day shall dawn, a "morning without clouds," when a new people of God shall be born, like the dew from the womb of the dawn, in which all shall have the Spirit, and all shall have forgiveness of sins, and all shall have the Law written in their hearts, and all shall know the Lord, and all shall prophesy.

These are indeed the promises. It is against these that one sins altogether, when one teaches that two or three Christians in each assembly are enough to make a congregation out of it.

Jesus Christ himself says: "You are Peter, and upon this rock I will build my congregation." And already from that one ought to understand that congregation is not merely a place where God's Word is preached and the Sacraments administered, or a district with geographical boundaries, or a gathering of hearers of God's Word. No, Christ's congregation consists precisely of the same kind of Spirit-filled persons as Simon son of Jonah, whose knowledge and confession were not of flesh and blood, but from the Father in heaven.

And what the prophets had foretold, and Jesus promised, that God did when he sent the Spirit at Pentecost after Jesus' resurrection and ascension. Then the congregation was born; and the signs that accompanied the birth are precisely the signs of the Spirit and of life, in order that it may be established for all times that where there is not the mighty power of the Spirit, and where there is not the fire of love, and where there is not united witness to the Lord's great work, there is no congregation.

This newborn congregation was a visible company of human beings. Not only the Word and the Sacraments were visible; the persons who constituted the congregation were visible. The sound of the mighty storm-wind was heard out through the city, so that the multitude came together; the tongues of fire which settled upon each of them showed who it was the Lord had filled with the Spirit; the witness to the Lord's great works was heard, and those speaking were seen by all, both believers and unbelievers.

So far the congregation is visible; and when 3,000 were added to the congregation by baptism, then the congregation was still visible. And when all those who believed were steadfast in the apostles' teaching and the fellowship and the breaking of bread and the prayers, and when they were of one accord daily in the temple, and when they were together and had all things in common, then it was a visible congregation of believing human beings.

Was all this then a mistake, a fanaticism without meaning and without significance for the future? Was this a misunderstanding which history was to correct? Or was it the light, the light of the Spirit and of truth, which was to shine for souls and for congregations through all times until Christ's return?

We hold that this was the truth and is the truth and remains the truth; and that what is called congregation is bound to examine itself by this light.

One says that it is meaningless, for all know that we cannot rise to this pattern. But is not Jesus Christ a pattern for us, and are we not bound to walk as he walked? We know indeed that we cannot attain it; but does it not become us then to live in acknowledgment of sin and humility? And for the congregation even this would already be an advance, if it would begin to live in repentance instead of in carnal security and self-assurance. Hold up the light, and be assured that it never becomes too bright in the Church.

But is it impossible? Is it impossible for us to repent and believe in Jesus Christ? Let us not give up hope for the conversion of any human being or any member of the congregation. So long as there is life, there is hope. The Lord will pour out his Spirit upon all flesh; the question is whether all flesh is ready to receive the Spirit; for Spirit cannot be forced upon anyone.

Thus according to the New Testament there can be no doubt about the essence of the congregation. It is the people of the Spirit, so that it extends exactly as far as the working of God's Spirit. It is Christ's body, it is Jesus' bride, it is God's living temple of living stones, it is God's household and his dwelling in the Spirit.

One will say, yes, that is the whole Church; it is so good, but each little congregation is so poor.

Not at all. That first congregation in Jerusalem was indeed both the whole Christian Church and the single local congregation. On that day the one was no greater or wider in extent than the other. And nothing has ever become good by becoming large. The congregation is the “little Church,” as the learned are wont to say. And by that is meant that all that the Church has, the congregation also has; and all that the Church is, the congregation also is. And besides, it is surely clear to all thinking people that each single little part of a building can more easily be good and strong and complete than the whole building; for among 100 stones a bad stone may easily be found, while perhaps the 99 may be good stones; and while the one bad stone does not alter the 99 good stones each in itself, it can nevertheless do much harm to the whole building. In any case it is clear that the responsibility falls upon each single congregation; it is that which first and foremost is to be God’s house and the body of Jesus Christ.

But if the congregation consists of believing human beings, is it thereby meant that it is perfect, that is, without sin?

No, by no means. The Christian persons are not perfect, but shall become so. Or was it not said to Peter—perhaps the very same day he was called the rock—Get behind me, Satan! There is no perfect congregation before the resurrection of the dead.

Let us await him who is to come again to fetch the bride to the wedding of the Lamb, and let not the bride fail to prepare herself. And while we wait, let this be our daily prayer: Come, Lord Jesus, come soon! For where this expectation stiffens, whether because one has sunk back into the world, or because one thinks one has already come to the goal, there the congregation is no longer living.

The congregation has means of grace and gifts of grace, with and by which it works. The common explanation, that the congregation has means of grace, and that it has the power and authority to choose whom it will, believer or unbeliever, to administer them, only provided he “has passed his examination,” is not Christian, even if it suits well our state-church institutions and usages. The congregation also has gifts of grace, if it is faithful in its calling. Indeed every believer has his gift of grace and is bound to use it for the edification of Christ’s body.

For all means and all gifts have this one goal, which is the same as the salvation of souls, or the spread and growth of the Kingdom at home and abroad. We are all called to work in the vineyard, each according to his ability and gift, each with his pound. And whatever our station in life may be, if we are in the congregation, then this is our calling: to live for God and for his Kingdom, to labor for it with all the zeal that God’s Spirit works and Christ’s love creates.

For if the congregation is the people of God’s Spirit, then it is the instrument of God’s love upon earth. But God’s love is in a wholly particular sense that which seeks after the lost in order to save it. For many reasons it is necessary to lay great weight upon this last point just now. For the strayed and scattered sheep are surely not far from any one of us. And this is the most important of all signs of life in the congregation, that it wills to have all the lost saved. All those here at home, all those out there, all in the Christian lands, all heathen who do not know God. World-embracing is the congregation’s calling, and yet the work for its

fulfillment is so near at hand that it sounds to every soul: Go today into my vineyard!

If the believers in each outward congregation will begin this work, then there will soon be change among us, and in the midst of our spiritless age it will become manifest that God's Spirit is still mighty to bring forth congregation.

3.20.3 According to the New Testament, the congregation needs an outward organization, with a register of its members, election of officers, fixed times and places for its assemblies, etc.

The congregation, which from the beginning is born of the Spirit, can live only by the Spirit. Therefore the Spirit's means, the Word and the Sacraments, are the means by which the life of the congregation is propagated and preserved. It is only Baptism, the Word, and the Lord's Supper that can bring forth a living congregation and sustain it, when these means are rightly used.

It appears that some have come upon the thought that it is the organization and the constitution that decide the matter. And perhaps it is not so few who have this thought, though in somewhat different fashion. Some think that if a person only enters the orthodox congregation, then he is a Christian; for the congregation, after all, consists of Christians. Others think that if a person enters our congregation and is acknowledged by us as a Christian, then it is—if not certain—yet at least probable, that he is a Christian. Both sides—as opposite as they are to one another—perhaps lay greater weight upon the organization and the constitution than is right. For neither can a constitution or organization make alive, nor can it sustain life.

Nevertheless, we maintain with full conviction that the congregation needs an outward organization, and that this need is already known and met in the New Testament: the Lord did not conclude the revelation of and concerning the congregation before the need had shown itself and had been remedied.

We lay no little weight upon this matter, since there are not so few voices to be heard which reject and almost despise every outward organization of the congregation.

The necessity of this outward organization is not the same kind of necessity as that of grace and of the Word and of the Sacraments. That is to say, it does not serve directly for the creation and sustaining of life. But surely we can say that it serves directly for the preservation and protection of life.

In other words, organization does nearly the same service for the congregation that good clothing and a good house do for a man or a family. And this service is by no means so very small under most circumstances.

As the body exists before the clothes, so also the congregation exists in the New Testament before the outward organization. It is the congregation that itself organizes itself by counting and recording its members, by choosing its officers, by determining when and where one shall assemble, and how things shall proceed in the assemblies. These things, and perhaps others that someone might mention, are clearly and plainly set forth in the New Testament; and

without doubt Christian people do well to heed them, for he who will not heed the will of God also in such matters cannot expect divine blessing in full measure.

That the congregation may count its members and keep them in a register follows, according to the testimony of the New Testament, quite straightforwardly from the fact that it receives its members by Baptism. To baptize is in its form such an outward act that it is very simple to count how many are baptized. That none was compelled by civil law to be baptized, and that none was baptized who did not confess his sins and his faith in the risen Jesus, is surely self-evident to every attentive reader of the Bible. But, as said, this outward act made the persons easy to know and to count.

And that the congregation had to choose officers and make other determinations—which arose rather from the congregation’s imperfection than from its perfection—involved the use of the vote, which according to Acts 6:2 and other places belonged to “the whole multitude of the disciples,” so that there was no difference of rank between governors and governed; they were all sharers in the government, if they were members of the congregation.

There is also no doubt that from the beginning the congregation had its regular assemblies, and that these assemblies, in all their unique freedom, were nevertheless beautifully and decently ordered. Read Paul’s movingly simple description of the assembly in 1 Corinthians 14:26: “What then, brothers, is to be done? When you come together, each one has a psalm, he has a teaching, he has a tongue, he has a revelation, he has an interpretation; let all be done for edification.” And the following verses in the same chapter give still more exact insight into the life and the order that were found in the assemblies. There is no stiffness and no excited vehemence; there is also no disorder, and no arbitrary self-exaltation of one at another’s expense.

Surely, the Lord has not left His congregation to human cleverness and subtlety, as many think, so that we have no instruction concerning “church polity” in the Bible, but must speculate our way to something “suited to the times”; there is light enough for the congregation in the New Testament, and it is not worth while to let anyone persuade himself that it does not fit “in our time.” It did not suit worldly people any better then than it does now. It always has been and will continue to be foolishness to the Greeks and an offense to the Jews, together with the crucified Christ and His congregation.

And here there is only one thing that we will point to in conclusion, and which perhaps some will think a little about. Every Christian congregation ought to be fully self-sustaining in the question of its own edification. For three or four congregations to have one pastor in common is a rather imperfect arrangement; and it becomes so defective that it is almost intolerable when there can be no service because the pastor does not come. When the congregation does not even assemble every Sunday, how then can it be expected that life and fellowship should thrive? If the congregation cannot assemble for edification when the pastor does not come, then every congregation ought to have its own pastor, and it should surely prove that this was not too much. And if a congregation has become so far Christian that it can build itself up with God’s Word even when the pastor is ill or in the neighboring congregation, then with a little experience it will surely discover that the more living the congregation is, the more it will need the pastor’s labor.

I know that some will answer that it costs too much, and to that I will say nothing more than this, that the first congregations were scarcely so rich as is commonly the case among us; yet they met their expenses chiefly on account of their strong organization. At this point too, some of the clever heads of our time could learn much by studying the New Testament and its instruction for ordering the financial affairs of the congregation. And there is no doubt that in this matter also better results would be attained by strict accordance with Scripture than by all sorts of worldly contrivances and arrangements.

If our people would bestow as much diligence upon the congregation's organization as upon the so-called societies, then the whole aspect of churchly work would be quite different from what it now is.

Whether one dissolves the congregation by laying all weight upon the church association, or one dissolves the congregation by laying all weight upon the individual person, one does equal harm and acts equally wrongly. In the final result, for the dissolution of the congregation, there is no difference between the stiffest high-churchmen and the loosest "free-free." Both parties, in truth, abolish the congregation.

Hold fast to the congregation, and take pains with its exact and careful organization! Only a well-organized and united congregation is fully capable of labor. For organization is in truth nothing other than every man and every woman at his or her post and in his or her work.

3.20.4 Since not all members of the congregation's outward organization are always believing people, and since such hypocrites often take false comfort from their outward connection with the congregation, it is the congregation's holy calling to cleanse itself both by awakening proclamation of the Word of God, by earnest admonition and reminder, and by exclusion of open and obstinate sinners.

The congregation consists in reality of believing people. And just as every human being is instructed by the Word of God that he cannot be saved and blessed except through faith in Jesus, so all are likewise instructed by the Word of God that only when they are true believers are they also actual members of the congregation.

When, however, there is question of the congregation's outward organization, then the Word of God and Christian experience down through church history bear witness that it both can and will happen that such persons are included in the organization as do not in spirit and truth belong to the congregation. Likewise, that it can and will happen that some, who began in the Spirit, end in the flesh, or fall away from the faith in their hearts, even though they retain the outward connection with the congregation's organization. For these things take place in the heart's secret hiddenness, and there are no definite outward signs of them.

This fact has its simple explanation in this, that the congregation's outward organization must take account of the outward signs and marks of the congregation or of Christian life, and cannot judge the hidden state of the heart.

We say that the Word of God bears witness to this fact. And then we think not so much of the seven parables mentioned, as of the Acts of the Apostles, the Epistles, and the Revelation

of John.

For of Jesus' parables one may indeed rightly say that they speak rather of the effect of the Word in general than specifically of the congregation's organization. For example, when the kingdom is compared with a dragnet that catches good fish and rotten fish, then the net is rather the Gospel in its work upon human souls than it is the congregation's outward organization. Yet it is also right to say that at least several of the parables can be applied to the congregation's organization, as for example the workers in the vineyard and the ten virgins.

But when we read the Acts of the Apostles and the Epistles and the Revelation, then we receive a full and clear light upon this matter, that the organized congregations, according to their outward boundaries, comprise not only vessels of gold and silver, but also of wood and clay, and some for honor, others for dishonor. It is also clearly shown that the New Testament contains the truth as it is applied to the most various spiritual conditions, and it is presupposed that these are found within the organized congregations.

In other words, just as each individual Christian is never all that he ought to be, so it is also with the congregation, and admonition, warning, encouragement, comfort and consolation, instruction and teaching must be used within the congregation's outward organization, in order that the sleeping may awake, the wavering be kept from falling, the doubting be established in the truth, and so forth. As a rule, the whole Word of God will find its application within the congregation; at any rate the apostolic Epistles, with their varying content and their many exhortations, were written to Christian congregations.

It almost awakens astonishment, and it ought to awaken horror, that it was so already in the first congregations. Yet God had in a quite particular way governed all things so that the congregation's outward organization from the beginning should comprise believing people and no others.

What was John the Baptist's work other than to prepare for the Lord a people made ready, that is, to prepare the congregation by preaching repentance and baptism? Within the people of the old covenant there was by John's ministry to take place a separation of those who would truly flee from the judgment and receive salvation. And John set as the separating mark the baptism of repentance, with which he baptized those who confessed their sins. And after John had thus worked in Israel in a separating and setting-apart manner, Jesus came, and He did not establish the congregation while the people by the thousands thronged around Him and wanted to make Him king; He waited until persecution and crucifixion and death had frightened away all who had carnal and worldly notions concerning Him and the kingdom. And only when the flock had become so little that it seemed wholly useless as a beginning to the kingdom, only then did Jesus make this little flock into a congregation by sending it His Spirit.

Truly, there is something solemn in this that God has done in order to prepare and bring forth the congregation. And those are not right who teach that this was mere exaggeration and fanaticism, and who think that they know much better what the congregation is and ought to be than John and Jesus and the Spirit of truth Himself.

And yet unworthy, hypocritical people pressed their way into the congregation's outward organization. And while this fact at the same time speaks loudly of the power of divine truth, in that it shows that man gladly wants to appear to be on the right way, even when he is not, this fact must nevertheless strike us with horror at human falsehood and wickedness, that they will sneak in by dishonest means there where only the highest degree of sincerity and honest acknowledgment of sin gives rightful access.

It is therefore not to be wondered at if in the so-called congregations of our own time also we find many false members. But it is in truth both to be wondered at and to be horrified over, that there are ministers who teach that this is right and proper.

When for centuries one has by the power of the Law, the ban, and the national church forced people into the church (we will not even call such a thing a congregation), then of course it is self-evident that matters must be in a bad state. And matters are in a bad state. Not merely because gross vices are found in the midst of the great majority of congregations, but most of all because one makes no attempt whatever to return to the congregation's concept and essence.

What then is to be done about it? Fold the hands in the lap and comfort ourselves that we are, after all, not Sodom and Gomorrah?

Is that any comfort? Or is it not written: It shall be more tolerable for Sodom and Gomorrah on the Day of Judgment than for you? Where then is the comfort?

No, what is to be done? First and foremost the same as John the Baptist and Jesus and the apostles did. That is the main thing, and all else is secondary, though it belongs to the work as well.

And we all know what these did; but there is so frightfully little done in following after them.

They preached the Word without favor and without fear; wholly and truly, personally and directly, without respect of persons.

And this is and remains the main thing: light, light, and yet more light in the church. It never becomes too bright, nor bright enough. And upon this the congregation's true thriving depends. In the light from God, the good thrives, just as surely as the evil fails to thrive. In God's truth there is nourishment for the souls that seek the truth; in God's truth there is also cutting judgment over all dishonest and hypocritical hearts. Let the truth sound forth in full, and there shall come both brokenness and resistance, both faith and hardening, both love and hatred.

But the truth is Jesus Christ. Only by a real preaching of Christ does a congregation come into being. Let that sound forth, and the congregation is built and grows and is strengthened; put something else in its place, however popular it may be, and the congregation sinks into a swamp and is corrupted and loses more and more of its true essence and its true strength.

This is the struggle for life in the congregation. It must be kept going all the time, as long as the congregation is here below. It never stops, except where spiritual death takes complete control.

And God, who is rich in mercy, has graciously led and ordered it so that even where everything seems to be death and sleep, He has raised up or sent instruments that have kindled the fire again where it had been extinguished.

But where the proclamation is as it should be, there comes another means in addition, which we also will mention: work.

The congregation lives and exists in order to work. It is a gathering of workers. The congregation is not organized unless there is work for all. It is not a congregation where a gathering of people “hire” a minister to work for them, so that they may be spared it themselves. No, the congregation may in that respect be likened to a choir, which must have a choirmaster to lead and instruct it. Shall the instructor sing alone? Shall not all take part? So it is in the congregation; it is a gathering of God’s servants, men and women, who labor for God’s kingdom, for Christ’s cause. The leader does not become superfluous, but all the more necessary in such a company.

But this work will also help to raise up the congregation and keep it free from worldliness. If all have enough to do with spiritual work and spiritual interests, then worldly elements will surely find the congregation quite a narrow place.

Let the work become so heavy to flesh and blood that it becomes a real cross to bear in Jesus’ footsteps, and it shall help the congregation exceedingly much to be truly a congregation. Then the point will not be to become many in order to make it easy, but the point will be to become living strong, in order to do the Lord’s work with power.

The congregation which will not by these means resist its own becoming worldly will soon lie under, and it will become a disgrace to God’s name instead of unto honor for the Lord and unto light for the world.

When therefore we acknowledge that the congregation must have an outward organization, and at the same time acknowledge that there is occasion for hypocrites to sneak into the organization, then this is the strongest exhortation to be on guard and to use the means the Lord has given us, so that the congregation’s enemies may not become its masters through the congregation’s sloth and unwillingness to take up its cross and bear its burdens. Only the Gospel of the cross and the cross of the Gospel can preserve the congregation, so that it does not become a shameful distortion of Christ’s body and Jesus’ bride.

3.20.5 The congregation governs its own affairs under the authority of God’s Word and Spirit, and acknowledges no other ecclesiastical authority or tutelage over itself.

3.20.6 The free congregation esteems and loves all the spiritual gifts which the Lord bestows for its edification, and seeks to quicken the gifts and promote their use.

If it is true, as God’s Word bears witness, that the congregation consists of the believers in each place who there on that place have formed an organization in order to labor for God’s kingdom, then it follows of necessity therefrom that the congregation is self-governing and

independent of other men in this its work.

For Christianity is in its innermost essence a relation to God, which brings with it a complete dependence on Him and yet a complete freedom in Him.

If therefore other men have no authority over the congregation in its congregational work, then in the fullest possible measure the congregation does have an authority over it, namely the Word and the Spirit. And so absolute is this authority, that the congregation is no longer a congregation when it tears itself loose from this; and only so far is the congregation a congregation as it follows this authority.

It is this which gives the congregation its self-dependence and its responsibility. It acts as it acts because it is fully persuaded in its own mind that thus it is right and proper according to God's Word, and thus God's Spirit drives it through the Word. Therefore it knows also that God will call it to account for every single one of its actions.

For God has not left His believing congregation without light and without strength.

Over the way and work of God's congregation the light of the Word shines clearly and mightily; and God's Spirit gives ability and strength to walk the way and to carry out the work.

It is not seldom heard in this connection that the gifts of grace are so scanty nowadays that one properly speaking finds them only among the clergy. And among the clergy they are found, not because God's Spirit has given them gifts of grace, but because the congregation has chosen and appointed them to the "office."

This false doctrine is widely spread also among us and is frequently used in defense of the ungodly opinion that an unconverted pastor is a true pastor, provided only that a congregation has called him in an outwardly lawful manner.

A more forcible distortion of God's truth is scarcely to be found. And yet it is not rare to hear such opinions advanced and defended within the Church.

It is true that no one can be a true pastor, such as a pastor ought to be, unless he has both true faith and the Spirit's gift of grace for the proclamation of God's Word; but it is also true that he does not receive the gift of grace, nor faith either, by receiving through the congregation's election the outward position as preacher or pastor. It is also true that he is not the only one who has received a gift of grace. To all His believers the Lord has given gift and ability to labor for the cause of God's kingdom.

It is likewise not true that all pastors have gift and power to preach and govern, while all laypeople have only gift and ability to support the office by paying.

The order according to God's Word is altogether different. According to Scripture, the matter stands thus: the Lord, who ascended on high after the humiliation, crowned His victory by distributing gifts among men. And these gifts made some fit for one kind of work in the congregation, others for another. If then the congregation is to choose its pastors and officeholders in a right and scriptural manner, it must try to choose those whom God has made fit, and not others. Therefore it is written concerning one of the first elections—perhaps

the first actual congregational election: "Therefore, brothers, select from among you seven men of good report, full of the Holy Spirit and wisdom." There a rule is laid down for a right election, and only when the congregation understands and acknowledges this rule and acts according to it will its election be pleasing to the Lord and profitable to the congregation.

It is a great demand upon the congregation's spirit and insight that it should know those who not only have good report, but also are "full of the Holy Spirit and wisdom"; and this agrees poorly with all the theologians' frivolous, superficial, and thoughtless use of the saying that "we are not knowers of hearts." According to Scripture, the congregation is bound to know who are "full of the Holy Spirit and wisdom," if it is truly to be a free and self-governing congregation.

Thus then the congregation receives its true officeholders, by the Lord's gifts of grace and by the congregation's upright election. And it may surely be said, without too great an error, that the congregation's officeholders are in a special sense the congregation's workers, cut out for that by God and by the congregation. But by this it is not said that only these shall labor and no one else. All believers, great and small, young and old, men and women, shall be workers in the vineyard. There is no sense at all in understanding the matter so that the members of the congregation lay their work down upon the officeholders. These receive their separate charge, but there always remains more than enough over for all the others.

Take, for example, the Christian upbringing and instruction of children. Can the school of religion abolish parents' duty and obligation to bring up their children in the discipline and admonition of the Lord? And so in all the spiritual branches of congregational work. The more spiritual a matter is, the more are all believers bound to take part in it with their gifts and abilities.

Naturally, we understand well the significance of outward order, so that when the congregation elects a treasurer, all the others cannot be treasurers at the same time. But they all can and shall help the treasurer to keep the books in good order. Yet just as idiotic as it would be to suppose that the treasurer alone is to procure the money and manage the money, and no one else is to have the very least concern with that matter, quite as idiotic and a little worse besides is the common conception that all edifying work in the congregation is a matter entrusted entirely to the pastor, and that no other Christian either can or shall contribute anything to that matter with his spiritual gift or ability.

But the congregation must not only use the gifts it receives; it also lies upon it to quicken and cultivate, to draw forth and call forth the gifts.

Here first and foremost the public proclamation of the Word must be called to account. It must not only be said to a man and to a member of the congregation's outward organization that you must give the Lord your heart in a true and living faith; but also that you must present yourself as a living, holy, and God-pleasing sacrifice through a true and inward and self-sacrificing love to God and to your neighbor. The proclamation must become congregational, so that light falls upon the Christians' calling and task as members of the congregation, upon their entrusted pounds and talents.

And not that alone. Brotherly spirit and mutual confidence must reign within the congregation,

so that one converses and deliberates with one another precisely about these questions: What shall we do, and how shall we do it? Which of us is fit, and what is the duty of the one who is fit?

If one never seeks after the gifts of grace, one surely does not find them; then it sometimes comes to pass that they almost must thrust themselves forward; and that is one of the reasons why many gifts are among us partly wasted and partly warped.

We cannot afford this. The congregation ought to search after the gifts as after noble and precious gold, and then “test everything and hold fast to what is good” in this respect also.

This then is the congregation’s true form in the world: a people of believing, praying, and working men and women, who receive from the Lord all that they need in their work, both the faith and the life and the gifts, and who therefore acknowledge this wholly and fully, that they belong to the Lord with all that they are and all that they have, so that they all are the Lord’s servants, male and female, created by Him for every good work.

Are we such congregations? If not, why not?

And if anyone says that such a thing is fanaticism, that it is altogether impossible, then we answer: Have faith in God; what is impossible for men, that is possible for God!

VI.

- 3.20.7 The free congregation receives with joy the mutual help which congregations can render one another in the work of advancing God’s kingdom.**
- 3.20.8 Such mutual help consists partly in this, that the spiritual forces of the one congregation come to the benefit of the other by free meetings, mutual visits, lay activity, etc.; partly in this, that the congregations voluntarily and at the prompting of God’s Spirit cooperate for the solving of such tasks as may surpass the strength of a single congregation.**
- 3.20.9 Among such purposes are named in particular a pastors’ school, the spreading of Bibles and other writings and periodicals, home mission, heathen mission, deaconess homes, children’s homes, and other works of mercy.**

If the Free Church in its leading principles lays the chief weight upon the congregation and its spirit, life, and freedom, it is very far from being opposed to cooperation among congregations.

We do not deny that the old organizations of synods and councils have taken a fair name when in Norwegian they often call themselves fellowships. We have only a painful experience that at least a part of them do not answer to the name.

Instead of “fellowship” being the free cooperation and the mutual influence of spiritual forces, we have among us party organizations, where that which does not go in the leading-strings of the church-political “machine” is shut out and cut off, and one is as though afraid of a breath of freedom, so that one hates everything that is free, even to the very name of it.

That large parts of our people by means of these organizations have been led into the fanaticism of party-spirit, and into the bitter, spiritless strife and contention that follow from it, is something which all nobler spirits among us agree in lamenting. But many of them are still of the opinion that this frightful form which the "Church" presents to the people can be remedied by "new fellowships" and constantly "new fellowships," which in reality are little more than new parties with new slogans and new fanaticism and new bitterness.

The Free Church's guiding principles seek to show a new way by the abolition of parties.

It is not a question of abolishing and doing away with fellowships, but of abolishing party-spirit in the fellowships.

Although therefore all church politicians know well the rapidly kindling fire of party-spirit and the immediate power that follows from it, the Free Church has nevertheless in its principles declared that it renounces this false power, so that freedom may have a little room among us. Perhaps the day may dawn when there can be a cooperation of Christians and of Christian congregations which is led by the Spirit, not by church politics.

We see well enough that the goal is high and distant; but if only the congregation first becomes congregation, then the union of congregations too will surely become a real fellowship.

Meanwhile we must try to practice whatever little we are able of free and spiritual cooperation and of mutual spiritual influence.

Therefore we believe in free meetings, where men and women from different congregations come together to exchange thoughts concerning what is serviceable for the advancement of God's kingdom. And the freer these meetings are, and the more they break through and strike down the thorn-hedges which party-spirit has set between our people, so much the better.

Let them come together! Those from the one and those from the other "fellowship"! Those who by "fellowship" have lost the real fellowship, and those who without "fellowship" have found the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace! Provided only that we stand on New Testament and Lutheran ground, we may well meet together and speak with one another concerning the awakening and preservation of spiritual life, concerning the enlivening and liberation of our Church. This is a consideration that is equally useful for the one party as for the other, and these are matters that can be practiced without regard to "fellowship."

Our Norwegian Lutheran Church with its stiff, spiked, and jagged fences, with churches that pastor shuts against pastor and congregation against congregation, although they have the same doctrine and confession, presents a pitiful and lamentable sight.

Something must be done in order to come out of this shame and wretchedness. While the parties labor to preserve the evil, the Free Church must try by sober, brotherly, and persevering labor to remedy and overcome it.

To this end mutual visits, especially by laymen, will serve greatly, if they are carried out in the right spirit. The fellowship agents cannot do the work that is needed for this aim. The lay preachers ought to understand that it is not for the party they are to labor; it is for the Spirit and the life. We may perhaps come so far one day in the Lutheran Church that

even a pastor may preach in another pastor's church unhindered by the fences; but for the present the lay preachers must make serious business of an impartial awakening work, and the conviction must press through more and more that it is sin to use the gifts of grace in the service of party-spirit, and that it is sin to shut the churches against the proclamation of God's Word.

Let the very greatest leaders of the fellowships come forward among us and say whether even they must not admit that such a program is justified and such a work required.

But, one says, what will become of such common works as the congregations must do? What will become of mission and school and children's homes?

The question in truth answers itself. It will be no otherwise than it already is for many such works. Those who were most interested in the mission to the Jews began to carry it on and to work for it. They received gifts and contributions from whoever was willing, and there was no compulsion. Has it not gone well enough? We think, has it not gone better than if it had been a single party that had managed it?

That those most interested should be allowed to tend a cause is freedom's demand and the gain and advantage of the cause itself. Why should it not be able to go?

Those who have church-political tendencies and would exalt themselves by help of the great force of ecclesiastical interests do not like this. But in return the interests thrive best when not too many politicians are sitting on the load.

This seems to us to be the advantage of the free work. It gathers the interested, and that is fair enough. Those who are not interested ought not either by the fellowship-machine to be compelled and driven to take part in that which lies far from them.

Yes, one says, but many of these interested persons then come, as it were, to appoint themselves to the work; they ought to wait until someone elected them. But suppose now that God put into their mind what they should do, and they followed His call to heavy and burdensome labor?

Or is [1-3 words unclear] less a missionary because he went himself to the Santals and no one sent him? Must God also wait for fellowship resolutions?

Where the Lord's Spirit is, there is freedom, freedom to labor, freedom to suffer, freedom to live for a cause, freedom even to die for the cause. Should it not be possible to believe also in the Holy Spirit?

- 3.20.10 Free Congregations have no Right to demand that other Congregations submit to their Opinion, Will, Judgment, or Determination; therefore every dominion of a majority of Congregations over a minority is to be rejected.**
- 3.20.11 The common organs that may be found desirable for the Congregations' cooperation, such as greater or smaller meetings, committees, officers, etc., cannot in a Lutheran Free Church impose upon the single Congregation any duty, bond, compulsion, or burden, but are only entitled to come forward with proposals and exhortations to Congregations and persons.**

In civil society it is long since recognized that pure and absolute majority rule is of dubious worth. Modern society ought properly to consist in the employment of all abilities and powers for the common good; but then it is plainly the less fitting that one should, for example, in a society of 100 exclude 49 from all influence because they are not so many as 51. For experience shows that the 49 may be just as capable and as well-intentioned as the 51. People are not measured by the ell-measure, neither can one in all cases attain the best results merely by counting. It is enough that, in most civil societies—and thus also among us—provision has in one way or another been made for a counterweight against simple and absolute majority rule.

In the Church this question is infinitely more serious, more difficult, and more significant than in the State. And for many different reasons it is an altogether different thing in the Church than in the State to apply a wholly unrestricted majority rule.

In the United Church they have tried to carry it to an extreme, which I believe was done not from principle, but from considerations of expediency. It was a convenient means of displacing Augsburgers, who were in the minority. And because it seemed convenient, they therefore went to such an extreme as is impossible in civil society; they not only denied the minority all influence, even the most rightful, but simply drove it out of the body and then called this expulsion—church discipline. That, thanks be to God, one cannot do in the United States; the minority has the right to remain in society and try to become the majority; but in the Church it is so easy to resort to church discipline and cast out those whom the majority does not like.

But, as said, it is dangerous for many reasons to establish bare majority rule in the Church. Perhaps the United Church is even now already beginning to taste the bitterness of the dangerous methods that were brought into use in order to displace Augsburgers from society and congregation.

For first, the Church is dependent upon God's Word and its authority and truth before there is any talk of majority and minority. This limitation of majority rule is of such surpassing significance that where it is not heeded and respected, there the Church soon ceases to be Church. In other words, it is a fundamental matter in the Church that the Word be allowed to retain its proper authority.

Further, there is this circumstance to be taken into account, that there is no guarantee that

the majority alone has good forces and sound views. At times there may be serviceable men and wise counsel in the minority. Therefore to exclude the minority from all influence and cast it out of the body, in order that it may never become the majority, is almost madness for those who would gather God's Church and not scatter it.

And, not to go through everything, there is finally this peculiar feature of the Church's apostolic and biblical order, that the congregation is free, self-standing, and independent in its very essence, so that it stands under no human or ecclesiastical authority. Congregations may cooperate with other Congregations in all freedom and brotherliness; but one congregation cannot rule over another and command what it shall do. There is not a hint of anything of that kind in Scripture. And therefore to arrange matters in such a way that one abolishes the congregation's independence and responsibility is not scriptural.

For my part, it is in any case clear that a dominion of an ecclesiastical-political majority over the Congregations dissolves the fellowship of the Congregations instead of gathering it. Compulsion and tyranny will necessarily abolish the Church's unity, however much they themselves lay claim to promoting it.

Free cooperation without compulsion is the proper ecclesial and Christian condition. Doubtless it is also that which leads to the happiest results. The so-called societies that have practiced forced cooperation have hitherto at any rate attained only divisions, because they have wished to carry on by force and majority what was meant to be free.

If therefore among our freedom-loving people, and among believing men who have responsibility before God, a real ecclesial life and brotherly cooperation are to come into being, then we must get out of the worldly and political tracks into which the societies have led us.

It will take a long time to get out of them, I know that well. And it is something to be thankful for, that one says this to us, that it goes no otherwise in the Free Church than elsewhere. Very well, what may one fairly expect? We must try to grow in age and wisdom.

A free cooperation is brought about only by the approval of all who cooperate. Every Congregation and every individual in the Congregation is asked whether they will be with us. It costs a great deal of labor, which forced cooperation seems to avoid. Yet it is done, because there is interest and spirit behind it. Therefore it also costs less money.

The short time in which we have tried free and brotherly cooperation has at any rate shown that, with all the difficulties which the coercive societies have diligently enumerated to us, it has nevertheless gone forward. And our conviction is this: if only we practice freedom and love in full earnest and with full integrity, then our cooperation will not be poor because it is free.

But if by freedom we mean only to be free from labor, and by love, that we will share no pain or toil with anyone, but only enjoy the pleasant company of others and other good things, then it is self-evident that we are good for nothing. Let us practice freedom and love, and voluntary cooperation shall show results that answer to the divine promises resting upon his free servants and self-sacrificing and self-denying children.

If all does not go on in sheer glory and joy, then let us not lose heart at once. Fair-weather

Christians, who can come forward only when everything is compliant, never become truly free, because they have altogether too much to accommodate themselves to and to take account of. Let us go forward courageously, and let each bear his own burden, because it is right, and bear one another's burdens, because thus we fulfil the Law of Christ.

If one will then call this fanaticism, it is nothing other than what has always been faith's lot and portion. And yet faith is an equally sure and good way, by whatever name it may be called.

3.20.12 Every free Congregation has, like each individual believer, through the prompting of God's Spirit and by the right of love, the right to do good and to labor for the salvation of souls and the awakening of spiritual life as far as its ability and strength reach; in such free, spiritual activity it is restricted neither by parish ties nor by the boundaries of societies.

"Christ's love compels us" is the principle that lies behind and beneath all truly Christian action.

God loved; therefore he sent the Son into the world, that he should be the Savior of the world.

God's Son loved; therefore he came into the world to seek and to save that which was lost. Out of free and living love he became the servant of the many and gave his life as a ransom-payment for them.

And God's Spirit is he who pours out love into believers' hearts, so that they are driven by the same mind as Jesus Christ himself. They love, because they are born of God and have his life in their hearts.

He who has the true faith and the living love cannot be still where there is a world round about that is led astray by falsehood, perishes through unbelief, and dies the eternal death in its sins. He must seek to "do likewise" as the merciful Samaritan, as Jesus Christ. The salvation of souls lies upon the heart of the saved, and they must try to get more to go with them on the way to eternal life. "Come and go with us" is the invitation of the saved to all who need salvation.

But what applies to the individual Christian must also apply to the Congregation. Or how should the Body of Christ have another will, prompting, and desire than Christ himself?

For the Congregation exists in order to manifest Christ's life and be his instrument and servant. What else can it do, then, than do the works of him who has bought it with his blood and bestowed his Spirit upon it?

Christ's love reaches to all; he will draw all to himself, he will gather all to his great supper. Human beings unto the uttermost ends of the earth are the object of his love.

The Congregation therefore cannot be without mission. It must farther forward and farther out. Its whole being is ordered toward the spread of God's Kingdom; it has come forth by mission, and it is appointed to carry on mission. The one follows from the other.

And here mission is taken in its most general sense, embracing those who are near and those who are far away, both what is called Inner Mission and Jewish Mission and Heathen Mission. The meaning is to seek after that which is lost, wherever it is found.

Love from God is unrestricted by everything except God and God's Word. When therefore men often employ human arrangements in order to shut God's Word and Spirit out from themselves, love tries to leap over walls and break through barriers. And whether the barriers are called Chinese walls or Catholic boundary-bolts or state-church parish ties makes no difference to love.

Or how was it with the merciful Samaritan? Was that his "district," where the poor traveler was assaulted between Jericho and Jerusalem? Was there first a question about the boundaries? Or was not mercy free according to its own eternal law and nature, so that it has mercy on whom it has mercy, without asking after anything else than the need and misery?

When therefore one has spread abroad among worldly church-people the delusion that one need only enter into a certain society, and then one is sheltered from lay preachers, awakening, and other pestilence, then it is the Congregation's calling to overcome such false notions and break down such fences. Nowhere have souls the freedom and the right to sleep in peace in spiritual matters, so surely as the Congregation can do anything to awaken them and pull them out of a burning house. Even though the spiritually sleeping have hired pastor and sexton ever so much to protect their sleep and make it heavier and more secure, the Congregation is nevertheless equally bound to labor for the salvation of the sleeping. Jesus visited every synagogue into which he could enter, and the Temple itself became witness to the manifestation of his mighty power despite the displeasure of his adversaries. And Paul preached wherever he came, despite synagogue rulers. And the Congregation in Jerusalem wrote to all Congregations and admonished them.

There is only one consideration which the Congregation takes; it is love's own consideration, namely this question: Can we accomplish something good? Where no benefit is done, love commands that one refrain from doing harm.

If the Congregation's freedom and right were only ever so little acknowledged among us, then party spirit and its many thorn-fences between the hearts of the people would soon have to yield. The brotherhood, which rests upon fellowship with Christ in his Congregation, would then be able to thrive; and the brotherhood which exists only within the party would disappear before the true and rightful brotherhood.

But there is still a long way to the goal that must be reached if we are to be pleasing to God. From Congregation to Congregation the holy bonds of brotherhood must be knit without the societies' shutting partition-walls.

Will it ever be reached? At all events, it is a worthy goal for which to labor and suffer.

Many are they who have suffered and suffer exceedingly much because of our people's ecclesiastical sundering. There is only one remedy, and that is the working of God's Spirit unto the liberation of hearts and Congregations. If the Congregation becomes what it ought to be, then party spirit receives its death-blow.

It is therefore extraordinarily characteristic to see the zeal with which the ecclesiastical-political organs among us work against the congregational idea. They seem to see only misfortune and ruin in it.

But that Congregation should have care for Congregation, that Congregation should have trust and confidence toward Congregation, that a believing person should be well received from Congregation to Congregation, that there should be an invisible chain linking those who serve the same Lord and contend for the same cause—how can that be any misfortune? Does this not accord with God’s Word and God’s Spirit, with the innermost essence of Christianity and with apostolic practice?

The matter is this, that men believe in the society which human beings build by constitutions; they esteem so lightly the fellowship which God builds by the Spirit.

Therefore we will conclude with the same with which we began: the task is to bring forth the Congregation from the rubble and to rebuild the ruins of the Lord’s temple among men. And if we do not reach far, which is indeed to be expected under our own great and dreadful sloth and weakness and the opponents’ enormous preponderance, humanly speaking, then well and good: we count it a high thing to labor for the right goal, and we are altogether certain of this, that the day shall come when all truth-loving souls shall see it clearly in the Spirit’s light, that no ecclesial labor was more urgently required in the present time than labor for the Congregation.

It is the only labor that guards against the danger of Hierarchy on the one side and the danger of Individualism on the other. Let it go forward with power.

3.21 On the Congregations’ Responsibility for Synodical Acts

Editorial article in “Folkebladet” for February 24, 1897.

Some time ago there was printed in “Folkebladet” a piece on “The Free-Church Inner Mission.” It pointed out what effect the Ole Nilsen Decision had upon the synod’s mission work, namely, to make it a partisan matter.

On that occasion “Lutheraneren,” in its issue of February 4 of this year, writes:

“No darker accusation can be brought against a synod of congregations. It amounts to nothing less than to pronounce all these congregations devoid of all Christian life. For where there is Christian life, there it always stands also as a principal task to carry the message of salvation in Christ onward to those who do not know it.

If, then, The United Church, which consists of more than 700 congregations, has something else as its principal task, then at any rate the greater part of these 700 congregations must not only be spiritually dead, but so perverted that they do not even care to bear the Christian name.”

From this one may thus see that “Lutheraneren” straightforwardly makes all the congregations of the synod, and all the individual members of them, responsible for the Ole Nilsen Decision to so great a degree that the relation becomes this: if anyone censures this decision and its

effect upon The United Church's missionary work, then that is the same as "pronouncing all the 700 congregations devoid of all Christian life."

So strong, in the opinion of that organ, is the solidarity in The United Church: if the Ole Nilsen Decision is unchristian, then the synod is unchristian, and then there is no Christian life in 700 congregations?

This claim concerning responsibility goes farther, it seems to us, than is fair. But if within The United Church it is to hold that each congregation and each congregation member is responsible, with person, soul, body, and goods, for all that the annual meeting resolves, then it is a question whether it will be possible for any congregation or person to remain with it, if one otherwise cares what one takes upon oneself.

If the synod adopts a very upright decision in money matters, incurs a vast debt, or the like, will then each congregation and each congregation member be liable, one for all and all for one?

And if the synod adopts an unchristian decision, is that then something which really annihilates the Christian life of all the individual congregation members?

Is there no way out for those who vote against it, testify against it, and work against it either? Does the Christian life of all the members stand and fall with a single synodical decision?

Yes, so it appears, if the claim of "Lutheraneren" is correct, that he who censures a synodical decision concerning inner mission thereby pronounces 700 congregations devoid of all Christian life.

If the matter of the congregations' responsibility for the annual meeting's decisions hangs together in this way, then it is altogether understandable why The United Church excludes delegates and casts out congregations which oppose a proposal or a decision. For if every testimony concerning the annual meeting's misstep is a complete sentence of condemnation over all congregations and congregation members, then it is altogether natural that such a testimony is not tolerated.

For us this understanding of solidarity is a new and strong testimony that the majority means it sincerely in its declaration that its conduct up to 1895 has been without guilt in the sinful strife in the synod. For only a majority infallible in its own eyes can feel itself so deeply offended by harsh criticism or reproof.

Will the congregations now take this matter seriously and really hold fast to these two things: that, first, they are responsible for all that the annual meeting determines, so that the annual meeting's decision carries the same moral responsibility for them as if they themselves had determined it;

and that, second, it is sinful and presumptuous for any congregation or any congregation member to oppose or criticize any synodical decision, because by doing so they pronounce 700 congregations devoid of all Christian life?

It is very possible that some congregations would gladly have it so. It is quite convenient to settle down in the assurance that, being so many, one must be right and cannot be mistaken.

But then one must not be surprised either that there still remain some independent-minded congregations and congregation members who will reserve to themselves their own conviction and their own responsibility, and be cast out, if that is not tolerated.

Georg Sverdrup

3.22 The Free Church Came

Editorial article in "Folkebladet," June 23, 1897.

It was not any particularly great event. It was nothing other than to establish what is already being practiced, and to give it a name. We do not expect anything great from the name, and we know that if the Free Church is ever to become anything, long and faithful work will be needed all the while.

The question therefore is really this: Will the work come that is designated by the name the Free Church?

People always say that the people are not mature for freedom; therefore they must not have it. In this way they say: The congregations are not mature for freedom; therefore they must not have it.

The truth is that one ought to reason the other way: If the congregations are not mature for freedom, then let them take freedom at once, so that they may become mature.

The congregations cannot properly receive freedom; they can only take it. That is to say, they can receive it only from God; for surely there is no human being who can give it to them. Therefore we say that the sooner the congregations cease asking human beings for permission, and take the freedom that lies ready for them in the Word, the better.

That is the Free Church. When the congregations begin, each of them, to order themselves after the apostolic pattern, so that in all their work they seek only and follow only the light of the Word and the Spirit, then with that the free-church work has also begun.

But the congregations, or the single congregation, cannot begin anything, unless some man or woman in the congregation begins.

Therefore there are many who have it in such a way that they turn this matter upside down. They go about waiting for a congregational resolution before they can begin to work. If there is something that requires a congregational resolution, then some man or woman must begin to work in order to get the congregational resolution adopted; that is clear enough. The resolution comes after a proposal; if no one makes the proposal, then the resolution does not come into being either.

But by far the greater number of Christian actions can and must be done by men and women without a congregational resolution. And there the free-church work begins in the strictest sense. It begins in the believers' work for the salvation of souls.

Therefore this, that "the Free Church came," is so insignificant. But this is the great question, whether the Free Church will come. That depends upon each individual Christian man and

woman throughout the congregations.

But surely this is not anything new? All who are against the Free Church will answer No. The Free Church people feel that to this they must answer both No and Yes. We mean that free Christian work is as old as the time of the apostles. But we also mean that it has grown very quiet around the believers' free Christian work since the state church ordered and commanded, forbade and prescribed, everything by law. We have seen that in the so-called "societies" free Christian work has almost ceased; in some places, indeed, it has in many ways even been forbidden, because such a work of freedom would disturb the generally prevailing sleep. Priest and sexton and collection committees are to work; others ought simply to leave it alone.

If the believers will not stir themselves more and more as time goes on, then the Free Church is in vain. Therefore the name is only a hope that has been uttered, a call that goes out to the Christians in all congregations.

The Free Church came; will it truly come?

Georg Sverdrup

3.23 Is There a Difference?

Editorial article in "Folkebladet," August 4, 1897.

There is no little lack of clarity among many as to whether there is any difference between the Free Church and the old "church bodies." We will try to shed a little light on this matter.

By "the Free Church" is meant the free cooperation of free congregations. By "church bodies" is meant a centralized common government which uses congregations and pastors in its service for the advancement of its own aims. There proves to be no little difference between these two things, when it comes down to it.

It is the same difference as between many small landowners and farmers, each of whom builds his own home and cultivates his own piece of land, on the one side, and, on the other, one great and mighty estate-owner with many tenant farmers under him.

Suppose one were to try these two methods, many small farms and one great estate, side by side under conditions as nearly equal as possible: the same kind of soil, the same kind of climate, the same kind of products and crops; where would the land then be best used, and where would the people's well-being and prosperity thrive most?

Take one "large farm" of 10,000 acres and set beside it one hundred "small farms" of 100 acres each; where would there be the happier population, the better farming, and the greater prosperity? Where would there be the most real yield? Or would there be no difference?

It is true that in the statistics it looks rather impressive when the large farmer comes with his heavy figures, his thousands of bushels of every kind, while the small farmers have only some hundreds each. But when the reckoning is carried a little further, it comes to matter, after all, whether the figures have counted rightly, and whether glad hearts and happy homes are also measured by the bushel.

Experience shows that there is no better way to build up a country than that each man own his home and his land and use and cultivate it in such a way as is serviceable for him. Experience also shows that the people thrive best, and peace dwells most securely in the community, where one man stands about as high as another, and all are equally free to do with their own as they will.

They cooperate none the less. With each man's prosperity the community's grows; with each plot that is made more beautiful, the whole community becomes fairer. Can this be avoided, or is it not self-evident?

Think carefully upon this picture, and see whether it does not fit the Free Church well enough. All that is meant by the Free Church is the independence and freedom of the congregations, so that each one for itself may become a true spiritual congregation, which seeks to do its work as well as possible, because in that are God's good pleasure and its own true good.

That does not hinder them from cooperating. It does not hinder them from learning from one another, helping one another, supporting one another, encouraging one another, living together and working together in love.

On the contrary, it is inevitable. If there is spiritual life in one congregation, this will of itself have its effect upon many other congregations.

In English we have two words which roughly express the difference between the Free Church and church bodies. These are "Co-operation" and "Concentration." By "Co-operation" is meant that many forces work together because they have common interests which they must look after; by "Concentration" is meant that there is a central power which directs the labor of all, because only thus does one attain the greatest possible unity in the work.

These two methods are very different from one another; and in the ecclesiastical sphere they lead to very different results. That the Free Church is both the biblical and the Lutheran way, and therefore also the one which brings the best results, upon that point the learned ought not to be in disagreement.

Georg Sverdrup

3.24 Is It Progress?

Editorial in "Folkebladet," August 11, 1897.

It is not enough that there is a difference between the Free Church and the church bodies, or between congregational freedom and church government. There is a question that is still more important, and it is this: Is the Free Church now also truly a progress?

For those who believe that the congregation is about the same thing as rebellion and disorder and anarchy, while it is the church body with its wise government that brings a little order into the confusion, it is self-evident that the free-church tendency is a nuisance and a relapse into chaos. They reason in this way: in the church body the congregations have with great labor been gathered together, just as a builder laboriously drags the stones together for a building. And just as the one who tears the stones apart again and scatters them over the field

is a vandal, so much more is he a vandal of the worst kind who works for the congregations to be independent and self-governed.*

These ways of speaking do indeed sound so reasonable and sensible that one might think the matter were thereby settled. One does not think of the fact that, if that sort of language could settle the matter, then it was also settled that the old Roman Church, with the Pope at its head, had the noblest and best right of all church bodies, and that it could with good reason complain that such rebels as Luther and others had disturbed the glorious building that had been raised with such great diligence and such great labor.

The question is this: Does it go forward when it goes from the state church toward the free congregation, so that it is progress so long as it goes that way? Or is it progress when the development goes from the free congregation toward an ever stronger church government, until at last this is everything and the congregation nothing, or at least nothing other than a mere supporting foundation?

One must not mix these two opposite things together. Either the free congregation is the goal,* and then one must work for it; or else the strong church body is the goal,* and then the task is to work for that, however it may go with the congregation and its freedom.

What shall we choose? History has indeed pronounced its judgment, so that we really need not doubt. The Catholic Church advanced great and strong in the delusion that the true progress was to build the Church ever higher, with the congregation deep below as a good foundation, until the Church became "a tower with its top in heaven" that gathered all Christians together and preserved them from dispersion. But God struck that proud church-building a crushing blow, and the Christians were scattered abroad as they were set free from the crushing absolute rule. Was it progress or decline when Luther shook the mighty church walls until the cracks appeared everywhere?

It was progress. And though the progress was lamed in its course when secular princes inherited the Pope's power, yet it is again progress when the free people, as here among us, forbids the civil authority to govern the people's religion and rule over consciences by worldly power and law.

But where the state church is no more, there the so-called "church bodies" now try to fill its place and preserve the old church order, which is the congregation's tutelage.* An annual meeting is arranged, which grants the funds, and there is a chairman who appoints the ministers; and the congregations get less and less influence upon their own affairs and those of the church body, the greater the body becomes.

It is progress when congregational freedom is actually carried through, so that the congregations gain the right to determine their own expenses, choose their own ministers, and keep them undisturbed by the "church body" and its chairman. If the "church body" could have remained faithful to its task and defended the congregations' freedom, then it would surely have been a long time before any doubt had been raised about its legitimacy.* But when the "church body" set power in the place of right and no longer took any account of the congregations' freedom, but drove ministers from their congregations, cast congregational delegates out of the annual meeting, and expelled congregations from the body, then it became

clear that here a tyrannical power had been established, under which the congregations could bow only with shame and harm.

The expelled congregations, and many with them, could not cease to exist; neither could they begin a new "body," when they had precisely been expelled by an old one. They had no other way out than to go straight forward to the full realization of congregational freedom.* In that there is a progress, and one that is all the more secure because it is biblical and Lutheran.

Georg Sverdrup

NOTES ON UNCERTAIN READINGS

* "Anarki[?]sme" has been understood as "Anarkisme" = "anarchy." * "frikirkelige Ste[v?]" has been rendered contextually as "the free-church tendency." The damaged reading appears to indicate a word such as "stræv" or "strev," but the sense is clearly a free-church movement or tendency. * "æd[l?]ste" has been understood as "ædleste" = "noblest." * Asterisks in the source have been retained where they appear to mark emphasis or editorial significance. * "Stattefundament" has been translated contextually as "a mere supporting foundation," since the exact printed form appears unusual or damaged, but the sense is clear: the congregation reduced to a passive supporting base. * "Kunde 'Kirkesamfundet' blevet sin Opgave tro" has been understood as "If the 'church body' could have remained faithful to its task." The source likely reflects a damaged or archaic printed form where the intended sense is evident from context. * "Menighedsfrihedens fuldstændige Gjennemførelse" has been rendered as "the full realization of congregational freedom" to preserve both completion and principled implementation.

3.25 Compulsion or Freedom

Editorial article in "Folkebladet" for September 1, 1897.

A reply to Prof. F. A. Schmidt's article in "Lutheraneren," which attempts to prove that the congregations are much freer in the old synods than in the Free Church.

We shall begin by asking whether the representative system does not necessarily entail compulsion, if it is to have any meaning at all. When the representatives of our states meet in Congress at Washington, is it not self-evident that, both by law and by logic, they meet with power and authority to decide the matters entrusted to them, and that the states are compelled to submit to their decisions? The United States as a whole forms, by means of President, Congress, and Supreme Court, a higher unity, which must compel each individual state to bow under the decision of the common authority. If the people do not like these decisions, then they must wait until the next election, in case representatives may then be chosen who will change what is not satisfactory.

The representative system remains true to itself when it is transferred into the Church. It imposes a higher unity over the congregation, and it imposes compulsion upon all those congregations which are not convinced of the benefit and necessity of the resolutions adopted. It often makes no difference whether a congregation's delegate votes for or against a resolution at the annual meeting; the congregation may therefore be opposed to the resolution, and

its implementation in the congregation is a compulsion, not a freedom. The representative system with its ruling annual meeting can, when it is misused in the service of machine politics, even bring matters to such a pass that the body decides such things as hardly a single congregation in the whole body would vote in favor of, if it had opportunity to do so. But because it has been decided by the representative annual meeting, all the congregations have both the shame and the harm from it—very much against their will.

In the Free Church there is no representative system. Therefore there is also no ruling annual meeting. The congregations are altogether free, for each congregation by itself decides what it will. No annual meeting decides anything whatsoever for the congregations. Since there are no representatives, there is absolutely no power or authority in the meetings that are held.

The meetings of the Free Church consist of volunteers; and when these volunteers agree on a matter, they recommend it to the congregations. Then the congregations do with the matter as they will. What power or authority, then, have the congregations lost? If they are for the matter, they work for it; if they are against the matter, they take no part in it. No one can command them, and no one can forbid them to work as they find fitting. But one thing there is no room for in the Free Church: a majority cannot force upon a minority matters with which it wants nothing to do. Neither can a majority hinder a minority from working for a cause that it holds dear.

Is this not biblical? Or how was it that Paul's Gentile mission was carried on? Was it a representative annual meeting that sent him out? Was it the "majority" that compelled the congregations to support him? It has always been the Lord's way to carry on his work by the instruments he himself has chosen, and by the servants whom his Spirit has driven to the labor. Does not each congregation by itself have full right and warrant to help whatever cause it will?

Georg Sverdrup

3.26 The Free Church's Mode of Working

Editorial article in "Fodfehødet" for September 22, 1897. A rebuttal of J. A. S.'s assertion that the Free Church's constitution is anarchistic.

The Free Church's proper fundamental principle is this: that the congregation is the proper divine order within the Christian religion. This principle, which includes within itself that there is no authority which, by ecclesiastical right, may set itself above the congregation or lay claim to its obedience and submission, is, so far as we can see, biblically grounded and justified.

We therefore demand first and foremost of J. A. S. that he must prove from the New Testament that the congregations are obliged to introduce the "representative system," in order thereby to bring forth a higher unity of the congregations in a church or church body, which is then elevated above them and whose decisions they are obliged to obey, because these church bodies are "authority" over the congregation.

If J. A. S. cannot prove from the New Testament that the congregations are obliged to

have synods or associations or annual meetings as authority over themselves and obey their decisions, then all his talk about anarchism and anarchistic principles becomes in reality only a reproach against the Word of God itself, which, so far as we can see, recognizes no authority over the congregations.

It is here that this discussion must seek to find its true ground. It does not help in the least that J. A. S. shows that our constitutional forms of state have introduced a representative system and much compulsion in connection with it.

It does not help a grain. For, in the first place, it is now surely generally acknowledged by all thinking men that there is much imperfection in politics, and that it is not at all a suitable model for the church. Next, there is no state that can drive out the minority or take the right to vote from its representatives, as the United Church, like the Papal Church, is accustomed to do. But finally—and this is absolutely decisive—the Savior himself says definitely and incontrovertibly that “it shall not be so among you.”*

If there is to be any Lutheranism among us, then we must return to the Lutheran principle that Scripture is our only rule and guide. And so long as we, on the ground of Scripture, maintain the congregation’s freedom and authority, then no Lutheran has the right to revile us as anarchists and anarchistic principles.

The example of the state is not binding for the church. The Word of God is our guide. Show us from the Word that the church must work through annual meetings which coerce or expel the congregations, and we will be convinced.

We maintain that according to the Word of God the congregations are fully entitled to decide all their own matters themselves, without an annual meeting or certain association officials deciding them for them.

If now J. A. S. will acknowledge that this our position is the biblical and Lutheran one, then there can further be discussion of how the congregations should cooperate. We must necessarily first get it clarified whether J. A. S. recognizes the decisive authority of Holy Scripture in this question.

Nor is it difficult to show that by the Free Church’s arrangement of purely voluntary meetings, without compulsion upon the congregations, the congregations have a far better opportunity to exercise influence upon the course of affairs than they have in the old associations.

And when J. A. S. means that the same rule that applies to associations must also apply to congregations, then it is precisely this that we deny and reject. The congregation is a body; 3 or 4 congregations, which organize an association, are not a body in the scriptural sense.* They are only bound together by contract, and they are bound only to that which is determined and stipulated in the contract. Why then is not the Free Church’s contract of freedom just as good as the United Church’s contract of compulsion?

Georg Sverdrup

3.27 Freedom and Equality

Editorial article in "Folkebladet" for October 27, 1897.

"Lutheraneren" has had to abandon the hope of proving that the congregations have lost their freedom in the Free Church. But now it has discovered another danger: equality is gone. Congregations which came out from under the church body's guardianship are no longer equal.

Why not? Because the Free Church does not have the representative system.

So then, because the congregations have taken back the power and authority of which the representative system deprives them, they therefore cannot be equal.

It is said: Yes, but at the Free Church's meetings there may be so many from one congregation that the other congregations are wronged.

This would have some value if our meetings were representative, with supremacy over the congregations. Since they have no other influence than the purely voluntary, and since they may be held anywhere, or wherever it may be, there is surely no sense in saying that they make the congregations unequal.

The Free Church consists of congregations, not of annual meetings. Each congregation by itself governs itself and all its affairs without asking anyone else. If that is not equality, then it is surely difficult to find it.

But the equality which consists in this, that all congregations resemble one another as one drop of water another, that they are equally large, equally spiritual, equally wise, equally gifted, equally godly, equally useful, etc., etc., endlessly—that kind of equality has surely never existed and can hardly exist either.

But this equality, that they are equally free, equally responsible, equally precious, equal "before the Law," that kind of equality there is surely more of when one is free of the representative system than when one lies under it....

Georg Sverdrup

3.28 The Federation of Free Congregations

Editorial article in "Folkebladet" for January 26, 1898.

Those who have been so fortunate, we might almost say, as to have got hold of the Report of the Free Church's Meeting in 1897, will, upon reading this valuable book, no doubt have come fully to see that such a federation of congregations as that of the Free Church is at any rate no freer—or, as the mockers say, "looser"—than the free connection among the apostolic congregations.

If we, who desire a free federation of congregations, are anarchists, then surely the Apostles must have been so as well. If it really is true that the New Testament is rule and guide, then the free federation of free congregations is at any rate not too free.

We have not yet seen anyone who, out of God's Word, has been able to adduce a single statement that points in the direction that a Christian congregation is not absolutely independent and equipped with all the gifts and means that it needs for its existence, so that it can govern itself and has no need to be governed by any other power or authority.

That Christians love one another, and that Christian congregations love one another and support one another and help one another, that we know full well God's Word teaches. But that they dominate one another and subdue one another, of that, for our part, we find not a trace.

Nothing therefore stands more firmly established, after the discussion that has been carried on since summer, than this: that a free federation of free congregations is biblical, apostolic, New Testament.

There is need of this also for the Free Church's men, that under all the bitter mockery that is practiced against them and against their name and their work, they may have the firm and unshakable ground of God's Word to stand upon.

We also intend to maintain—despite the learning of the learned—that the Lutheran Confession stands on the side of the Free Church in the question of the freedom and parity of the congregations. The Lutheran Church teaches that Lutheran congregations are joined together with one another into ecclesial unity, not by constitution, nor yet by ceremonies, but by the preaching or confession of the Gospel.

If anyone would claim that the free federation of congregations is anarchistic, then surely the Lutheran Confession must have been the same; for it also makes no claim that a majority dominion must be established in the Church.

Or perhaps there is someone who can show us that our Confession knows anything of annual meetings that rule over the congregations?

Georg Sverdrup

3.29 On Withdrawal from a Synod

Editorial article in "Folkebladet" for February 23, 1898.

We included Pastor A. Wright's piece on "Going out" in the last issue of "Folkebladet."¹²

¹²Pastor Wright's piece reads as follows:

Should we not "go out" again? A Letter to My Friends.

[Reprinted in Folkebladet for February 16, 1898.]

Among those who first went from Augsburg Seminary to Gjertsen's Church at the Union meeting in 1890 was the undersigned. The reasons for this hesitation were several, which shall not be mentioned here; at any rate not this time. Since that time, the development in our Synod has [also] shown that something of what I foresaw would happen has in fact taken place. Among those of you who have looked critically at one thing and another, I am one; and because of that, some radicals have lost confidence in me, insofar as they ever had any, perhaps chiefly because I have defended the Augsburg people in one thing and another (never in one and all things), when they themselves were not present, and some of them count themselves among my personal friends. I have sought not to do them harm, but [to show] good.

So then, when I have found in our Synod things with which I was not in agreement, and have spoken to

And we should very much like to ask many to read it again aloud. It contains a good deal that is sound, if it is applied to withdrawal from a congregation; at the same time, it is extraordinarily weak when it is applied to withdrawal from a "Synod."

We also wish to make a few remarks on the piece, which we hope will bring Christian people onto the right track in this matter.

Concerning the reasons why one ought not to go out of "our Synod," Pastor Wright says among other things:

"1. God wills that His Church should be one, not only in the Spirit but also in the body. John 17. 1 Cor. Frailties among persons in the Synod do not annul this will of God."

It appears that Pastor Wright means that Jesus in John 17, the so-called High-Priestly Prayer, prayed about and for an outward organization of the Church, so that this prayer is fulfilled by all congregations joining themselves to one and the same outward organization, and then

some of the leaders about this, without their having, so far as I can see, followed all my suggestions, would it not then have been more right to leave the Synod and seek to bring my friends with me, so that we could be free and work freely? It is about this that I now, as I "request the floor" in "Lutheraner," should like to be allowed to include something in this letter.

1. God wills that His Church should be one, not only in the Spirit, but also in the body. John 17. 1 Cor. "Frailties" among persons in the Synod do not annul this will of God. That this will should be done, toward that end and upon that the Christian works as well as he can, when he understands his task and is obedient.

2. Sins and faults among fellow Christians are to be punished and disciplined. Matt. 18. There is much good material in the Synod for the building of the Synod. If I am worth anything as a workman, I understand how to value and work it in company with "fellow workers," so that we may build upon God's building; but this we cannot do by rejecting and being impatient.

3. How many years we are to "forbear" and labor before we give up hope of improvement is not prescribed in God's Word; in the vast majority of cases it is the whole lifetime.

4. I have the right to go out of the congregation or the Synod only: a) When false doctrine is taught and defended. b) When, on that account, false practice (ungodly conduct) develops. c) When testimony against these things (the testimony of Scripture) is stamped as error and is thus forbidden from being preached.

5. To go out is the very highest degree of church discipline. Before I can resort to this means, I must in my conscience before God be certain that the one or those from whom I separate myself are as "a Gentile or a tax collector."

6. If I myself sin (commit wrong) while I am to discipline, I become a partaker in the guilt and therefore have one support less for my case. "Rarely does only one of two cause a quarrel."

7. By taking note of the withdrawals that have not taken place on the basis described in God's Word (mentioned above), I have, in the years I have been here in this country, seen that such withdrawal ends badly. There is danger when you button your vest and make a mistake the first time; it goes well for quite a long while. But in the end you make the discovery that you have either one buttonhole too many or one button too many. And in any case, something essential is either too much or too little after a fair lapse of time, where withdrawals have been undertaken for invalid reasons.

Therefore, dear friends, let us not go out! Shall we flee the house when there is danger? What sort of watchmen are we then? No. Let us labor honestly and openly against that which, according to our conviction, is wrong, but not run away. We also need to be tested. There are, after all, two possibilities: what we think is wrong may be wrong, but we ourselves might also be mistaken. Perhaps we do not see it until we have come a good way farther on.

As for me, I may say: late I went in; late I go out. So before that, entirely different grounds than those now on the agenda will be required before I can entertain such thoughts.

Brotherly greeting from yours, bound together in the Lord,

A. Wright.

no doubt preferably the United Church.

Here, then, the question arises: Is the Church's inward and outward unity advanced or hindered by the formation of the so-called "Synods"?

We know from the New Testament that the Church's unity is not hindered by the many congregations. Jesus and His apostles were not opposed to the number of congregations increasing in a lawful manner.

But if synod after synod is formed, and synod against synod, and each of them claims to be the one true Church, does not this hinder the Church's unity?

Is it absolutely certain that the formation of these governing church bodies really belonged to the plan of Jesus and the apostles?

But if it should be so that the freedom and independence of the congregations, without any governing "Synod" over them, is the original order, the one best fitted for the Church's unity, then it is indeed asked whether those who tighten the synodical bond the most and make it into such a matter of conscience also serve the Church's unity best.

For we all know that congregations are divided and torn apart on account of the so-called synods; is this then also an advancement of the Church's unity?

And Pastor Wright further says: "4. To go out of the congregation or the Synod I have a right only" etc.

To this we would only remark that this view, according to which congregation or synod is placed absolutely side by side, seems to us either to place the congregation too low or the synod too high.

"Folkebladet" does not wish to pronounce itself on the many reasons that speak for withdrawal from the United Church. We are certain that the congregations will find out where the shoe pinches. If there are any among them who feel that they cannot with good conscience remain with the "Synod," then they know well enough what they are to do. "Folkebladet" has no anxiety about the merely outward side of the matter.

Georg Sverdrup

3.30 Free Church Meetings

Editorial article in "Folkebladet" for March 16, 1898.

Both Dr. (J. A. S.) and Pastor Kildahl seem to think that it is far better to have the association government over the congregations than that the congregations, entirely free and independent, should decide all their own matters for themselves. And when these men hold this opinion, they surely have the right to maintain it.

But this does not give them the right to present matters as though the Free Church meetings had the same authority as the old association meetings, though they were constituted in an entirely different manner.

Let us come to a clear understanding of this matter; for otherwise we do one another wrong without intending it.

The Free Church meetings are constituted differently from the associations' annual meetings, and therefore they have absolutely no power or authority over a single congregation.

With respect to the congregation's right, the Free Church has laid down this principle in its work, that no congregation shall or may be bound by any decision other than its own.

Now one may certainly hold the opinion, if one wishes, that it is foolish to work according to such a principle, and that the congregations do not have so much understanding that they can be entrusted with so much authority in their own affairs. But one ought not, when the Free Church has this principle, to assert that it does not have it.

It is self-evident that when the Free Church meetings cannot command and prescribe anything, then they cannot forbid the congregations anything either.

But then there comes the question, which is put to us with full justification: Why in the world does one have Free Church meetings, if these meetings have no authority either to command or to forbid the congregations anything?

Yes, it is an altogether legitimate question, one to which all Free Church people must be prepared to give an answer.

There is no one who is so fond of voluntary meetings as the Free Church people, and they must surely have a reason for it. There must be something that draws them together; otherwise they would not come in such numbers.

The purpose of these meetings, which work so strengthening and enlivening an effect both upon those who are guests and upon those who receive the guests, is, in its general character, to encourage one another to love and good works.

That those who carry on association politics in the old style cannot understand what such a thing is for is only too natural. Those, on the other hand, who are beginning to glimpse something, however little, of the way of the Spirit and the nature of freedom set great value on the most brotherly urging and counsel, even though no compulsion can be laid upon the congregations. They know what Paul calls exhortation in Christ, love's encouragement, and the fellowship of the Spirit, tender love and mercies. And experience demonstrates that free Christian meetings are serviceable precisely for this.

Now it is entirely true that these are lofty and difficult things, and that it is very easy for the Free Church meetings to strike into the political track of the association meetings....

What is at issue is the unity of the Spirit, not the compulsion of the Law. If Spirit and love are not present, then let us go back to the old association order; for then it is only self-deception if we imagine that we have come out of it.

Georg Sverdrup

3.31 Try Again

Editorial article in "Folkebladet" for May 11, 1898.

By its conduct the majority has made the whole church-body system so distasteful to a large part of our people, both within and outside ecclesiastical connection, that for our nationality's part the Lutheran Church has become altogether unattainable by the way of the church body. In other words, the United Church has put division upon its program instead of gathering. By that way it is impossible to attain peace in the Lutheran Church, even if one were to go on for thousands of years.

And yet peace and unity are very important Christian virtues and goods, necessary in some measure for the Church's thriving.

It is unavoidable that one must begin again from the beginning, that is to say, with the congregation. If there is to be any talk of a united Lutheran Church among the Norwegians in America, then the very foundation must be laid deep in apostolic spirit.

But if one begins to take this matter up and to look seriously into how things stand with the congregation among us, then one finds quite remarkable and sorrowful things.

Both in the so-called Inner Mission and in the ordering of congregations that has followed from it, the interest of the church body has, in by far the most places, been altogether predominant. Far too often the mission pastor has been degraded into an agent of the church body, who has labored with more thought for the church body and for church politics than for the salvation of souls and the right establishment of the congregation. And not only that: many a young pastor who entered the work with sincere zeal in his soul has fallen into the hands of some local boss and church politician who in reality has steered the pastor's work into the tracks of party politics. The result has been that congregational organization has become of a church-political kind instead of resting upon Christian and apostolic ground.

And as the beginning in many places is askew, so very often the continuation of the work becomes in accordance with that askew beginning. Both pastors and congregations become so interested and so trained in labor for the church body and in church politics that there remain neither time nor desire nor strength for the main thing, which is the edification of the congregation. And by laboring for the standing of the church body and for ecclesiastical interests, the torpid flesh has, besides, this advantage: it escapes from spiritual work and from serious thoughts of eternity. In the end both pastors and members of the congregation place their Christianity in this, that they are zealous men of the church body and fanatics of party.

Or is there any serious man or woman who does not see with piercing sorrow that many of the noblest and best powers in our Lutheran Church are wasted and blunted precisely for this reason?

What then is to be done? How shall we take hold of the matter?

People cry out to us that we must see to it that a church body of the old sort is formed. This, indeed, is Kildahl's cry to us. We are on the wrong way, he thinks, because we do not

form a church body. We are Catholic, he says, because we are not governed by the majority at the representative annual meeting.

But can in truth a new church body do it better than the old church bodies? Must it not increase the confusion, the division, and the church politics?

Our meaning is this: that the true remedy consists not in laboring for a church body but for the congregation. We understand the New Testament in such a way that it does not command us to have or to maintain any representative church body. We have said that neither do we find it forbidden. Church bodies must therefore be judged according to the experience of church history; they cannot be established beforehand as necessary. It is otherwise with the congregation. We must have the congregation, if we would be Christians. It is therefore best to begin with the congregation. If by God's Spirit we obtain real congregations with God's power in them, and with the advance of the Kingdom of God as their calling, then it will grow brighter over the churchly future, which is now darkened by church-political clouds.

With the freedom of the congregation will come the peace of the Church.

Georg Sverdrup

3.32 The Majority's Dominion in the Church

Editorial article in "Folkebladet" for April 20, 1898.

Pastor Kildahl published in "Folkebladet" for March 30 a longer article in defense of the absolute dominion of the majority in the Church, as this is exercised in the United Church through what he calls "the representative system." It is evident that Kildahl nowhere imagines the possibility of anything other or better than the polity of the United Church; it is this that he defends as the right one, because it is "representative."¹³

¹³From Pastor T. M. Kildahl's article the following is reproduced:

"... I believe that the old church order is better than the new, because according to the old church order it is the congregations that have joined themselves together into a church body, and it is the congregations that alone, through their representatives, decide all things that concern the church body. I believe further that the old church order is better than the new, because according to the old church order it is the congregation itself that is to own and administer its theological school, choose and depose teachers at the theological school, and in every respect govern it. Thirdly, I believe that the old church order is better than the new, because according to the old church order it is the congregations that hold the right of call, both when it concerns calling theological teachers, and when it concerns calling missionaries. Finally, I believe that the old church order is better than the new, because according to the old church order the right of ordination too rests with the congregations. I believe, therefore, that the old church order is better than the new, because the old church order is wholly throughout lawful and liberal-minded. It safeguards the congregation's freedom and rights in the affairs of the church body.

I do not believe that the new church order is as good as the old, because according to the new church order the congregations as such are completely deprived of independent standing in all the affairs of the church body. They have nothing to say in the affairs of the church body. They can adopt no resolution concerning the use of the church body's money. They do not have the right of call when it concerns sending out missionaries for the church body; they cannot choose the church body's ordaining minister. All these things are decided by people who come together for a meeting, without the congregations having chosen them for that. They do not have the right of call when it concerns choosing teachers at the theological school; they do not own the theological school; they have nothing to say over the theological school. For it all lies in the

This system is, in Kildahl's opinion, the most perfect, because when the congregations have elected, then they are represented, and when they are represented, then the opinion of the representatives is also the opinion of the congregations.

Here we note at once a great omission. God and his Son and his Spirit are altogether omitted from Kildahl's consideration of church polity. The whole manner of consideration and conception is altogether outward and worldly. It cannot be supposed that the will of

hands of a board which chooses itself. The congregations have only the right to provide the means, when it concerns the affairs of the church body. . . .

Therefore in the United Church there is no upper house consisting of pastors and no lower house consisting of laypeople. There is one assembly, where all have the same right, because they all represent congregations. It is the congregations that through their pastors and lay delegates govern and order everything. . . .

My opinion is this, that in church matters for the congregations there exists no higher authority than the congregations themselves. But I mean that this is the case not only when it concerns the particular local congregation's own internal affairs, but also when it concerns the matters that the congregations have in common, namely the affairs of the church body. And so it is according to the old church order. The church body is not over the congregations, but the congregations are over the church body; for it is the congregations that govern the church body, but the church body does not govern the congregations. According to the old church order the congregations themselves decide, altogether freely and independently, all matters, both congregational matters and the affairs of the church body. The old church order is therefore free-church, and for that reason I hold to it.

And I am altogether against the new church order as an order dangerous to a free Church and free congregations. For according to the new church order the congregations cannot freely and independently decide all their matters themselves. For according to the new church order the congregations cannot decide the matters that the congregations have in common, that is, the affairs of the church body. They cannot determine how the church body's money is to be used. They cannot determine who shall teach those who at the theological school are to be educated as pastors for the congregations. They cannot decide how the theological school is to be ordered. They cannot decide whom the church body shall appoint as missionaries to the heathen. They have lost the right of call in all those matters where the congregation in common, that is, as a church body, issues the call. Where the representative system is abolished, there the congregations are deprived of authority in all the affairs of the church body; they have lost their voting right in the affairs of the church body. There are other authorities which are altogether independent of the congregations, and which have not received their authorization from the congregations, which therefore come in one respect to be over the congregations, and which decide all these things. The congregations have only the freedom either to submit to what these authorities determine, or to withdraw. And then it seems to me that a considerable breach has been made in their freedom. One may perhaps object that as many of the members of the congregations as wish may come to the Annual Meeting and exercise influence on the course of things. That is true, but if these are not chosen by the congregations and therefore do not represent the congregations, then it is not the congregations that decide and act. And then the free-church principle is given up.

And then "Folkebladet" says that when I hold the opinion that it is much better to have the government of the church body over the congregations than that the congregations altogether freely and independently decide all their matters themselves, then I surely have the right to hold that opinion. Against that, however, I will protest in the strongest terms. I have often heard this, that a man has the right to hold whatever sort of opinion he pleases, if only he is true to his conviction. But that is a false rationalistic principle. One must indeed often put up with people if they hold opinions that are contrary to the Word of God; but they do not have the right to hold such opinions. I believe that it is contrary to the Word of God that the church body should be over the congregations; therefore I do not believe that anyone, whether "Folkebladet" or I, has the right to hold such an opinion. I believe that it is a high-church, Catholic, and contrary-to-the-Word-of-God opinion that the congregations should not have all authority, right, and freedom also with respect to the government of the church body. And because I believe that the new church order is high-church, Catholic, and contrary to the Word of God, therefore I am against it, and therefore I do not believe that its defenders have the right to hold the opinion they hold."

God could be different from the will of the majority.

Further, when Kildahl proceeds from the point of view that the majority at the Annual Meetings is the congregations, in this sense namely, that when the majority has determined something, then it is the congregations that have determined it, then that is simply subtlety and sophistry, which Kildahl knows very well. . . . Kildahl's assertion, that the determinations of the Annual-Meeting majority are the determinations of the congregations, is altogether untenable, because it is disingenuous.

It is also untenable because it is unreasonable. If, for example, 2 small congregations with 20 eligible voters between them send 4 delegates, and 1 large congregation with 200 eligible voters sends 2 delegates (it can send no more), then those two small congregations can vote for a measure which the large congregation votes against; yet according to Kildahl's opinion the case is supposed to stand thus, that such a resolution is also the resolution of the large congregation!! Which is nonsense.

Then indeed the Annual Meeting of the United Church is generally a good deal more honest in its statements; it commonly introduces its resolutions with "The church body resolves" or "The Annual Meeting resolves;" one never finds: "The congregations resolve."

As we said before: God is omitted from this church polity. And therefore conscience too is omitted from this church polity. . . . We venture to assert that if 100 congregations voted for what was wrong, and one congregation alone for what was right, then the 100 had no right whatever to rule over the conscience of the one.

But suppose now that Kildahl were right, that when someone is chosen to represent the congregation, then the congregation's understanding, feeling, and will are gathered in him. . . .

The consequence becomes this, that the most practical thing of all would be for the congregations all together to choose only one representative, or pope, and in him the congregations' understanding, feeling, and will were then gathered because he was chosen, and when the chairman spoke, then it was the congregations, because he was chosen by them. In this way matters could be decided more easily, more quickly, more cheaply, and more surely, and yet it was always the congregations' decision; for they themselves had chosen for themselves one great representative!

Yes, "the representative system," which is a Catholic invention in the Church, has indeed led to the papacy. Well then; if Kildahl can show from Scripture that God has ordained this representative system, then we shall bow and acknowledge that we have been altogether mistaken about the congregations and their right. But be altogether certain of this, that in the congregational question we bow to no other authority.

Georg Sverdrup

3.33 Clergy-Body or Congregational Freedom

Editorial article in "Folkeladet" for May 18, 1898.

Many a time it seems almost hopeless to write on this subject, though for our Church it is so highly important. There are none deeper than the one who will not hear, and it seems futile to argue this matter with those pastors—of all Norwegian church bodies—who at any cost will have a clergy-body, even if they are willing to call it a congregational body or even a free church. It is not merely lack of sincerity that makes them so altogether unwilling to discuss the question of church order in a becoming manner; nor is it only the consciousness that something would have to be attempted for the sake of “the Body of Christ,” even if, in order to make room for a free and living congregation, they should have to relinquish an illegitimate power and authority, equally ruinous to both parties, according to the Word of God; “not as those who would rule over the congregations” (1 Pet. 5:3); for there is also an excuse for the state-church clerical party: from childhood onward, and by a state-church upbringing, they have been so altogether permeated with prejudices over against the congregational question, that even the simplest statements grounded in God’s Word concerning it sound like to them a wholly foreign and incomprehensible language, a language for which many of them lack the spiritual prerequisites to understand, even if they were willing.

It is with them as it was with the priesthood in the time of the Reformers; they were so thoroughly worked through with notions of “the extraordinary holiness of the office and its unlimited mediating authority,” so terrifyingly secure because their views had the sanction of many, many centuries and the testimony of the fathers on their side, that the Reformers’ word concerning the individual’s justification solely by his own personal faith sounded to them like a foreign and heretical speech, a speech sprung from self-interest, lust for domination, and ignobility, however much it was grounded—indeed precisely because, passing by the fathers, it was grounded in God’s Word itself.

It ought surely to be a simple and indisputable truth that the ordering of the congregation and the mutual connection of the congregations, upon which their spiritual life and activity so greatly depend, must be grounded and regulated by God’s Word just as much as doctrine. And nevertheless it seems almost impossible to get the state-church clerical party of The United Church to understand or acknowledge this plain truth, and on that basis to ground the discussion apart from all personal and foreign considerations.

And if it were not because men and women round about in the congregations in all the bodies had begun to think seriously and independently about this most holy thing among us, the Body of Christ, the congregation, it would be a thankless labor to convince narrow-sighted, prejudice-bound pastors of former days.

In “Lutheraneren” for May 11 there stand, on the occasion of Prof. Briggs, who, although judged by the Presbytery to be a heretic, is nevertheless to continue as theological teacher at Union Seminary, the following tendentious remarks:

“This shows how helpless a church body can become over against false doctrine, when it does not itself own and administer its seminary. It may declare a theological professor to be a heretic, and yet he continues all the same to spread his heresy within the body. It is precisely this relation that the leading Augsburgers have wished to place Augsburg Seminary in toward The United Church, and now most recently toward the Free Church.”

For the present we shall call attention to the fact that in the remark cited above—consistently

with the language usage of The United Church—the expression “church body” is used, not “the congregations.” “Church body” is a word or concept that is not found in the New Testament; but in its historical development it has always denoted a communal connection in which the pastors have been either sole rulers or nearly sole rulers, partly on the basis of a pretended divine authority, as in the Catholic Church and the state churches, partly on the basis of a gradually heightened supremacy with the prescriptive right of age, as in most church bodies outside the state churches. The congregations and their right have in all these cases—except at the very most as wards—been left out of consideration.

Let us now make some observations drawn from historical reality concerning these “church bodies” and their “helplessness” over against heretical teachers.

When the Catholic church body, or “the Church,” as they were pleased to call it, deposed and condemned, and in part burned, such teachers as Wycliffe, Hus, and Jerome of Prague as heretics and false teachers, then surely on account of its power it was anything but “helpless.” But were the men named above therefore, from a Protestant point of view, heretics, or was there in the unrestricted power of the priesthood any guarantee for the congregations or for pure doctrine? Was not Luther entirely in his right when, on the ground of God’s Word and on behalf of God’s congregation, he protested against those teachers of theology whom the Catholic Church, with all authority and unanimity, appointed in all schools, and in whose appointment the people, who paid, had neither access nor right.

But, you say, they were Catholics and Jesuits, and we all know that they were heretical and jesuitical.

Let us then pass over to a church body with which we are well acquainted, the Norwegian Lutheran State Church. There too the priesthood had everything to say in matters of doctrine or theology, and the congregations were till the very latest unable to exercise any influence upon the choice of their own pastors or teachers.

In Hauge’s time the entire priesthood in Norway, together with the civil government, was rationalistic, and the teachers at the schools of higher learning were of the same sort. The state-church body, that is to say, the priesthood, had all the power; they were anything but “helpless,” and no one could prevent them from appointing rationalistic teachers of pastors. Is that the condition which the defenders of clergy-bodies regard as the one most in accord with God’s Word?

But, people say, that was a state church; here in this country we have free-church bodies. Very well, let us consider one of them, for example the Norwegian Synod. It makes claim to be free-church enough and asserts that it represents the congregations, in that they have the right to send representatives to the annual meetings. As is well known, the Norwegian Synod owns and controls its pastoral seminary as far as that is at all possible; otherwise the Anti-Missourians would doubtless have taken it too. Thus it is not helpless in this question. Are the congregations thereby now secured with respect to the doctrinal soundness of the theological teachers? [—] will be able to answer that better than Pastor Kildahl in Chicago.

For it is an equally well-known fact that, however much one may speak of free-church constitution and the right of the congregations in the Norwegian Synod, it is still the pastors

who, partly through their pastors' conferences, partly through the annual meetings, have the decisive, not to say the absolute, voice in all questions of the body, especially concerning doctrine and theological teachers.

If now the priesthood in the Norwegian Synod has the decisive voice in the choice of theological teachers, will it not require of them that they have the doctrinal position of the priesthood, or even of a majority of the priesthood? If now this position should happen to be false in doctrine, what remedy then have the congregations? Who then become helpless, the body or the congregations?

Is not this precisely what has happened in the Norwegian Synod, at least according to the Anti-Missourians' understanding and course of action.

It helped nothing that the body owned and controlled the chair; it helped nothing that a number of congregations and pastors protested against the false doctrine of grace-election, and over it carried on the bitterest separations in earnest—the false teachers remained standing, upheld by the majority of the body, that is to say the majority of the pastors.

And what was the only remedy that the opposing part of the body, namely the Anti-Missourians, could find? Division, division.

The anti-Missourian pastors split the body; indeed, more than that, they went around from congregation to congregation, split as many as they could, brought bitterness and party-spirit into hearts, tore up the Norwegian church people anew under the leadership of a German professor, and led them into litigious wrangling and desire for property not rightfully theirs, which has followed the Anti-Missourians down to their latest Augsburg lawsuit.

The facts lie before everyone's eyes, and each may draw his own conclusions. In truth, the clergy-bodies have been neither a spiritual nor a temporal blessing for our Norwegian church people. When the priesthood with its leaders has gained so complete an upper hand in The United Church, where by the constitution one had nevertheless hoped to secure to the congregations some right, that they have even been able to cast out of the body congregations and lawfully chosen delegates partly in order to satisfy personal revenge, partly because the congregations had maintained a school which The United Church now in court claims that the expelled members of the congregation have always lawfully been corporate members of—what security then have the congregations in such a clergy-body, either for the doctrine of a seminary or for its property?

When that same church body has in addition incorporated itself, and in many ways gathered considerable property, so that the priesthood can gradually feel itself fairly secure in its power, what regard will one then have for the congregations except as a taxable subject?

. . . Oh no, take freedom and voluntariness away from the congregations, and put a priesthood with clerical rule in their stead—however well it may begin, it will soon end in an absolute and spiritless clerical dominion. And of The United Church it cannot even be said that it has the advantage of beginning well.

The Presbyterians have a remedy against Prof. Briggs's rationalism; they can withdraw their support from his school.

And a free congregation has this remedy against a pastoral seminary which does not uphold the congregation's right and does not labor for the preservation of spiritual life: it can withhold its support. And if it is free and unhindered by all bonds of church-body organization and chains of the clergy, it can, without any regard to such things, lay its powers there where God's Word is taught purely and rightly, and the life of God is esteemed and nurtured. . . .

S. Oftedal

3.34 Simony

Editorial article in "Foldebladet" for May 18, 1898.

Since the days of Simon Magus (Acts 8), one has called it simony when someone has used money and outward means to obtain that which can rightly be obtained only by spiritual means. To buy an office in the Church is simony; to buy and sell congregations is doubly so.

This latter form of simony has become rather widespread by the help of the ties of the church bodies and the party zeal that follows with them. In some places it is carried on in a wholly coarse and open manner. There is a small congregation in a place that in church-political significance is called important. The congregation has been formed according to the old church order; one has asked only who wants a pastor, and in no way asked whether one wants a congregation. Naturally the congregation is beforehand well fitted for the work of church politics. If then occasion arises for the choosing of a pastor, agitation breaks loose from within and from without.

The matter is this: from which church body shall one call a pastor? And if the congregation thinks it is too poor to support a pastor by itself, then the matter is where one shall turn for help from the mission fund. Here lies the opportunity of the church parties. They have money, gathered for the purpose of working for the spread of the Kingdom of God; the question of where this money is to be used is often difficult to decide. If, then, the power to decide this lies in the hands of the great church politicians, one knows how it will go.

A congregational meeting is held for the choosing of a pastor in such a small and poor congregation. When the deliberations have begun, one of the politicians in the congregation comes forward with a letter from one of the politicians in one of the church bodies, stating that since the congregation is poor, but loyal to the church body and has bravely stood against "fanaticism," the church body will help the congregation by paying its pastor from the mission fund, provided that the mission committee is allowed to decide which pastor the congregation shall have.

That is a telling stroke in the matter, and no small one either. For a congregation in which a majority is perhaps altogether worldly is very susceptible to worldly arguments. If one was in doubt before, the majority is convinced now, and with thanks one accepts the offer and turns to the kindly disposed mission committee. The congregation has been won. — Simony has been committed.

Such practice is carried on among us, more and less crudely, and thereby irreparable damage is done to congregational life. In this way congregations surrender their most sacred rights

and their Christian independence, at the same time that the mission money becomes a means of corruption. It is one of the most important tasks of the Free Church to awaken the right understanding and sense for a Christian work of home mission.

Also on this point there is only one solution that is Christian. It is that the work of home mission direct its aim toward congregation, not toward church body.* Only by self-denying and self-sacrificing labor for the building up of the congregation in each place, without regard to what the "party" may gain, does one truly do any good.

Georg Sverdrup

3.35 The Free Church Is Not a "Church Body"

Editorial article in "Folkebladet," April 5, 1899.

The Committee of the United Church for the Revision of the Clergy List makes the assertion that it must strike some ministers from the clergy list of the United Church because they have taken part in the meetings of the Free Church. For, says the Committee: "It must be evident that you cannot stand as a member of two different church bodies at the same time."

This is not "evident." Even if there really were question here of two church bodies, that is surely no sufficient reason why one could not be a member of both, provided that they have the same confession and work for what is good.

So many "church bodies" or parties are, after all, organized here. Suppose now that one wished to work for the salvation of the Jews, another for the heathen, one for mission in China, another for mission in Africa; one for a seminary in Chicago, another for a seminary in St. Paul; one for preaching in English, another for preaching in Norwegian, and so forth—would it then without more ado be "evident" that a man or a congregation cannot stand as a member of two or more of these?

Behind this "evident" thing there must presumably lie the thought that each "church body" is to and must think of itself as being the whole Thing, as we say. For if the meaning is that each "church body" must think of itself as being the whole Church, or the whole Kingdom of God, or at least the Lutheran Church, or at the very least the whole true Church, then of course it is so that it becomes meaningless to be a member of more than the one true body. But we cannot now believe that the United Church has fallen into such a delusion about itself.

If that does not lie behind it, then it must be the meaning one wishes to assert, that a church body is a party which must necessarily combat all other similar parties; for then too it is true that it does not really work to be on both sides in a war of extermination. But we can hardly imagine that either, that the United Church has such an opinion of itself.

But now this must also be added: the Free Church has never been any "church body" in the outdated sense of the word. If it were, then it would presumably have to have a constitution that gathered and delimited it, and it would have to have an authority over the congregations, such as all so-called "church bodies" more or less have.

This is not found in the Free Church. It is a free association of Lutheran congregations without any governing authority over them. The congregations are as independent of one another as England and the United States. They may cooperate when and where they will; but the one cannot compel the other to join where it does not itself see a call to do so.

The meetings of the Free Church are therefore free open meetings for Lutheran Christians. Their resolutions are binding upon the committees which the meetings themselves appoint; for all others they are only to be regarded as encouragements, urgings, proposals, and counsel. Their influence therefore rests exclusively upon the spirit and wisdom that may be found in them.

This can only by great distortion and misuse of words be called a "church body." And it is by no means "evident" why a man could not take part in such a free meeting and nevertheless be fit to stand as a minister in the United Church.

[Georg Sverdrup.]

3.36 Trust in the Congregations

Editorial article in "Folkebladet" for April 26, 1899.

It is clearly noticeable throughout the whole ecclesiastical discussion among us that the urge to build "church bodies" derives, at least in large part, from a kind of distrust of the congregations. For what among us is called "church body" has hitherto, at least, become nothing other than organizations of pastors, in which the congregations as such have nothing to say. These organizations of pastors are regarded as trustworthy in the cause of religion; but people seem to be afraid to entrust the cause of Christianity, or at least of Lutheranism, to the congregations.

It is feared that the congregations either lack sufficient interest or sufficient insight, or both.

And there is surely some ground for this fear, since it is so common. Nor is it strange if people who come out of the coercion of the state church, and often without any living Christianity, should begin by supporting pastor and church, and, at least in the beginning, have both little interest and little understanding of the matter.

When one has never asked the people whether they want a congregation, or whether they want to be a congregation, but only whether they want a pastor and administrations of the sacraments, then it is indeed reasonable enough that many feel as though pastor and church and ceremonies and customs are a burden, which is necessary, but which they would prefer to see made as light as possible.

In other words, the distrust of the congregations, which is discernible among many pastors, perhaps is in reality a distrust of the work that has been done for the congregation's edification among us.

If a shipbuilder does not dare to go aboard a ship which he himself has built, then that is not any especially strong recommendation of the shipbuilder himself.

If, however, we go to God's Word, then we do not find this distrust of the congregations. The New Testament presents it in such a way that the congregation is equipped by God Himself with all the necessary gifts to preserve and spread God's Kingdom on earth. Jesus and His apostles are not afraid—under God—to entrust the cause of the Gospel in the world to the congregation. There is no higher organization above the congregation that is more trustworthy than the congregation itself.

Is it to be understood, then, that the congregations in those days had greater interest and more insight? And did not the congregations' competence grow by the responsibility that rested upon them?

When we think over this matter, it appears as though the congregations among us have lost their freedom because they have lost their competence. And now they are kept in tutelage, and thereby their incapacity continues.

Is it not then right for the Free Church to work for this matter to return once more to its proper course? And is it not fitting that freedom and responsibility, and responsibility and freedom, should go together, so that the one grows with the other?

Let the congregations receive the work and the responsibility that God's Word gives them, and the cause of Christianity shall not suffer if it is entrusted to those to whom God's Word entrusts it.

But do not misunderstand us. We do not mean a congregation without a pastor; when we speak of congregations, everything that belongs to the congregation is included therein. And we believe that it would be an exceedingly great advance if on both sides it could be acknowledged that there is no advantage in cultivating opposition between pastors and laypeople, since both are members of the congregation and need one another.

Georg Sverdrup

3.37 The Ecclesiastical Discussion

Editorial article in "Folkebladet," April 5, 1899.

... The question of resuming the constitution of the Conference is of an altogether different nature from the question of the name. [Shall the Free Church be called "the Free Church" or "the Conference"?] It would be to form something new, and something so different from the Free Church that it is even doubtful whether the Free Church's annual meeting could do anything in the matter other than, at the very most, recommend it to the congregations. One would presumably first have to hold an organizing meeting of those who wished to form such a new church body, in order to adopt a constitution. One would then in all likelihood increase the number of church bodies and still have the Free Church besides. For many men and congregations seem to think that there are church bodies enough already. ...

Georg Sverdrup

3.38 No Difference

Editorial article in “Folkebladet” for September 21, 1904.

In the last number of “Folkebladet” we discussed the remarkable claim advanced by the organ of the United Church, “Lutheraneren,” namely, that there is really no difference between the United Church and the Free Church, but that only “the leaders at Augsburg” have, in their cunning, “found out” something of that sort.

The question especially is this: Is the question, Do you want congregation? one such “dug-up” question, by which the “leaders” have wished to make it appear as though there were a difference where there was no difference?

All old Conference people, whether they belonged to the “old” or the “new” direction in the Conference, know well that there was a difference even within the Conference; and then they know all the more that there was a great difference between the “new” direction and the Synod.

But it may be that the anti-Missourians know nothing of this, or that they think that, in the days of conflict and union, they took such a decided stand with “the new direction,” that is, the Augsburgers within the Conference, that at any rate from that time there could be no talk of difference.

Believe that, whoever can!

We shall begin by presenting a testimony which shows that it has already become part of church history on a large scale that there was a difference in church principles and views, which lay at the foundation of the transfer question and of the coming-into-being of the Free Church.

We take this testimony from the most important theological work of the present age, namely Herzog’s Theological Realencyclopedia, issued in its third edition by Professor Hauck in Leipzig. In this work some 250 of the most learned men of our time within the Protestant churches are collaborating, and little nonsense is likely to find its way into it. In the fourteenth volume of this encyclopedia (printed in 1904) there is an article on the Lutheran Church in the United States, written by Adolf Spaeth, in which it says concerning the Lutheran Free Church:

“At the newly effected formation of the United Norwegian Lutheran Church in America, Augsburg Seminary in Minneapolis, which had previously belonged to the Norwegian-Danish Conference, was to pass over to the newly founded union. But difficulties soon arose in regard to this, since the views maintained by Augsburg Seminary concerning the requirements for theological formation, the pastoral office, congregation, and church did not meet with the approval of the United Norwegian Lutheran Church. These differences led to a complete rupture. In the year 1893 the United Church removed its theological institution from Augsburg Seminary and founded a new theological school under Professor M. O. Bøckman. The following year the leaders of Augsburg Seminary, Sverdrup and Oftedal, then organized the Lutheran Free Church upon a strongly congregationalistic basis. According to its latest church almanac, it numbers 112 pastors, 300 congregations, 38,000 communicants.”

We have translated this whole passage, that is, all that is found about the Free Church, because we regard it as an altogether impartial testimony, and because it is the understanding of the matter which, for a long time at any rate, will count as the sure and reliable one in church history.

We will not say that we are absolutely satisfied with everything in Spaeth's testimony; but we accept it as, in all essentials, correct with respect to the difference between the majority of the United Church and the Augsburgers, and with respect to the difference which "led to a complete rupture." We also wish to add that we feel assured that Spaeth's information was not gathered from any man in the Lutheran Free Church. Should we be mistaken in this, it still does not alter our opinion of the significance of the testimony for the present and the future. It will remain standing as church-historical truth through long ages, however much "Lutheraneren" may try to overturn it.

And why should it not? It does the United Church no injustice that it is said that it did not approve Augsburg's principles, unless "Lutheraneren" means that these principles are the only right ones. But surely "Lutheraneren" does not mean that?

The matter is simply this, that Augsburg has always, at any rate since the days of the "Open Declaration,"¹⁴ maintained the same views concerning theological training, the pastoral ministry, congregation, and church which it maintains to this very day.

Georg Sverdrup

3.39 A Curious Piece of News

Editorial article in "Folkebladet" for November 22, 1905.

In "Lutheraneren" for November 1 of this year, one reads:

"The committee of the United Church appointed to negotiate concerning union with the other Lutheran bodies over here has approached the Norwegian Synod, Hauge's Synod, the Free Church, the Brotherhood, and the Evangelical Church in America, with a view to opening negotiations for union. The committee consists of the president of the body and the theological faculty."

We call it a remarkable piece of news. For at its last annual meeting the United Church defined its position toward "the other Lutheran bodies over here" so sharply that one might well regard all "negotiations for union" as altogether useless and meaningless.

That the Free Church is mentioned as one of "the other Lutheran bodies over here" in such a connection as this must surely be due to thoughtlessness. The Free Church consists, as is well known, of an annual meeting open to all Lutheran Christians who will cooperate for free and living congregations. With this annual meeting no body can very well unite. Nor is it easy to see how anyone can prevent this annual meeting from being held; yet that was perhaps the plan of union which some people would like best as far as the Free Church is concerned.

We may therefore leave the Free Church out of consideration in this matter.

¹⁴See Professor Oftedal's decisive testimony in court regarding the "Open Declaration," FIXME page 198.

3.40 On “Lay Activity”

Editorial article in “Foldebladet” for April 3, 1907.

The large Joint Committee which is negotiating concerning the union of the church bodies also dealt with “lay activity” at its meeting last autumn. The result of the work is set forth in seven theses which, it is said, were unanimously adopted by the representatives of the different bodies. To each of the seven theses there has been appended one or more passages of Scripture, or else statements from the Lutheran Confessional Writings. The connection between the Scripture passages and the theses is, however, so unclear that interpretation is needed in order to make them fit together.

Nor do the theses speak of “lay activity” alone, not even chiefly. They speak of the congregation, the means of grace, the preaching office, the gifts of grace, the universal priesthood, and finally perhaps of “lay activity.” But although all these things are spoken of, there is nevertheless no explanation either of what is meant by the congregation or by “lay activity.” Indeed, we say that perhaps “lay activity” is spoken of; for it is not mentioned by name in any of the theses. Strictly speaking, we infer that Thesis 5 speaks of “lay activity,” because there are certain expressions which somewhat recall this matter, and because such great care is taken to have it properly controlled.

Proposition 5 reads as follows:

God also wills that the special gifts of grace which he may have given to certain persons in the congregation, and which therefore are the property of the congregation, shall be put to use by the congregation; and thus in particular the gift of grace of being able to proclaim God’s Word before an assembly. According to God’s Word, the one who has received this gift of grace shall be called to this service in the congregation by its request or consent, and shall use the gift under the oversight of the congregation or of those whom the congregation has called to exercise oversight over the work in the congregation, as God’s Word and our Church’s Confession say.

Nothing is said about what is meant by the congregation, either in this thesis or in any of the others; we read only in Thesis 1 that “God has given to the congregation, also to the individual local congregation, the means of grace,” etc. Presumably, therefore, by the congregation is meant simply the outward organization which in each place bears the name congregation, whether it deserves the name or not, whether it is dead or living, awake or asleep.

If we look at the thesis on this assumption, we find the following assertions, some with and some without the assurance that they are “according to God’s Word”:

1. When certain persons in the congregation have received a gift of grace, that gift is therefore “the property of the congregation.”

2. When someone has received “the gift to proclaim God’s Word before an assembly,” he shall be called to this service in the congregation by its request or consent.
3. When he has thus been called, he shall use the gift under the oversight of the congregation or of those whom the congregation has called to exercise oversight over the work in the congregation.

The first of these assertions stands on its own merits; but the second is said to be “according to God’s Word”; the third, “as God’s Word and our Church’s Confession teach.”

We have understood the Joint Committee in this Thesis 5 to be thinking of “lay activity”; for the quotation marks which are used must surely indicate here that the expression is taken from ordinary usage, which has made the term so well known among us; and the “lay activity” commonly known among us may perhaps be described as a “gift of grace to proclaim God’s Word in an assembly,” without our thereby acknowledging that the explanation is exact or sufficient.

Now it is asserted in Thesis 5 that all gifts of grace which God has given to certain persons in the congregation are therefore the property of the congregation. From what follows, the meaning is that the congregation can and shall determine whether these gifts are to be used and how they are to be used, of course under responsibility to God, but with such power and authority that no one has the right to use the gift—at least not the gift of speaking in an assembly—without the congregation’s permission.

Here we must ask: Where is it written that the individual Christian’s gift of grace is the property of the congregation? “All things are yours,” says Paul, but surely that is meant of the Christians, not of an outward organization of people concerning whose Christianity no more can be said than that they are entered in a congregational register? Christians can say that all things are ours because they are Christ’s and Christ is God’s; but surely it is not thereby said that an outward organization of Christians and non-Christians may dispose of and command all things in heaven and on earth, and in particular may determine whether the Christian shall use his gift of grace or not? Can a congregational decision remove the responsibility from those who have received the gift, so that a man need not use it because the congregation does not call upon him to do so? God’s Word says that the individual Christian bears responsibility for his gift of grace or his talent. God’s Word says that only the one who has gained a return from his pound enters into his master’s joy, and that the one who has no return, because he has buried his pound so carefully in the ground, is cast into the outer darkness, where there is weeping and gnashing of teeth. See, that speech has an altogether different sound from the Committee’s Thesis 5, and it gives no excuse to the lazy flesh.

No, one says, the Committee has meant nothing of the kind except with respect to the gift of proclaiming God’s Word in an assembly. “Lay activity” in the Haugean sense, then, is the one gift which the congregation must acknowledge by request or consent, and the one who has received it must conduct himself accordingly. If he receives a request, he shall speak; if he receives no request, he shall be silent in an assembly.

If this is the meaning, does it make the matter any better? Or is it written anywhere that

the one who has received this gift is free of his responsibility when the congregation does not call upon him?

Suppose now that the congregation sleeps, and God in his grace sends a crying voice to awaken it? Or suppose that the congregation is dead, even though it has the name that it lives; must the one who was sent even to awaken the spiritually dead then be silent until the dead call upon the living one to speak?

No, neither the first assertion, that the gifts of grace are the property of the congregation, nor the second assertion, that no one may bear witness in an assembly before he has been called upon by the congregation, holds good “according to God’s Word,” which, on the contrary, makes the duty of witness dependent not upon a congregational call but simply and directly upon the personal Christian calling. Whether the witness is given to an individual or “in an assembly” makes no difference according to Scripture. Let the one who has the gift to speak to the individual speak to the individual, and let the one who has the gift to speak in an assembly speak in an assembly.

What is meant, after all, by “an assembly”? Notice that it does not say the congregation’s assembly, or the congregation; it says merely “an assembly.” How many constitute an assembly, and where and when may people come together before it becomes an assembly? Anyone can see that such indefinite words can be used by a misguided congregation or pastor to suppress the proclamation of God’s Word and every testimony of individual Christians both within and outside the congregation. French law in Madagascar provides that a Christian evangelist or missionary may, outside the church building, speak God’s Word to two but not to three, for three are an assembly; at home in France the law says that a Christian preacher may speak God’s Word outside the church building to nineteen but not to twenty persons, for twenty persons are an assembly. Is it not possible that the enemies of living Christianity are of the same kind in America as in France? And are there not many, many congregations in which the majority is opposed to lay activity?

We ought not frame our rules in such a way that the enemies of the awakening are given so useful a handle to seize upon as this. It was precisely by such means that Hauge was made a criminal in Norway, because without the call of men he spoke God’s Word in assemblies. Are we to return to such rules, which here in our country may indeed be unable to bring a man to fines and imprisonment, but which can nevertheless close his mouth, so that he is silent where he ought to speak?

And the final assertion in Thesis 5, that lay activity shall be exercised under the oversight of the congregation or of those whom the congregation has chosen for that purpose, plainly moves in the same direction. For in this context such oversight must mean that the congregation, or pastor, or congregational council has the right once again to deny the one who has the gift the use of it, if they so choose. For it comes to the same thing: God may give gift and call, but men, because they have formed an outward congregational order, may forbid the use of the gift.

To all this the Committee can say that it has a Thesis 6 which declares that in such a case “the congregation suffers harm.” But that does not meet the issue; for the question is this: Can the one who has received the gift refrain from using it for any reason whatever without

himself suffering harm? And it is a harm which, according to God's Word, consists in this, that "his hands and feet are bound, and he is cast into the outer darkness, where there is weeping and gnashing of teeth."

[Georg Sverdrup.]

3.41 The Congregation and Lay Activity

Editorial article in "Folkebladet" for April 10, 1907.

In the previous number of "Folkebladet" we had to write something about the manner in which the large Association Committee dealt with "Lay Activity." It is unpleasant enough to have to take up such misleading representations of a precious cause; and we therefore owe it to ourselves this time to speak more positively about the matter.

When, then, we wish to speak about the congregation and lay activity, it is in order to say that it is to be expected that it will make a difference also for the cause of lay activity where there is a congregation.

By a congregation we mean a gathering of working Christians who use the means of grace and the gifts of grace for their own salvation and blessedness and that of their fellow human beings. Where such a gathering of active Christians is found, the question will not be one of binding and controlling lay activity and other gifts of grace, but much rather of giving them room and freedom, opportunity and encouragement, so that they may attain their greatest flourishing and most effective use.

Here, then, a question arises which there was no occasion to discuss in the previous article, namely: who has this gift of speaking in an assembly, which is, after all, one of the conditions of lay activity? And who is to decide whether such a gift is present? And how is such a gift best to be discovered and developed?

Here lies a difficulty which all have felt who have thought with interest and love about lay activity and its flourishing. Not everyone has received the gift merely because he imagines that he has it. Nor does anyone receive the gift by being called by a congregation to speak in an assembly. It is evident, indeed, in the case of a number of pastors that they themselves believe they have the gift, and they also have the call of the congregation, but nevertheless the gift of grace does not appear to be present.

With regard to this matter we have heard that Hauge's friends had the custom that some of the older, tested Christians and preachers of God's Word exercised the work of testing spirits and gifts, and that new and younger forces had to submit to a fairly long period of testing before they received an independent place in the ranks of the witnesses. And a similar procedure should surely be sought also among us. We say "similar," for precisely the same manner will probably be difficult to attain.

It is clear that neither chairs nor examinations can produce a lay preacher; but neither does anyone become a lay preacher simply by giving up other work without further ado and making it his livelihood to travel about and preach. A traveling evangelist or revivalist who has this work as his sole occupation and livelihood is not a lay preacher in the older sense of the word.

We understand also that those who make the work of preaching their only occupation are preferably called emissaries, both in Norway and here among us.

Without doubt the work of an evangelist has its great significance. But it is not Haugean lay activity. We do not depreciate the one work merely because we write in commendation of the other.

A lay preacher is a preacher who has a message from God to bring to his fellow human beings, and who cannot remain silent concerning that message which God has given him to bear forth without unfaithfulness; and who therefore, both in conversation with individuals and in larger or smaller assemblies of various kinds, brings forth this message. But he continues to be a layman while he thus preaches, and does not derive his livelihood from this work of preaching.

They are driven to speak and cannot refrain from it; they begin wherever they have opportunity, in their home and in their home district; they travel about for shorter or longer distances, and neither congregational resolutions nor other prohibitions bar their way.

Naturally, they are dependent upon what trust they gain, especially among other Christians. To give them a congregational call is not necessary and therefore not desirable either; for then they could regulate neither their time nor their preaching according to their ability and gift, but would have to try to please those in whose pay they were. But this does not exclude the congregation from encouraging and urging them on in such a manner as it itself finds right and useful.

But their gift is tested through the use of the gift and is proved by the reception they gain. There are honorable and upright ways by which their influence may gradually be extended into wider circles, if they attain that glorious thing of gaining the trust of Christians. But to procure for oneself a whole number of testimonials, which perhaps are given half unwillingly because no one wishes to offend them by refusing them a testimonial, is often equivalent to a lack of real trust.

The true lay preacher is independent of monetary gifts. He has his temporal work and his livelihood apart from his Christian witness. Therefore his authority is greater, and his witness is often more effective among many people.

Such men stand as free and independent as is at all compatible with the Christian estate and brotherhood. And in this lies, in no small degree, their value to the congregation. They belong to the congregation, and they belong to the Lord; they are driven by the Lord's Spirit to bear witness to those within the congregation and to those outside the congregation. The congregation cannot, without overreach, command them to be silent when it must be acknowledged that God has given them a message and a gift; neither can they demand of the congregation that it support them when it has not called them. But where there is a free and living congregation, it may be expected both that there will be much such lay activity and that broad room and free opportunity will be opened for it. For although not many in each place have great gifts in this direction, many Christians ought nevertheless to have spirit and power to bear such witness as might be for the edification of those who hear it.

We are altogether convinced that living congregations will do well to heed the apostolic rule

in 1 Corinthians 14:

“What then is to be done, brothers? When you come together, each of you has a psalm, he has a teaching, he has a word, he has an interpretation; let all things be done for edification!”

And it is surely not too much to say that if, according to this apostolic rule, all Christians become the Savior’s witnesses also “in an assembly,” lay activity too will flourish better. For, first, the gifts will come into use in the proper Christian manner; and second, a lay preacher will not come to stand so alone as a “lone tree” on the prairie, which is always a dangerous and sorrowful position.

Let a little life come into the work, and things will go better with us in every direction!

[Georg Sverdrup.]

3.42 Appendix

3.42.1 On Admission to the Congregation

[At the Free Church’s annual meeting in 1898, which among other things discussed a draft for a congregational constitution, there was discussion of what conditions a congregation had the right to require of those who applied for admission to the congregation. Some held that the congregation ought to require a confession, for example: “I believe in Jesus,” “I know that I love Jesus,” or the like. In the course of the conversation Sverdrup expressed himself as follows, according to the report in *Foldebladet* for June 22, 1898:]

“One may also speak falsely about Jesus. One may adopt certain over-bold ways of speaking about Jesus and mean little by them; so neither is that any sure sign of true life in God.

The difficulty is not admission to the congregation, but the difficulties must be placed in connection with the congregation itself. Who is to admit? What is the congregation like?

When the congregation is worldly and the pastor is worldly, then they naturally admit such as are like themselves. If, on the other hand, one had an assembly of believers and a believing pastor, there would not be such great difficulties with admission to the congregation.

As conditions are in most places, it is simply impossible to get matters into proper order. An abuse is abroad. Many enter the congregation in order to obtain reassurance over against eternity; others want protection against attacks upon sins and vices within the congregation. When, for example, a pastor rises up against acts of moral recklessness, then people are brought into the congregation in order to drive the pastor away.

It is therefore right to be very careful about admission to the congregation; above all, that one admit man by man, person by person. Admission in this connection means nothing other than that one gives those who are admitted occasion to be among those who govern the congregation, not that one gives them an endorsement as Christians or gives them access to hear God’s Word.

The stricter one is, the better. One thereby hinders no one from salvation and blessedness.

One can be saved even if one does not have one’s name in the congregational register.

According to God's Word we see that those who were baptized and saved were also added to the congregation. If now some congregation wished to draw a boundary and say: only when you have come to conscious faith may you take part in governing the congregation, then it surely has the right to do so.

I should prefer to write the point differently, so that it might come into agreement with VII, 4, where it says that the congregational council shall 'examine whether those who request admission to the congregation have the requisite conditions for it.' There ought to be some testimony, and preferably the testimony of those who have tested the person concerned."

[In accordance with what has been communicated above, Sverdrup at the Free Church's 9th annual meeting, 1905, gave an address on the conditions for the formation of a congregation, in which he says:]

"It lies in the nature of the matter that, as the congregations grew older and increased in number and esteem, and there came to be many different reasons that might move a person to join the congregation, it had to seek to guard itself against the danger that lies in admitting such members as are drawn to the congregation not by God's Spirit, but by fleshly reasons. Everything that lives and grows has within itself the instinct of self-preservation and seeks to keep away and to remove what is called 'foreign matter.' It is therefore also self-evident that the highest and most delicate of all organisms, Christ's body, or the congregation, was careful both with admission into and exclusion from the congregation. And partly through its office-bearers and partly through the congregation's meetings, the congregation exercised the oversight which it recognized as its holy duty toward the Lord and His body. But this did not, of course, conflict with the principle of voluntariness; it only imposed a necessary and justified test upon the character of that voluntariness, whether it was the work of the Spirit or of the flesh."

3.42.2 Dogmatic Paragraphs on the Church

Georg Sverdrup Manuscript 1907

§ 1. To treat the doctrine of the Church after the doctrine of the means of grace, so that the Church should be "the community of people among whom the means of grace have had their intended effect" (Tønning), does not answer to the Christian understanding of the Church's coming into being, nor either to the individual Christian's experience of how he himself has been incorporated into the Church.

§ 2. The Church came into being through a divine act, which is part of God's revelation among men, and belongs to the eternal counsel of salvation which promises the race's restoration from its fall. This divine act consists in the sending of the Holy Spirit into the hearts of Jesus' disciples on the first (Jewish) Pentecost after Christ's ascension. The signs which accompanied the Spirit's sending are such as reveal what the Spirit's working is like in character, and what it aims at. The storm signifies the mighty power, the tongues of fire the heavenly light, the foreign tongues the spread among all peoples.

§ 3. The divine benefaction which the Spirit's sending brings to Jesus' believing disciples is, according to Jesus' promise in the Gospel of John chapters 14-17, Luke 24:49, and Acts 1:4-8, and according to Christian experience of the Spirit's working: new, divine life, and new, spiritual light joined with the power for action and urge to witness that belong thereto. Both the divine life, which according to its essence is love, and the spiritual light, which is truth, proceed from the exalted and glorified Jesus Christ, with whom the Spirit unites the believing disciples, so that they become His body, and He their Head.

§ 4. The Church is thus, for Christian understanding, a new creation, a new race, which again bears the image of God; yet not a new bodily human race alongside the old, but a renewal of the old race through the forgiveness of sins and the life of the Holy Spirit in the hearts, in such a way that this community lives the renewed human life amid the outward conditions of the fallen race, surrounded by sin in the flesh and in the world, and with temporal death as the regular, though not unavoidable, issue from the present world.

§ 5. The Church, which consists of those who have received the Holy Spirit, takes on its outward form, manifests itself, and shows itself effectual and capable of inward and outward growth through the use of the gifts of grace and the means of grace. All have received the same Spirit, but not therefore precisely the same gifts; therefore there arise several different branches of activity in the Church through such persons as God has given gifts, and the Church has received by its recognition of the gifts. Of all activity in the Church, the use of the means of grace, the Word and the Sacraments, is the most significant and, under all historical conditions, necessary for the Church's preservation and growth; and for that reason the gifts of grace which fit men for the administration of the means of grace, and most particularly for the proclamation of God's Word, are those which the Church esteems most highly and cultivates with particular care.

§ 6. The Spirit's working for the Church's inward and outward growth thus takes place through the gifts of grace and the means of grace, and since order and coherence are needed in the Church's work within its own midst and in and for the surrounding world, there follows from this of necessity the Church's organization, in order that the work may become as effective as possible, and all members of the Church may find their place in it.

§ 7. The relation of the means of grace to the Church consists in this, that by the Word faith in Jesus Christ is created and preserved; by Baptism the believing are received into living fellowship with Jesus Christ and thereby into His body, the Church; and by the Lord's Supper this living fellowship between the Lord and the Church is sustained and preserved.

§ 8. The relation of the Church to the means of grace consists in this, that the Church administers them through men whom it elects for that purpose; in this its election the Church seeks to find the men whom the Lord Himself has furnished with the gifts which are especially required for the proclamation of the Word and the Church's spiritual guidance. The "inner call" to this work thus consists essentially in the gift of grace from God, whereas the "outer call" consists in the Church's election to labor in the definite field. Since no difference of rank takes place among the Church's members, the Church's election or ordination cannot produce any such difference either, since the matter concerns only the distribution of work among the persons fitted for it. The less therefore Scripture permits the priests to rule in the Church,

the more it holds true that all in the Church owe the obedience of faith to the Lord's Word.

§ 9. From these outward conditions of the Church it follows that from the one first Church many congregations spring forth, which nevertheless all together constitute only the one Christian community on earth, which began with the sending of the Holy Spirit, which community therefore also in the New Testament is called by the same name as the individual congregation, namely *ecclesia*, whereas we frequently give it the name Church (from *kyriaké*, an adjective with *ecclesia* understood, meaning "belonging to the Lord"). Yet this new name must not lead us to think that thereby there should be designated a community which stood above the congregation or had an essence different from it.

§ 10. This Christian community on earth is, despite the division into many congregations, despite the various confessions, in part mutually contradictory, despite the many different ecclesiastical organizations, despite the theological controversies, still only one, in that the unity consists (invisibly) in the one Spirit and the one Lord with all the spiritual qualities that follow therefrom, and (visibly) in the one and the same Word of God, the one Baptism, the one Lord's Supper, the common ecumenical confessions, and a multiplicity of less significant marks. The most important division of which the history of the Church reports is that which took place at the Reformation, in that the opposition to the Church's secularization, which was present more or less strongly in the Church history of antiquity and the Middle Ages, became so strong that it brought about a breach which can be healed only slowly. But neither does this abolish the Church's unity, because the Reformation has precisely its roots in the Christian foundation which was found within the Roman Church itself, though buried beneath the rubble of many human ordinances.

§ 11. The one Christian community on earth is holy on account of the indwelling and working of the Holy Spirit therein, whereby the believing disciples of Jesus are sanctified in an ever more inward union with the Lord Jesus Christ, while those who have fallen away from the faith, through the working of the Word and the Spirit upon their resistant hearts, ripen unto the final and unavoidable judgment. Holiness is therefore not abolished by the participation of hypocrites in the outward Church.

§ 12. In the Apostles' Creed the Christians also confess faith in the Church's catholicity, which consists in this, that the Holy Spirit works for the salvation and eternal blessedness of all men, and that this missionary activity does not cease until all who will let themselves be saved have been saved, and thus the work of the Son and the Spirit on earth has reached its perfect completion, in that the fallen human race has been restored from its fall, and those who, despite the Gospel's offer, have resisted the Spirit and grace, are excluded from the kingdom of God's eternal glory and from the redeemed human race.

§ 13. The Church's apostolicity, or the Christian conviction that the Church still is the same as that which in the New Testament period of revelation was built upon the foundation of the apostles and prophets, rests upon the truth that the Church's coming into being and all its existence and history are wrought and borne by the Holy Spirit; and it is served by this, that the Church preserves agreement with the holy New Testament Scripture, which is the complete and infallible witness concerning the Church's essence and reality from the beginning.

§ 14. Since the Church has come into being through the Spirit's sending into the hearts of Jesus' earthly disciples, and these have Jesus' command to make all peoples His disciples, it becomes unavoidable that the question should be raised and decided already in the apostolic age whether the Church is only a form of the Jewish religious community modified by faith in the Messiah who has come, and whether therefore the Church is bound by the Law that was given to the Jews, so that the Church can be known only by the observance of Jewish customs and ceremonies. And through the struggle which the deciding of this question costs, the great result is won for Christian faith, that the Church is a new community dependent only on faith in Jesus Christ and the new creation, which consists in the Spirit's imparting of the new life, so that none of the signs and symbols, customs and ceremonies of the Jewish Law are binding upon the Church and of course neither necessary for salvation. This mighty victory over all demands for the observance of the Law has the abiding significance for the Church in all ages, that it is impossible to bind it by such regulations, laws, customs, ceremonies, and the like, as are commandments of men, and make them, or the observance of them, marks of the one true Church.

§ 15. The question whether the Kingdom of God, or the Kingdom of Heaven, is the same as the Church, must first be answered to this effect, that the Church can only be the Kingdom of God on earth, and second, that even if we speak only of the Kingdom of God here on earth or in the present world, yet the concept of the Kingdom of God is broader than the concept of the Church, in that to it belongs not only the Spirit's life in the hearts, which is the Church's inward essence, but also the preparing and guiding divine government and governance of the human race, and doubtless also the manifold effects of divine revelation in the Gospel outside of and alongside the Church in the life of the human spirit, in art, science, literature, the constitution of the state, etc.; just as also the exceedingly great changes which take place in the world, and especially in the existence of the human race, at Christ's return belong under the concept of the Kingdom of God. The relation between the Church and the Kingdom of God on earth must therefore be determined to this effect, that the Church is the central current of life in the Kingdom of God on earth, alongside of which divine operations of grace and power are perceived, which indeed belong to the Kingdom of God, but yet do not serve unto salvation for those who are touched by them, unless they become means to draw them to the Son and His body, which is the Church. The Church's course is concluded and brought to completion at Christ's return and the final judgment, when the Kingdom of glory with its rest and blessedness replaces the Church's labor, struggle, and tribulation.

Can the Lutheran Free Church Possess Property?

At the Free Church's annual meeting in 1897 the question whether the Free Church can possess property was, according to the report in "Foldebladet" for June 16, 1897, answered as follows:

(Prof. Sverdrup said) "the Free Church could own nothing and yet possess all things in a spiritual sense. The Free Church can no more own the bookstore than it can own Augsburg Seminary or the Deaconess Home."

3.42.3 About Open Declaration

(1897.)

STATE OF MINNESOTA; COUNTY OF HENNEPIN. DISTRICT COURT; FOURTH JUDICIAL DISTRICT.

In the Matter of the Application of Nils C. Brun, Lauritz F. Clausen, Lars Swenson, Orson A. Veblen and Ole O. Aanstad, for leave to File an Information, in the nature of quo warranto, against Sven Oftedal, Olaf Hoff, Ole Paulson, Theodore Helgesen and Andrew Knutson.

AFFIDAVIT OF SVEN OFTEDAL.

State of Minnesota, County of Hennepin—ss.

Sven Oftedal being first duly sworn, upon his oath deposes and says:

At the time I thus became connected with Augsburg Seminary there existed a difference of opinion among Norwegian Lutherans respecting church polity and methods of theological instruction.* Such difference of opinion has ever since existed among them, and contributed largely to the controversies which thereafter arose in the Conference, as will be shown in this affidavit. On the one hand were the adherents of the “new school,” as it is called, whose convictions were and are that the individual congregation is “the church;”* and should act with other congregations for common purposes only, and reserve to itself control respecting questions pertaining to the administration of its own affairs and those also bearing upon “purity of doctrine,” as these words are understood among theologians. Those entertaining these views respecting church polity call them “free church” ideas.* On the same side were those who believed that ministers should be trained and educated in accordance with these views,* and with reference to their future calling, throughout their collegiate or preparatory course, as well as during their theological course, as the same is commonly understood. On the other side were the adherents of what is called the “old school,” who opposed, to a greater or less extent, the views of the new school, and desired, as it was believed, to partially adopt or retain certain methods of church government* prevailing in the established or state church of Norway.

The theological professors and instructors of Augsburg Seminary, and its board of trustees now in control of the seminary, have adhered to the new school as herein defined, and have conducted the seminary in accordance with its views. And in entering upon my work at Augsburg Seminary I was actuated by a desire and willingness to devote my entire life to the advancement of free church ideas,* and what I then believed, and still believe, to be the true purpose and end of a theological or divinity school. As will be seen, these free church doctrines and ideas thus entertained by the present theological professors of Augsburg Seminary, while antagonizing certain of the ministers of the Conference, obtained for them the earnest and enthusiastic support of a large majority of the lay delegates participating in the annual meetings of the society, and of the individual members of the various congregations constituting that association.

In the year 1873, and ever since, there has been in this country an organization of Norwegian Lutheran churches officially entitled “The Synod of the Norwegian Evangelical Lutheran

Church of America,” and commonly called the Norwegian Synod, between which and the Conference there existed in the year last mentioned, as well as in later years, a somewhat bitter doctrinal controversy. The doctrines and church polity of this Norwegian Synod has always, as I believe, been extremely inimical to the growth of a free church,* and on January 20th, 1874 Professor Weenaas and this affiant caused to be published a written document or statement signed by ourselves, the title of which, translated into English, was “An Open Declaration.” In this statement the church polity of the Norwegian Synod was arraigned and criticised.* In this statement were set forth the principles, already mentioned, by which the subscribers intended to be guided in church work, and by it they emphasized the necessity for the maintenance and building up of Augsburg Seminary. This document brought forth much adverse criticism from the adherents of the said Norwegian Synod, and created some dissatisfaction among a faction of the Conference itself. This writing subsequently received official mention in the proceedings of the Conference, and gave rise in the society to opposition on the part of certain of its members to Augsburg Seminary and its management. As will be seen, this opposition, thus initiated, continued until the present time, but was, from the year 1883, at least, until the formation of what is called the United Church, at all times in a hopeless minority; but after the union such minority, through a combination with other element and churches which were never a part of the Conference, caused to be instituted and brought this application now pending. . . .

SVEN OFTEDAL

Subscribed and sworn to before me this 17th of March, 1897.

F. N. HENDRIX, Notary Public, Hennepin County, Minn.

Notarial Seal

4 The Position

John O. Evjen

4.1 The Congregation as the Church's Proper Form

[editorial title]

Installment 1: "Folkebladet" March 13, 1918

For several years certain disagreements have made themselves felt in Folkebladet concerning the Free Church's Guiding Principles, regarding what they mean and what consequences they entail. There has been much discussion about it.

The discussion does not seem likely to cease. It is almost as if the Free Church has a broken arm that must be set. The sufferer's thoughts remain on the broken arm until it is healed. Since the understandings of the principles are exceedingly different, frictions arise. They may often look worse than they are, and those involved in the frictions may sometimes be subjected to harsh judgments. These judgments can sound quite peculiar, for example like the one a little schoolboy wrote in a composition about a horse: "The horse is a very fierce animal. If you attack him he will kick you." So it can happen that men such as Birkeland and myself may be thought both brute beasts and 'fierce'.

But, as has been said, so long as the arm is in pain, the thoughts remain fixed on it. And so it is with the principles. It is possible that they mean more than an arm on the Free Church's body; it is possible that they mean less. At any rate, they play an exceedingly important role in determining the right to vote at the Free Church's annual meetings. And surely the meaning is that the principles are to be respected between the annual meetings as well. But so long as there prevails lack of clarity with respect to their meaning and their consequences, it is natural that there should be discussion about them.

More recently, the discussion has centered most sharply on the question: Is Folkebladet against Augsburg? In other words, does the present editorial board of Folkebladet interpret the understanding of the congregation maintained in the Guiding Principles, which were in fact essentially drafted by Sverdrup and Oftedal, who were the leading voices both at Augsburg and in Folkebladet?

From the very beginning of his work in America, Folkebladet's founder,¹⁵ Prof. Oftedal upheld the concept of the church advanced in the Guiding Principles, while Sverdrup, it seems, did not fully come over to his side until after 1876. They were always agreed about ecclesiastical freedom. But in the first years at Augsburg Sverdrup taught, as we still so often find among Lutheran theologians, that the congregation began at Christ's ascension, not first at the outpouring of the Spirit. In this connection he could say that it was the "first congregation" that chose an apostle to take Judas's office, whereas later he always taught that the choice of this apostle was not a congregational election, since the congregation was first born at the outpouring of the Spirit. Likewise, he taught that a local congregation, a

¹⁵Oftedal founded Folkebladet in FIXME.

church body, a branch of the church, is a member of Christ's body, a stone in God's temple. "Christ is the head of all, and every congregation is a member of His body, a living stone in the new temple of God." A church body is "an independent member of the body." "The Church as a whole is Christ's body." (Collected Writings I.)¹⁶

After 1876, and right up to his death, Sverdrup taught, like Oftedal, that the local congregation—that is, the believers within it—is not a stone in the temple, nor a member of Christ's body, but is itself the temple, God's house, Christ's body. The other ecclesiastical organizations he regarded as historical arrangements, not divinely instituted in the way the local congregation is, though useful organs for the congregation. Both Sverdrup and Oftedal were, until the 1890s, advocates of church association in the sense that they desired an association of congregations; but they were not church-body men in the sense that the church body or synod was anything more than an outward expedient.

In faculty opinions, treatises, and in part also sermons, the theological professors at Augsburg again and again set forth that the congregation (the local congregation) is the "only outward form of the Church" (the Church—the holy catholic Church; compare question 243 in the Free Church's edition of Pontoppidan's Explanation): "the proper divine order within the Christian religion"; "the truly proper form of Christianity's manifestation in the world"; "the proper form of God's kingdom on earth"; the only outward form of His kingdom on earth appointed by God; "the foundational truth of the Church is and remains according to God's Word the congregation alone and no church body"; "according to Scripture the congregation is the highest form of association"; "the outward form of the kingdom of God, which is the congregation." Prof. Oftedal wrote in the 1870s that Elling Eielsen abolished the visible Church in order to set the invisible Church, the communion of saints, in its place. In Eielsen's understanding he found "no room for the only outward form of the Church that God's Word mentions, namely the congregation." In a long joint declaration from the 1870s it was stated that the church body "has no such divine right as the congregation, but, like all outward church bodies, has arisen through historical development"; likewise that "it belongs inseparably to the essence of the Christian Church to exist in the form of congregations."

That it is local congregations everywhere that are meant here is self-evident. But this will, moreover, also appear from many other citations in this article. The congregation is everywhere presented as the proper form, set by God, for the holy catholic Church, the Church, or the kingdom, in contrast to the state-church form, the church-body form, the papal-church form, and the 'free-free' form. For the time being, it will suffice to refer to the treatise "What Is the Congregation" in Collected Writings II, p. 12, where we read this:

Our children's catechism teaches what the Church is, but not directly of what the congregation is. The New Testament, however, speaks all the more of the congregation or the congregations. Now people sometimes call them local congregations, or 'local churches.' It is by no means free from a certain tinge of disparagement when people speak of 'local congregations.' We therefore take the liberty of observing that what is spoken of here is the 'local congregation.' And

¹⁶Professor Georg Sverdrup Biblical and Church-Historical Sketches and Addresses Edited by Andreas Helland 1909)

since it is an indisputable fact that the New Testament speaks with the deepest reverence and utmost holy seriousness precisely of the local congregations, and calls them God's congregations and God's temple and Christ's body and Christ's bride, it is not too much if we also, with all reverence and respect, speak of this divine institution among us and esteem it very highly for Christ's and God's sake.

Let it be noted that the local congregation is designated a 'divine institution.'

Sverdrup considered it a deficiency in the children's catechism that it did not speak directly of what the congregation was. For this reason he altered question 243¹⁷ in the Explanation, and wrote: "Is the holy catholic Church found here among us?" His answer reads: "Yes, in the congregation, which in Scripture is called Jesus Christ's body and God's house." The next question, concerning the outward congregation, might lead one to think that the word "congregation" in the answer to question 243 means all believers on earth. But that would be a hasty conclusion, which cannot be defended in the light of all that both Sverdrup and Oftedal wrote about "congregation" and "outward congregation."

Thus the congregation is the proper form. It is governed by the law of Christ's body.

Church bodies, state churches, and free churches (associations of congregations) are not governed by the law of Christ's body (Guidance II, 33, 145).¹⁸ We may use an analogy: the congregation is the proper form of the kingdom of God, somewhat as monogamy is the highest form of union between man and woman, in contrast to polygamy. This is admittedly a very imperfect comparison; it limps, as all figures do, especially if one were to regard the other forms of the kingdom as somehow immoral. But the point is plain enough.

This understanding of the congregation as the "proper form" and Christ's body is, so far as Lutherans are concerned, distinctive of the Free Church (and we may add the free-church people in Norway, for example Odland, Jens Greve, and Solem; but not The Evangelical Lutheran Free Church). Otherwise I know of no other Lutheran church body in the world that maintains this understanding. All other Lutheran church bodies maintain that "Christ's body," when applied to the concept of the Church, has reference to the holy catholic Church, which consists of all believers on earth, but has no reference to any local congregation. In other words, "Christ's body" must be applied to the whole organism, not to any organization.

In this respect, the Free Church stands almost alone among Lutherans. It is true that a couple of editors in the new church body, The Norwegian Lutheran Church body, have stated that this church body also teaches that the congregation is the "proper form." But their statements show that they have not penetrated deeply enough into the Free Church understanding of the congregation. And one cannot hold that against them, seeing that so many of our own people do not have one and the same understanding of principle no. 1 in our "Guiding Principles." Besides, they are contradicted by Pastor Langjærd in "The Lutheranism of Our Four-Hundred-Year Lutheranism."

But if this principle is peculiar to the Free Church as a Lutheran 'body,' then it shares that principle with Congregationalists and Baptists. It may indeed offend many to hear that we

¹⁷FIXME to point to question 243

¹⁸FIXME point to Guidance II, 33, 145

are in such company. But a fact is not abolished by offense. Nor does it make Sverdrup and Oftedal dependent on the Reformed, any more than The Open Declaration—simply because it accused the Synod of Catholicism—made Synod people into Catholics, so it does not make Sverdrup and Oftedal dependent upon the Reformed, although Sverdrup already in 1876 thought that we could learn from “such a congregational church as the Reformed has long been,” and that “it would be sheer self-conceit to think that there was nothing to learn from those who have tried these things before us” (the Reformed in America). *Collected Writings* I, 143.

One cannot expect the ordinary man, nor even the pastor strongly occupied in practical work, to be able to find time and occasion to acquaint himself very much with the Lutheran and Reformed literature on church polity. But it is fair to expect of one who writes publicly about the Guiding Principles and criticizes others’ understanding of them, that he acquaint himself with them well enough to know what the principles mean, what is consistent with them, and how much they have in common with Luther and how much or how little they have in common with Calvin. One does not gain much insight into the ‘Guiding Principles’ by reading dogmatics, for dogmatics treats the congregation as an object of faith. But one finds light in the literature on church polity and in church history.

But do we not already have all the teaching we need? Have we not sat at the feet of the “older teachers”?

Yes—but how much did we hear there about the “Guiding Principles” and the Augsburg understanding of the congregation? From Oftedal, almost nothing; from Sverdrup, a few lectures, given every third year when he came to the end of Lønning’s dogmatics, which he mercilessly tore to pieces.

But what we did not hear, we did get to read in the papers. Several of us have read Sverdrup’s and Oftedal’s articles again and again, and in context. Here at Augsburg almost everything that Sverdrup and Oftedal wrote is accessible; and almost all the books they used as professors (including the marginal notes they made) are accessible. As far as possible I have tried to acquaint myself with their work as teachers and public writers, so that I dare say that I have a fairly well-grounded knowledge of their ecclesiastical views.

I hope that no one will take this as though it were spoken in a proud spirit. I am well aware of my limitations. As for me, I did not gallop through Augsburg, as many others did. And when I was finished with Augsburg I had to continue my schooling for three to four years before I could, with a reasonably good scholarly conscience—if one may use that expression, present myself as a candidate for a pastoral call or a teaching post. And finally, after several years of teaching at other schools, I had thus come to know Augsburg both at close hand and from afar, and now once again I came to know it more intimately than ever before. (To be continued.)

4.2 The Guiding Principles as Church Polity

[editorial title]

Installment 2: “Folkebladet,” March 20, 1918

When I took up Sverdrup’s Collected Writings, the principles, and so forth, I studied them without any preconceived opinion. I studied them in the light of the experiences I had had, and the knowledge I had gathered.

When I read the second volume of the Collected Writings, the volume that bears the title *The Congregation*, I had to say: this volume has for the most part to do with church polity.

What a spiritually dead conclusion! I hear someone say. Can Eyen not see that the volume *The Congregation* deals directly with awakening and life?

But no, I classified the book under ecclesiastical literature on church polity. Nor was I the only one who did so. Pastor S. E. Sjørgensen,¹⁹ of Trondhjem, Norway, did the same, when in 1910 he wrote:

“The second volume consists almost exclusively of articles from the long debate over questions of church polity that has been carried on among our countrymen in America.”

And he added: “The rich and mighty Reformed church life pulsating all around him (Sverdrup) would seem to have been able to furnish him with more than enough analogies, at any rate. But it is remarkable how small a role all this plays, if indeed it can be said to be touched upon at all.”

Thus, Sjørgensen held that the second volume of Sverdrup’s Collected Writings was directed toward church polity, and that the Reformed church life could have furnished Sverdrup with more than enough analogies. Unfortunately, however, we were told by our pastors that there had never been any discussion of church polity among the Norwegian Lutherans in America! Reflections force themselves upon one.

Was Sjørgensen mistaken? Was it lack of spirit, of experience, of theological formation, that caused him to write thus?

I do not think so. I believe he could hold his own with any of us in these matters. As a competent theologian he gave the matter its right name.

Sjørgensen spoke, as we see, of analogies. I have more than once called attention to these

¹⁹Pastor S. E. Sjørgensen, born in 1846, cand. theol. 1873, missionary pastor in the service of the Norwegian Missionary Society in Madagascar, where he directed the Norwegian Mission’s seminary, 1875–1886. Director of the Mission School in Stavanger, 1892–97. Later pastor in Trondheim. *Illustreret Norsk Konversations Leksikon* says: “S. has been one of the most prolific authors in the field of missionary literature. We mention here *Missionslære* [Theory of Missions], *Trold og Kirke paa Madagaskar* [Sorcery and the Church in Madagascar], *Vidnesbyrd fra Missionen* [Testimonies from the Mission], *Missionsprækener* [Mission Sermons], and many articles concerning church questions and missions in church periodicals and the daily press. In the Malagasy language he has written a larger church history, pastoral theology, liturgics, and several other commentaries.

analogies in my lectures on church polity. And I hope this will not be regarded as some unpardonable offense.

What Sjørgensen says of Volume II may, with greater or lesser reservation, also be said of Volumes III and IV.

By comparing Sverdrup's articles on the congregation with the polity literature that stands at my disposal, I find exceedingly little in Sverdrup for which I do not find analogies in my works on church polity, which fill a shelf six feet long. I speak perhaps speaking as a fool before the wise, but others do the same also, for example Harvard's five-foot shelf of classics. I do not at all mean to say that Sverdrup drew from this literature. But no one can deny the kinship: it is intimate.

Now there are doubtless those who would dismiss this six-foot shelf as a mere little list, and its contents as trivial stuff. But there is something strange about this content: it is counted trivial on that shelf, but becomes at once spirit and life when it comes between the covers of the Collected Writings. One wonders whether opponents are justified in drawing the distinction they have habitually drawn: polity versus spirit and life.

What is true of most of Sverdrup's and Oftedal's contributions to church debate holds especially for "Guiding Principles." All these principles — they are eight, in twelve paragraphs — are polity principles, neither more nor less.

Any recognized Protestant theological faculty in Scandinavia or Germany that is allowed to see the principles will be able to tell us that. That they are of significance for spirit and life, no one will deny. But one may say that about all work for the kingdom of God, yes, also about collections of money for seminary, mission, and so forth. Week after week the receipts lay claim to many columns in *Folkebladet*. It never comes to an end, yet no one complains that they are not "spiritual." At times they represent no little spirit.

Guiding Principles are principles of church polity. Pastor Caspersen has come into a tremendously mystical vein when in certain articles in *Folkebladet* he maintains that the question 'Do you want a congregation?' and 'Guiding Principles' concern the person as such, or that sets forth a "new type of Christian." It is almost incomprehensible that a man with theological formation can write such a thing.

Quite otherwise thought, wrote, and spoke Pastor E. Lou, who knew his Bible as few among us did, and who kept up with theology and labored zealously as perhaps none of us did. Lou wrote an immense amount in former days in *Luthersk Kirkeblad* and in *Folkebladet*. He both thought and theologized, but in an altogether different, sober, unpretentious manner. In June 1914, when he reviewed *Guide to the Free Church's Principles*, he wrote in *Folkebladet*:

If the people of the Free Church do not agree on this, that the principles are matters of church polity, then the Free Church's days are numbered.

Words almost prophetic, whose fulfillment perhaps lies nearer than many think.

And this was not Lou's view only in 1914. In the last letter he wrote to me, shortly before his death — and I have permission to quote him — he said: "We agree that the principles

are matters of church polity and not an exhortation to ‘awakening’ in this word’s meaning, as the ‘awakened’ understand it.”

Now it may well be rather indifferent what we call the principles. If we had called them practical theology, that name would doubtless have given less offense than the more precise term principles of church polity, for church polity is, after all, a part of practical theology.

But since exceedingly different understandings of the principles prevail with respect to what they mean — and as to their value there will always be difference of opinion — it is surely right that they be made the object of discussion until agreement is reached on what they actually entail. For the Free Church gains little by having principles that mean one thing to some, another thing to others. It is meaningless to connect them with a “new type of Christian,” and it is likewise meaningless to confuse the Free Church’s task or purpose with its principles. The key to their understanding lies in the literature of church polity.

Pastor Holck in Norway, one of the friends of reform, who in his day wrote much about questions of church polity, wrote in the 1870s: “Indirectly it has been stated that the supreme principle for the church must be to look to its own welfare, to its purpose, to bring souls to salvation, and that to this concern every other consideration must give way. In spite of its appearance of truth, this rests upon a manifest misunderstanding. To advance the church’s purpose, the salvation of souls, can never become a principle in the same sense in which religious liberty is one; it is a task that is to be solved.”

When I hear that the principles are time and again classified under “spirit and life” and similar slogans, I see a picture: a schoolman lays four open books on a table, all in the English language; the one book treats astronomy, the second physiology, the third physics, and the fourth philosophy. “This is astronomy,” says the schoolman, “this is physiology, this is physics, this is philosophy.” No and again no, comes the answer from a stubborn onlooker: “It is neither the one nor the other: it is all English!” There is no making anything precise for such a fellow.²⁰

But if we could agree that the principles concern church polity, would that mean that the Free Church’s chief task is to labor for church polity?

No, every church’s foremost task must be the salvation of souls. But if that were all that mattered, then one could simply refrain from organizing congregations, let alone associations of congregations. There must be something more.

In the Free Church’s Rules — rules are not the same as principles — we read that the purpose of the association called the Lutheran Free Church is to labor “for the quickening and liberation of all Norwegian Lutheran congregations.” Is it only the awakening and salvation of souls that are here being aimed at?

Those who authored the principles should here be allowed to speak. Sverdrup wrote: “It is not merely a question of awakening the individual conscience. It is not solely the task to bring the individual to the Savior. The task is to awaken consciousness of the congregation’s

²⁰Historically offensive content removed.

essence and calling, by the power of the Word and the Spirit, to build up and people the body of Christ.” (Collected Writings III.)

And in other places he writes of the manifestation of the body of Christ, that the congregation shall win its proper position among us, and so forth.

It is the duty of all Christians to labor for the quickening and liberation of individuals. But it is not thereby said that this, without more ado, means “the quickening and liberation of the congregations.” In Norway much Christian work is done — I am inclined to think that there is even more fear of God among the church people there than among us. But in spite of this Sverdrup would not admit that in the Norwegian state church there are congregations in the proper sense of the word. I do not state my own opinion here, but Sverdrup’s — and precisely in order to shed light on the principles. After a visit to Norway in 1886 Sverdrup wrote this:

The state church has too little room for Christian and ecclesiastical work.... There is no congregation in the proper sense of the word in which there is room for all gifts and use for all hands. If some Christian man or woman feels a call and inclination to some work, then they must break their own way on their own. There is no one who marks out the field of labor for them....

Naturally there is room for many works of love and much self-sacrifice in family life, in the school, in private intercourse with people. But the actual specifically Christian field of labor is lacking, the congregation, the body of Jesus Christ. In all outward respects it is so bound by law, and in a certain sense so fatherly provided for by the state, that there is no room for the Christians’ self-sacrificing labor for it.

Christian people who come from Norway to America often find that the brethren in the Free Church are so dry and cold, so filled with busyness, that it is almost doubtful whether they can really have any true heart Christianity, any inward life in God. They seem far too outwardly oriented and absorbed in work.

Conversely, he who comes from America to Norway gets the impression that Christianity is chiefly feeling, inwardness, contemplation, thought, but little or no work....

But it would be altogether unjust to conclude from this that there is therefore less true and honest fear of God in the one place than in the other.”

Thus: the fear of God is to be equally true and honest in both lands. And yet: no congregation in the proper sense of the word in Norway.

How then can the sort of language we hear so much of be grounded in Sverdrup, language which says that if only souls are converted and brought to God, then one is thereby, simply, laboring for the quickening and liberation of the congregation?

Certainly, one must begin with individuals, but one cannot remain standing with individuals. If there should be found a little congregation in which all were believers, could one then say that it did not need to be counted among those congregations to which the Free Church

refers when in its rules it speaks of “the vivification and liberation of all Norwegian Lutheran congregations”?

No, according to the Augsburg Confession’s understanding of the congregation, something more is required: there must be labor so that the congregation becomes a visible congregation, which, because it bears the name of the invisible congregation, must correspond to that name.

Therefore it is not consistent to say that the organizations are indifferent. But it is tempting to speak thus, which Sverdrup also emphasizes when he says:

In the New Testament such high and holy words are spoken about the congregation that many have given it up in despair and have sought to escape from the holy demand by teaching that all the great and glorious things are said about an invisible congregation, and that is — another matter.”

The body of Christ, that whereby Christ is seen, that through which Christ works, is visible, because it is believing men and women who labor with the Word and the Sacraments, and it is precisely these outwardly organized fellowships that are called congregations.” (1897.)

Here the Norwegian Lutheran Free Church distinguishes itself from the “societies” and the “people’s churches” and the “state churches,” which make the congregations into wholly subordinate members of the larger organizations or at any rate do not set them higher than these organizations. The Free Church regards the local congregation as a divine institution; it regards the other organizations as human arrangements.

Pastor P. L. Tangjerd has in *Four Hundred Years of Lutheranism* criticized the Free Church for this. He says that sentences such as “the congregation is of divine origin, but the association is of human origin,” “the local congregation is the proper form of the kingdom of God on earth” — are “suited to confuse the concepts.”

He continues:

“What is a congregation? Disciples gathered around the means of grace (‘two or three in Jesus’ name’). Whether they have an outward organization, how long the gathering lasts, how near one another the disciples live, and so forth, makes no difference. An annual meeting of the church body is, in the biblical sense, just as much a congregation as any local congregation within it. Both are equally much and equally little ‘instituted by God’ and ‘the proper form of the kingdom of God on earth’.... ‘Congregation’ and ‘association’ stand side by side with respect to divine institution....

4.3 Sverdrup on the Congregation's Proper Form

[editorial title]

Installment 3: "Folkebladet" March 27, 1918

The Free Church says only this: the congregation is divinely instituted. No, say the others.

It is precisely here that the Free Church's kinship with the Congregationalists shows itself. What Congregationalists call their 'distinctive function' is "to reveal and to realise the true idea of the church." In the work of an English writer we read the following:

Dr. R. W. Dale, in an essay written years ago, closes with a statement of what he considered to be 'the distinctive function' of Congregationalists.

It was he thought, not the work of Evangelisation, for that is the work alike of all Christians; still less was it the work of testifying against the evils, real or supposed, of other churches—for example, the evil of 'ecclesiastical establishment'; nor was it the work of reconstructing theological science, or taking a chief place in the controversy with unbelief. All such work may form a part of their duty, and sometimes an inevitable part. But their distinctive function is 'to reveal and to realise the true idea of the Church.'

One must not misunderstand such an analogy (or one like it). Such a misunderstanding seems to be contained in the "Kristelig Folkekalender" for 1917, page 43, where it is said: "The mission of the Free Church, then, is not first and foremost to uphold the Congregationalist principle of church order among us Norwegian Lutherans, but rather to work for the renewal and liberation of the congregations."

This is no doubt meant as a correction addressed to me. But I have not ascribed that task to the Free Church. I have only said that the Free Church's distinctive feature among Lutherans lies in the area of church order, and that its principles of polity resemble those of the Congregationalists very closely, which Professor J. O. Andersen at the University of Copenhagen also maintains in his article on Sverdrup in "Kirkeleksikon for Norden" (three columns in issue no. 66, year 1917): "The new C. (the Free Church) was ordered according to decidedly Congregationalist principles." I should add that Andersen here is speaking of the Principles and Rules, and that he has the 'Collected Writings' before him. Further, that Andersen, as author of a larger work on church organization, understands tolerably well what Congregationalist principles are.

Distinctiveness, I said; not task. There is a difference between these two things. There are, for example, one hundred students at a school. One of them is black; the others are white. There is something distinctive about the one: he is black. But we will not say that it is first and foremost his task to be black.

The distinctive feature of the Free Church among Lutherans lies in the area of church order. But since it has essentially the same principles of polity as the Congregationalists, it may also be said of it that it has the same "distinctive function." For the Free Church is not a congregation, but an association of congregations which takes on tasks that the individual

congregation cannot well carry out on its own.

The distinctive function of the Free Church is to bring the congregation forth in its proper form, or “to reveal and realise the true idea of the church.” Therefore it declares as its purpose “to labor for the enlivening and liberation of all Norwegian Lutheran congregations, so that according to their calling and ability they may work in spiritual independence and freedom for the cause of God’s kingdom at home and abroad” (Rule 2).

And how is this purpose to be achieved? Is it by constantly preaching awakening? Rule 3 says: “This purpose is to be achieved chiefly by the training of men and women for spiritual labor in and for the congregation, by the holding of greater and smaller meetings, by the dissemination of suitable literature, by the organization of Free-Church committees and associations, by sending out workers, and by other means which from time to time may show themselves expedient.”

Nota bene—workers as well. Pastor Nisløv is no doubt not entirely in agreement with Rule 3. For he says in the previous issue of this paper: the work of emissaries “will become a foreign plant in the Free-Church soil.”

Now the editors will scarcely be among those who compare the distinctive function of the Free Church with that of the Congregationalists. And yet it seems that what the Congregationalists call their distinctive function, “to reveal and to realise the true idea of the church,” becomes a main matter, indeed the main matter, for the editors. “The main matter for us is that the congregation come forth in its proper form.” (Folkebladet no. 34.)

And yet we read this: “We know, however, that according to God’s Word there is a congregation where two or three are gathered in Jesus’ name or where two or more believers are gathered around God’s Word and the sacraments. The fact that a group of people forms an association does not create any congregation, but the fact that souls come to life in God. For us in the Free Church, who have this view, the organization is of less importance.” (The editors.)

Here it is suggested that the main thing is that souls come to life in God, whereas just before it is said that the main thing is that the congregation come into its proper form. Presumably this is meant to signify the same thing. If it does not do so for the editors, then it does so for many in the Free Church.

But this is not the view of the Principles. In his explanation of Principle No. 1, S. says: “And next to the question of the salvation of the individual soul, there is no more important question than that of the congregation.”

Thus, two questions.

Now we know that the first is included in the second; but the second is not simply included in the first. We know also that Sverdrup used the word awakening in a very comprehensive sense: the gifts of grace too were to be awakened. And therefore he could say: “That which is really the main thing in the free congregation, and which we cannot stress often enough, is the unfolding and right use of the gifts of grace” (C. W. II).

That souls come to life in God does not without more ado mean that the gifts of grace are unfolded and put to use, and that there is a congregation in the sense of the Principles.

To be sure, the congregation may be present according to its essence, but Sverdrup also wants it to be present according to its form—its proper form.

Hans Nielsen Hauge was a great instrument in the Lord's hand for leading souls to God. But a congregation according to the demands of the New Testament he could not form, says Sverdrup (C. W. II, 207). The congregation did not receive its proper form in Norway—not through Hauge and not through Johnsen. For Sverdrup reproaches the Johnsen revival for having too little sense for the congregation: "In this whole movement there was lacking the right view of the congregation or of Jesus Christ's body" (C. W. I, 200).

Thus: according to Sverdrup's view, the congregation's proper form does not come of itself from what we commonly understand by awakening and conversion.

In all church and Free Church work the salvation of the individual is surely a main matter. But no society would presume to claim that this is its distinctive function. A function that is common to many or to all is distinctive for none.

The principles of the Free Church are distinctive; and the task of the Free Church, which is first mentioned in the Rules (not in the Principles), is distinctive, just as its function is.

The most important thing for us all—and of this we are surely heartily agreed—is the salvation of the individual. But the Free Church believes that the work for the individual's salvation and preservation in the life of faith, and for spiritual activity, may be better promoted by means of the realization of the Principles, especially Principle No. 1, that principle of which S. said: "The Free Church's proper main principle is this, that the congregation is the right divine order within the Christian religion" (Guide 143).

I will not say that the editors deny the legitimacy of the local congregation. Quite the contrary. But they do not let the Augsburg understanding of the congregation come clearly forth. The congregation becomes something indefinite, more like the holy catholic church or the communion of saints. And congregational work becomes virtually a mission work, going out to bring souls to life in God.

Now I will not in these observations express my opinion as to whether the line of thought the editors seem to represent is less biblical or more biblical than that represented by Principle No. 1. I do not here set myself up as judge between right and wrong. But I do think that there is some difference in the line of thought.

My position is this:

First, we must become clear about what the Augsburg understanding of the congregation is. And later there may be occasion to test it in the light of God's Word. And in this testing by the Word, it is not persons that matter, but the Word alone.

For the present, the following may deserve our consideration: Is there a congregation where two or three are gathered in Jesus' name?

Yes, says Luther, for whom the church was an organism of all believers on earth, but no organization.

Yes, says Luther, who held that if all believers on earth died, and he were left alone, then the church would still be there in that one believer.

Yes, says Luther, who never spoke of the enlivening of the congregation and never spoke of dead members of the congregation. For his church was a religious, spiritual reality, independent of the boundaries of time and space, independent of outward organization and form. The holy catholic church, he said, consisted only of believers: it is invisible to others; they cannot grasp that on earth there is an assembly of believers who are bound together not by rule, right, or law, but by the bonds of freedom, Christ's Spirit. This assembly, or congregation, is visible only to believers. They perceive this unity, this unity of the Spirit; but they cannot point to anything concrete and say: Here is the church. For the church is the work of the Holy Spirit. Everything outward, whether it is called congregation or church, is not church in the biblical sense. Organizations are indeed psychologically necessary, but they are of a worldly (here not sinful) nature. The church, or God's congregation, is not bound to time, place, organization. This, at any rate, is what the four-hundredth anniversary of the Reformation has sought to establish concerning Luther. I cannot develop this more fully now.

But no, says Sverdrup: the word about "the two or three" is not really spoken concerning the congregation. "If one would apply the word about two or three to the congregation, then the result would be this: if in a place there were no more than two or three believers, then these were nevertheless many enough to be a congregation" (C. W. II, 196).

No, says Sverdrup: Luther's word in the Third Article concerning the "whole Christian congregation on earth" must also be true of each individual congregation, if this is really to answer to its name. "The congregation consists of the believers in each place, who there in that place have formed an organization in order to labor in God's kingdom" (Guide 143).

No, says Sverdrup: a believing missionary in a heathen land is no congregation. And he and an assembly of converted people are no congregation, but only a mission.

And no, says Oftedal: "For Paul and the other New-Testament writers the congregation too does not stand as something loose and indefinite, something invisible and universal—the believers, wherever they might be found, without regard to their outward visible union and assembly; but it stands as a closed circle consisting of men and women separated from the rest of the world by their ordered life together and by the word and the Spirit by which they had been separated" (Guide 74). In another place we read that it belongs to the essence of the church to exist in the form of congregations, not as individual Christian persons (1875).

4.4 Sverdrup Between Lutheranism and Congregationalism

[editorial title]

Installment 4: "Folkebladet" April 3, 1918

It will thus be seen that principle no. 1, "the proper chief principle of Scripture" (Veiledning, 143), is by no means a small matter. It is anything but a devout manner of speaking. Its rejection would, to a greater or lesser extent, modify the other fundamental propositions concerning church polity.

The Guiding Principles have again and again been attacked as being at variance with the New Testament's teaching concerning the congregation. And in these attacks there has been no lack of proofs from Scripture. I mean that the thoughts which the Guiding Principles interpret, and the consequences which they involve, have fairly often and quite thoroughly been treated in the literature on church polity. The arguments have been both for and against—indirectly against, where Scripture has been broken in order to prove the supposed scriptural warrant for another concept of the church. For Norway's part it is enough to point to a great number of articles in *Luthersk Kirketidende*, in *Ny luthersk Kirketidende*, and in *Luthersk Ugeskrift*. Germany has a large body of material to offer in its many works on ecclesiastical law and in innumerable contributions interpreting the most various church-political views. And the English Reformed literature on church polity is very extensive.

If we take up principle no. 1, we may first mention Professor von Oettingen (d. 1905) in Dorpat. He was known as a capable Lutheran dogmatician. But he unconditionally rejected the opinion that the New Testament knows only local congregations and contains no "doctrine of the church."

The teacher of ecclesiastical law, Professor Sohm, too, has several times, with good use of passages from Scripture, polemicized against that which principle no. 1 seeks to establish. As the best authority on Luther among jurists, he assures us that Luther could never have agreed with such a principle.

The church historian Professor Wm. Walter of Rostock, unquestionably the leading living authority on Luther among theologians, says the same of Luther and assures us that Jesus himself could not teach anything such as principle no. 1 teaches: it is too exclusive. (*Ev. Luth. Kirchenzeitung*, 1913.)

It is in the Reformed literature on church polity that principle no. 1 receives its strongest support. In the Lutheran it receives but little assent. I do not know of a single Lutheran theological faculty of rank in the whole world that would vote for it.

Nor do I know many Lutheran theologians (Professor Odland and Jens Greve must be counted among the exceptions) who agree that this principle is grounded in the New Testament. The great majority regard it as Reformed and will doubtless agree with the teacher of ecclesiastical law, Stahl, when he says: "The Reformed church has a strong tendency to let the concept of church pass over into the concept of congregation; it comes to that completely—in its offshoots, the Independents and Baptists, and so forth."

If one wishes to see how the principles of church polity in the Reformed church are judged by Lutherans, one does well to read Sohm's *Kirchenrecht*, pp. 634–657, and especially the jurist Karl Rieter's *Grundsätze reformierter Kirchenverfassung* (about 200 pages), a work that will cast a surprising light upon the Guiding Principles and their consistent interpretation.

But we need not stop with the German Lutherans. We may point to Norway. In 1915–16 a lively discussion concerning the concept of the church was carried on in *Luthersk Kirketidende*. It was between schoolmaster Jens Greve and parish pastor H. U. Sverdrup. Greve maintained the Free Church concept of the church, while H. U. Sverdrup rejected it. Both men are known as friends of the work for spirit and life.

Greve says:

"If we ask where the church is to be found on earth, then, according to our confession, we ask: Where is the Word preached purely, where are the Sacraments rightly administered? And where we find that this takes place, there we recognize the congregation to be. But then we turn our gaze to the local congregation; we cannot turn it elsewhere; even if it consisted of only two or three gathered in Jesus' name, we must in it see the church made manifest.

Greve teaches that the visible forms of manifestation are the church's forms of manifestation, and that accordingly the true church of Jesus Christ in empirical reality comes forth in the visible congregations, there where the Word is preached purely and the Sacraments rightly administered. In other words: Not in an ecclesiastical organization embracing all Christians, nor yet in a mighty hierarchical order with a pope as supreme head, do we find the church, but in the local congregations, where the Word is rightly preached, etc., even where only two or three are assembled in Jesus' name. We must acknowledge such an assembly, gathered around Word and Sacrament, as a congregation of Christ, a congregation of God; in such a congregation we see "the communion of saints," "the body of Christ," made manifest in a visible form of existence on earth."

This means: according to Scripture, the congregation is the right form of the kingdom of God on earth—which is precisely what the adherents of the state church and of the people's church reject. Therefore Greve says:

"What, at bottom, is the fault among both the men of the state church and the adherents of the national church? They raise their building upon a foundation that fails; they build upon a false concept of the church," etc.

To this H. U. Sverdrup replies:

"I maintain that in ordinary Norwegian this can only mean that in the constitutional question the men of the state church and the adherents of the national church are, broadly speaking, one, only that the men of the state church, or their theories, are perhaps a little worse in any case, for they are altogether impossible."

Greve maintains that there is only one form of manifestation for the body of Christ. It is precisely the local congregation that is the body of Christ.

H. U. Sverdrup, on the other hand, maintains that there are many kinds of forms of manifestation. No visible form of existence can claim to be the body of Christ. He says:

"The Lutheran concept of the church has, within the evangelical division of the church, allowed itself to be joined with the most various forms of polity, the free-church forms as well, provided only that these, like this concept of the church itself, are of a folk-church character. The 'free-church concept' leads by inward consequence to the voluntaristic church with congregational order. For biblical and Lutheran thought, the legitimacy of the Free Church is dependent upon special conditions (the time of beginnings, the time of persecution, the end time); and since these conditions are always something that the church must seek to overcome, the Free Church (that is, the voluntaristic Free Church) will never stand as a goal that for principial reasons ought to be striven after. But this is precisely what the 'free-churchmen,' by virtue of their concept of the church, do. And indeed to such a degree that they designate the folk-church formation of the church as a deep fall."

H. U. Sverdrup thus rejects that line of thought which makes the church's outward organization something essential. Indeed he says:

"The concept of the free-churchmen is neither Lutheran, nor ancient-church, nor biblical, whereas the concept of the church among the adherents of the state church and of the folk church—precisely in the essential point that the church as the communion of saints, as the body of Christ, is invisible, and that it cannot in any visible form of existence claim to be this—agrees both with the Lutheran confession, the ancient-church conception, and with Scripture."

Thus: the foregoing shows that there is fairly strong opposition to principle no. 1. It would be too lengthy to illuminate the other principles in this manner. Those who wish to have them illuminated will find them illuminated in the literature on church polity.

The Guiding Principles do not stand alone. But there lies a whole history behind them. They attempt to apply the Reformation principle of "the universal priesthood" to the local congregation and to the relation between the local congregations. The reason they are so little understood among us is doubtless the high-church upbringing which has entered into the blood even of many of the ablest and most zealous spokesmen of the revival: that direction which has set its stamp upon Krogh-Tønning's doctrinal theology has also strongly influenced the home, religious instruction, the pulpit, the church press, indeed the whole of Christian thinking.

There are doubtless several directions that have been negatively determinative for the Guiding Principles. Thus the high-church tendency in Norway, with men like Heuch and Bugge at its head and with its many heirs in this country. We need not enter into these tendencies, but will only say that the the Guiding Principles have sought to take a stand against them.

It is of importance just now that we become more closely acquainted with the directions which, theoretically considered, have been positively determinative for the formulation of the principles and for the interpretation which their authors have given them.

If I am not mistaken, the authors have been influenced by four closely related currents:

1. The authors were strongly influenced by the church reform movement in Western Norway. In principle it recognized lay activity as something that normally belongs in an evangelical congregation. It maintained a democratic view of the ministerial office. It taught that all ecclesiastical right has its root in the congregation. In other words: "it championed the cause of religious liberty and congregational liberty" (Samlede Skrifter II, 201–211). This tendency found early expression in *Luthersk Kirketidende*. Later it received its organ in *Ny luthersk Kirketidende*, edited by Jakob Sverdrup and O. Volla (1877–81). It was zealously opposed by *Luthersk Ugeskrift*, edited by Bugge and Heuch, who were then high-church.

To those who wish to know what polity is, we recommend *Ny luthersk Kirketidende*. Krogh-Tønning polemicized much against this paper and wrote of it in 1880: "The paper concerns itself almost exclusively with its favorite ideas about reforms in church polity; and it is precisely these that can only be explained by Reformed spirit, the spirit of independentism." He meant that the paper had fixed its gaze so blindly upon evangelical freedom that it had no sight for ecclesiastical authority; it had "a concept of the Christians' spiritual priesthood which is at variance with the concept of the special priesthood"; it shut itself off from the truth that the office is instituted by God; it lacked the view of Jesus Christ's church as the 'one' and 'catholic'; and without further ado, in independentist fashion, transferred all right and power to the single local congregation. So much for Tønning.

2. Sverdrup and Oftedal nevertheless went further than the reform movement, for which the congregation was only the center of gravity in the ecclesiastical organization. They made the congregation the church itself, the only right form of the kingdom of God on earth. According to S. and O., the local congregation is an institution *de jure divino*.

But this is precisely the doctrine of the older Congregationalists (down to about 1870), although the newer school of Congregationalists maintains that there is no prescribed church form in the New Testament. To be sure, it finds no other church form in the New Testament than the local congregation, but it no longer constructs a *de jure divino* church polity on this basis. At the very most it regards the congregational form as something recommended, but not as something commanded. These are the ideas of the newer school, whereas S. and O. follow the old one with respect to the idea of the congregation's divine institution.

The Congregationalists also went a step further than the reform party did in the democratic understanding of the ministerial office. They were very free with regard to lay activity and had no objection to a layman's administering the Sacraments on the congregation's behalf. But with respect both to the reception of members into the congregation and to church discipline, they were legal-minded, and therefore in this area diverged from S. and O., who here sought, as far as possible, to preserve evangelical freedom. In this respect the Congregationalists were more consistent than S. and O., who thought that logic must bend to life, although others object that principle no. 1 is a false premise, where life in reality bends to logic.

If S. and O. held the older Congregationalists' view of principle no. 1 (the congregation is the right form) and of the equality of the members within the congregational body, they also

shared their view with regard to the relation between the congregations. In his address "Free association among free congregations," 1897, Oftedal declared that the Lutheran Free Church, in the sense presented in his address, was "truly the old, good church order given of itself by the Word of God, in contrast to clerical rule, communal tyranny, and the state-church system."

How far S. and O. had acquainted themselves with the church polity of the Congregationalists (and Baptists) is not easy to determine. It is possible that they did not concern themselves much further with it, although Oftedal, as a church historian, must surely have known a good deal of it. It is possible that they took counsel with little besides the New Testament. In any case, Norway, despite the Haugean and Johnsonian revival, had not taught them much about the congregation. "There was no one in Norway," said Sverdrup, "who taught us anything about the free congregation or the true nature and form of Christ's church, so that we all came over here rather unenlightened and without understanding in the things that belong to a free church fellowship" (S. S. II, 101).

But one thing must not be left unsaid. Oftedal and Sverdrup used the same arguments to prove the scripturalness of their conception of the congregation and of their view of the office, lay activity, and church organization as the Congregationalists did. The patterns of argument are remarkably similar, which they can only be when the presuppositions are the same. This applies not only to their marshalling of scriptural proof, but also to the polemic against the arguments which the opponents of the congregational principle have brought into the field. Everything converged on the claim that the congregation is Christ's body, that it is therefore free and independent, that the other ecclesiastical organizations are human arrangements, and that the universal priesthood receives its application precisely in the congregation.

4.5 Reading Sverdrup with Sohm

[editorial title]

Installment 5: “Folkebladet,” April 10, 1918

The Congregationalists’ corresponding treatment of these matters is found in the literature which they call church polity. Oftedal too is content with this term: he uses it four times in his short affidavit concerning the Open Declaration (*Veiledning*, 198 ff).²¹

It is not I who have put this expression in their mouths. I ought also to add that it is not I who furnished the books on that six-foot-long constitutional shelf, of which I wrote, with the name *kirkeforfatning*, or church polity. They have this name on their title-pages. It is natural enough for the average churchgoer to think that this name has chiefly to do with legal provisions, laws, and rules concerning the church. But a theologian who knows nothing more and better about the “field” deserves our undivided sympathy and a heartfelt wish for improvement.

3. S. and O. have also been influenced by the biblicistic tendency whose original spokesman was J. T. Beck. The second volume of his ethics devotes about 50 pages to “The Christian Congregation’s Constitution” (the heading). In 27 pages Beck treats what he calls the “principles” or the “inner constitution.” Under the heading of the “outer constitution” he treats the gifts of grace. Beck’s conception of the local congregation is more like that of the Norwegian reform advocates than that of the Congregationalists. But his pronounced biblicism, his strong emphasis on the gifts of grace (in this he represents an advance beyond the reform advocates and the older Congregationalists), together with his sharp judgments upon the congregations, that they had progressed no further than the stage of mission congregations, are factors that have been determinative for Guiding Principles.

4. S. and O. also have much in common with the eminent Lutheran jurist Rudolph Sohm,²² who, more vigorously than Beck, places the emphasis on the charismatic organization (the church’s organization by the gifts of grace) and upon the freedom of the Spirit in contrast to everything that is juridical. Sverdrup’s words, “with the diversity of the gifts of grace and their right use, the freedom of the Spirit wins its true triumph,” are a genuinely Sohmian sentence.

Whereas Sverdrup places the emphasis on the use of the gifts of grace essentially in the local congregation, Sohm finds that the local congregation is altogether too narrow for this purpose. He maintains that the holy catholic church, the communion of saints, without regard to organization, is the place for their use. To be sure, Sverdrup would not have asserted that every organization which calls itself a congregation has the right to determine whether the Christian shall use his gift of grace or not (II, 314). But he held fast in principle to this,

²¹(1897) STATE OF MINNESOTA; COUNTY OF HENNEPIN. DISTRICT COURT; FOURTH JUDICIAL DISTRICT. In the Matter of the Application of Nils C. Brun, Lauritz F. Clausen, Lars Swenson, Orson A. Veblen and Ole O. Aanstad, for leave to File an Information, in the nature of quo warranto, against Sven Oftedal, Olaf Hoff, Ole Paulson, Theodore Helgesen and Andrew Knutson.

²²Wikipedia: Gotthold Julius Rudolph Sohm (29 October 1841 in Rostock – 16 May 1917 in Leipzig) was a German jurist and Church historian as well as a theologian.

that “without the congregation, the gifts of grace have no attachment and no purpose” (*Luth. Kirkeblad* 1893). He regarded, for example, “Christian lay activity as one of the most precious gifts of grace in our time” (there).

With respect to Sverdrup’s mild conditions for the reception of members into the congregation, and his likewise mild doctrine of church discipline, this is as characteristically Sohm as it can be in one who, differing from Sohm, taught that “the congregation is the proper form,” and that all the glorious things which are said about the church, the communion of saints, in Sohm’s brilliant, spirited work *Church Law*, are to apply to the local congregation.

Sohm regards the church as wholly and entirely religious, an organism, not an organization; that is to say, the congregation is not any local organization, no organized church body, no state church, no confessional church (denomination); but it is God’s people on earth, the body of Christ, the work of the Holy Spirit. “Local congregations” and other ecclesiastical organizations are indeed necessary, but none of them is holy. They are no more “holy” or more “church” than any other organization which men have agreed to form and maintain.

Here Sohm departs from Sverdrup, who according to *Samlede Skrifter* (II, 5) called “the holiness of the congregation” “the real main question in the Free Church. ”Indeed, Sverdrup went so far as to say that the cause of the American doctrinal controversy was that people had different conceptions of the congregation.” “But behind the doctrinal controversy too there has lurked a different conception of the congregation and of its composition and work” (II, C, 7).

Sohm does not like the word church law or church polity, because he means that the church cannot be organized: the body of Christ cannot have juridical determinations imposed upon it; the outward ecclesiastical system is, strictly speaking, no church system at all, and therefore its juridical norms (all law is formal, coercive) are a contradiction of the essence of freedom. His well-known thesis concerning church law therefore runs thus: “All church law is a contradiction of the essence of the church.” The congregation, he teaches, is no definite empirical entity, no social concept in general; it is a spiritual reality raised above earthly norms; it withdraws from the dominion of “law” and is unfit for juridical organization. (Luther’s view.)

Although Sohm rejects the expressions “church law” and “church polity,” yet he does bow to common usage and writes an epoch-making work with the title *Church Law*. If one will accept Sohm’s rejection of these expressions, then one must also adopt his definition of “law” (which jurists as a rule will not do) and understand the main principle of the Free Church movement.

Meanwhile one cannot all at once change the name of the literature which casts the strongest light upon principles such as Guiding Principles, or even upon Sohm’s own ecclesiastical views. After all, it is not so much the name that matters as the benefit—the benefit of consulting literature on church polity in order to see whether Guiding Principles stands or fails. For in this literature there is a wealth of contributions for and against the norms and forms that determine the ways in which the church becomes manifest, its inner and outer life. Most of these contributions will be built upon Scripture or upon history or upon both.

It is characteristic that the pastor J. J. Jansen (Nøsen)²³ relates that when he wished to write about the concept of church and office, he turned to church law (he names a full dozen authors) there to “study, understand, and first arrive at a conclusion about what the New Testament teaches concerning the office.” It may seem to be a strange way of studying the New Testament—by a roundabout way. But Jansen doubtless knew what he was doing.

But back to Sohm. S. and O. had their ecclesiastical views essentially ready long before Sohm came forth with his in 1892. Yet it cannot be denied that Sverdrup found in Sohm a powerful support for his conception of the gifts of grace and the freedom of the Spirit. For after 1892 he was much more forceful in advancing it than before. And many of his ablest articles bear witness—linguistically as well—to influence from Sohm.

In Oftedal there are fewer traces of this influence. But Oftedal, on the other hand, had from earlier days been strongly influenced by Professor Michael Baumgarten,²⁴ who—as Professor Hansleiter points out (*Herzog-Hauck's Encyclopædie* II, 461)—was a kind of forerunner of Sohm. Baumgarten could say: “God grant we had never got a church law. We should then long ago have had a ‘spiritual’ church order.”

Baumgarten was one of Germany's most zealous champions of free-church ideas, and believed in what he called “the autonomy of the saints.” He felt nothing but aversion toward the connection between state and church, laid stress upon the freedom and inwardness of faith, hated all coercion and legalism. He taught that the church ought to use the apostolic writings as its standard also for church government: there ought to be an apostolic church polity. It was chiefly the latter that caused the church historian Kliefoth to secure from the Duke of Mecklenburg Baumgarten's dismissal as theological professor at the University of Rostock. In his understanding of the Acts of the Apostles Oftedal was markedly influenced by Baumgarten's work on apostolic history (1858), which is not difficult to demonstrate.

These four currents—the reform movement, Congregationalism, the Beckian current, and the Sohmian current—the authors of the Principles have taken into account. The kinship is greatest, however, with the Congregationalists, and next with Sohm, despite the fact that Sohm denies principle no. 1.

I do not hesitate to say that I cannot see how anyone can rightly assess Sverdrup's ecclesiastical views unless he acquaints himself with the literature on church polity of the older Congregationalists and with Sohm's works on church law.

To suggest something of this sort—that one must read certain writings, not authored by S. and O., in order rightly to understand these writings authored by S. and O—can hardly do otherwise than have an irritating effect. I know that very well. But as one who has “made the attempt,” and thus speaks from a little experience, I am free enough to say it. For among us too there are those who read the principles and interpret them just as a Jew reads his Old Testament through the books of Moses, absolutely certain that they have the right understanding, that they see the thread running through it, and that they have no need of

²³FIXME: Jansen, Jens Jonas Elstrand ?

²⁴Wikipedia: Michael Baumgarten (25 March 1812 – 21 July 1889) was a German Protestant theologian. Baumgarten was born at Haseldorf in Schleswig-Holstein.

guidance.

I especially single out Sohm. He can indeed be of real help to anyone not too proud to learn from him. If the recommendation I give him does not suffice, then perhaps the following from a pastor in Norway will be acceptable:

“It is . . . Sohm’s great merit to have vindicated the great significance of the pneumatic-charismatic element (*pneuma* = spirit, *charisma* = gift of grace) in the constitution of the ancient church. He has found the right point of departure for understanding what is characteristic and unique in the church’s formation as a communal body, and thereby has become able, with unsurpassed clarity and sharpness, to set forth the constitutional-historical problems which here call for the attention of research.

“One’s heart can be seized by the lofty idealism in Sohm’s thoughts. One feels how he suffers under the church’s dualism, how it pains him to see the element of law bring a foreign and dangerous spirit into the church’s development, how he longs for harmony and clarity. And in all his work one particularly notices how he burns with zeal to bring God glory and let his Spirit be the church’s only Lord and ruler. He would cleanse the alien elements out of God’s house and make earnest of the fact that this shall be the Lord’s body and a spiritual temple built of living stones.”

How strongly this recalls Sverdrup’s statement: “That which is really the principal matter in the free congregation, and which we cannot stress often enough, is the unfolding and right use of the gifts of grace.” Or, “with the diversity of the gifts of grace and their right use, the freedom of the Spirit wins its true triumph” (S. S. II).

The longer Sverdrup wrote, the more he tended toward Sohm. And it is possible that Sohm’s new work of 1914, which represents an intense labor continued all the way from 1892, when his first volume on church law appeared, might have led Sverdrup to modify his view with respect to principle no. 1. Their line of thought is very similar; agreement in the implications seems unavoidable.

One of Sohm’s colleagues defines the concept of the church as follows:

“§ 1. The church is a religious reality, God’s people, the body of Christ. It has its citizenship in heaven and has there its home. But in this church God’s redeeming will is carried out in humanity here on earth. § 2. Therefore the church here on earth appears in the form of a community: a communal life. This form, however imperfect it may be, is essential for the church. Consequently the communal aspect is more than a ‘support and help’; it belongs to the very concept of the church, and is the form in which the church of faith is realized, in so far as it can be realized here in the world.”

Sohm and Sverdrup would agree in § 1.

Sohm would reject § 2 and say that this “form” is not essential for the church, does not belong to the very concept of the church, but is only a support and help. Sverdrup would

have endorsed § 2, but on the condition that “form” means the local congregation, and that all other outward ecclesiastical organizations are “support and help,” or else obstruction and hindrance, depending on the circumstances.

4.6 Sverdrup and the Necessity of the Local Congregation

[editorial title]

Installment 6: “Folkebladet,” April 17, 1918

Whoever has read the significant work of the Swedish professor Gustaf Aulen from 1912, “The Lutheran Church-Idea,” in which the author deals with the Lutheran concept of the church as well as the ‘Lundensian’ and ‘Uppsalian’ concepts of the church, will have noticed a quotation in the preface from one of Scotland’s leading churchmen, John Cairns (died 1892). Cairns says:

With all that the labour of the theologians has done to define and vindicate the idea of the church, I believe that we are as yet only on the surface of its depths.

I think Cairns would have appreciated Sohm’s treatment of the church. Yes, I think he would also have rejoiced over the “guiding principles,” though they do not go so far as Sohm.

One thing must now be clear. The guiding principles and that which their authors have written concerning them must be studied, discussed, and clarified—at least in private. If one immerses oneself in these principles, then a hundred questions will arise, and one will scarcely give up before one has received satisfactory answers from the authors. If, in addition, one reads related literature written by others, then new points of view emerge; and one then returns to the principles with these, makes comparisons, and forms for oneself a comprehensive view in which no details have been skipped over, nothing foreign has been imported, and the greater and the lesser have received their proper importance and their proper place.

It is not for everyone to do this work. Where prejudice has anchored itself fast, where intellectual alertness is dull, indifference great, and the assertion “We have Abraham as our father” strong, there the prospects for a fruitful engagement with the principles and the literature on church polity are by no means promising. But where there is good will, an honest endeavor to get hold of what is right, there one may come a long way. And it is needed.

Principle no. 1 especially needs our attention. Do we all understand it? Is it too much to ask whether it is fully in accord with the Word? Is it absolutely excluded that the authors could have been mistaken? The opposition to this principle at any rate justifies the raising of such questions. Thus: questions awaiting answers, tasks awaiting solution.

One may, of course, get away from these questions and tasks by once more asserting that principle no. 1 aims at the unorganized holy catholic Church, the communion of saints. But that is precisely what it does not do.

One may indeed make objections by pointing to the exposition of principle 4, which speaks of the congregation’s outward organization. But this principle must be understood in connection with principle no. 1.

Principle no. 1 is directed against two things. First, against the complex organizations which we call the organized church, the state churches, the denominations, and so forth. The principles regard these organizations not as church or congregation in the sense of Scripture,

but as worldly organizations. Second, they are directed against the view that the communion of saints, the unorganized church, is all that is needed. For the Church in the sense of Scripture is presented by S. and D. as consisting of congregations, not individuals.

Already in 1875 S. and D. turned “the weapons ... against pietism and false spirituality, which dissolves the Christian community into isolated individuals.” “It belongs inseparably to the essence of the Christian Church to exist in the form of congregations, not as individual Christians.”

In 1895 S. and D. wrote (joint declaration): “The Church is the Kingdom of God on earth, which between Christ’s ascension and His coming in glory has no other rightful form than the congregation.”

In 1898 S. declared: “This is something new when in point 1 we declare the congregation to be the proper form of the Kingdom of God on earth; for for hundreds of years men have called the church the proper form.”

That this means something other than adopting a new name for an old thing appears from what S. wrote in 1896:

The first thing, then, which comes forward as the scriptural principle in the relation between congregation and church body is this: that the congregation is the original, and the church body the derived; the congregation is the true, proper, apostolic, and Christian form of the Kingdom of God on earth in the time from the outpouring of the Spirit until Christ’s coming again; all outward societies or churches or institutions or associations or companies have, according to God’s Word, their justification only as serving instruments for the congregation, not as authorities that govern and issue commands.

This principle is the first and most far-reaching of all rules for church polity. The individual local congregation has God’s Word over it, has Jesus Christ as head and Lord, has God’s Spirit as its guide; but it has no other authority over it.

It is entirely clear that the New Testament teaches that Christians should not only have an inward fellowship of the Spirit with one another, but that they should also form outwardly organized congregations with their officebearers and their rules. We should depart from the altogether clear demand of God’s Word if we sought to be so spiritual that we would have no outward congregation. The outward congregation belongs to apostolic and biblical Christianity. Among the many who refuse to belong to any outward congregation because it is not spiritual enough for them, some suffer from a grievous lack and weakness in their Christianity, though it is far from us to mean that such frail Christians are not Christians at all. On the other hand, the same does not hold for what is called church bodies ...

“The very first principle of the critique of church polity is therefore this, that the Christian Church consists of free, independent, and self-governing congregations ... Such is the teaching of Scripture. (Veiledning 335).

The congregational form is necessary, according to S. “The Kingdom of God has its inner

essence, which is righteousness, peace, and joy in the Holy Spirit. It also has its outward form, which is the congregation, the Spirit's people in the world." The congregation is this outward form, "the only outward form appointed by God for His Kingdom on earth."

But this outward form of the Kingdom of God, the congregation, itself has both an outward side and an inward side.

There is talk of "its inward side in its invisible essence," its "inner spiritual essence." According to this, in "its innermost essence it [the congregation] is the body of Jesus Christ, or the work of the Holy Spirit." "In the dogmatic sense, people are not received into the congregation by a decision of the congregational meeting—but by the Word, Baptism, and faith." (S. and D. 1895).

But the congregation also has its outward side, its mixed character, the formal organization.

It is the believers in the local congregation who are the body of Christ. The unbelieving members are members of the congregation in an improper sense; they stand only in an outward connection.

The proper form of the Kingdom is the outward congregation: "The individual outward congregation is the body of Christ ... every member in this outward congregation is a member of Christ's body" (Oftedal in *Veiledning* 65). "The body of Christ ... is visible, because it is believing men and women who work with the Word and the Sacraments, and it is the outward, organized fellowship of these which is called congregation." (S. in *Veiledning*, 38). "What is said about the unity of all congregations is also said about the individual outward congregation." (Oftedal in *Veiledning*, 65).

And again Sverdrup:

For all congregations and for every one of them Jesus Christ is the living foundation upon which the congregation is built ...

"Paul did not mean that Jesus and His life, death, and resurrection are once for all the foundation of the Church, and since it has once been laid, it cannot be laid again; rather, he means that by the preaching of the Gospel in Corinth this foundation was laid there again, and the Corinthian congregation was built upon it.

"And not that alone. All congregations, and every single one of them, are the body of Jesus Christ. In this body He is the soul, and for this body He is the head ... As intimately as the soul is joined to the body, so near is Jesus to the congregation ... He Himself is the head and governs and leads the congregation, works through it. (Luth. Kirkeblad 1893, no. 4).

... every congregation and every congregational member must remember that it is not merely the whole great Church, the gathering of all congregations, which is the body of Jesus and the bride of Jesus; rather, it is precisely the little gathering of people who in each place gather around the Word and the Sacraments that has the calling to be God's temple, the body of the risen and glorified Savior, through which He Himself will work on earth, by which He still reveals Himself on earth.

Therefore the responsibility is so great. God's temple is holy; therefore it is all the greater a transgression for a congregational member to be profane and thereby corrupt God's temple.

Luther's words about 'the whole Christian congregation on earth' must also be true of each individual congregation, if this truly answers to its name. (L. K. 1893, no. 10).

Some of the most unfortunate expressions theologians have been accustomed to use concerning the congregation are: visible and invisible, inward and outward. They are thoroughly confusing. S. and O. have to some degree accepted this usage, and it was scarcely to be expected that they could use these expressions for 35 years without committing one inconsistency or another—for who has not been made to stumble by these expressions? ²⁵

One should note the difference.

There may be an outward congregation even where external organization is lacking. "It is the use of the Word and the Sacraments that constitutes a congregation in the biblical sense" ²⁶. This means the local congregation—not "the whole Christian Church." The outward organization, the outward congregational form, follows as a rule afterward.

Where these means [Word and Sacraments] are rightly used, there is at least a mission, and where these means work eternal life in souls, there the body of Christ and His congregation are present according to their essence, even though there is not yet any congregational organization" (S. S. II, 236).

"The congregation [the outward congregation] was there ... already at Pentecost. It had adopted no constitution, chosen no officebearers, organized itself in any way by outward regulations and decisions; nevertheless it was there." (S. S. II, 9).

The formal organization is the external, outward organization. But the organization in reality is the congregation, the local congregation.

(N. B. We distinguish sharply between outward organization and outward congregation.)

The local congregation, when it answers to its name, is a gathering of believers. It is defined in principle no. 2, which deals precisely with the congregation's constitutive members. This principle states what the congregation theoretically is. Those who are called constitutive members are believers. But in the outward organization there are also hypocrites; they intrude into it, they are no constituent part, their connection is only outward. That is what the congregation in its practice is according to principle no. 4, and the Augsburg Confession, art. 8. (cf. S. S. III, 368).

S. and O. laid such weight on the constituted local congregation (organization may follow later) that some may say that they made it into a sacrament. And it is true that S.'s view of the congregation resembled very much the early church's view of the sacraments. Therefore S.

²⁵In 1877 Oftedal wrote: The congregation is visible because God's Word and the Sacraments are there, and invisible because the believers are there and it is "the body of Christ" (Kvartalskrift 1877, 15).

²⁶In 1897 Sverdrup wrote: The congregation becomes visible by its believing members and their activity. ... The body of Christ ... is visible. (Veiledning 37, 38).

could say that one who lived alone on an island had no need of the Supper, the congregation's meal. The older theologians said that it is not the lack of the Sacraments that condemns, but contempt for them. Compare Sverdrup: "Where an individual Christian lives alone in prison or under some other compulsion, there the lack of a congregation will not lead to his perdition (Veiledning 95)." "The congregation is absolutely necessary where it is possible." "Where Christians can be congregation and will not, there is at times great danger for their soul (95)."

"For our Free Church people, the matter stands thus: that when God's Word has set the congregation as the proper form for the Kingdom of God on earth until Christ's coming, then it is both necessary and possible to have congregation, whatever it may cost" (against the free-free).

All this, of course, points to the "outward congregation."

The local congregation was of such significance for S. and O. that, for example, in the 1870s they did not wish any local congregation to be established at Augsburg, although their colleagues Gunnerson and Gjeldaker wished this. The matter was dealt with several times in the faculty. Even a faculty opinion was submitted. Among the grounds S. and O. advanced was this, that school discipline with its strictness would interfere disruptively with the congregation as a community of professors (and their families) and students. Church discipline and school discipline might conflict with one another.

The local congregation was of such significance for S. and O. that they never stated, so far as I know, that an individual could be a member of several congregations at once; whereas they saw nothing wrong in a congregation's standing in connection with several church bodies, since these (in contrast to the congregation) are not governed by the law of the body of Christ. The church bodies were only organs, worldly arrangements, which could serve the congregation, which was the actual organization, the divine institution, the only form in which the holy catholic church becomes manifest (cf. Pontoppidan F. C. B. edition, col. 243).

No matter how much one wishes to get away from the fact that S. and O. held this doctrine of the congregation; it is the same how much one wishes to twist their statements—one cannot get away from the concept of the local congregation as the fundamental thing in S. and O's conception of the Church. **For them the local congregation was not merely something expedient, not merely an organization necessary in an organic sense; for them it was at least just as necessary in the specifically Christian sphere as the family is in the social. One may call the whole human race a family, but the individual family is a necessary ordinance for the proper growth and upbringing of the human race.** Neither state nor school nor orphanage can wholly replace upbringing in the home. So too, all Christians together are called congregation, or church, but this whole Christian congregation or church consists of individual congregations.

4.7 Why the Congregation Is Not Optional

[editorial title]

Installment 7: “Folkebladet,” April 24, 1918

The controversy over Augsburg in the 1890s arose from disagreements about the concept of the church, disagreements that also shaped ministerial education. The view held by S. and O. differed greatly, especially from that of Dr. Schmidt, who in 1893 left Augsburg together with his colleagues, Professors Bøckman and Lund.

For Schmidt the outward congregation was of lesser significance. For him, what mattered above all was “the whole Christian congregation,” that is, the holy catholic Church. His concept of the church is found in *Luthersk Kirkeblad*, no. 41:

Christ’s true congregation is not first and foremost an outward union around certain officeholders or a certain visible organization that catches the eye, but it is the fellowship and union of true believers in the spirit, as Jesus’ true believing disciples and, each for his part, members of His spiritual body...

Thus also now, as formerly, God’s true Israel is not this or that outward flock or association of persons, a visible organization under a definite and conspicuous form of rule; rather, God’s right and genuine household are all those whom He who searches the hearts knows and loves as His own, that is, as true regenerate children of God through faith in Jesus Christ. All these true believers are members of the one body, and besides these true believers, whether they be adults or little children, there exists no member in Jesus’ body. The true and glorious unity of the Church as Jesus’ body is therefore a spiritual unity, the unity of hearts by the same spirit of faith.

Outward difference with respect to time, place, language, nation, yes, even outward ecclesiastical connection and the teaching ministry, makes no breach here in the unity of faith and spirit. All who in the wilderness of this world have learned to feel themselves bitten by the serpent, and who with the longing of faith look up to the Lamb of God, who bears the sin of the world, all these are united with Jesus by this faith that seeks salvation and are members of His body, whether moreover they be a Jew or Greek, barbarians or Scythians, whether they live in the Old or in the New Testament, whether they speak this or that tongue, yes, whether moreover they be Catholics or Protestants, or whatever kind of society they may belong to by outward confessional connection....

But if this is so, that the essential and proper unity of the Christian Church, whereby according to God’s judgment it is one single Church, is a spiritual unity, then does it perhaps follow from this that the outward and visible unity is an altogether unessential and indifferent matter?

With respect to the answer that Dr. Schmidt gives, S. and O. found that the view of “the congregation” was lacking. And several years later Sv. wrote: “The core of the matter is this, which Dr. Schmidt has not yet touched: Are the New Testament’s statements about

the congregation as binding upon Christians as its statements about what has been called doctrine?" This was in the years when Schmidt entered the lists on behalf of "the old church order."

According to S. and O., therefore, the New Testament was normative also for church polity. According to Schmidt, it was a rule only for doctrine.

S. wrote: "And above all other principles in the Free Church there stands the decisive authority of the Word of God in the matter of the congregation and of church polity no less than in the question of doctrine" (Veiledning 93).

"We... have... enlightenment about 'church polity' in the Bible." We need not "speculate out something 'that suits the times'; there is light enough for the congregation in the New Testament, and it is not worth letting anyone persuade us that it does not suit our time" (105; cf. 33).

"The very first principle of the Free Church regarding church polity is this, that the Christian church consists of free, independent, and self-governing congregations" (35).

All this is comprised in the formal principle of Congregationalism:

"The Word of God in Scriptures is designed to furnish, and actually does furnish, the sole objective authority, not only for the doctrines, but also for the constitution, worship, and discipline, of the Christian church." (Ladd 38).

"It is a principle of congregationalism, that the Scriptures are the only infallible guide in matters of church order and discipline." (Punchard 19).

Or, as the Declaration of the English Congregationalists of 1833 says:

"They believe that the New Testament contains, either in the form of express statute, or in the example and practice of apostles and apostolic churches, all the articles of faith necessary to be believed, and all the principles of order and discipline requisite for constituting and governing Christian societies; and that human traditions fathers and councils, canons and creeds, possess no authority over the faith and practice of Christians."

We now understand why S., in a newspaper discussion with Dr. Kildahl, could say: "God and His Son and His Spirit are entirely omitted from Kildahl's consideration of church polity" (Veiledning 159).

For S. and O. the question of church polity was a fundamental question: church polity had to be derived from Scripture just as truly as doctrine. Not so for Schmidt and Kildahl. And not so for the great majority in the Lutheran church, as is illuminated in the following citation from one of the newest works in theology. After having set forth the Catholic church's conception of divine right, the author says:

"According to the evangelical conception there is no divine right (church law). The Bible is a source only for faith, not for law. The Symbols are confessional writings, not law-books. For Luther, Christ was no 'jurist or ruler in outward matters.' The Lutheran confessional writings do indeed contain a series of thoughts that have become determinative for later legal formations, yet they are nevertheless not sources of law.

Somewhat otherwise it is with the Reformed church, insofar as it has seen itself occasioned to adopt the apostolic congregational order. But it too rejects the Roman juridical conception.

We have now made it clear that principle 1 is a constitutional principle: it is not a dogmatic principle. As a principle of church order, it belongs to ethics, and as applied ethics it belongs to church polity. If one wants the dogmatic side of the congregation, one can find it treated, for example, in Sverdrup's "Dogmatic paragraphs on the congregation" (S. S. VI.)

Dogmatics sets forth chiefly what God does, His work; ethics, what the human being does, his activity.

Dogmatics presents the congregation as the work of the Spirit, furnished with means of grace and gifts of grace.

Ethics presents the congregation as a gathering of people who know the conditions of salvation, proclaim the Kingdom of God, and labor for its advancement among themselves and others. Therefore it also treats the church's ministry, organization, relation to the state, tasks, and so forth.

Dogmatics presents the congregation as a gift from God; ethics presents it as a task: God's gifts become our tasks; He gives the power to carry them out, He uses us as His instruments.

Ethics also treats church polity, but more from an abstract standpoint. A parallel discipline to ethics is practical theology; it applies theological knowledge to practical life, as we live it in experience. Church polity is one of the special branches of practical theology and treats—both theoretically and practically, historically and systematically—the area peculiar to it, which ethics, so to speak, only brushes upon.

Guiding Principles are throughout principles (or fundamental propositions) for church polity. They are principles, not a task. They do not pertain to the individual person, but to the community. They are not an ideal. They do not set forth an unrealizable demand.

Gynild indeed says: "If the same principles did not demand more than what we could carry out, then they would not be Christian."

An astonishing statement about what Christian principles demand..

Thus perhaps Søren Kierkegaard might have spoken—the spokesman of paradox and of life-denying asceticism, he who called himself a police talent and an angel of accusation, and thought he was appointed to point out what Christianity required and to maintain that there was no one who could fulfill its demands. For K. Christianity was something so exacting that he did not profess himself to be a Christian.

Thus perhaps Bjørnstjerne Bjørnson too might have spoken, when he was working on his drama *Over Evne*, where—in another spirit than Kierkegaard's—he sought to show that Christianity is beyond one's power: its demands cannot be met.

But thus it ought not to be spoken where one wishes to preach evangelical Lutheran Christianity, even if one makes a principle identical with a demand or an ideal.

The highest ideals we possess come from Christianity. The ideals of the ancient world were poor; it did not take much to realize them. Its “god” could not help; for he was so infinitely far away. But the ideals of Christianity lie in the distance. Much is required to realize them. But then the Christian’s God is always near. He gives the power to realize even the highest Christian ideal.

The further away the ideals are, the more exertion is needed in order to attain them (activity). The nearer God is, the more receptivity there is for Him and His gifts (receptivity). He gives us what He requires. And the highest thing He requires is evangelical perfection (Matt. 5:48, not the perfection demanded by the Law). He gives us this perfection (Phil. 3:14, 15: “Let us then, as many as be perfect...”)

The doctrine of Scripture concerning this highest goal or ideal we also find in the Augsburg Confession, art. 27, 12:

Christian perfection consists in this: earnestly to fear God, and yet at the same time to set one’s whole confidence in Him, and on account of Christ to trust that we have a reconciled God; to pray to God for help and confidently expect it from Him in all that, according to one’s calling, one has to do; and besides this, in one’s outward conduct, unweariedly to do good works and take heed to one’s calling. In this consists true perfection and true worship of God.

By Christian perfection is meant neither sinlessness nor the state of being complete. But according to Scripture the predicate perfect belongs to the one who has the moral quality that God wills him to have. The Christian strives to make faith and love a settled part of his spiritual life, so that they determine what he does and what he is.

One of the great thinkers in the realm of Christian thought has said: “The highest ideal of life is Christian perfection. It is a goal that is not of the world to come, but which can be understood and realized here on earth.”

It is precisely the Christian ideals that can be realized.

There is also a heavenly goal. It is not thought to be realized on earth. But it shall be realized there where it is appointed to be realized, when we “see Him as He is” and when the Son “delivers the kingdom to God the Father” (1 Cor. 15:24). There is another order there than in the Christian economy on earth, where we may say: By the grace of God I am what I am (1 Cor. 15:10); I can do all things in Christ who makes me strong. Or: by the grace of God it is possible to keep one’s baptismal covenant.

He who is a Christian must fight. Luther said, “A Christian is not one who has already become one (nicht im Wordensein), but one who is becoming (im Werden) a Christian. He who is a Christian is no Christian.” Or, as Chrysostom said: “To be perfect is: not to think oneself perfect.” Or, as others have expressed it: “The Christian’s perfection consists in this, that he is always conscious of his imperfection.” The more the Christian life increases, the more one comes to know one’s own imperfection; but the more one also learns to know grace, that God does not require more than He gives.

It is possible that this sounds strange to our ears, but it is nothing new—at any rate not new

for a man such as, for example, Gustav Jensen, who in his book *Fra Menighedsforsamlingen* says of Matt. 5:43–48, Be ye perfect:

He (Jesus) does not hesitate to set before them the highest goal that it is possible at all to set... A father does not lay before his children what is impossible and unattainable, and when your heavenly Father wills that His children should strive after the highest, then it is because He, as Father, wills to help them attain it. Therefore we also see in the New Testament that the Lord Himself and His apostles often speak of perfection, and indeed of a perfection which already here, according to its basic features, can be attained by His Holy Spirit... Be grasped by Christ, and then be among those who strive after it... And you shall surely advance in that perfection which can be attained here on earth under the grace of the forgiveness of sins, and when the time comes, win the prize.

This therefore applies to an ideal, a goal (S. would presumably say: a principle) which Jesus Himself has set forth as “the highest goal that it is possible at all to set.” Leading Lutheran men proclaim that it is attainable here on earth. But then Gynild comes and proclaims that Guiding Principles (which are not at all ideals of life and which were, moreover, written by sons of the nineteenth century) are Christian in so high a degree that they demand more than we can carry out: “If the same principles did not demand more than what we could carry out, then they would not be Christian.”

If some solitary schoolmaster had concocted something of that sort, I should have remained silent. But when a pastor, who time and again has been chairman of the Free Church, publishes something like this, then it is right to go against such an assertion.

Guiding Principles are not demands, are not ideals. They are principles.

What is a principle?

The word principle is used in very different senses. In philosophy—which, to use a Gynildian word, the “learned fools” must now and then condescend to concern themselves a little with—principle means: highest concept, supreme proposition, law, axiom, explanatory ground, point of departure. A favorite definition of philosophy is the science of principles.

In the science of religion, principle means the conception of the fundamental impulse or fundamental power that lies behind the individual psychological expressions of life and facts.

In historical psychology, “principle” is applied to a totality determined by certain interests, for example in the analysis of an individual, the character of a people, a section of culture. Here principle can be paraphrased by words such as national spirit, spirit of the age, essence, fundamental view, fundamental idea, idea, and so forth.

The psychological conception of religion sees in “principle” not ready-made propositions, but a fundamental disposition of the soul: the principle is the point of unity behind consciousness.

4.8 Principle, Not Impossible Demand

[editorial title]

Installment 8: “Folkebladet,” May 01, 1918

A principle is commonly a foundational proposition. It means beginning, and it is applied to the first propositions or chief rules which one follows within a given domain. It is “that ground with whose validity the rest stands or falls.”

It is, in other words, the unity of a way of thought from which a multiplicity of expressions of life are derived and explained, an original unity to which thought may be led back. As such it may be what one might call, using a foreign term, an ‘ideal aim’. But in the first place, and essentially, it is a resting-point, fertilizing seed for the whole generation of thought, a point of support, an explanatory ground for the whole of the powers of development in, and a foundation for, the moral, religious, material, personal, and social life.

A Christian principle is not beyond our powers. It is a foundation upon which to stand, something that supports, that bears. Therefore Sverdrup could write—and it was among the last things he wrote (see facsimile in S. S. III.)—“A false principle is like a failing foundation.”

Dogmatics has its principles. They are treated in what is called the doctrine of principles in dogmatics, or fundamental doctrine, which constitutes almost a third of this discipline (for example, Kirms’s, v. Oettingen’s). Lønning’s little doctrine of faith, which in my school days was used at Augsburg, contained no treatment of principles, for which reason nothing further was said about it in “class.”

Ethics also has its principles. They are found in the doctrine of principles in ethics, which likewise constitutes about a third of the discipline of ethics. Since nothing in this discipline was taught at Augsburg, nothing further was said there about the principles of ethics either.

Church polity also has certain principles which are derived from a fundamental principle. The principles of church polity were not discussed to any extent in “class.” Instruction in this area came, in theory, chiefly through the church papers, and practically through the church conflict.

Thus: three groups of principles.

1. What are the dogmatic principles? One speaks of two great Reformation principles, which at the same time are the chief foundational propositions for all Protestant dogmatic thought: the formal principle and the material principle, first set forth by Twesten in 1829.

The formal principle is the foundational proposition concerning Scripture as the sole decisive norm of Christianity. It is the epistemological point of departure, the source to which we must go. It is the principle of Scripture.

The material principle is the foundational proposition of justification by faith alone. It is the religious principle for a dogmatic evaluation of Christianity. It may also be designated as the Kingdom of God, a revealed act of divine grace, realized in Christ’s righteousness.

Dogmatics has to do with knowledge. On the one hand, it has a direction and an aim. On

the other hand, it has a regulative principle, something that guides. The Danish dogmatician T. R. Vang says that “the direction and goal of Paul’s understanding” are “God’s thoughts concerning human beings, the content of his will, his plan of salvation and its fulfillment.” And then he asks: “But what now is the principle that guides him in this his energetic thinking?” “He has expressed it in the words that return again and again: in Christ.”

2. If one asks: What is the principle of ethics? then the answers differ. In ancient ethics it was pride. In Abelard’s ethics (the Middle Ages) it was conscience. Reinhard (ca. 1800) held that the principle of ethics was love (against Kant’s principle, pure morality). Goethe said: “I bow before him (Christ) as the divine revelation of the highest principle of morality;” but in Goethe’s eyes Christianity was surely only a revelation of natural religion. He also wanted to worship the sun, “for it is likewise a revelation of the highest!” De Wette made faith the principle of ethics, Harleß regeneration, Darwin evolution.

According to J. T. Beck, the principle of ethics is “Christ living and working in us through the Word.” Gisle Johnson: “The Christian faith, as it shows itself working through love.” Luthardt: “Communion with God in Christ, which in faith becomes a personal reality, and in life shows itself working in love.” N. Seeberg: “Man’s living communion with God in order to serve God with a view to the aim of the eternal ideal.” Grützmacher: “The source and principle of theological ethics is the Christian character.” Oftedal, Gunnersen, and Sverdrup: “Christ’s liberating power in a distinctly personal Christian life.”

3. If we were to seek a highest principle for polity, a fundamental thought from which, for example, the principles of Guiding Principles are derived, it would have to be the universal priesthood, which Kahnis regarded as the third principle of the Reformation. But whereas Kahnis called it the Church principle and applied it to the invisible Church, S. and O. applied it to the visible body of Christ, the congregation, and called it the congregational principle.

Guiding Principles are foundational propositions for church polity derived from one of the chief principles of the Reformation, the universal priesthood.

It is to be regretted that S. and O. did not have time to give expression to their principles in a rounded, concluding work. With such a work they could have made—for the time being—a contribution in practical theology which they could scarcely have made by any other work. In the area of polity they represented, for more than a generation—and with all diligence—a direction which must be described as new within Lutheran theology. Here their strength was greater than it was in dogmatics, exegesis, or history. Sverdrup was a gifted teacher in dogmatics, and he was well at home in the Old Testament. But did he represent any new direction in these disciplines? If so, wherein did it consist? Oftedal had wide-ranging interests, but did he represent any new direction in New Testament exegesis or in church history? In these areas, compared with the field of polity, they were essentially eclectics.

I do not say that this was less important than that which they contributed to polity. But in the history of theology, in the area of the concept of the Church, their exposition of church polity will stand as their distinct contribution. Even the little that has been included in “Veiledning” can, in its significance, be placed on a par with Høffling’s well-known work, *Fundamental Propositions for Evangelical Lutheran Church Polity* (year 1850, 225 pages, 3 editions in two years, also translated into Norwegian). Høffling’s book was described as

‘epoch-making’ and ‘of enduring significance.’ It is not too much to say that the contribution of S. and O. (even in *Veiledning*) just as fully deserves the same descriptions. In several respects the contribution of S. and O. signifies a great advance.

Høfling’s book ought to be able to contribute a little toward setting some “Doubting Thomas” among us on the right track, since it both says and proves that church polity goes deeper than merely external forms and various trifles, about which those who know least of the discipline never grow tired of talking. In the preface Høfling says:

It is not single forms of Evangelical-Lutheran church polity, but properly its principles and foundational propositions, concerning which in our day, alongside great confusion, there prevails a great difference of opinion, and concerning which in various places a controversy has arisen that threatens to become serious and could even give rise to a lamentable schism, if it should continue to be conducted in the same manner as hitherto and if it should not succeed in being settled by way of conviction. A manifestly Catholicizing hierarchical basic conception seeks to assert itself within the sphere of our Church, even if not as exclusively legitimate, then at any rate first of all as equally legitimate, in that it supposes itself to display a quite particular fidelity to the Church and its confession. The less now the author can regard the important meaning of our confession, or the true consequences of our Church principle with respect to this point, as doubtful, the more must he, in the interest of that Church and that confession to which he belongs with all his heart, feel himself called to restatement and rebuttal. And his highest wish is now that he may be so fortunate as to set forth the distinctive principles and foundational propositions of Evangelical-Lutheran church polity in a manner convincing to all. When he believes that he gives here one thing or another that is new, this applies not so much to practical results as to understanding of principle, development, systematic presentation, and justification. . .

So much for Høfling.

Høfling represents the low-church standpoint in the ecclesiastical controversy in Germany around 1850. The leaders of the high-church party who attacked him were men such as Stahl, Löhe, Lechler, Huschke, Kliefoth, Dieckhoff, Münchmeyer—well-known names in church history. These men laid great weight on the Church’s legal determinations, regarded the ministry as a divine institution, and held semi-Catholic notions concerning the administration of the sacraments, ordination, and so forth (Lønning became their faithful disciple).

Høfling’s writing became a liberating word. The tendency he combated suffered a great defeat. There are now exceedingly few in the Lutheran lands of Europe who represent this tendency. Its successors came to America. Here that tendency has become a dominant force.

4.9 The Principles Must First Be Understood

[editorial title]

Installment 9: “Folkebladet” May 08, 1918

Among us too there have been controversies, yes, schisms. Among us too words have been spoken that are wearing and corrosive. But over these words there reigns great disagreement, and there may come new schisms. These can be prevented—not by resorting to threats or the language of power, not by empty plotting or compromises—but by going the way of conviction. If there is agreement as to what the principles are and what they seek, then much will have been gained. It may be another question to decide whether the principles stand wholly and entirely on the ground of Scripture. First there must be agreement on what the thing is, before there can be discussion of its “how.”

That seeking to promote this understanding—and both Birkeland and I have sought it—has nothing to do with person and personal wrangling, is plain. It is small-minded thinking that writes, for example, Birkeland’s articles to the account of personal squabbling. Birkeland’s contributions have not concerned anything personal between individuals, but something outside the personal sphere, namely what the principles are and what they are meant to accomplish.

Peace comes with understanding. But it can also come in another way. It is possible to bury the principles and get a peace that is as silent as the grave’s. In the graveyard it is hushed and still: the silence of death. There, no one battles either over personal issues or over principles.

If the Free Church buries the principles—or whatever still remains of them—this will not, without more, mean the Free Church’s downfall. It can surely continue its existence, finding comfort in memories of old days, lowering its aim and writing “the enlivening and liberation of the individuals” instead of “the enlivening and liberation of the congregations.” But then it must also prepare itself to find an answer to the question: Why does S stand alone?

But even if the principles are allowed for some time yet to exist upon the surface of the earth, there is nevertheless danger that they may become a petrification, or a common program from which everyone fetches whatever best suits his own purposes, whether it be a new Christian type, or an ideal, or something else.

Therefore: the way of conviction.

If the understanding of the principles were greater, the annual meetings would look different. As things now are, they are a kind of adding machine for the politicking carried on between the annual meetings, an emergency brake to which the train staff resort every time they “see ghosts” on the line. So it was in Marinette, in Willmar, and in Fargo, where arrangements were even made to put some inconvenient passengers off. Had the understanding of the principles been greater, the meeting in Fargo would not have witnessed that concerted, peevish opposition to Birkeland and me. The meeting in Fargo was a classic expression of the situation among us.

Birkeland's and my articles in *Folkebladet* took principle no. 2 as their point of departure. And this principle is, after all, acknowledged as essentially correct—even in the most conservative Lutheran circles in Europe. What our articles asserted were old Lutheran truths concerning the religious equality of the laity with the pastors. No attempt was made to overturn formal rights and arrangements, which were valued for precisely what they are—human arrangements.

I showed myself to be fully in agreement with Scripture and Lutheran doctrine and paid due regard to the principles. No one has refuted anything that B. and I wrote. The opposition's fire and defenses were vaporous declamations about "spirit," personalities, and "periphery." Nothing tangible. Yet the loudest spokesmen against the ordination articles were certainly not the Coast pastor's (J. J. Jansen's) faithful followers in matters of church law, who himself also gives a detailed account of the questions surrounding ordination. Jansen wrote—as we have earlier indicated—in his autobiography:

Alongside the influence of my aunts and my dreams of becoming a pastor,, there had developed in me a sort of high-church enthusiasm for the church and the office, and with that also an intense interest in church law as a whole. It was here that I meant to study, understand, and come to a result, first concerning what the New Testament teaches regarding the office. I read Ritschl, A. Rothe, Thiersch, Stahl, Löhe, Lechler, but on the other side also Höfling, Richter, Rudelbach. I studied Carpzov, Böhmer, Buseudorf, and many more. The great folios in my library still remind me of many an eager hour.....

"My heart was from the beginning with Stahl and Löhe, with the high-church, catholicizing, mystical doctrine of the church and doctrine of office. But in the course of study I became more and more low-church. How did I become low-church? The New Testament compelled me. Thus there came forth my, no doubt very imperfect, scholarly attempt, 'The Ecclesiastical Office in the Apostolic Age.' (1877–78)."

It should be known that Jakob Sverdrup attacked this attempt in **Ny luthersk Kirketidende**. It was too high-church for Jakob Sverdrup, who himself wrote much about the office from a low-church standpoint. But more low-church than Jakob Sverdrup was his brother Georg, who with respect to the office essentially shared Sohm's view.

But when this low-church doctrine of office, with the corresponding contentious understanding of ordination, came forward again in **Folkebladet**, 1917, it seemed to some like something eerily foreign and 'free-churchish' in character. Our contributions were even perceived as personal attacks.

Birkeland's and my articles were lumped together at the Fargo meeting. What the dissatisfied said about the one of us was also made to apply to the other. A remarkable, artificially contrived solidarity! As for "personalities," I knew myself quite free of them. And as regards Birkeland, it astonishes me that he could write as objectively as he did, after the unjust treatment given him in Willmar, and after the maneuvering that had been employed, and had succeeded, in preventing his reelection as chairman of Augsburg's Board of Trustees. It was said that funds would no longer come to Augsburg if he were to retain the chairman's

seat, and that confidence in the school would disappear! Even the ordination committees had brought Birkeland's name into the questions they put to the theological candidates. In view of this and much else I say: all respect for Birkeland.

As for me, I have always sought to argue as one generally argues in respectable theological journals. It has been objective truth that has concerned me. When I have said or shown that this or that publicly advanced assertion is untenable, then I have said no more than a conscientious carpenter has the right and duty to say to another carpenter: This beam will not do. Get something else! But such an address is no personal attack. Nor is it an act of murder—a point I wish to stress in reply to an editorial statement. It is not for murder's sake that holes are shot in untenable arguments. Supporting structures that serve to protect what is false—it is all one how well-intentioned they may be—deserve to be leveled.

My language has been the bracing language of duty. Such language speaks openly. It does not whisper, does not threaten. It does not whisper in the twilight, does not compose protests and does not circulate petitions. It does not maneuver under cover of committee chairmen's reports. In its embarrassment it does not take refuge in words like "spirit and life," words which in Scripture mean very much, but which here and there among us have in fact been degraded into a slogan that conceals a multitude of sins, including intellectual irrationality and sloth.

The non-narcotizing language of duty has also been Birkeland's language, yes, even where he cited Oftedal's words about Christ and Belial. For there are indeed clashes among us. And if one takes into consideration that the men who most often speak grandly of 'spirit and life' took two days of the Fargo meeting's costly time to discuss Birkeland's (and my) contributions, then one gets the impression that the clashes are anything but child's play. Yes, it seems as though there were a little (perhaps much) something of a Christ-against-Belial contrast, where Birkeland and I are made into a kind of modern Belial-spawn, trafficking in personalities and needing publicly to be chastised and instructed concerning the necessity of the one thing needful, exactly as though we had never before heard or known what the basic truths of Christianity are.

I have always respected Birkeland for his labors on behalf of the principles. He is one of the few who has shown a firm grasp of the principles and has interpreted them consistently. If there is anything to object to in the consequences B. has set forth, then the fault is not Birkeland's, but the principles'.

Now when *Folkebladet* has undertaken to humiliate Birkeland by editorial rebukes—boldly personal rebukes—and by publishing others' disapproving criticism of his person without any sort of editorial dissent, it seems to me that he has good ground to take issue with *Folkebladet*, even if he sets aside the personal element in these articles and focuses on the more substantive side.

1. Birkeland had good reason to criticize the decision that the Fargo meeting adopted in connection with the union matter. Neither the decision—which was sprung on the meeting without warning—nor the editorial defense, which was surely prepared in calm and comfort, is in harmony with *Leading Principles*.

2. Birkeland also had good reason to criticize the editorial 'Impressions from the Annual Meeting.' I must say I did not recognize the annual meeting in these impressions; nor did I know with what justification the editors expressed their hope that "those who hereafter write in the paper will respect the general sentiment among the people with regard to this matter." But I did recognize the annual meeting in the criticism that P. Fostervold exercised upon the "Impressions." Fostervold wrote among other things this:

But how the paper can write such things is more than I can understand. When one tries to make it appear that the general sentiment among the people was on the side of those pastors who attacked the articles on ordination, then *Folkebladet* must know that it is doing the annual meeting an injustice. For every single layman who spoke in this matter—and they were not so few—placed himself clearly and decidedly against these pastors. And they surely, better than anyone else, represented the general sentiment among the people at large. These men were not, either, some young brawlers. They were older, sober-minded men. There were, moreover, several pastors as well who wholly sided with the laity. Besides, it was in the votes that the strongest words were spoken, and it was these that showed the general sentiment among the people in the meeting.

So far as I was able to survey the situation at the annual meeting, two thirds of the meeting's voting members voted with Birkeland in the decisive divisions. The laity for a time thought of holding their own meeting and protesting against the dissatisfied pastors' tactics. But nothing came of it: they saw that it was unnecessary.

The chairman cast a little light on the situation when, in characteristic fashion, he explained that the articles in *Folkebladet* (B.'s and mine) had widened the gulf between the pastors and the laity.

Unfortunately—there was indeed a gulf. It had come into being in former times. But a new element had been added: by these articles the people had, more than ever before, become conscious of this gulf. The gulf had been created long before—by the high-church doctrine of office, by the conception of the pastor's privileged religious standing by virtue of call and ordination. For it was no secret that at a pastors' meeting in Minneapolis it had been declared that a pastor stands in a nearer relation to God than a layman does.

4.10 Vocation and the Right to Interpret

[editorial title]

Installment 10: “Folkebladet” May 15, 1918

It is remarkable that there are not a few in the Free Church who still adhere to neo-Lutheranism’s concept of the Church, as it was maintained by the once powerful theological faculty in Lund, Sweden—by such men as Professors Flensburg, Reuterdaahl, Sundberg, Billing. In contrast to what Sverdrup taught in “Dogmatiske paragrafer” (S. S. VI), the Lund professors maintained that “the administration of the means of grace is not a product of the congregation’s life of faith, but rather its source; it is the Lord’s own institution. The Lord has not only ordered their function, but together with them an office for their administration, and the one who has not received this office by the ordered way has no right to administer the means of grace. If he does so, he breaks not only a human, but a divine order.”

Is it “the irony of fate” that this—the so-called “Lundensian church-concept,” over which there has been so much strife in Sweden, and which a portion of the Swedish Augustana Synod bequeathed to the Conference—still is upheld in the Free Church, whose principle no. 2 is to a great extent a negation of Lund theology’s concept of the Church?

Principle no. 2—that was the core of Birkeland’s articles and mine. These articles emphasized the religious (not formal) equality of the laity with the pastors, grounded in the principle of the universal priesthood. For most laypeople this was self-evident. But some pastors were thrown into confusion by it. The Board of Home Missions lost its head to such a degree that it connected a young pastor’s “fall” with these articles and with their authors’ influence upon the students at Augsburg. A semi-secret meeting of several pastors—both local and nonlocal—had been held in Minneapolis to go after the ordination articles and, naturally, their authors. The result was a declaration that was read before the meeting in Fargo. It served the reactionaries’ cause, was spiritless, and received the ambiguous epitaph, ‘It had already had its effect.’ A pity it was not allowed to stand in the annual report as a worthy and lasting piece of salt.²⁷

But to what end is it to contend over who it was that won? It is of very little significance to establish who the victors were. He who stands in accord with the truth is the victor, even if outwardly he suffers defeat. With that both parties may comfort themselves. For my own part I will say that no annual meeting decision can nullify the truth in these articles, which were both biblical and Lutheran.

²⁷On Professor Helland’s proposal it had been decided that the declaration should be printed in the annual report. I supported the proposal (as did several others). It was adopted. At a later session two pastors proposed “that this decision be reconsidered, and that it be recommended to the signatories that they permit this to take place. We ground this on the fact that this resolution has already done its work...”

This proposal was not in order, insofar as it recommended to the signatories (Pastor Caspersen, etc.) that they grant permission for reconsideration. The declaration was, after all, the property of the meeting. It could dispose of the property as it wished, without asking any of the signatories’ advice. The comic thing was that a couple of the signatories, at the chairman’s prompting, rose and gave their “permission.” Did the chairman lose his bearings, or the movers, or the signatories—or all of them? A peculiar parliamentarian, very considerate besides.

These articles combated the neo-Lutheran, Romanizing concept of office, which the new direction had always combated. Among other things, they showed indirectly that the annual meetings in Brainerd and Marinette had fumbled in regard to ordination. And directly they reproduced the genuinely Lutheran doctrine, which has never been foreign to Augsburg.

For in 1895 Sverdrup wrote that ordination was not “a priestly matter,” not “an act of the gathered priesthood, but a Christian act, which can be performed by any congregation” (Veiledning 27); that it was “a congregational act, which only for reasons of expediency is carried out by several congregations in common” (25).

Evidently not very many at the annual meeting in Marinette were aware of these statements, where it was said that at Augsburg a new doctrine of ordination was being advanced. Evidently the ordainer at the annual meeting in Brainerd regarded ordination as a priestly matter, since he set aside two laymen (whom the meeting had elected to assist the ordainer, together with a couple of other pastors) and on his own authority appointed two pastors to function in their place. Evidently there is still confusion on the matter. A layman recently asked whether ordination would lose anything of its force if several laypeople were to take part in the laying on of hands. The answer he received was that Sverdrup, to be sure, was a layman, but he never took part in ordaining anyone. So then, what S. did or did not do was to determine ecclesiastical practice for generations to come!

With respect to the laying on of hands itself—well, it was not misconstrued in our articles. Our view of it was by no means foreign to Augsburg. As early as 1875 Sverdrup felt prompted to write the following, supported by Richard Rothe’s work, “Die Anfänge der chr. Kirche und ihrer Verfassung,” 160f. (S. has underlined important places in this work concerning polity):

For the laying on of hands in the apostolic Church is not an ordination in our sense of the word, as clearly appears from Acts 8:17, where the laying on of hands accompanies the prayer over all the baptized, that they might receive the Holy Spirit—from Acts 13:3, where the congregation in Antioch prays with laying on of hands for Paul and Barnabas, who are sent out to the work of missions, after they have already long preached the word—and from 1 Tim. 4:14 and 2 Tim. 1:6, according to which it is at any rate highly probable that Timothy twice received laying on of hands without its ever being said that by this he received any power of office. In the same way we also understand the laying on of hands here, where there is mention of the overseers of the poor, as a special direction of the intercession toward the individual. (Samlede Skrifter I, 92).

Even the great German stiffly orthodox Missouri Synod, on which the Free Church has not lavished many words of praise, is so free that it teaches:

It is the call of the congregation that constitutes ministers, and actually confers the ministerial office. Ordination is not a divine ordinance, but an apostolic-ecclesiastical institution. It does not confer the ministry, as Papists and Romanizing Protestants assert, but it is only a public testimony and confirmation of the call. Ordination is not essential to the validity of the ministerial office.”

I do not know what the editor teaches about ordination, but I think the annual meeting got

the understanding that he would not agree that Augsburg had the view of ordination that B. and I had maintained.

3. It seems to me that Birkeland also has good reason to take a questioning and critical stance toward the editorial article “Church and the Churches,” an extract from the Lutheran’s reproduction of Dr. H. E. Jacobs’s article in “Constructive Quarterly.”

For many years I have known Jacobs’s concept of the Church. It is that of the General Council, concerning which in the East there has been strife for more than fifty years and of whose principle Oftedal wrote: it “is very far from Augsburg’s.” I was therefore painfully surprised when I saw Folkebladet’s editorial article “Church and the Churches,” and most of all when I read the editorial board’s assent to the quotations from Jacobs: “What is said here, we assent to with our whole heart in the Lutheran Free Church.”

No one who knows Jacobs can write like that, and who in more than a merely formal sense is in agreement with the Guiding Principles.

For with Dr. Jacobs doctrine is decisive in the church question. It is determinative for the boundaries of the confessional church and the particular church. The question of organization is for Jacobs merely and simply a question of expediency. The local congregation is to him no more divine than a church body; it is not the Kingdom’s proper form, for the Kingdom of God has many forms. Jacobs is also an eager spokesman for what we call “point 3.” He believes in the divine institution of the office, and finds the representative system in the New Testament. It was Jacobs’s view of the particular church that prevented the English-speaking Lutheran General Synod (1,400 pastors) from obtaining a place in the proposed general Lutheran conference in Philadelphia, because it (the Synod) did not accept the whole Book of Concord! I have written a couple of pamphlets in English about this. It takes a great deal of imagination to make Jacobs’s concept of the Church harmonize with the Free Church’s. And nevertheless—the editorial board wholeheartedly endorses the Lutheran’s extract from Jacobs’s article. I suppose the editorial board intended by its article “The Church and the Churches” to emphasize the whole Christian congregation—and that may be needed. But according to the Augsburg principle, the whole Christian congregation exists only in the form of individual congregations, not as individuals. And this emphasis on the whole Christian congregation becomes nothing other than what Dr. Schmidt emphasized, and which called forth S. and O.’s disapproval. In the light of this, and of what we have maintained concerning the principles, and of much else that we have not expressly cited—for example S. S. II, 222 and Veiledning 36–38—we see how difficult it is for the editorial board to steer by principle no. 1. We will see it even more if, for example, we should adopt the definition of the Church given by the late missionary pastor and professor Johs. Johnson.

In a lecture, 1915, Johnson says: “The Church is the common name for all the activity that the name of Jesus calls forth. From the most stiff-legged institution to the most unchurchly private endeavor to make God the center of human life.” An appealing definition—but very far from the one that “stands in harmony with Augsburg’s past.”

With these things before our eyes—and I could mention many others—it seems to me that Birkeland, who has been almost iron-consistent in his interpretation of the principles, has reason to ask, Is Folkebladet against Augsburg? By this question he has hardly meant to

say that the one who thinks otherwise than the principles thinks unbiblically. But he has certainly meant to establish that only one authentic interpretation of the principles is possible, and that this interpretation in recent times has received headwind rather than fair wind in Folkebladet's editorial articles.

By "Augsburg" B. must surely mean the old teachers who framed the principles. For now, it is evidently very different with the interpretation of the principles at Augsburg. Some think that principle no. 1 concerns the local congregation. Some teach that it concerns the holy catholic Church. And some perhaps take the golden middle way and think that it concerns both.

The same difference of opinion appears also among the pastors.

What applies to the different interpretations of principle no. 1 can also apply to the other principles. One solemnly professes them, and yet has different interpretations of them. But only one interpretation can be the right one. Now, according to the editorial board, the laity has "the right and call to interpret the Word of God," and therefore they should have the right and indeed ought to have access to express themselves concerning the principles—in Folkebladet. The editorial board understands Birkeland's interpretation and mine as dictatorship and absolutism—and wishes to hear from the laity. But:

The editorial board heard from the laity at the last annual meeting, but did not listen closely enough—so thought Fostervold.

With respect to the right and the call, it must be so that the right is conditioned by the call, and the call by the gift of grace. But is the gift of grace that enables one to interpret the Guiding Principles the common to all? Might it not be that those who have shown that they possess something of this gift are more qualified for this interpretation than those who have displayed only a superficial acquaintance with them?

If the principles are an intellectual deduction from the Word, then surely those who have thought most about them and have applied themselves most to understand them in the light of Scripture and church-historical development must be the more entitled to interpret them.

Now everyone does indeed have the right to have his opinion about the principles. Birkeland has it. The editorial board has it. A fourteen-year-old confirmand has it too. But I will not say that the fourteen-year-old has a call and therefore the right to write in Folkebladet about Guiding Principles as, for example, Birkeland and the editorial board do. Something does depend upon the regenerate personality—and that is true. But it depends likewise upon maturity, wide reading, and much else besides. Or has the twentieth century done away with the difference in gifts of grace?

With respect to B. and the editorial board, it seems to me that B. has furnished quite different and much more reassuring guarantees for the understanding of the principles than the editorial board has done. To be sure, the editor has been both professor and student at Augsburg for more than a generation. I mention this because the editorial board ascribes to seniority and locality a certain special value. But Birkeland, for his part, is not without redeeming qualifications.

Birkeland too, after all, has been at Augsburg—but likewise out in the wider world—both here in this country and in distant lands. He has kept his eyes open, reaped profit from his association with many church-historically significant personalities also outside Augsburg’s narrow walls. He has read much ecclesiastical literature and produced much that entitles him to be heard in the ecclesiastical sphere at least as much as any of his opponents. There is force and originality in what he writes. No compromise-making. No foggy speech. But straight-lined thoughts and a firm grasp. As regards the interpretation of the principles, he has kept himself surely and firmly and steadily turned in the right direction. If he has at times shot beyond the mark—and who does not do that?—he has nevertheless held the direction.

But now the editorial board has taken Birkeland to school. And me as well. And those poor “learned works” on polity, which are to yield place to the unschooled layman’s judgment! How this reminds one of that colleague of Luther who left his professorship in Wittenberg, took his Bible to the untaught peasants and asked them to interpret it for him, since he thought that theological learning was a hindrance to the Spirit! Flattering for the peasants, but nothing but the sheerest enthusiasm, in Luther’s view, for Luther, who was not dualistic in his conception of Christianity.

It is precisely for men like the editor that I have again and again referred to the literature of polity, history’s commentary on Scripture’s doctrine of the universal priesthood, the foundation of the Guiding Principles. There lies documented in this literature the thinking and experience of many generations, from which the editorial board somewhat grandly distances itself, and of which his writing betrays so little knowledge.

There are many who understand the Guiding Principles without having specialized in polity literature. Laypeople especially, Norwegian academics as well. But how difficult it proves for a portion of the Augsburg men to understand them! Is it because Augsburg has not been able to give them enough light, or does the fault lie in themselves?

4.11 Daring to Raise the Question

[editorial title]

Installment 11: “Folkebladet” May 22, 1918

I do not find that the editorial board fully subscribes to the view of the Guiding Principles held by their authors. The editor’s earlier rejoinder to Birkeland and his two most recent editorial articles, ‘The Congregation,’ shows no change in his understanding of the principles—nor any understanding of what I have been striving to show. To be sure, he states that we are agreed on three or four points. But this agreement is, at the very most, an agreement in a formal sense, not a substantive one. The editor’s concession that the principles are “essentially a matter of polity” means, for the conclusions he draws, no more than if he had written: the principles are “essentially water.” The same I would say of the points he designates as 1 and 2: they are immaterial to the consequences the editor deduces. The fourth point—“The church’s chief task is not, however, to work for church polity, but for the salvation of souls, for spirit and life”—with this, however, I am heartily in agreement. For that is, or ought to be, the self-evident principal task of all congregations, churches, and denominations, indeed of every single man and woman who is called by Christ’s name.

Otherwise I see no agreement in principle in our understanding of the principles. The editorial office’s understanding of principles no. 1 and 2 is not in harmony with what I have cited from S. and O. on pages 251 and 301 of Folkebladet (second column) and in many other places. Sverdrup never taught that where there is one believing man, there the congregation is present ‘in its essence.’ Two Christians in one place are not, without more, a congregation, either according to essence or according to form. But if they come together around the Word and the Sacraments in order to help one another, then they are a congregation according to the essence; and if they organize the outward organization of the congregation, then they are a congregation also according to the form. That was Sverdrup’s doctrine and that is the doctrine of the principles.

The editor confuses the inward essence of the kingdom (righteousness, peace, and joy in the Holy Spirit) with the essence of the congregation (the body of Christ manifested in the world). And he confuses the outward form of the kingdom (the congregation) with the form of the congregation (the outward organization).

In 1875 the faculty contended (to use its own words) “against pietism and false spirituality, which dissolves Christian society into isolated individuals.” It contended for what it regarded as the truth, that ‘it belongs essentially to the nature of the Christian church to exist in the form of congregations, not as individual Christians standing alone.’ There is nothing to indicate that the editor has ever understood this language—the fundamental principle in the Augsburg view of the congregation. Had he done so, then he would have understood both the principles and their authors, both Birkeland and the spirit at the Fargo meeting, better than he now does; nor would he have voted with Dr. Jacobs as he has done.

Now Prof. Nydahl has the right to hold his opinion. No one can challenge him for that. And he has the right to criticize the principles—under his own name. But the matter becomes somewhat different when he gives editorial interpretations that explain the principles away,

and when he puts the brakes on Birkeland's writings and classifies them under headings such as dictatorship, absolutism, and the like.

For nine years now I have been a theological teacher at Augsburg, where the theological faculty has charged me with lecturing on various theological subjects—church polity as well. I have felt it to be a duty to teach in accordance with the Guiding Principles. It is possible that I do not possess the qualifications to teach this subject, and that the editorial board has been aware of that through all these years. There can now be no doubt that the editorial board believes this could be taught better, and that there are those at Augsburg who could do it better. I hope that the appropriate parties will go to the appropriate person and bring about a better arrangement. What I wish to make clear is that I share Birkeland's interpretation of the principles, but not that of the editorial board.

In maintaining my position in my teaching I have consulted both Scripture and the literature on polity and much else besides, in order to illuminate the individual principles. I know their strength and their weakness. About their weakness I have kept silent. But I have always interpreted them as I believe their authors intended them. I have never pronounced on the principles' complete conformity to Scripture or their absolute validity.

In my contributions to the paper I have both in season and out of season cited S. and O.—not in order to prove the conformity of the principles to Scripture (for that I do not need the help of others), but to show that in my understanding and interpretation of the principles I have been faithful to the authors. I have not misrepresented them. "Scripture interprets Scripture; author interprets author;" therefore I also published the little collection called "Guidance," which has been a guide both to me and to many students, and which could have served the same purpose for the editors.

If in these years I have not been able to interpret the principles rightly, then I have never deserved to lecture on theology or to teach anything whatever. If I am so spiritually blind, so scientifically unfit, indeed so intellectually incapable, that through all this time I have been unable to provide a correct diagnosis of the principles, then that is a sorrowful commentary on the annual meetings' appointment to professorships, and an even more sorrowful commentary on our whole higher educational system, both domestic and foreign; for I have, after all, had some experience of both.

I mentioned something about the weakness of the principles. It can be risky to suggest anything of that sort; it can be taken as though the disciple would be above the master. But one must reckon with imperfections in masters also. I shall illustrate this. In Sweden there was carried on for more than a generation a sharp conflict between the theological faculty in Lund and the theological faculty in Uppsala. It concerned the concept of the church. We have mentioned a little about it before.

The Lund faculty's concept of the church was high-church; the means of grace constituted the church, the office was given in and with the means of grace, which were thus regarded as instituted by God; the congregation, the believers, were a product of the means of grace and the office.

The Uppsala faculty's concept of the church was low-church: the means of grace were a

product of the believing congregation, the office likewise; the congregation chose a man for the office, but the holder of the office was to be a man with a gift of grace.

A massive literature was the result of the clashes between these two concepts of the church. Each of the two theological camps developed and fortified its own concept of the church and pointed out the weaknesses in the concept embraced by the opponent. Experienced men, situated very differently in the academic arena from the students and professors at the Scandinavian-American schools, repeatedly entered the fray in attack and defense. And now? Now the dust has settled. It has been shown that neither of these concepts of the church could stand. In each of them there was a hidden dualism.

Is there any dualism in the Guiding Principles? If we are like the sort of Americans of whom it is said, ‘The American cares only for the acts of the apostles, and the acts of his grandfather’, then we shall not want to know of any such question. If we are Augsburg people in such a way that we care only for the acts of the apostles and the acts of Sverdrup and Oftedal—that is, care little about history and the continuity of history—then it is daring to raise such a question in our midst.

But let anyone take up Luther, Sohm, W. Walther, and he cannot avoid this question. And if he finds the answer—may he be allowed to state it? When it is so difficult to be permitted to express one’s agreement with the principles, as Birkeland does, how much more difficult will it not be to document a possible disagreement? The times to come must answer that.

The principles have their significance. But they are not the center of Christianity. And neither B. nor I have made them that. To be sure, it may look as though they were the central thing, if one is to judge from all the column-space they have received from B. and me, especially from me. Yet they have always taken up a good deal of space in *Folkebladet*, even before I began to write. Still, this I will emphasize: the Free Church’s Guiding Principles “lay the chief weight upon the congregation and its spirit, life, and freedom.” For those who think that constitutional principles concern only outward arrangements, this sentence, taken from Guidance 118, ought to be given some serious thought. Individual ethics aims at the individual’s spirit, life, and freedom. Polity aims at the congregation’s spirit, life, and freedom, although—what of course no one will deny—the former is a condition for the latter. But the principles intend more than this condition: they intend a congregational life brought forth by the Spirit and lived in freedom.

One may be saved without knowing the principles. But, as I have said, they do have their significance—only as a means to an end, which also holds true of the organized church, great or small, of the office, of the public service of worship including preaching and hymn-singing, of the confessional writings, yes, also of Augsburg Seminary, which one has not—rhetorically at least—relegated to the periphery, but has outright made into “the Free Church’s heart.”

Compared with Christ, who is the center of Christianity, everything else is peripheral. Church polity is no exception, and therefore neither are the Guiding Principles, nor Augsburg Seminary either—which, moreover, ought to be superfluous to say.

The great question does not become: Does one align with this or that group of principles, this or that wing of a clerical aristocracy, this or that institution? But the question—the real

one—becomes: Does one stand in living accord with the future of God’s kingdom, and is one willing to let oneself be used for the kingdom’s advance, to labor for the fulfillment of the prayer: hallowed be your name; your kingdom come; as in heaven so also on earth—your will be done!

(Conclusion.)

5 The Editors

5.1 The Congregation

Installment 1: textitFolkebladet, April 24, 1918

I.

It is not so difficult to be editor of *Folkebladet* when friends are so ready to write as they have been of late. In any case, he need not write much himself. The difficulty is rather to find room for all the reading matter that is sent to the paper. From time to time, however, the editor may feel prompted to have a word in the matter, especially when it concerns the paper's editorial position.

Now Dr. Evjen has, in a series of articles on "the Position," thoroughly and clearly shown what, in his opinion, the Free Church's doctrine of the church is, as set forth by Professors Sverdrup and Oftedal, and as it has found expression in *Guiding Principles*. Although *Folkebladet* has not written much editorially on that matter, there are nevertheless a couple of incidental statements that are weighed and tested, and found not to be sufficiently clear; yet no major objection is raised against them.

A more exact explanation or account from the side of *Folkebladet* is perhaps not necessary or demanded; yet we shall try to write a little more directly on the subject that is here being discussed.

For the sake of clarity, we shall state our position in the following points:

1. In accordance with *Guiding Principles*, we believe that the church is the proper form of the Kingdom of God on earth.
2. The church organizations are human institutions, which may indeed have significance for the advancement of the Kingdom of God, but are nevertheless not the proper form of the Kingdom of God.
3. We can agree that *Guiding Principles* is essentially a constitutional document, that the Free Church's polity is congregationalist, and that it differs from that of other Lutheran bodies.
4. The Free Church's chief task, however, is not to labor for polity, but for the salvation of souls, for spirit and life.

So far as we understand Dr. Evjen, this is also his position. His articles, however, have this time been mainly expository; he has cited the statements of others and does not set forth so much his own personal opinion, or what he himself considers to be most in agreement with the Word of God. We understand that he has altered his view somewhat of late, and he hints, as his opinion, that if Prof. Sverdrup had lived long enough to read Rudolf Sohm's 1914 work on church law, it might perhaps have led him to moderate his view with regard to principle no. 1. He further says that principle no. 1 requires our special attention, and he raises these questions: "Is it too much to ask whether it is fully in accord with the Word? Is it absolutely excluded that the authors could have been mistaken? The opposition to this

principle at any rate warrants the posing of such questions. Thus: questions that await an answer, tasks that await a solution.”

We assume, however, that Dr. Evjen still assents to this principle, and then we are agreed in the main matter. And the thought suggests itself involuntarily: Why not look more to the fundamental principles on which we are agreed, and less to the unessential things which are of such a kind that there may very well be room for differing opinions? We have such need to work together rather than to split apart.

Take, for example, the thorny question of the Free Church’s distinct position among the Norwegian Lutherans. Some hold that there is only a difference of polity; others that there is more, namely also a difference in spiritual tendency. Some lay the weight upon polity, others upon spirit and life. And it might look as though the two parties stood so far from one another, indeed as though they were even the very opposite of one another. Perhaps, when it comes down to it, they are in reality nearer to one another than they themselves suppose.

It seems to us that the difficulty lies in the question of what is meant by polity. If we could obtain a sound definition of this concept, it would surely help us to understand one another better. Most people, no doubt, understand “polity” to mean much the same as constitution, laws, rules, statutes for the government of a church, a church organization, or a country—that is, the outward form of government. But then there are those who mean not only the forms, the rules, but also the spirit, the inward pulsating life, life together with its forms (life, after all, is presupposed).

It will readily be seen that there is a considerable difference between the two ways of viewing the matter, and herein lies the difficulty, we believe.

It may be that it is true that some of us have distinguished too much. But that too is not so simple. It appears that the elder Sverdrup, whose pupils we all believe ourselves to be, also distinguished between spirit and polity, for example in the following statement:

Without spirit there is no freedom in church or congregation. To suppose that one can produce freedom in the congregation by laws and constitutions is a mistake or misconception of the same sort as if a man should imagine that he could obtain steam power, if only he had a steam boiler, or that he could go on producing wheat indefinitely, if only he had a threshing machine. A good constitution and good laws are useful, if freedom is there; but if freedom is not in the congregation, then the law cannot produce it. Law does not create freedom; but if it is the right kind of law, then it serves to give freedom occasion to work and can even serve to preserve and protect freedom.

In the Norwegian state church there is at present quite great freedom for lay activity, because the law protects it. There is far, far greater freedom for lay activity than in the great majority of congregations here among us. That shows that freedom comes from spirit, not from church polity. It also shows that the law can serve freedom by protecting it; and conversely that good laws can become altogether ineffectual if there is no spirit in the congregation.

The first chief condition for a freed congregation is therefore spirit, God’s Spirit.

And if then the polity is sufficiently spacious, so that not all spiritual life is driven out of the congregation, then freedom too can accomplish its work.

If there is spirit in the congregation, then the first great effect of it will be a living zeal for the salvation of souls. That is the first and most important of all expressions of life and acts of freedom in the congregation, the very burning zeal of divine love for the salvation of souls.

(*Collected Writings* II, 21–22).

In this connection we also recall what Sverdrup once said in a lecture concerning the congregationalists in this country. He called attention to the fact that they are the continuation of the old Puritans. They have preserved the congregationalist polity, but the spirit is not the same; for the congregationalists have now become the most rationalistic of all the Reformed church bodies.

We may learn from this development among the congregationalists. It would be fatal for us to settle ourselves down and think that we have grasped it, that we have reached the goal, because we have a free polity. Above all, what matters is that we have spirit and life. All that concerns laboring for awakening and for the preservation of spiritual life always remains the main matter. If there was anything our old leaders laid particular weight upon, it was precisely this.

Do not misunderstand us, as though we meant to insinuate that those who so strongly emphasize this matter of polity are opposed to spiritual life. Not at all. On the contrary, it is the purpose of this article to advance the claim that at bottom we want the same thing: that those who stress polity also want spirit and life, and that those who lay the weight on spirit and life also want a free polity—most of them at least. Why then devour one another?

That there are some who in some respect desire a different polity may well be. But if we in writing, speech, and conduct show Christian forbearance and the right brotherly spirit, the “basis-robbers” will not gain much of a following. We must make room for one another. There must be freedom in the Free Church. It does us no good to have anyone set himself up as a dictator with a claim to sole right to decide what is truly Free Church.

We who speak so much about putting spiritual gifts to use in the practical work of the church ought also to be willing to let people, both pastors and laypeople, have opportunity to express themselves in our paper on questions of principle, even if they have not had occasion to read so many learned works. It is, after all, in the practical work of the church that the principles are to be carried through, and what is learned in the practical school of life is not to be despised. Besides, we all have access to the Bible—the Book—upon which our guiding principles are built; and when laypeople have the right and calling to expound the Word of God, they should surely also be given the right and opportunity to speak on the principles, for these are not holier than the Word itself.

As we have often stated, we favor free, objective discussion of questions of principle. We are not among those who would have everyone keep silent, and have no discussion at all. We believe in freedom of speech, and we believe that mutual, brotherly criticism does good. We all have our peculiarities, sharp edges, and faults that may need to be corrected. If criticism

falls silent, everything will bog down. We therefore do not want any strict censorship as in the days of absolutism. We want full freedom of speech, but indeed under responsibility.

We have spoken against personal attacks upon brothers, and we do so still; but we do not simply call it a personal attack when one answers another's opinion, and perhaps even uses strong expressions when they are needed. No, let the ideas contend. Nor ought any of us to be so thin-skinned that we cannot bear criticism. To grow sulky, or play the martyr, when one is contradicted, is altogether too childish.

(To be continued.)

5.2 A little further concerning our statements regarding the congregation

Installment 2: "Folkebladet" May 1, 1918

We have said that a congregation exists wherever two or three are gathered in Jesus' name, or, in other words, where two or more believers are gathered around the Word of God and the sacraments. This is Luther's view, and this is, it seems to us, in accordance with article 2 in **Living Principles**, which says: "The congregation consists of believing people, who by the use of the means of grace and the spiritual gifts, according to the direction of God's Word, seek their own salvation and eternal blessedness and that of all their fellow men."

We believe, in accordance with point 3, that according to the New Testament the congregation requires an outward organization, with a register of its members, the election of officers, fixed times and places for its gatherings, etc.

The congregation is, however, Christ's body, and one becomes a member of His body only by a true and living faith in Jesus Christ.

By nature we are all dead; but by a new birth, wrought by the Holy Spirit, we receive life in God, become one with Him, and thus true members of the congregation.

We say that the congregation is the true form of the Kingdom of God on earth; but we cannot simply say that when someone becomes a member of the congregation's outward organization, he thereby also becomes a member of the Kingdom of God; for membership in the Kingdom of God depends upon living union with God. And one can have living fellowship with God without being a member of the congregation's outward organization. In accordance with this understanding, we also use the word "congregation" to denote the gathering of all believers wherever they are found, within or outside an organization. For in the third article we confess that the church (the congregation) is one; but this unity consists not in organization, not in doctrinal confession, not in liturgical form, but in life, life in God.

Here, then, a distinction is made between the congregation according to its inward essence and according to its outward form. Such a distinction is in full accordance both with the Word of God and with **Living Principles**. When, however, the congregation according to its inward, spiritual essence has been termed "the invisible church," this is not a happy expression, since the Word of God plainly says that it is to be as the city set on the hill that

cannot be hidden. To be sure, the Savior says: "The Kingdom of God does not come in such a way as to be observed; neither shall they say, See here, or, See there! for behold, the Kingdom of God is within you." But He also says that believers are to be light and salt in the world, that the light is not to be put under the bushel, but on the stand, so that it may shine for all in the house.

"Let your light so shine before people, that they may see your good works and praise your Father in heaven."

These words of the Savior may be applied to the congregation as a whole just as well as to the individual believers; for the congregation becomes such as its individual members are. If the individuals are shining lights, then the congregation also will shine. If the life is warm and vigorous in the individuals, it will also manifest itself in the congregation and outward from it. Our life is hidden with Christ in God; but it must also come visibly forth in the congregation, in the individual members. Believers are to be living epistles, known and read by all. God's Spirit is indeed invisible, but He makes Himself known by His working in and through believers. When they walk worthy of their calling, it will always be possible to say of them: they have been with Jesus; they have been in the school of the Holy Spirit. For them God's will is always law; they walk with the Lord, they serve Him.

Life itself is invisible; but it manifests itself by the forms it assumes, by the development through which it passes. Where there is life, there is movement, activity, labor. Stagnation is death.

The disciples of Jesus Christ are called to labor. They have received life not only to enjoy, but also to give. They are to bear fruit for the Kingdom of God; indeed, they are even to receive grace to suffer with Christ, to fill up in their flesh what is yet lacking in Christ's afflictions, for His body, which is the congregation.

How much affliction are we willing to bear for God's congregation? How great sacrifices are we willing to make? How much labor are we willing to perform? Is it a matter of the heart for us to do our part that the Kingdom of God may flourish among us? Or are our fair words about the congregation only empty phrases? May God give us more and more of the mind of Jesus Christ, that we may become more and more like Him in serving, suffering, sacrificing.

Self-sacrificing labor is required. The individual believer is to labor for the advancement of the Kingdom of God; the whole congregation is to be a well-organized working body. The gifts of grace must be cultivated and put to use. It is not God's thought that believers should sit still and inactive, each by himself, one here and one there; He wills that they should come together in order to encourage, urge, and help one another. They need such mutual help both as regards their own salvation and the salvation of other souls. Besides, brotherly love will draw God's children together; spiritual kinship, the need for common edification and prayer, will unite them, make them one. The believers in the first congregation remained steadfast in the apostles' teaching and in the fellowship, in the breaking of bread and in the prayers. And these are at all times the true marks of a sound congregational life. There is therefore something amiss with those who do not feel the need to gather with others around the Word of God and the sacraments for common edification, common prayer, and common labor. They lack, at any rate, the proper congregational sense, the proper sense of fellowship,

and the proper responsibility toward the advancement of the Kingdom of God on earth.

A congregational organization is also needed so that there may be order and discipline and so that with united strength one may carry out work that the individual cannot accomplish alone.

But it ought always to be remembered that the congregation properly consists of believing people, that it is to be holy and blameless, without spot or wrinkle, and it ought to be our aim, with God's help, to present the congregation in its proper form according to the plan the Lord has indicated in His Word. Here is our task. It is a high and glorious goal. We shall scarcely attain it fully here upon earth; but to come as near to it as possible ought to be our striving.

To labor unceasingly for the congregation's quickening and liberation among us is our task. Awakening, Spirit, and life are the essential thing. It is not enough to presuppose life; we must do our part that there may be life, more and more life, among us.

Yet awakening to life does not come merely by speaking about awakening and crying out for awakening.

Our stock expressions about awakening, Spirit, and life can, like so much else, easily become customary forms of speech and empty phrases without the slightest effect.

To stir up a religious movement with much fuss and display, moving stories, many tears, and appeal to the emotions is not, without more, true awakening either.

All this may be very harmful.

God's Spirit alone can awaken to life.

Human contrivances are of no use.

We must therefore let God's Spirit do His work in us and through us.

We must become fervent in spirit, steadfast in prayer, and zealous for every good work.

It must be our highest delight and longing to be the Spirit's willing instruments in bearing forth the testimony of salvation and grace in Jesus Christ and leading sinners to Him.

But it is true that souls can be saved one by one and liberated from the power and dominion of sin without the congregation to which they belong being liberated. Therefore we say with Ditzel that "next to the question of the salvation of the individual soul there is no more important question than that of the congregation." And therefore we continue to say with point 2 in the Free Church's rules that "its (the Lutheran Free Church's) purpose is to labor for the quickening and liberation of all Norwegian Lutheran congregations, so that according to their calling and their ability they may work in spiritual independence and freedom for the cause of the Kingdom of God at home and abroad through such agencies and institutions as the congregations themselves may determine."

So then, it is both quickening and liberation. Of spiritual liberation there can be no question apart from spiritual life. Freedom must come as a fruit of the Spirit; for "where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is freedom."